

Antioch/Reimann - Lausanne

Pregame - 0.0

Note: Antioch drafted and got the 'Cauldron' option, alongside one other trigger, and elected to take the Cauldron option:

C. Cauldron option. You write up a character with history, background, motivations and goals, and present it to me. Depending on the originality, quality, and depth of the sheet, I present more/better vials to you, based on what the character asked for and desired. We roleplay conversation between Cauldron employee and yourself in a mini-session, with you picking a vial.

He sent me his sheet, with a backstory & details for Reimann, a cape enthusiast who'd made a hobby and a career both from studying capes, but who was buckling under jealousy during his internship at the PRT. The roleplay session was as follows:

Wildbow **You return to your apartment, as you have hundreds of times before. Your bag of books finds its usual spot as you enter the door, automatically locking it behind you, sweaty despite the lower temperatures. Something feels off, a subtle change in the air, hairs at the back of your neck moving. On the alert, you make your way out of the hall and into the living room.**

The back wall of the apartment is gone. A gaping room that looks like a hangar extends out beyond it. Two figures stand at the intersection of the spaces. Man and woman, both dark haired, very possibly siblings, both wearing lab coats.

Antioch "I... uh..."

There are a thousand things running through my mind, but I blurt out the first thing that finds its way to my tongue.

"The fuck did you do to my apartment?"

Wildbow **"It's very possible," the man says, with an Australian accent, "That you won't wish to return to your apartment after we are done our discussion."**

"If you do," the woman says, her accent matching the man's, "You'll find it the same as you left it. What was done can be undone. Will you come with us? We mean you no harm."

Antioch "Y-yeah, definitely."

The initial shock is still there, numbing, but possibilities start racing through my mind, wild and unfounded.

There's very little hesitation as I cross the threshold between apartment and hangar, heart racing, pounding audibly.

Wildbow The air rustles as the gateway behind you closes. You stand in the middle of a vast, open space. The distant walls are tiled with white, the floor and ceiling gray. Double doors stand at regular intervals along the four walls, eight in all. It's cooler here than it was in your heated apartment.

"You're an avid researcher of parahumans, but there are hints that you wouldn't be happy working for the PRT, hm?" the woman asks.

"Not over the long term," the man says.

Antioch I snap myself out of my reverie, awash with awe and uncertainty as I survey the interior of the massive building.

Responding a little too late, I say, "I won't say that it isn't awesome, researching capes, how they work, how they interact, all of that, but..."

"... researching parahumans all the time? Working with them?"

"You start to get more than a little jealous," I finish, shrugging haplessly.

Wildbow "We know you have an NDA with the PRT. We won't ask you to break it," the woman says. "Though it's very possible that you may decide that such things are remarkably minor, in the grand scheme of it all, by the time today is done."

She snaps her fingers twice, gesturing blithely into the air. A doorway like the one in your apartment appears, wide and tall.

They lead the way through, onto a rooftop. The wind blows, the sky is dark and roiling, and something about the city feels -off- somehow.

((Knowledge check to identify - passed))

"I know that it's strange to say the PRT is minor, when it's the largest group of capes in the world, but..." the man trails off. He indicates the world before you.

The architecture is odd. There's a goal or a design behind it all. A regality, like the ornamentation of a grandfather clock. You're pretty damn sure that this isn't architecture you've seen in any photos about Earth.

Antioch I'm slack-jawed, in awe for too many reasons to count, words spilling out of my mouth too fast, stumbling over my tongue.

"D-did you do that?" I'm wildly gesticulating at the doorway, the woman who summoned it with two snaps of her fingers.

"And, andandand, /where/ is that?"

Wildbow **"I didn't," she says. "He didn't either. We have resources."**

"According to the PRT's most classified files," the man says, "This would be Earth Shin. Earth S for short. A Professor Haywire first raised attention to its existence. The number of parahumans are low in numbers on this alternate Earth, but they operate under a very subtle hive mind, all in allegiance to a Queen. For this reason, it is exceptionally dangerous for a parahuman to visit this world. They would quickly and inevitably fall under the woman's thrall."

"Obviously," the woman says, "We aren't parahumans, us three."

The man continues, "The PRT higher-ups remain aware of this threat, among others. It's part of their reason for being paranoid about breaching other worlds. Part of what -we- do, my colleague and I, is study the threats and try to weigh viability and potential. This is a threat that our organization has decided to leave alone, because it has potential."

"There are other threats, what the PRT calls S-class threats, that we regularly and systematically target and eliminate. Sometimes working with the PRT, more often we work alone."

The man nods. "We lost one of our best, a few years back. We're looking to build our numbers. We would like to invite you to become a parahuman, working for us."

Antioch This, this is entirely too much for me to handle. Mouth already hanging wide open from the demonstration of Earth Shin, I spend a moment far too long, choking on air, in wide-eyed shock, before spluttering out, "H-how?"

Wildbow "We have vials that can cause triggers, without having to endure a trigger event. Though it's our understanding that you tried to provoke your own, and suffered a great deal in the process," the woman says.

Antioch "That's, wow, that's absolutely fucking nuts," I babble, before catching myself - pulling my sleeves up, showing the burn scars, "yeah, yeah, that happened."

Wildbow "We often find the best candidates for powers and expect them to repay us in time. Debts and favors owed," the man says.

"With you, if you were willing, we would want a long-term working relationship. You've shown promise, you have the level of obsession required. Right now, we're working on extending our reach. We want more people on the ground in Europe, as the cape community evolves there."

Antioch "I, uh, I, yeah, I understand you."

I'm chewing ferociously on the inside of my left cheek, the pain firmly reminding me that this is, somehow, very much so /real/.

A question occurs to me. "Is about that thing in Switzerland, the sudden cape boom, or something?"

There's a thousand more questions I want to ask, but I keep my mouth shut, teeth firmly clamped on the inside of my mouth.

Wildbow **"It's less about that, and more about a burgeoning group of parahumans," the woman says. "The Suits."**

"Parahumans tend toward conflict. They have traumas, flaws, complications. Ours, ones we create, the flaws tend to be more external, if they exist at all, or they arise from issues in the individual. By inserting our capes into groups and organizations, we can give them firmer backbone, where they would otherwise implode."

"What kind of powers would you want, if you had a choice?" the woman asks.

Antioch Oh, holy shit. That's not a question I ever expected to seriously answer.

"Well, uhm. The reason might be a little stupid, but, I think it'd be pretty goddamn cool to be a Tinker."

The idea, half-formed, coalesces even as I speak - "I always looked up to Hero, as a kid, thought it was the coolest goddamn thing -"

I pause, clearing my throat.

"This stuff you guys are talking about? Being able to make a difference, an impact?"

"I never really thought too much about what I'd do, if I had powers, just daydreaming about having them to /have/ them, you know?"

"But hearing this from you? It seems a lot more obvious, now, heh."

"I guess what I'm trying to say, is, gimme what you think it takes, for me to make enough of a difference."

Wildbow **"We have more than two hundred different vials that can grant tinker powers. The question is, what risks are you willing to take?" the man asks.**

The woman speaks, "There's a very small chance your body changes. It can be monstrous. There's a chance you lose your mind."

"And, let's not forget, you'd have to abandon your old life," the man adds.

"Would you rather play it safe, or take a greater risk for more power?"

Antioch I take a deep breath, replying almost immediately.

"I'll take the risks."

Maybe I didn't give myself enough time to think it through.

Maybe that's for the better.

Wildbow **"Higher chance of mutation. Deviation, we call it. Would you rather have something more unique, or follow in Hero's footsteps and take something more traditional? Uniqueness can factor into fame and notoriety, if you're the type to use such."**

Antioch That's... that's a really difficult question.

"I'm not sure how I feel about the fame, the notoriety bit, but I feel like I shouldn't be a copycat."

"Something unique, then, I suppose."

Wildbow "That increases the chance of deviation further, and would have us pick something less powerful, as a rule," she says. She looks at her companion. "Which ones are you thinking?"

Antioch "If it's just for the sake of avoiding being a copycat, hm."

"Could I change my mind on that? I don't think it's worth the trade-off."

Wildbow "You can," she says.

"More power, then?" the man asks.

Antioch "Heh. Yeah."

I'm slightly distracted now, revisiting old daydreams of having powers, far too excited.

Wildbow "The strongest basic tinker vial we have is Unary. Singular focus on one specialty. Specifically lasers, or specifically vehicles, or specifically flame technology," the man says. "Easily mixed with other vials, to draw 'inspiration' from those vials for what your specialty would be. At a higher cost of mutation, unfortunately."

"The mutations are mild," the woman says. "Almost always something that can be covered, but they affect a great deal of your body. Where one mutation might affect your hands alone, it might spread from hand to arm to shoulder, a circuit pattern."

"'Clad' is the name of our powersuit tinker. Mechs, armor, bodysuits. It doesn't draw inspiration like Unary does, not from other vials. What we've found is that it will draw inspiration from the host. From you. But if you do not have enough of something for it to draw on, it tends to deviate. Correspondingly greater deviation, the less unique of a person you are," the man explains.

"Well!" the woman says to her partner, as if inspired. She looks at you, "That's the name of the vial. Always a battery or

reactor, something the host will carry with them. Powerful, powerful items, weapons, armor."

"Albeit larger, clunkier, heavier," the man says.

"But," the woman points out, "Stronger than baseline. Then -more- power, depending on modifications to the reactor or battery's energies."

"If you don't want to go with technology," the man says, "Perhaps biology? You've shown interest in parahumans, what they are, what they can do. You had a project involving their 'stats', as a youth. Grading and rating. It was what made us think of you. The McCoy vial varies. Sliding scale of either lifesign scanning and using those lifescans on one side, biology tinkering on the other end. Your personality would dictate where on the slide you fell."

"Or would you want something else?" the woman asks. "We shouldn't inundate you with information. What are you thinking?"

Antioch Fuck, fuck, fuck. These are all so fucking cool, how do I even choose?

The researchers have it right on the money, 'McCoy' would be completely up my alley.

I'll admit, the curiosity about Clad is niggling at the back of my mind, curious about whether I'd be a unique enough individual to pass muster for the vial, and, what its powered take on my characteristics would be.

Nah. Minor curiosity shouldn't affect my decision.

"You're right, heheh, I think the McCoy vial definitely works for me."

Wildbow "You seemed to consider for a while. Were you caught between two options?"

Antioch "I was thinking about Clad, what its take on my personality and characteristics would be, yeah."

"And honestly, the other two have their appeal as well."
"But the 'drawing inspiration from the host' thing caught my interest, though I suppose the McCoy vial does something similar."

Wildbow **"All of them do, to a degree. If you felt insecure about having only the McCoy vial, you could combine the two, in hopes of a workable middle ground."**

Antioch "Hmm. Nah, I think just McCoy will do just fine," I say, smiling nervously.

Wildbow **She nods. Her attention goes out to the landscape of Earth S for a moment, and her partner reaches out to put a hand on her shoulder, his expression changing slightly. He takes over, gesturing. A doorway appears. This time back into the hangar. He indicates for you to pass through.**

Antioch I step through almost immediately, the combination of excitement and nervousness, making me move too quickly.

Wildbow **Only the woman follows you. The door closes behind, and then another appears in front of you.**

The man steps out of a laboratory, holding a vial.

"We're still refining the process with candidates. Any thoughts you have after the fact would be welcome. For now, all you have to do is drink it, all in one go."

Antioch "Oh man, alright," I say accepting the vial. "Can I go ahead?"

Wildbow **"Please."**

Antioch Down the hatch.

Wildbow **It's thick and chalky, coating the inside of your throat. You find it hard to swallow, and harder still to breathe after the fact, as it jams up the works.**

**It starts to burn, making the older burn scars on your arms
prickle in turn.**

((Athletics, Athletics & Guts checks - pass fail pass))

**Your body seizes, you manage to catch yourself, then it
happens again, and you fall to your knees. You manage to hold
your breath long enough to avoid coughing up any of the stuff.**

**The darkness at the edge of your vision becomes sharper,
almost deeper than real life, then creeps in to swallow up your
vision, creep up into your mind, and swallow that up as well.**

**You're in what appears to be a garden, but you're not alive.
There are living things, teeming, pouring over one another,
crawling through each other, expelling spores.**

In a distant place your body seizes again. The image changes.

**The life you saw before is only death. The lifeforms... you
watch them for what appear to be years, looking for mates.**

Then even that life dies, dying and becoming husks.

A heartbeat sounds, deep inside the planet. It is time.

The cold planet swells—

The vision ends.

**You lie on the floor. Slowly at first, you can feel your brain
spinning up, a second track of thoughts running along your
own. Ideas.**

**[[Rolls happen behind the scene, for variables in this particular vial -
specialty is set, is a question of methodology]]**

You'd dismissed that, but the first ideas to pass through your mind are for weapons and armor. Life transference, absorption, collection and use. It's going to require materials. It's going to take resources, and some of those resources are going to have to be living things. More than two thirds of the ideas that pass through your mind are pieces of equipment you'd use in a fight. Of the remaining third, half are meant to facilitate that combat, and half are to better analyze your enemies.

Your body seizes once again.

"Now we see," the woman says.

"Mm," the man responds. "Hate this part."

[[At this point, he rolls a 3 on a d100 for mutation, with a 5% chance of mutating. He rolls and gets four mutations in total]]

You feel your skin crawl, quite literally. The pain in your arms intensifies, and your skin splits.

"Damn," the woman says, dispassionately. "Damn, damn, damn."

[[Rolled mutation - extra limb, moderate]]

The pain intensifies. You feel something erupt from your shoulders. As your hands and toes scrabble blindly and frantically at the ground, new limbs do the same, scratching the ground a few feet above your head.

[[Rolled mutation - shoulder, severe]]

Your shoulders heave up, muscles tensing, clenching- then opening. You feel fresh air reach past the new limbs and musculature, touch the inside of the fleshy gaps in your back, brushing against muscle and bone, reaching all the way in, the cool filtered-air breeze embracing exposed heart and lungs.

[[Rolled mutation - mouth, moderate]]

You scream, finally, and your mouth yawns open - too far. Where it touches your chest, it binds there, skin melting into skin, then stretching it. Until neck and mouth and chest are all one unit, your jaw affixed to collarbone.

[[Rolled mutation - hands, moderate]]

The split skin where your arms were once burned tears away. You feel new flesh grow, as if trying to cover it, and failing as bones and muscles swell, taking over, overcompensating.

[He rolls a 1 on the d22 on the Cauldron Deviation table, and gets 'memory loss' - 1 not being better or worse by virtue of being a low number, but still, not the best result for the intellectual Reimann]

But the worst part of it. The part that really scares you...

You feel your memories go. Your hard-earned skills. Your talents, your education, all the knowledge you'd curried about parahumans.

Lost.

"We'll go with plan B?" the man asks, his tone light, stepping away a hair to avoid the scrabbling extra limb.

"I think so," the woman says. "We'll put him in Lausanne all the same. Give him to the slug for the Nemesis programming, so our plan B can step in if he becomes a serious problem?"

"I'll let the good doctor know," the man says. "Leave him here for now?"

"Yes. Dinner tonight? I have wine but no food."

"Food but no wine, here. Perfect."

The two of them snap their fingers.

Two different doorways open. You instinctively claw toward them, reaching out for help, but the doorways close.

Antioch rolled two power flaws, as he spent the most out of any of the players, during the auction. He got 'Shadows of Power' - his power has short term effects or has a bark worse than its bite, and 'Crowd Uncontrol' - he gets discombobulated when around a large number of parahumans.

Quig/Abattoir - Lausanne

‘Down’ Arc - 1.1a

The session was broken into two parts, with a fight being run as a short session at a later date. The second part can be found [here](#).

Quanfinigon (Often called Quig for brevity) drafted the ‘Ring of Death’ trigger:

7. Your trigger event happened a while ago. You believed your classmates when they said that Mika was a wizard now. They had a ring and when they punched people with the ring, terrible things happened to them. The biggest humiliations, wardrobe malfunctions, they were the ones to fall off their bikes or lose their homework. Then Noah got sick, and it turned out to be cancer. Mika apparently hit Noah ~twice~, and even Mika was scared about what happened. Then Mika told you that if you didn’t kiss them before and after school, they’d hit you with the ring. You believed them, you did it... until one day, after you were done kissing, they grabbed your arm, whispered they had someone else they liked now, then hit you just hard enough to leave an indent in your arm. Once, twice- and before they could hit you a third time, you triggered. Aware that something was wrong, panicking, seeing the look in Mika’s face, you freak out so much that you trigger -again-, halfway through the first. 1.5 trigger events.

As the person with the second-highest amount of remaining points after the draft ended, Quig got two perks, getting the power perks ‘wing’ and ‘ferocia’, a ‘mover’ ability tacked on to another ability, and an offensive secondary power fitting to the striker/blaster/brute/shaker classification.

The result was a veritable suite of abilities: the primary ability being the ability to touch objects or enchant weapons to pass on an effect that he could activate at will, tearing up the target and staggering them, with fragments cutting and scratching those nearby. The character, dubbed Abattoir, could sense affected targets, and could make the effect ‘jump’ from one item to those within 5’, and he could use this to focus the damage dealt on worn equipment or on the target, if he hadn’t already used the jump. If he left the effect on a target for more than a minute, the tearing/damaging effect was worse.

Finally, they had a milder, secondary breaker state that gave them evasion against physical attacks (a side-bonus for being striker), the ability to concentrate and teleport to

a seen location if given 20-30 uninterrupted seconds (Wing perk, tied to breaker state), and an toggled, passive aura that made wounded enemies feel extra pain (Ferocia perk).

The backstory was decided as such: Abattoir triggered at a young age and found a home with mercenaries as an assassin for hire. A conflict with another organization sundered his group, and as they try to rebuild, they hear rumor of the power suits in Lausanne. He's sent in to investigate, which he does as a civilian private investigator and an assassin of a cape.

The session followed, and remains unfinished, as the game ran into later hours of the evening; Quig took more than an hour to respond to the game's start (asking a great many questions in the meantime) and took 8 minutes at a minimum for each reply. The encounter noted at the end remains to be wrapped up, and will be done at a later date. There are a number of points I simply skipped ahead or had time pass because Quig took an especially long time to respond - often 30 min.

Wildbow Crows caw, perched in trees above an accident. A section of the road is cordoned off, and police have gathered around. They have power tools, and are busy at work, sparks flying.

In the midst of it all is a person, affixed to the ground with iron skewers that stand as tall as any of the officers.

Traffic crawls as you make your way into Lausanne, rubberneckers staring. The violence, however, isn't something strange to you. You want to get where you're going.

You're going in alone, here. Again, something you're somewhat used to, given your job. The organization you work for has been sundered, and there aren't enough people to go around right now. With rumors of special armor being given away for little to no cost, tied to particular rules, Les Prestataires decided to send you in to verify and gather what information you could.

Once you're past the accident, the crows cawing incessantly around you, traffic clears up. You drive into Lausanne, amid quaint, older buildings, as much style as function. This isn't a city

with proper skyscrapers - there are more churches with steeples and towers that loom over the city than there are businesses and other fixtures.

You drive to your destination and stop the car. You remove the keys from the ignition and find the key you were given. The modest apartment waits for you, the essentials already bought and in place.

Food in the cupboards, civilian outfits in the closet.

Snow drifts down outside the window, where more birds huddle for warmth. It's early evening. There's still something to accomplish, should you want to get started with your task.

[some time passes without a response from Quig, answer OOC question]

You didn't see any obvious parahumans, but the fact that the attack was out in the open was a good indicator that they shouldn't be hard to find, if you were to go looking.

Quig ((Can I have a fake ID for my civilian?))

Wildbow ((If you take it with assets/buy it with funds, which you don't have))

[some time passes without a response from Quig]

You while away enough time looking after details and making sure your things are in order that the best hours of the evening pass. It's darker now, there'll be less people out and about, and it may be harder to find clues.

Quig Time to do some research before making a fool of myself out there. Stretching out on the bed, I take out my laptop and search for details of known local heros and villains, and the more solid-looking rumors of who is coming to town that I should be on the lookout for. Unlikely to find anything truly useful, but every bit counts.

Wildbow ((Knowledge & Dex rolls))

The searches online prove largely fruitless. You get a lot of news stories about crime, murders, and cape involvement, but the results don't turn up many names. There seem to only be a few mentions of armored suit wearers lingering in the city, or ones coming from Lausanne and operating in other areas of Europe.

You crack your knuckles, leaning back, just a little frustrated. It's been a little while since you broke out the computer and tried doing research, and you're a little rusty. You haven't learned anything new, and you've only used up time.

Quig Glad that's over with, at least now they can't blame me for not trying. I close the useless device, get up, don my elegant dark purple/black costume, stow my various weapons and business cards, and step out into the night, locking the door behind me.

**Wildbow ((Knowledge check))
((Sneak roll))**

Quig ((I wasn't finished))

**Wildbow ((I'm interrupting for a reason))
((Continue))**

Quig That was dumb. Walking around in costume without a destination in mind is just asking to get attacked. I go back inside and change back into my respectable civilian garb with trenchcoat. Keeping the baton, hidden knives, and business cards, I wait a few minutes more, then step out the back door this time to avoid anyone making a connection. Wary of my surroundings since there are bound to be plenty of villains, I head over to a nearby convenience store to buy a local newspaper. Looking for any noteworthy incidents that happened recently in the immediate vicinity.

Wildbow ((Knowledge check))

There's a section of the paper, you find, that discusses the problem and what's feeding into the crime wave. An expert talks about how the new arrivals to the city are operating. There's a great deal of posturing and a lot of small conflicts. They aren't hiding themselves, and many are openly picking fights. Vigilantes have been visiting the city to combat the villainy, but there's not alot local authorities can manage when it comes to capes in costume, sauntering down a street with chips on their shoulders.

Quig Not really what I was looking for, but good to know; it's even worse than I thought. Keeping a hand near one of the hidden knives for a quick defense if necessary, I wander around a little and head into the first moderately active bar I see.

Wildbow **You wander down streets, noting the lack of people. For a city with a tourist presence and many international visitors, Lausanne seems oddly barren. The crime wave is on everyone's mind, it seems.**

You pass by shops with iron grilles and shutters pulled down over windows, and see a bar with people standing outside the door, smoking.

The man outside the door gives you a nod as you approach.

Quig I pause and give a nod back, "Rough times, eh".

Wildbow **He nods, and responds in French, "Rough enough we only have the very regulars coming here these nights. But you're new here, oui?"**

Quig "Oui, I'm new in town. In fact, I came because of the rough times, it means good business." I hand him a business card: Les Prestataires: Anything, for Anyone. "If you know anyone with a problem I can solve, give me a call. Any problem at all, for the right price."

Wildbow **"Yeah? Hm. Might just," he says. "You having a drink?"**

He jerks a thumb toward the door.

Quig "I sure am." Head inside.

Wildbow **He told the truth. It's somewhat desolate inside, and the people who are there are hunched over their drinks. Alcoholics and heavy drinkers who are already a ways into the day or evening's drinking. Conversation is but a murmur in the background, almost drowned out by the light music playing from behind the bar.**

The man joins you, "So are you a private eye or something?"

He nods at the bartender, gestures, and the bartender seems to know what he wants. A glass appears in front of him. The bartender looks your way.

Quig **For some reason I have the urge for a pastis, and order one. "Yes, a private eye, but also more than that. Enough about me, I take it you have a problem? Tell me."**

Wildbow **"Well, long and short of it is my wife lives on the other side of the city. Haven't heard from her, my daughter either. I don't know what your rates are, but the police are busy and I would like someone to go have a look-see, perhaps? If it was affordable. Four days without a word, no answer on the phones."**

Quig **"My prices can be variable. How much is it worth to you?"**

((I don't know how much to charge, and my character would have a better idea what people can afford than I do))

Wildbow **"Forty?" he suggests. "Fifty if you wanted to go tonight, instead of this morning?"**

Quig **"Fifty it is. Normally I prefer the tougher, more expensive jobs, but it's a new city and I have to start somewhere." I sip the pastis. "Anything you want me to give them?"**

Wildbow **He shakes his head. He gets the bartender's information and has the man write down the bar's phone number. "I'll be here for the**

rest of the evening. Call the bar if you finish by eleven. Call me at my home number here if you finish later than that. Just give them my best wishes, let me know if they're safe."

He pauses. "If you're new to the city, you know this is dangerous, yes? There are scary people out there. I don't want to send you blind into danger, mon ami."

Quig "I'm not new to danger. I'll need something to go on though. Names? Address? Directions, perhaps?"

Wildbow **He makes note on the sheet. "Laura, my ex, and Mia, my daughter. Be safe. This feels like a different kind of danger. Everyone feels it."**

The bartender, silent, nods in agreement.

Quig I finish the drink, still wondering why I ordered a pastis of all things, and hand him a few more cards. "I know. Pass these around if you like. The card means what it says, or it would if my buddies were here with me. Finding people, removing enemies, protection, it's all the same to us." I get up to leave.

Wildbow **His eyes widen a bit at the 'removing enemies' bit. Perhaps a little too much.**

A crow caws as you step onto the street. Perched on the sign for the bar, it continues to caw, as if trying to outdo a grouping of siren that sounds in the distance.

It's been a couple of years since you were in Lausanne. You can't remember if the orange glow in the distance is natural city light or not. It might be a fire somewhere.

Quig These crows are suspicious. Is someone watching the whole city through their eyes? Scary thought. I calmly walk back to the apartment, keeping an eye out.

((how high up is the apartment window, is it possible to climb in/out))

Wildbow ((2nd floor, no))

Quig I walk in the back door I came out of, close all the blinds, change into costume as before, put my civvies in a small bag ((will this affect sneak?)) and wait a few minutes again, before heading to the front. I peek out the window to see if any crows are looking at the door.

Wildbow ((Wits check))

You don't notice any birds, but it's dark and hard to see. Either way. You're fairly sure there's nothing close enough to really be watching you.

Quig I quietly open the door and close it behind me, and attempt to sneak my way across the city to the damsels who maybe in distress, making care to avoid crows and capes along the way ((how far is it?))

Wildbow **He said 'across the city', and he apparently meant it. It's an hour on foot, it seems.**

Quig I look around for cars on the road, to confirm my guess that I would have stuck out if driving at night. Being attacked by capes in a car would likely mean I no longer have a car. Regardless, I use this opportunity to get a feel for what goes on in the Lausanne streets at night.

Wildbow **There are cars on the road, but not many. You make your way on foot, taking in the city.**

((Wits roll, investigate))

Making your way through the city, you notice a pattern. Graffiti on the walls. A large spray painted 'z' recurs, frequently alongside numbers ranging from 1-24.

The number of cars on the road increase as you get closer to the Avenue de Tivoli, the highway. You find your way over a little

bridge. As with the man and the metal skewers you saw on your arrival, police are gathered around another crime scene.

The same kind of spray paint that was used with the 'z', written on the wall above a man they're putting into a body bag.

'Candidate failure', written in french.

Quig Interesting. I want to ask them what's going on, but not in costume. I continue on my way, trying to find a pattern in the numbers.

Wildbow An hour is a long time to be walking, and while the citizens of Lausanne are keeping off the street, many stand on balconies or sit by open windows, smoking and watching. You seem to be the sort of thing they are watching for.

All the same, you know what it takes to stay out of sight, and your costume is dark. When you wish to be unobserved, you are.

**You see a woman speaking to herself, underdressed for the weather in only a nightgown, her short hair standing up here and there, wringing her hands.
She doesn't seem to see you.**

Quig ((This the address?))

Wildbow ((Only three-quarters of the way there at this point))

Quig ((how high up?))
I look around for crows.

Wildbow ((You see none))

Quig ((she's on a balcony, yes?))

Wildbow She stands on the street. While you observe, watching for trouble, she raises her head, turning abruptly. She spits out an invective in a language you don't know, then strides forward, faster than a normal person should move, leaving behind a silhouette of herself where she had been standing.

As the distance between them grows, you sense a change in air pressure, almost painful.

Then in the next moment, the silhouette moves away in the opposite direction, disappearing into shadows, while her real body disintegrates.

((The air pressure resolves normally))

Quig ((she turned toward me, yes?))
((and was the only person I could see?))

Wildbow ((No, off to one side))
((Yes))

Quig I carefully make my way in the direction the silhouette went, eyes peeled.

Wildbow ((Investigate roll))

A thorough search of the side street turns up nothing more interesting than a frozen dog corpse in the corner, picked apart by scavengers.

Quig A shrug. Oh well, I should have spoken up sooner. Continue walking.

Wildbow **It's clear that you're making your way into a lower-income part of Lausanne. Quaint, old-fashioned houses give way to larger block-style buildings. Apartment complexes, but with so little care for aesthetic that they might well be tenements. Balconies have belongings piled on them or things strewn over or around the railings.**

You check your map, find the right street, and find the right building. Three stories high, but wide, with perhaps ten apartments a floor, red brick, small windows, and no balconies.

You check the exact address. Apt 308.

Quig I look for a convenient hidey-hole to change costume. Is there anyone around?

Wildbow The street appears to be empty.

Quig ((Did I pass another nearby bar on the way here?))

Wildbow ((A few, but they're a ways back))

Quig ((nowhere convenient to change? Phone-booth, perhaps?))

Wildbow ((Dark corners abound))

Quig Taking a gamble, I double check that no one is watching, and step into a dark corner to quickly change back into civvies, stuffing the costume and sword into the bag. It may poke out a little, but it's all under the trenchcoat anyway. Straightening up, I approach the building and look for a doorbell.

Wildbow It appears this isn't the sort of building where you have to press a button to gain entrance. Mailboxes are arranged in a grid inside the door. Looking around, you see that the building is laid out with the hallways forming a square. The area between the four hallways is apparently for the singular elevator, a supply room and a manager's desk, which remains empty. The apartments line the exterior walls. They can't be very big.

Quig ((So I can walk straight to the apartment door?))
I walk straight to the apartment door and knock sharply.

Wildbow A quick search reveals that the apartments on the first floor are 101-110, and you make your way to the stairwell, glancing at the first apartment by the stairs on the second floor - 205 - before heading up to the third.

((Wits check))

The thought lingers as you make your way up to the third floor, that even for ten-thirty at night, it's very, very quiet for a building with so many apartments.

You could blame the thick concrete walls - even the railing of the stairwell is concrete - but you'd expect to hear someone's child or a blaring television from someone elderly.

Quig I peek in a window or two on the way.

Wildbow There are no windows - the apartments are basically a door, and the only windows are the ones facing outward from the apartments, and the ones that would shed light on the stairwell during the daytime.

Quig I walk straight to 308 and knock sharply. Expecting no answer, I check to see if it's locked about 10 seconds later.

Wildbow The rap of your knuckles pushes the door open - it was ajar. There's no light within.

Quig Should have brought a flashlight. I draw my baton, and flip the lightswitch

Wildbow The light flickers on. You have a glimpse of what appear to be vines, crawling across the room, all of them a dark green, thick around as your leg, over floor, ceiling, and furniture. Four individual 'pods' bulge out - one in the hallway and three more in the living room beyond, just swollen, twisted growths where multiple vines intersect.

The lights in the room die - not with a flicker, but as if someone threw a breaker.

Quig I infuse the baton, and toss the fire over to the hallway pod. Ready to bolt, I rend it.

Wildbow There's a violent, vicious noise as you destroy the baton you paid \$50 for. Given the darkness, you can't make out what happened. ((I did not toss the baton))

Wildbow ((Then why infuse it?))

Quig ((I have to infuse something in order to toss the fire))

Wildbow **You can hear other sounds in the building now, almost a stirring, reacting to the noise of your power.**

You hear a sound, agonized, a little girl crying out in a way that drags out a single word for so long it almost loses its meaning, sobbing as she says it. You can figure it out, though. 'Please'

Quig **I can't fight in the dark like this. Time to get out. Leaning over the balcony, I concentrate, and teleport to the ground, then start running away.**

Wildbow **((Balcony? No balconies))**

((Try again))

Quig **I run over to the window at the end of the hallway, trying to dodge any vines I might walk past, and teleport to the ground, then start running away.**

Wildbow **You reach the window, stopping in place, as a man groans in a place beneath you, long and loud, as he might if he were taking the biggest dump of his life, except it becomes a howl of pain instead. You concentrate on the destination, your breaker state gripping you-**

and something strikes you from behind, hard enough to drive your face into the window.

((Guts check, Quig.))

Glass slices your face. It takes you a frantic moment to figure out how to extricate your own head from the glass without cutting yourself worse. Blood drips onto your civilian clothes as you turn around, to see nobody and nothing behind you.

((Minor wound; slashed, scars if not tended to))

Quig **I whirl around, lashing out with the baton and rending the vines if I hit.**

Wildbow **You strike only open air.**

You hear someone crying out, a haunted, agonized sound. "Trine!"

A man screaming for his lover or child, perhaps.

Quig I crouch into a defensive position, an idea forming. I reach into my pocket and pull out a disposable phone, turning it on for the light.

Wildbow **You have your phone, for what it's worth - only the lights in the room went out, but perhaps this will help?**

Your wound isn't bleeding badly, but you're worried about what it might look like later.

**That worry disappears from your mind as you see a ghostly figure appear, staggering, walking perpendicular to you on the floor below, as if blind to your existence.
It disappears from sight, too far to the left to be seen.**

Quig Phone out for light, I put the baton away and pull out a knife, lobbing a fireball at the man's face for a quick rend

Wildbow **The 'fireball' travels a mere five feet before splatting out on the stairs below you. The ghost is long gone anyway.**

Quig Not wanting to leave my back open again, I carefully make my way down the stairs, phone and knife ready.

Wildbow **The calls, screams, and sobbing sounds echo around you as you make your way down to the second floor.**

A crowd of ghostly figures stand at the bend in the stairwell, each one independent from the rest, struggling, flailing at nothing, curled up into fetal positions. You note that the noises are not coming from the ghosts. They're silent and separate.

Quig Avoiding the ghosts as best I can, I continue down the stairs.

Wildbow **They stir, reacting as you get closer, paying more attention, and drawing nearer to one another, until they begin to overlap.**

Quig If I can't get down without going through them, I sidle back over to the window, keeping my back to the wall so I can easily glance in both directions.

Wildbow **The ghosts continue overlapping. The screaming and moaning intensifies, and this time, the sound -is- coming from them. They start flickering violently, the overlapping movements and something else built up.**

Looking upstairs, it seems there are more ghosts in the stairwell above.

More ghosts gather around you, off to the sides and behind, in the adjacent hallways.

Quig Not seeing any better options, I put the phone away and run back up the stairs where there seem to be fewer ghosts, avoiding them if I can, and over to the window.

Wildbow **You draw closer to the ghosts. They react to your presence, moving suddenly, lunging at you-**

((Dodge roll x3))

You're moving too fast as you make your way up the stairs, watching where you place your feet, to move fast enough to either side.

They don't grab you or hit you. They dissolve as they strike you, with a force spread out across your entire body - shoving you up and back. All three make contact, and your feet are nowhere near the stairs below you as you're knocked back and away.

((Guts roll))

You hit the ground hard, your elbow striking it with a degree of force that startles you, as you roll and tumble several more feet.

You hear footsteps. A figure ascends the stairs, leaning against the wall. A woman with a green hooded robe, wearing a wooden mask with antlers that extend through holes in the hood. She leans against the wall by the stairs down to the first floor, and gestures, bidding ghosts to collect between you and her.

"Hm, not who I expected," she says, with a heavy accent. Not France-french or Swiss-french, by dialect. Harsher, with more gutturals. "You had the same idea as I did, hanh?"

((Major Wound - you're knocked down - staggered next turn as well. You're very dazed))

Quig Finally a person to talk to. Probably not the source of the plants. I really need a breather. "I beg your pardon? I am most certainly France-french. And I don't know what idea you think I had." Extend the free hand. "The name's Abattoir, or it would be if I hadn't got caught out of costume. And you are?"

((amended first speech: "I don't know what idea you think I had, but I hope you're not opposed to working together for a bit."))

Wildbow She looks at your hand, but doesn't budge from where she stands. When she says 'non', it comes out almost like 'nah', "Non, I don't need friends."

She spreads her arms.

"I have many."

She folds her arms, taking her time. "I'm Ravir, and you do not look like a woman, Abattoir. I'd think you'd be a woman, to be here."

Quig Confusion. "What makes this place different that only a woman would want to be here? I was sent to rescue some women called Laura and

Mia, but it seems like I'm too late." I start to stand up. "Look, I don't want to start a meaningless fight, so am I at least free to leave?"

Wildbow Her mouth twists. "You attacked me first. You think I'll let you slink away, tail between your legs? Do you not understand what is going on? Why this is -far- from meaningless?"

((Staggered condition is cleared away, you're still lying on the ground))

Quig Oh dear, maybe she is the plant person. I silently tag the ground under me, grimacing as I stand up, foot on the spot to hide the effect. "I attacked a plant that appeared to be eating someone I wanted to rescue. I'm sorry for not realizing that it might hurt you. You still haven't explained why I would need to be a woman to come here."

Wildbow **(([Map](#)))**
((Social roll))

"You should be sorry," she says, with a measure of hostility. "You poor bastard. You don't get it? The Maiden? The Virgin? The sixth place?"

She shakes her head. "I don't think I can let you go, you'll tell others. Defeats the purpose of laying a trap for her."

Quig Looking her straight in the eyes, but paying attention to the stairs down in peripheral vision, I respond, "I can't tell anyone what I don't know. Surely you can see how confused I am. Perhaps I can help you kill her, whoever she is." I pull out a business card, and reach out to her, not wanting to throw it or approach. "I'm with Les Prestataires, and we are willing to help anyone, with any task."

Wildbow **"I know Les Prestataires," she says. "If I let you go, you might have them kill me."**

Quig "We don't kill former customers, and we try to avoid killing potential customers. Even if we did, I know better than to go after someone who would be expecting me. You have nothing to worry about." I continue

holding the card out. "We could even make it part of the deal that I don't tell anyone about whatever is going on here."

Wildbow ((Social roll))
((And another))

She declines to take the card, but she tilts her head a little before nodding to herself. "Maybe."

"But you said you were looking for someone. The girl in three-oh-eight, I think?"

You hear the plea from before, loud enough to echo down the stairwell, followed by a sharp shriek.

"If you'd go back on that little errand, how could I trust you to not turn on me and betray any task I hired you for?"

((She seems to be considering the offer, at least))

Quig I turn my head sharply at the shriek. "She's still alive? That changes things." I let the card fall to the floor, and turn back to her, my eyes narrowing. "I take my job very seriously. I'd like to go up and verify her health now." My knife hand, previously resting at my side, visibly tenses a little. Trying to bluff my way into a deal while only telling the truth.

Wildbow **"I asked you a question. You're offering to work with me against the Maiden. That means going against your previous job, because I'm not letting -anyone- in this building go. Except possibly you. If you're convincing enough."**

...

"I see," she says. "No answer for me?"

Quig ((still typing))

Darn. "I see. As it turns out, I am perfectly capable of doing what I was hired for without making you sacrifice any of your little puppets. I am

being paid merely to look around and see what state Laura and Mia are in. I try to go above and beyond for my customers when possible, which is why I exaggerated earlier when I said I was here to rescue them. I know that may seem like another lie, but I can call the customer to back me on that one. I'd prefer not to, of course. Anyway, as I just said, I'd like to go upstairs and verify her health, because that is all I need to give for a complete contract."

Wildbow ((Social roll x2, Quig))

She doesn't move a muscle, but the ghosts between you and the stairs leading up fade away. You're apparently free to go up.

Quig I put the knife away, tagging it so she doesn't see the spot on the floor, and calmly walk up the stairs, finally getting a chance to wipe the blood off my face.

Wildbow **You reach room 308. She ascends the stairs behind you, keeping a flock of her ghosts up.**

"Usually takes a few tries. Actions that require finesse are hard-"

A few seconds pass, and the lights come on.

You see the pod. Your rending attack damaged it, but it looks like most of the damage was to the exterior. You see the girl within.

Quig ?

Wildbow **"The screams and noise are psychological warfare. Meant for her. The Maiden. The ghosts are telekinesis, generated with my plants. The shapes they take are informed by the nightmares the people in the pods are having. When I move on, I'll pull my vines away. They'll be as fine, well rested, a little malnourished."**

Quig Interesting. Did I open the pod with my cut, or was that her? "I see." I look around the room for something to bandage my wounds.

Wildbow ((Wits check))

Quig "So you'll move on after we take down the Maiden, and I can bring her home then. Is Laura alive as well?"

Wildbow "The woman?" she asks. She points at a pod. "Her man-friend is next to her."

Your glance around the room doesn't turn up anything in particular - a wound to your face is especially hard to bandage.

"Hm," the woman says, her head turning, as she stares out into open air.

"She's here. Number Six."

"You're attacking her head on. Or ambushing, your choice. But if you run, I'm coming for you," the woman tells you. "She's at the first floor. Go."

Quig Sigh. "I'd prefer not fight until I'm a little more rested, but if you insist... I prefer to ambush. What does she do, so I'm not running in blind?"

Wildbow "She makes constructs out of light. They float in air, she'll lob them at you," the woman says. "Hurry. The sooner you attack her, the better."

That said, the entire building stirs. Ghosts appear, and the wailing, blood-curdling screams begin anew, until they fill the entire building.

Then, just as quickly, they die down.

"Natascha!" a man's voice echoes, as if calling out with a hundred individual voices, "Save me!"

Quig "So I don't have time to put my armor on?" Even more sigh. I pull my rapier out of my bag and quietly head down the stairs, listening for footsteps and stopping when I think someone might be directly below me, out of sight.

Wildbow ((Wits check))

You hear dull thuds and nothing more, too irregular to be heavy footsteps./

Quig I stop at the second floor, listening to the thuds coming from below. I pick up the card on the ground, tag it, and toss it down the stairwell, then back up around a corner.

Wildbow ((wits check))

The sounds continue. Clattering, and the sound of falling rubble, very possibly. She's tearing things apart down there.

Quig I call out "hey quiet down! some of us are trying to sleep here!"

Wildbow ((wits check x2))

Quig Since she clearly isn't falling for it, I cautiously head downstairs, peeking my head around the corner at the bottom into the hallway for a quick glance before backing up a step.

Wildbow ((final wits check))

At the last moment, you see the lighting shift. A glow emerging from downstairs. She's coming up the stairs, without the hint of a footstep, and she's glowing, or things around her are glowing.

Quig Assuming we don't see each other, I quietly run back up the stairs to floor 3 and jump the flame to her when she passes over the card.

Wildbow ((roll sneak))

Quig ((redo:)) I stay near enough to see the wall glow without being seen, doing my best to estimate when she passes over the card, and activate for the area slash. Then tag the ground connecting the downstairs to the 2nd floor and back up the stairs more.

Wildbow ((Objects. A patch of ground isn't an object))

Quig ((another card then))

Wildbow ((roll dex))

Your timing is off, you miss your target, and the light looms - faster than you'd expected.

She appears, rounding the bend in the stairs, and it's clear why she was quick, and without footsteps. You have a glimpse of the 'Maiden', as your ghost-summoning acquaintance called her.

She stands about nine feet tall, if 'stands' is the right word. She floats, ensconced in what would best be called a sarcophagus, all gold, and constituted of multiple pieces, each one floating with its own antigravity panels, it seems.

Hair, some real and some fabricated, floats around her head, billowing as vents blow it. There's -hatred- in her eyes, as she searches for you.

You'd wondered where the ghosts were. Now you see. They buffet and bash at her, and she barely budes. All around her, three dozen swords formed out of golden light are forming and slashing, spinning around her as if wielded by an individual swordsman. With the appearance of each one, you can see lights and chambers in the armor flare, as if they're powering or channeling or benefiting from the effect.

Wings of gold manifest above and behind her, detached from the rest of her. She activates a boost effect, and ascends to the second floor. As she does, you can see the marking on her side, where her arm would be, if it wasn't bound within the sarcophagus.

A 'Z' sits over the top, and the numbers 06 sit below it. The owner of the sixth suit of armor.

[Session part 1 end]

‘Down’ Arc - 1.1b

#WD_Lausanne

Wildbow Last time, on WD_Lausanne... A city in chaos, a father that couldn't meet up with his wife and child asks for help. Abattoir, in his civilian identity, volunteers to check in on the family, and finds an apartment building overrun with vines and ghosts. A fight, Abattoir is downed, wounded, and negotiates a truce. He promises to help the creator of the vines and Ghosts, Ravir, against the 'Maiden'

As we begin, Abattoir, still uncostumed, comes face to face with the Maiden. A hovering, golden sarcophagus of floating power armor, surrounded by phantasmal blades.

Quig This is definitely more than I signed up for, but it's far too late to back out now. No hesitation as I dart in, keeping as much distance as possible, and take a swing with my rapier, trying to get parried by one of the 40ish swords surrounding the target. If there's a connection I tag the floating sword with some fire, in either case I immediately back off out of range, ready to dodge.

Wildbow ((Dex or Brawn roll))

The blade successfully makes contact, but the sword of light

you've made contact with doesn't accept the energy transfer. It's energy, your power works with physical objects.

The sarcophagus fires jets at the back, giving you some notice before it barrels toward you, blades extended out to either side, like wings. Not hard to dodge, but dangerous if you misstep.

((roll dodge or brace))

She collides with you, a body check, driving you back-

and you stumble roughly ten feet away, chest only lightly bruised.

((no wound, but you're staggered, frontal attacks/approaching her is going to be penalized))

Quig Wonderful, I have to get real close to do any damage. At least I have the higher ground. Stepping back very slowly in a fencing pose, I prepare another attack as soon as she gets in range, this time aiming to tag the armor and avoid the swords. If I hit, release the tag to damage the person inside.

Wildbow **She watches you, her eyes narrowed with hatred and malice. Her head alone is exposed, her hair floating with the ventilation chambers around the collar. The ghosts are tearing at her and weighing her down, periodically clutching at a sword of light before the energy consumes them, but she hardly seems to care...**

((roll social, add bonus from subterfuge if you have any))

She seems to have an idea of what you're aiming to do, and, wary, she remains where she is. her swords move around her, and merge together, flashing as they blend and reform into a single, long sword, about fifteen feet in length.

If you're intent on touching her, then she aims to outrange you, striking you down before you can get to her.

Quig Since she's standing still, I have time to pull out another card,

mark it, and toss it at her feet. If she approaches while I'm doing this, I back up accordingly.

Wildbow ((Dex roll))

The explosion at her feet scours the floor and makes her waver, lightly scratching her armor with the trace effects of the blast. She doesn't seem to care overmuch.

Quig ((I did not intend to explode it at her feet))

Wildbow ((Ah, redacting then))

"Where is my boyfriend?" she screams. She amps up her jets and looms forward, charging, sword scraping past doors and wall as it swings for your head-

((roll dodge))

The blade slices past your face, cauterizing as fast as it cuts, incredibly hot as it sears flesh.

((roll guts))

Pain blinds you, you stagger, legs giving out, and you collapse. Everything is going dark.

"Where?" she asks, her voice sounding as if it comes from the top of a long well

Quig Not knowing who she's talking about, or where he might be, I have nothing to say to flying sword lady. Instead I hope she ignores the dying man on the ground and focus on staying awake, perhaps stopping up my head wound with a sleeve.

Wildbow **An energy blade pins the sleeve to the ground, stopping the arm from moving.**

"I asked you a question!"

((2 rounds left))

Quig Well if it worked once... "I don't know who you are talking about madame. Would you like me to help you find him?" I reply, as

calmly as I'm able to under the circumstances.

Wildbow ((Social roll))

"You attacked me! You were lying in wait! Your ghosts, your damn ploy!" she spouts off a number of French invectives. "End this. Call off the ghosts, tell me where he is. I am not a killer by habit, but I make exceptions for those who go after loved ones."

Quig "Alas, the ghosts aren't mine to call off. Their owner asked me for help against one trying to kill her, without informing me of her despicable tactics." Not that I find anything wrong with kidnapping, but you say what you have to...

Wildbow **"What are you going on about?" she asks. At least she's asking and not killing you. "These aren't yours?"**

((1 round left))

Quig "Not at all. In fact, if I knew they were capable of so little I might not have been so eager to engage you in the first place. Now let me die in peace, unless you have something in that glowing contraption of yours that heals?"

Wildbow **"I'm a healer," she says. "But you haven't given me a reason to heal you."**

((Social roll))

((Go ahead))

Quig "As I said, I can help you find your boyfriend, and I know some things about those ghosts."

"I'm with Les Prestataires, as you can see from the business card I tried to give you." I untag it. "We are a mercenary group that helps people with any problem they might have, for the appropriate price. In your case, that would be some healing."

Wildbow **She pulls her swords together into a nebulous, almost liquid form, before letting it drop on you. It's hot, and it burns.**

For a moment, you can't breathe. When you can, you find your breath comes easier.

She's healed you, but only a fraction, enough to bring you back from the cusp of death.

"That could just as easily be a sword," she intones. "Where is my boyfriend? Last chance."

Quig "I told you, I don't know who or where he is. I am reasonably certain the ghost lady kidnapped him to lure you here, so he should be in the building somewhere." I hope those ghosts can't convey our conversation to her.

Wildbow ((Social roll))

Quig "There is a chance the ghosts won't attack me if I look for him"

Wildbow "You told me you could help me find him," she says. "Now you're saying you don't know where he is. You said you were helping this woman, now you're not. You want to be useful? Follow along. Fight me on this, I put you down."

A golden chain manifests, multiple crystals studding her armor glowing.

It seems intent on fixing itself to your neck.

Quig I stand up, avoiding the chain while trying to look like I'm not actually trying to avoid it.

Wildbow ((Roll dex, add any modifier from subterfuge))

She watches you as you try to bob and weave in the process of getting up. You aren't as subtle as you intend.

She doesn't speak at first, as her chain reforms into a sword.

((You have 3 minor wounds, everything else is healed.))

Quig "Thank you for healing me, Natascha. Each of these ghosts is supported by a human encased in plant matter. The best way to find the hostage is to carefully open each one to see who's inside.

Shall we go?"

Wildbow "You're a weasel," she says. "A slimy, slippery weasel. All you had to do was let me chain you. All you had to do was tell me where my boyfriend was. All you're doing is buying -her- time."

She lunges, swinging-

((Roll defense))

You duck, and the blade passes over your head.

She manifests more blades around her.

Quig Looks like it's time for round 2. I didn't feel comfortable siding with her over an established contract anyway. I try to hit her armor with the rapier, using my power to rend Natascha from inside it if I connect, sidestepping to the higher ground again.

Wildbow **((Dex roll))**

The attack glances off, and contact is only brief enough for you to transfer the power. The armor, however, is too thick for you to relocate the energy.

((this is in your power notes, or it should be; sufficiently thick armor precludes ability to target individual))

Quig **((then I can try to rend the armor to hit her with the slash effect?))**

Wildbow **((Yes))**

Quig Seeing the rend effect fail to jump targets properly, I try to rend the armor to hit her with the slash effect.

Wildbow **The armor is ripped open at the front, her upper body exposed. Minor cuts criss-cross her breasts and throat.**

((Two minor wounds, one disappears after a round))

She swings once more, and this time follows it up with slashes of the smaller blades.

((Three dodge rolls))

((roll guts, -1))

You stagger, the second of two smaller blades slashing your shoulders. You can smell your own flesh burn in the blade's wake. She moves back a distance, putting blades between you and her. Almost a barrier you'd have to fight past to get to her.

Quig Three attacks vs my one hit is not good odds for me. On the other hand, her armor is gone where it counts. I back up to the top of the steps, pull out my pistol, and shoot her.

Wildbow ((Dex roll))

As you aim the gun, she moves, veering to one side, using the railing and side of the stairwell as cover. The bullet flies through the air, a miss.

You see a flash as light flares. She's attacking the building, now, plunging her sword into the stairs and wall. Cracks form, and things begin to give way.

You no longer have line of sight of her.

((and vice versa))

Quig Great! A chance to escape. I stagger over to the window, focus on the ground, and attempt to teleport down.

Wildbow The destruction of the building and stairwell was being done with an aim in mind. She tears her way forward, bringing rubble with her as she aggressively presses the attack. Your attempt to teleport away is interrupted, and you've more or less cornered yourself, your mobility limited by the rubble that's falling down around you.

She stabs her larger sword in your direction.

((Roll defensive))

It impales your side, smoking as it burns flesh.

((Roll guts -1))

As you stagger, once again fading out, she twists the blade, then wrenches it, so it cuts outward and upward, out of the shoulder, severing but not quite cauterizing arteries and other major parts of you.

A large portion of your body goes numb as you slump against the wall. A half-dozen swords of light hover, and as she turns away to move upstairs, they sink in, pinning your corpse to the wall.

Quig

"Please save Mia, if you can..."

Quig/Abattoir - Lausanne

‘Down’ Arc - 1.1a

The session was broken into two parts, with a fight being run as a short session at a later date. The second part can be found [here](#).

Quanfinigon (Often called Quig for brevity) drafted the ‘Ring of Death’ trigger:

7. Your trigger event happened a while ago. You believed your classmates when they said that Mika was a wizard now. They had a ring and when they punched people with the ring, terrible things happened to them. The biggest humiliations, wardrobe malfunctions, they were the ones to fall off their bikes or lose their homework. Then Noah got sick, and it turned out to be cancer. Mika apparently hit Noah ~twice~, and even Mika was scared about what happened. Then Mika told you that if you didn’t kiss them before and after school, they’d hit you with the ring. You believed them, you did it... until one day, after you were done kissing, they grabbed your arm, whispered they had someone else they liked now, then hit you just hard enough to leave an indent in your arm. Once, twice- and before they could hit you a third time, you triggered. Aware that something was wrong, panicking, seeing the look in Mika’s face, you freak out so much that you trigger -again-, halfway through the first. 1.5 trigger events.

As the person with the second-highest amount of remaining points after the draft ended, Quig got two perks, getting the power perks ‘wing’ and ‘ferocia’, a ‘mover’ ability tacked on to another ability, and an offensive secondary power fitting to the striker/blaster/brute/shaker classification.

The result was a veritable suite of abilities: the primary ability being the ability to touch objects or enchant weapons to pass on an effect that he could activate at will, tearing up the target and staggering them, with fragments cutting and scratching those nearby. The character, dubbed Abattoir, could sense affected targets, and could make the effect ‘jump’ from one item to those within 5’, and he could use this to focus the damage dealt on worn equipment or on the target, if he hadn’t already used the jump. If he left the effect on a target for more than a minute, the tearing/damaging effect was worse.

Finally, they had a milder, secondary breaker state that gave them evasion against physical attacks (a side-bonus for being striker), the ability to concentrate and teleport to

a seen location if given 20-30 uninterrupted seconds (Wing perk, tied to breaker state), and an toggled, passive aura that made wounded enemies feel extra pain (Ferocia perk).

The backstory was decided as such: Abattoir triggered at a young age and found a home with mercenaries as an assassin for hire. A conflict with another organization sundered his group, and as they try to rebuild, they hear rumor of the power suits in Lausanne. He's sent in to investigate, which he does as a civilian private investigator and an assassin of a cape.

The session followed, and remains unfinished, as the game ran into later hours of the evening; Quig took more than an hour to respond to the game's start (asking a great many questions in the meantime) and took 8 minutes at a minimum for each reply. The encounter noted at the end remains to be wrapped up, and will be done at a later date. There are a number of points I simply skipped ahead or had time pass because Quig took an especially long time to respond - often 30 min.

Wildbow Crows caw, perched in trees above an accident. A section of the road is cordoned off, and police have gathered around. They have power tools, and are busy at work, sparks flying.

In the midst of it all is a person, affixed to the ground with iron skewers that stand as tall as any of the officers.

Traffic crawls as you make your way into Lausanne, rubberneckers staring. The violence, however, isn't something strange to you. You want to get where you're going.

You're going in alone, here. Again, something you're somewhat used to, given your job. The organization you work for has been sundered, and there aren't enough people to go around right now. With rumors of special armor being given away for little to no cost, tied to particular rules, Les Prestataires decided to send you in to verify and gather what information you could.

Once you're past the accident, the crows cawing incessantly around you, traffic clears up. You drive into Lausanne, amid quaint, older buildings, as much style as function. This isn't a city

with proper skyscrapers - there are more churches with steeples and towers that loom over the city than there are businesses and other fixtures.

You drive to your destination and stop the car. You remove the keys from the ignition and find the key you were given. The modest apartment waits for you, the essentials already bought and in place.

Food in the cupboards, civilian outfits in the closet.

Snow drifts down outside the window, where more birds huddle for warmth. It's early evening. There's still something to accomplish, should you want to get started with your task.

[some time passes without a response from Quig, answer OOC question]

You didn't see any obvious parahumans, but the fact that the attack was out in the open was a good indicator that they shouldn't be hard to find, if you were to go looking.

Quig ((Can I have a fake ID for my civilian?))

Wildbow ((If you take it with assets/buy it with funds, which you don't have))

[some time passes without a response from Quig]

You while away enough time looking after details and making sure your things are in order that the best hours of the evening pass. It's darker now, there'll be less people out and about, and it may be harder to find clues.

Quig Time to do some research before making a fool of myself out there. Stretching out on the bed, I take out my laptop and search for details of known local heros and villains, and the more solid-looking rumors of who is coming to town that I should be on the lookout for. Unlikely to find anything truly useful, but every bit counts.

Wildbow ((Knowledge & Dex rolls))

The searches online prove largely fruitless. You get a lot of news stories about crime, murders, and cape involvement, but the results don't turn up many names. There seem to only be a few mentions of armored suit wearers lingering in the city, or ones coming from Lausanne and operating in other areas of Europe.

You crack your knuckles, leaning back, just a little frustrated. It's been a little while since you broke out the computer and tried doing research, and you're a little rusty. You haven't learned anything new, and you've only used up time.

Quig Glad that's over with, at least now they can't blame me for not trying. I close the useless device, get up, don my elegant dark purple/black costume, stow my various weapons and business cards, and step out into the night, locking the door behind me.

**Wildbow ((Knowledge check))
((Sneak roll))**

Quig ((I wasn't finished))

**Wildbow ((I'm interrupting for a reason))
((Continue))**

Quig That was dumb. Walking around in costume without a destination in mind is just asking to get attacked. I go back inside and change back into my respectable civilian garb with trenchcoat. Keeping the baton, hidden knives, and business cards, I wait a few minutes more, then step out the back door this time to avoid anyone making a connection. Wary of my surroundings since there are bound to be plenty of villains, I head over to a nearby convenience store to buy a local newspaper. Looking for any noteworthy incidents that happened recently in the immediate vicinity.

Wildbow ((Knowledge check))

There's a section of the paper, you find, that discusses the problem and what's feeding into the crime wave. An expert talks about how the new arrivals to the city are operating. There's a great deal of posturing and a lot of small conflicts. They aren't hiding themselves, and many are openly picking fights. Vigilantes have been visiting the city to combat the villainy, but there's not alot local authorities can manage when it comes to capes in costume, sauntering down a street with chips on their shoulders.

Quig Not really what I was looking for, but good to know; it's even worse than I thought. Keeping a hand near one of the hidden knives for a quick defense if necessary, I wander around a little and head into the first moderately active bar I see.

Wildbow **You wander down streets, noting the lack of people. For a city with a tourist presence and many international visitors, Lausanne seems oddly barren. The crime wave is on everyone's mind, it seems.**

You pass by shops with iron grilles and shutters pulled down over windows, and see a bar with people standing outside the door, smoking.

The man outside the door gives you a nod as you approach.

Quig I pause and give a nod back, "Rough times, eh".

Wildbow **He nods, and responds in French, "Rough enough we only have the very regulars coming here these nights. But you're new here, oui?"**

Quig "Oui, I'm new in town. In fact, I came because of the rough times, it means good business." I hand him a business card: Les Prestataires: Anything, for Anyone. "If you know anyone with a problem I can solve, give me a call. Any problem at all, for the right price."

Wildbow **"Yeah? Hm. Might just," he says. "You having a drink?"**

He jerks a thumb toward the door.

Quig "I sure am." Head inside.

Wildbow **He told the truth. It's somewhat desolate inside, and the people who are there are hunched over their drinks. Alcoholics and heavy drinkers who are already a ways into the day or evening's drinking. Conversation is but a murmur in the background, almost drowned out by the light music playing from behind the bar.**

The man joins you, "So are you a private eye or something?"

He nods at the bartender, gestures, and the bartender seems to know what he wants. A glass appears in front of him. The bartender looks your way.

Quig **For some reason I have the urge for a pastis, and order one. "Yes, a private eye, but also more than that. Enough about me, I take it you have a problem? Tell me."**

Wildbow **"Well, long and short of it is my wife lives on the other side of the city. Haven't heard from her, my daughter either. I don't know what your rates are, but the police are busy and I would like someone to go have a look-see, perhaps? If it was affordable. Four days without a word, no answer on the phones."**

Quig **"My prices can be variable. How much is it worth to you?"**

((I don't know how much to charge, and my character would have a better idea what people can afford than I do))

Wildbow **"Forty?" he suggests. "Fifty if you wanted to go tonight, instead of this morning?"**

Quig **"Fifty it is. Normally I prefer the tougher, more expensive jobs, but it's a new city and I have to start somewhere." I sip the pastis. "Anything you want me to give them?"**

Wildbow **He shakes his head. He gets the bartender's information and has the man write down the bar's phone number. "I'll be here for the**

rest of the evening. Call the bar if you finish by eleven. Call me at my home number here if you finish later than that. Just give them my best wishes, let me know if they're safe."

He pauses. "If you're new to the city, you know this is dangerous, yes? There are scary people out there. I don't want to send you blind into danger, mon ami."

Quig "I'm not new to danger. I'll need something to go on though. Names? Address? Directions, perhaps?"

Wildbow **He makes note on the sheet. "Laura, my ex, and Mia, my daughter. Be safe. This feels like a different kind of danger. Everyone feels it."**

The bartender, silent, nods in agreement.

Quig I finish the drink, still wondering why I ordered a pastis of all things, and hand him a few more cards. "I know. Pass these around if you like. The card means what it says, or it would if my buddies were here with me. Finding people, removing enemies, protection, it's all the same to us." I get up to leave.

Wildbow **His eyes widen a bit at the 'removing enemies' bit. Perhaps a little too much.**

A crow caws as you step onto the street. Perched on the sign for the bar, it continues to caw, as if trying to outdo a grouping of siren that sounds in the distance.

It's been a couple of years since you were in Lausanne. You can't remember if the orange glow in the distance is natural city light or not. It might be a fire somewhere.

Quig These crows are suspicious. Is someone watching the whole city through their eyes? Scary thought. I calmly walk back to the apartment, keeping an eye out.

((how high up is the apartment window, is it possible to climb in/out))

Wildbow ((2nd floor, no))

Quig I walk in the back door I came out of, close all the blinds, change into costume as before, put my civvies in a small bag ((will this affect sneak?)) and wait a few minutes again, before heading to the front. I peek out the window to see if any crows are looking at the door.

Wildbow ((Wits check))

You don't notice any birds, but it's dark and hard to see. Either way. You're fairly sure there's nothing close enough to really be watching you.

Quig I quietly open the door and close it behind me, and attempt to sneak my way across the city to the damsels who maybe in distress, making care to avoid crows and capes along the way ((how far is it?))

Wildbow **He said 'across the city', and he apparently meant it. It's an hour on foot, it seems.**

Quig I look around for cars on the road, to confirm my guess that I would have stuck out if driving at night. Being attacked by capes in a car would likely mean I no longer have a car. Regardless, I use this opportunity to get a feel for what goes on in the Lausanne streets at night.

Wildbow **There are cars on the road, but not many. You make your way on foot, taking in the city.**

((Wits roll, investigate))

Making your way through the city, you notice a pattern. Graffiti on the walls. A large spray painted 'z' recurs, frequently alongside numbers ranging from 1-24.

The number of cars on the road increase as you get closer to the Avenue de Tivoli, the highway. You find your way over a little

bridge. As with the man and the metal skewers you saw on your arrival, police are gathered around another crime scene.

The same kind of spray paint that was used with the 'z', written on the wall above a man they're putting into a body bag.

'Candidate failure', written in french.

Quig Interesting. I want to ask them what's going on, but not in costume. I continue on my way, trying to find a pattern in the numbers.

Wildbow An hour is a long time to be walking, and while the citizens of Lausanne are keeping off the street, many stand on balconies or sit by open windows, smoking and watching. You seem to be the sort of thing they are watching for.

All the same, you know what it takes to stay out of sight, and your costume is dark. When you wish to be unobserved, you are.

**You see a woman speaking to herself, underdressed for the weather in only a nightgown, her short hair standing up here and there, wringing her hands.
She doesn't seem to see you.**

Quig ((This the address?))

Wildbow ((Only three-quarters of the way there at this point))

Quig ((how high up?))
I look around for crows.

Wildbow ((You see none))

Quig ((she's on a balcony, yes?))

Wildbow She stands on the street. While you observe, watching for trouble, she raises her head, turning abruptly. She spits out an invective in a language you don't know, then strides forward, faster than a normal person should move, leaving behind a silhouette of herself where she had been standing.

As the distance between them grows, you sense a change in air pressure, almost painful.

Then in the next moment, the silhouette moves away in the opposite direction, disappearing into shadows, while her real body disintegrates.

((The air pressure resolves normally))

Quig ((she turned toward me, yes?))
((and was the only person I could see?))

Wildbow ((No, off to one side))
((Yes))

Quig I carefully make my way in the direction the silhouette went, eyes peeled.

Wildbow ((Investigate roll))

A thorough search of the side street turns up nothing more interesting than a frozen dog corpse in the corner, picked apart by scavengers.

Quig A shrug. Oh well, I should have spoken up sooner. Continue walking.

Wildbow **It's clear that you're making your way into a lower-income part of Lausanne. Quaint, old-fashioned houses give way to larger block-style buildings. Apartment complexes, but with so little care for aesthetic that they might well be tenements. Balconies have belongings piled on them or things strewn over or around the railings.**

You check your map, find the right street, and find the right building. Three stories high, but wide, with perhaps ten apartments a floor, red brick, small windows, and no balconies.

You check the exact address. Apt 308.

Quig I look for a convenient hidey-hole to change costume. Is there anyone around?

Wildbow The street appears to be empty.

Quig ((Did I pass another nearby bar on the way here?))

Wildbow ((A few, but they're a ways back))

Quig ((nowhere convenient to change? Phone-booth, perhaps?))

Wildbow ((Dark corners abound))

Quig Taking a gamble, I double check that no one is watching, and step into a dark corner to quickly change back into civvies, stuffing the costume and sword into the bag. It may poke out a little, but it's all under the trenchcoat anyway. Straightening up, I approach the building and look for a doorbell.

Wildbow It appears this isn't the sort of building where you have to press a button to gain entrance. Mailboxes are arranged in a grid inside the door. Looking around, you see that the building is laid out with the hallways forming a square. The area between the four hallways is apparently for the singular elevator, a supply room and a manager's desk, which remains empty. The apartments line the exterior walls. They can't be very big.

Quig ((So I can walk straight to the apartment door?))
I walk straight to the apartment door and knock sharply.

Wildbow A quick search reveals that the apartments on the first floor are 101-110, and you make your way to the stairwell, glancing at the first apartment by the stairs on the second floor - 205 - before heading up to the third.

((Wits check))

The thought lingers as you make your way up to the third floor, that even for ten-thirty at night, it's very, very quiet for a building with so many apartments.

You could blame the thick concrete walls - even the railing of the stairwell is concrete - but you'd expect to hear someone's child or a blaring television from someone elderly.

Quig I peek in a window or two on the way.

Wildbow There are no windows - the apartments are basically a door, and the only windows are the ones facing outward from the apartments, and the ones that would shed light on the stairwell during the daytime.

Quig I walk straight to 308 and knock sharply. Expecting no answer, I check to see if it's locked about 10 seconds later.

Wildbow The rap of your knuckles pushes the door open - it was ajar. There's no light within.

Quig Should have brought a flashlight. I draw my baton, and flip the lightswitch

Wildbow The light flickers on. You have a glimpse of what appear to be vines, crawling across the room, all of them a dark green, thick around as your leg, over floor, ceiling, and furniture. Four individual 'pods' bulge out - one in the hallway and three more in the living room beyond, just swollen, twisted growths where multiple vines intersect.

The lights in the room die - not with a flicker, but as if someone threw a breaker.

Quig I infuse the baton, and toss the fire over to the hallway pod. Ready to bolt, I rend it.

Wildbow There's a violent, vicious noise as you destroy the baton you paid \$50 for. Given the darkness, you can't make out what happened. ((I did not toss the baton))

Wildbow ((Then why infuse it?))

Quig ((I have to infuse something in order to toss the fire))

Wildbow **You can hear other sounds in the building now, almost a stirring, reacting to the noise of your power.**

You hear a sound, agonized, a little girl crying out in a way that drags out a single word for so long it almost loses its meaning, sobbing as she says it. You can figure it out, though. 'Please'

Quig **I can't fight in the dark like this. Time to get out. Leaning over the balcony, I concentrate, and teleport to the ground, then start running away.**

Wildbow **((Balcony? No balconies))**

((Try again))

Quig **I run over to the window at the end of the hallway, trying to dodge any vines I might walk past, and teleport to the ground, then start running away.**

Wildbow **You reach the window, stopping in place, as a man groans in a place beneath you, long and loud, as he might if he were taking the biggest dump of his life, except it becomes a howl of pain instead. You concentrate on the destination, your breaker state gripping you-**

and something strikes you from behind, hard enough to drive your face into the window.

((Guts check, Quig.))

Glass slices your face. It takes you a frantic moment to figure out how to extricate your own head from the glass without cutting yourself worse. Blood drips onto your civilian clothes as you turn around, to see nobody and nothing behind you.

((Minor wound; slashed, scars if not tended to))

Quig **I whirl around, lashing out with the baton and rending the vines if I hit.**

Wildbow **You strike only open air.**

You hear someone crying out, a haunted, agonized sound. "Trine!"

A man screaming for his lover or child, perhaps.

Quig I crouch into a defensive position, an idea forming. I reach into my pocket and pull out a disposable phone, turning it on for the light.

Wildbow **You have your phone, for what it's worth - only the lights in the room went out, but perhaps this will help?**

Your wound isn't bleeding badly, but you're worried about what it might look like later.

That worry disappears from your mind as you see a ghostly figure appear, staggering, walking perpendicular to you on the floor below, as if blind to your existence.

It disappears from sight, too far to the left to be seen.

Quig Phone out for light, I put the baton away and pull out a knife, lobbing a fireball at the man's face for a quick rend

Wildbow **The 'fireball' travels a mere five feet before splatting out on the stairs below you. The ghost is long gone anyway.**

Quig Not wanting to leave my back open again, I carefully make my way down the stairs, phone and knife ready.

Wildbow **The calls, screams, and sobbing sounds echo around you as you make your way down to the second floor.**

A crowd of ghostly figures stand at the bend in the stairwell, each one independent from the rest, struggling, flailing at nothing, curled up into fetal positions. You note that the noises are not coming from the ghosts. They're silent and separate.

Quig Avoiding the ghosts as best I can, I continue down the stairs.

Wildbow **They stir, reacting as you get closer, paying more attention, and drawing nearer to one another, until they begin to overlap.**

Quig If I can't get down without going through them, I sidle back over to the window, keeping my back to the wall so I can easily glance in both directions.

Wildbow **The ghosts continue overlapping. The screaming and moaning intensifies, and this time, the sound -is- coming from them. They start flickering violently, the overlapping movements and something else built up.**

Looking upstairs, it seems there are more ghosts in the stairwell above.

More ghosts gather around you, off to the sides and behind, in the adjacent hallways.

Quig Not seeing any better options, I put the phone away and run back up the stairs where there seem to be fewer ghosts, avoiding them if I can, and over to the window.

Wildbow **You draw closer to the ghosts. They react to your presence, moving suddenly, lunging at you-**

((Dodge roll x3))

You're moving too fast as you make your way up the stairs, watching where you place your feet, to move fast enough to either side.

They don't grab you or hit you. They dissolve as they strike you, with a force spread out across your entire body - shoving you up and back. All three make contact, and your feet are nowhere near the stairs below you as you're knocked back and away.

((Guts roll))

You hit the ground hard, your elbow striking it with a degree of force that startles you, as you roll and tumble several more feet.

You hear footsteps. A figure ascends the stairs, leaning against the wall. A woman with a green hooded robe, wearing a wooden mask with antlers that extend through holes in the hood. She leans against the wall by the stairs down to the first floor, and gestures, bidding ghosts to collect between you and her.

"Hm, not who I expected," she says, with a heavy accent. Not France-french or Swiss-french, by dialect. Harsher, with more gutturals. "You had the same idea as I did, hanh?"

((Major Wound - you're knocked down - staggered next turn as well. You're very dazed))

Quig Finally a person to talk to. Probably not the source of the plants. I really need a breather. "I beg your pardon? I am most certainly France-french. And I don't know what idea you think I had." Extend the free hand. "The name's Abattoir, or it would be if I hadn't got caught out of costume. And you are?"

((amended first speech: "I don't know what idea you think I had, but I hope you're not opposed to working together for a bit."))

Wildbow She looks at your hand, but doesn't budge from where she stands. When she says 'non', it comes out almost like 'nah', "Non, I don't need friends."

She spreads her arms.

"I have many."

She folds her arms, taking her time. "I'm Ravir, and you do not look like a woman, Abattoir. I'd think you'd be a woman, to be here."

Quig Confusion. "What makes this place different that only a woman would want to be here? I was sent to rescue some women called Laura and

Mia, but it seems like I'm too late." I start to stand up. "Look, I don't want to start a meaningless fight, so am I at least free to leave?"

Wildbow Her mouth twists. "You attacked me first. You think I'll let you slink away, tail between your legs? Do you not understand what is going on? Why this is -far- from meaningless?"

((Staggered condition is cleared away, you're still lying on the ground))

Quig Oh dear, maybe she is the plant person. I silently tag the ground under me, grimacing as I stand up, foot on the spot to hide the effect. "I attacked a plant that appeared to be eating someone I wanted to rescue. I'm sorry for not realizing that it might hurt you. You still haven't explained why I would need to be a woman to come here."

Wildbow **(([Map](#)))**
((Social roll))

"You should be sorry," she says, with a measure of hostility. "You poor bastard. You don't get it? The Maiden? The Virgin? The sixth place?"

She shakes her head. "I don't think I can let you go, you'll tell others. Defeats the purpose of laying a trap for her."

Quig Looking her straight in the eyes, but paying attention to the stairs down in perhipheral vision, I respond, "I can't tell anyone what I don't know. Surely you can see how confused I am. Perhaps I can help you kill her, whoever she is." I pull out a business card, and reach out to her, not wanting to throw it or approach. "I'm with Les Prestataires, and we are willing to help anyone, with any task."

Wildbow **"I know Les Prestataires," she says. "If I let you go, you might have them kill me."**

Quig "We don't kill former customers, and we try to avoid killing potential customers. Even if we did, I know better than to go after someone who would be expecting me. You have nothing to worry about." I continue

holding the card out. "We could even make it part of the deal that I don't tell anyone about whatever is going on here."

Wildbow ((Social roll))
((And another))

She declines to take the card, but she tilts her head a little before nodding to herself. "Maybe."

"But you said you were looking for someone. The girl in three-oh-eight, I think?"

You hear the plea from before, loud enough to echo down the stairwell, followed by a sharp shriek.

"If you'd go back on that little errand, how could I trust you to not turn on me and betray any task I hired you for?"

((She seems to be considering the offer, at least))

Quig I turn my head sharply at the shriek. "She's still alive? That changes things." I let the card fall to the floor, and turn back to her, my eyes narrowing. "I take my job very seriously. I'd like to go up and verify her health now." My knife hand, previously resting at my side, visibly tenses a little. Trying to bluff my way into a deal while only telling the truth.

Wildbow **"I asked you a question. You're offering to work with me against the Maiden. That means going against your previous job, because I'm not letting -anyone- in this building go. Except possibly you. If you're convincing enough."**

...

"I see," she says. "No answer for me?"

Quig ((still typing))

Darn. "I see. As it turns out, I am perfectly capable of doing what I was hired for without making you sacrifice any of your little puppets. I am

being paid merely to look around and see what state Laura and Mia are in. I try to go above and beyond for my customers when possible, which is why I exaggerated earlier when I said I was here to rescue them. I know that may seem like another lie, but I can call the customer to back me on that one. I'd prefer not to, of course. Anyway, as I just said, I'd like to go upstairs and verify her health, because that is all I need to give for a complete contract."

Wildbow ((Social roll x2, Quig))

She doesn't move a muscle, but the ghosts between you and the stairs leading up fade away. You're apparently free to go up.

Quig I put the knife away, tagging it so she doesn't see the spot on the floor, and calmly walk up the stairs, finally getting a chance to wipe the blood off my face.

Wildbow **You reach room 308. She ascends the stairs behind you, keeping a flock of her ghosts up.**

"Usually takes a few tries. Actions that require finesse are hard-"

A few seconds pass, and the lights come on.

You see the pod. Your rending attack damaged it, but it looks like most of the damage was to the exterior. You see the girl within.

Quig ?

Wildbow **"The screams and noise are psychological warfare. Meant for her. The Maiden. The ghosts are telekinesis, generated with my plants. The shapes they take are informed by the nightmares the people in the pods are having. When I move on, I'll pull my vines away. They'll be as fine, well rested, a little malnourished."**

Quig Interesting. Did I open the pod with my cut, or was that her? "I see." I look around the room for something to bandage my wounds.

Wildbow ((Wits check))

Quig "So you'll move on after we take down the Maiden, and I can bring her home then. Is Laura alive as well?"

Wildbow "The woman?" she asks. She points at a pod. "Her man-friend is next to her."

Your glance around the room doesn't turn up anything in particular - a wound to your face is especially hard to bandage.

"Hm," the woman says, her head turning, as she stares out into open air.

"She's here. Number Six."

"You're attacking her head on. Or ambushing, your choice. But if you run, I'm coming for you," the woman tells you. "She's at the first floor. Go."

Quig Sigh. "I'd prefer not fight until I'm a little more rested, but if you insist... I prefer to ambush. What does she do, so I'm not running in blind?"

Wildbow "She makes constructs out of light. They float in air, she'll lob them at you," the woman says. "Hurry. The sooner you attack her, the better."

That said, the entire building stirs. Ghosts appear, and the wailing, blood-curdling screams begin anew, until they fill the entire building.

Then, just as quickly, they die down.

"Natascha!" a man's voice echoes, as if calling out with a hundred individual voices, "Save me!"

Quig "So I don't have time to put my armor on?" Even more sigh. I pull my rapier out of my bag and quietly head down the stairs, listening for footsteps and stopping when I think someone might be directly below me, out of sight.

Wildbow ((Wits check))

You hear dull thuds and nothing more, too irregular to be heavy footsteps./

Quig I stop at the second floor, listening to the thuds coming from below. I pick up the card on the ground, tag it, and toss it down the stairwell, then back up around a corner.

Wildbow ((wits check))

The sounds continue. Clattering, and the sound of falling rubble, very possibly. She's tearing things apart down there.

Quig I call out "hey quiet down! some of us are trying to sleep here!"

Wildbow ((wits check x2))

Quig Since she clearly isn't falling for it, I cautiously head downstairs, peeking my head around the corner at the bottom into the hallway for a quick glance before backing up a step.

Wildbow ((final wits check))

At the last moment, you see the lighting shift. A glow emerging from downstairs. She's coming up the stairs, without the hint of a footstep, and she's glowing, or things around her are glowing.

Quig Assuming we don't see each other, I quietly run back up the stairs to floor 3 and jump the flame to her when she passes over the card.

Wildbow ((roll sneak))

Quig ((redo:)) I stay near enough to see the wall glow without being seen, doing my best to estimate when she passes over the card, and activate for the area slash. Then tag the ground connecting the downstairs to the 2nd floor and back up the stairs more.

Wildbow ((Objects. A patch of ground isn't an object))

Quig ((another card then))

Wildbow ((roll dex))

Your timing is off, you miss your target, and the light looms - faster than you'd expected.

She appears, rounding the bend in the stairs, and it's clear why she was quick, and without footsteps. You have a glimpse of the 'Maiden', as your ghost-summoning acquaintance called her.

She stands about nine feet tall, if 'stands' is the right word. She floats, ensconced in what would best be called a sarcophagus, all gold, and constituted of multiple pieces, each one floating with its own antigravity panels, it seems.

Hair, some real and some fabricated, floats around her head, billowing as vents blow it. There's -hatred- in her eyes, as she searches for you.

You'd wondered where the ghosts were. Now you see. They buffet and bash at her, and she barely budes. All around her, three dozen swords formed out of golden light are forming and slashing, spinning around her as if wielded by an individual swordsman. With the appearance of each one, you can see lights and chambers in the armor flare, as if they're powering or channeling or benefiting from the effect.

Wings of gold manifest above and behind her, detached from the rest of her. She activates a boost effect, and ascends to the second floor. As she does, you can see the marking on her side, where her arm would be, if it wasn't bound within the sarcophagus.

A 'Z' sits over the top, and the numbers 06 sit below it. The owner of the sixth suit of armor.

[Session part 1 end]

‘Down’ Arc - 1.1b

#WD_Lausanne

Wildbow Last time, on WD_Lausanne... A city in chaos, a father that couldn't meet up with his wife and child asks for help. Abattoir, in his civilian identity, volunteers to check in on the family, and finds an apartment building overrun with vines and ghosts. A fight, Abattoir is downed, wounded, and negotiates a truce. He promises to help the creator of the vines and Ghosts, Ravir, against the 'Maiden'

As we begin, Abattoir, still uncostumed, comes face to face with the Maiden. A hovering, golden sarcophagus of floating power armor, surrounded by phantasmal blades.

Quig This is definitely more than I signed up for, but it's far too late to back out now. No hesitation as I dart in, keeping as much distance as possible, and take a swing with my rapier, trying to get parried by one of the 40ish swords surrounding the target. If there's a connection I tag the floating sword with some fire, in either case I immediately back off out of range, ready to dodge.

Wildbow ((Dex or Brawn roll))

The blade successfully makes contact, but the sword of light

you've made contact with doesn't accept the energy transfer. It's energy, your power works with physical objects.

The sarcophagus fires jets at the back, giving you some notice before it barrels toward you, blades extended out to either side, like wings. Not hard to dodge, but dangerous if you misstep.

((roll dodge or brace))

She collides with you, a body check, driving you back-

and you stumble roughly ten feet away, chest only lightly bruised.

((no wound, but you're staggered, frontal attacks/approaching her is going to be penalized))

Quig Wonderful, I have to get real close to do any damage. At least I have the higher ground. Stepping back very slowly in a fencing pose, I prepare another attack as soon as she gets in range, this time aiming to tag the armor and avoid the swords. If I hit, release the tag to damage the person inside.

Wildbow **She watches you, her eyes narrowed with hatred and malice. Her head alone is exposed, her hair floating with the ventilation chambers around the collar. The ghosts are tearing at her and weighing her down, periodically clutching at a sword of light before the energy consumes them, but she hardly seems to care...**

((roll social, add bonus from subterfuge if you have any))

She seems to have an idea of what you're aiming to do, and, wary, she remains where she is. her swords move around her, and merge together, flashing as they blend and reform into a single, long sword, about fifteen feet in length.

If you're intent on touching her, then she aims to outrange you, striking you down before you can get to her.

Quig Since she's standing still, I have time to pull out another card,

mark it, and toss it at her feet. If she approaches while I'm doing this, I back up accordingly.

Wildbow ((Dex roll))

The explosion at her feet scours the floor and makes her waver, lightly scratching her armor with the trace effects of the blast. She doesn't seem to care overmuch.

Quig ((I did not intend to explode it at her feet))

Wildbow ((Ah, redacting then))

"Where is my boyfriend?" she screams. She amps up her jets and looms forward, charging, sword scraping past doors and wall as it swings for your head-

((roll dodge))

The blade slices past your face, cauterizing as fast as it cuts, incredibly hot as it sears flesh.

((roll guts))

Pain blinds you, you stagger, legs giving out, and you collapse. Everything is going dark.

"Where?" she asks, her voice sounding as if it comes from the top of a long well

Quig Not knowing who she's talking about, or where he might be, I have nothing to say to flying sword lady. Instead I hope she ignores the dying man on the ground and focus on staying awake, perhaps stopping up my head wound with a sleeve.

Wildbow **An energy blade pins the sleeve to the ground, stopping the arm from moving.**

"I asked you a question!"

((2 rounds left))

Quig Well if it worked once... "I don't know who you are talking about madame. Would you like me to help you find him?" I reply, as

calmly as I'm able to under the circumstances.

Wildbow ((Social roll))

"You attacked me! You were lying in wait! Your ghosts, your damn ploy!" she spouts off a number of French invectives. "End this. Call off the ghosts, tell me where he is. I am not a killer by habit, but I make exceptions for those who go after loved ones."

Quig "Alas, the ghosts aren't mine to call off. Their owner asked me for help against one trying to kill her, without informing me of her despicable tactics." Not that I find anything wrong with kidnapping, but you say what you have to...

Wildbow **"What are you going on about?" she asks. At least she's asking and not killing you. "These aren't yours?"**

((1 round left))

Quig "Not at all. In fact, if I knew they were capable of so little I might not have been so eager to engage you in the first place. Now let me die in peace, unless you have something in that glowing contraption of yours that heals?"

Wildbow **"I'm a healer," she says. "But you haven't given me a reason to heal you."**

((Social roll))

((Go ahead))

Quig "As I said, I can help you find your boyfriend, and I know some things about those ghosts."

"I'm with Les Prestataires, as you can see from the business card I tried to give you." I untag it. "We are a mercenary group that helps people with any problem they might have, for the appropriate price. In your case, that would be some healing."

Wildbow **She pulls her swords together into a nebulous, almost liquid form, before letting it drop on you. It's hot, and it burns.**

For a moment, you can't breathe. When you can, you find your breath comes easier.

She's healed you, but only a fraction, enough to bring you back from the cusp of death.

"That could just as easily be a sword," she intones. "Where is my boyfriend? Last chance."

Quig "I told you, I don't know who or where he is. I am reasonably certain the ghost lady kidnapped him to lure you here, so he should be in the building somewhere." I hope those ghosts can't convey our conversation to her.

Wildbow ((Social roll))

Quig "There is a chance the ghosts won't attack me if I look for him"

Wildbow "You told me you could help me find him," she says. "Now you're saying you don't know where he is. You said you were helping this woman, now you're not. You want to be useful? Follow along. Fight me on this, I put you down."

A golden chain manifests, multiple crystals studding her armor glowing.

It seems intent on fixing itself to your neck.

Quig I stand up, avoiding the chain while trying to look like I'm not actually trying to avoid it.

Wildbow ((Roll dex, add any modifier from subterfuge))

She watches you as you try to bob and weave in the process of getting up. You aren't as subtle as you intend.

She doesn't speak at first, as her chain reforms into a sword.

((You have 3 minor wounds, everything else is healed.))

Quig "Thank you for healing me, Natascha. Each of these ghosts is supported by a human encased in plant matter. The best way to find the hostage is to carefully open each one to see who's inside.

Shall we go?"

Wildbow "You're a weasel," she says. "A slimy, slippery weasel. All you had to do was let me chain you. All you had to do was tell me where my boyfriend was. All you're doing is buying -her- time."

She lunges, swinging-

((Roll defense))

You duck, and the blade passes over your head.

She manifests more blades around her.

Quig Looks like it's time for round 2. I didn't feel comfortable siding with her over an established contract anyway. I try to hit her armor with the rapier, using my power to rend Natascha from inside it if I connect, sidestepping to the higher ground again.

Wildbow **((Dex roll))**

The attack glances off, and contact is only brief enough for you to transfer the power. The armor, however, is too thick for you to relocate the energy.

((this is in your power notes, or it should be; sufficiently thick armor precludes ability to target individual))

Quig **((then I can try to rend the armor to hit her with the slash effect?))**

Wildbow **((Yes))**

Quig Seeing the rend effect fail to jump targets properly, I try to rend the armor to hit her with the slash effect.

Wildbow **The armor is ripped open at the front, her upper body exposed. Minor cuts criss-cross her breasts and throat.**

((Two minor wounds, one disappears after a round))

She swings once more, and this time follows it up with slashes of the smaller blades.

((Three dodge rolls))

((roll guts, -1))

You stagger, the second of two smaller blades slashing your shoulders. You can smell your own flesh burn in the blade's wake. She moves back a distance, putting blades between you and her. Almost a barrier you'd have to fight past to get to her.

Quig Three attacks vs my one hit is not good odds for me. On the other hand, her armor is gone where it counts. I back up to the top of the steps, pull out my pistol, and shoot her.

Wildbow **((Dex roll))**

As you aim the gun, she moves, veering to one side, using the railing and side of the stairwell as cover. The bullet flies through the air, a miss.

You see a flash as light flares. She's attacking the building, now, plunging her sword into the stairs and wall. Cracks form, and things begin to give way.

You no longer have line of sight of her.

((and vice versa))

Quig Great! A chance to escape. I stagger over to the window, focus on the ground, and attempt to teleport down.

Wildbow **The destruction of the building and stairwell was being done with an aim in mind. She tears her way forward, bringing rubble with her as she aggressively presses the attack. Your attempt to teleport away is interrupted, and you've more or less cornered yourself, your mobility limited by the rubble that's falling down around you.**

She stabs her larger sword in your direction.

((Roll defensive))

It impales your side, smoking as it burns flesh.

((Roll guts -1))

As you stagger, once again fading out, she twists the blade, then wrenches it, so it cuts outward and upward, out of the shoulder, severing but not quite cauterizing arteries and other major parts of you.

A large portion of your body goes numb as you slump against the wall. A half-dozen swords of light hover, and as she turns away to move upstairs, they sink in, pinning your corpse to the wall.

Quig

"Please save Mia, if you can..."

Ace/Cuttlefish - Lausanne

‘Down’ Arc - 1.2

AceofSpade (Often called Ace for brevity) drafted two triggers, ‘Arctic Isolation’ (Went up to the Arctic for a research project and got snowed in for weeks) and ‘Corkscrewed’, picking the latter, which is described here:

3. You got too close to a piece of industrial machinery. Your shirt got caught, and you got hauled against it, your arm getting caught and hauled up and around in a corkscrew motion, shattering and dislocating, while your leg did the same. They’re quick to hit the button and stop the machinery, cutting you free while paramedics load you into an ambulance. It starts to dawn on you just how destroyed your body is, the shock passing and leaving your thoughts clear and the pain free to take over your body. In horror and agony, you trigger.

The power was as such - his character is a changer/brute, capable of sprouting tentacles with more raw strength to them than her normal body. By picking up and entwining these tentacles around material, particularly rough, irregularly-shaped solid matter, she could essentially bulk up, grow, and add to her raw strength (Brawn) and tenacity (Guts). She can adjust between the two if she has enough rubble or other material, changing how it’s distributed, and can patch up (but not regenerate) her own wounds with tentacles. That said, she needs rubble to capitalize on it.

Ace was 2nd place in terms of points spent in the draft. As such, he rolled three flaws and had to pick two. He picked the life flaw ‘Hedonist’ (substance abusing, risk-taking pleasure seeker) and the power flaw ‘Monster’, which made him mutate. Generally it’s harder to get too horrific a mutation with ‘Monster’, it’s typically for glowing eyes or weird patterns on skin, but the rolls were rough. A mutation to the torso bad enough that clothes couldn’t cover it. The group decided that she has an eyeball growing out of her upper right shoulder - large enough that the front and back of the eyeball make a bulge. When she uses her power, it opens, staring, and when she’s going all-out it’s her primary method of seeing, but when she’s not, it’s simply an eyelid-covered fleshy orb bigger around than her head.

Given that the mutation means she can't work a conventional job, and rogues aren't a real thing in 2002 (especially not in countries where the PRT doesn't have much influence yet), it was decided that she's been getting by as a bounty hunter, living in Lausanne. Ace decides she'll go by 'Cuttlefish'.

Note: For a newcomer, Ace was quick to reply, which was a relief after Quanfinigon's session, but after a straight half hour of not rolling anything below a '4' on a d6, Ace started to get the lower rolls, and struggled for other reasons besides. It was a tough fight and I sort of hoped he'd use his head, but Cuttlefish fell into a trap a lot of parahumans in the Wormverse do, adapting too slowly to a situation that wasn't doing her any good.

Wildbow Your dinner sits beside your laptop as you trawl message boards for information on local bounties. It's been tough going lately, and you do have funds set aside for the next month's rent. That said, you never know when people will react badly to your obvious parahuman nature, and more money means more security. Too many parahumans in town, too many new vigilantes and assassins. The last...

...few times you've gone out, others have beaten you to the mark. If it keeps up, you might actually have to start worrying about funding.

You take a bite, then return to perusing the usual sites. A violent noise in the kitchen startles you enough you nearly choke.

Ace I turn toward the kitchen, then carefully walk toward it, ready to let the tentacles out at the first sign of danger, I might not have been very successful but I might have been enough of an annoyance to warrant a visit at home. Better safe than sorry.

Wildbow The window over the sink has cracked, and a bloodstain marks the glass. The city outside is dusted with snow - late evening.

A careful glance at the foot of the window shows you a bird, neck bent at an angle, fluttering and doing little more than

moving in circles.

It flaps helplessly about on the portion of roof stretching outside your kitchen window.

Ace Poor bird brain. I should probably put a scary silhouette on that window or something to avoid that in the future. However this does not concern her, anyway it's not like she can do anything, the bird was pretty much already dead if it had broken its neck and if it hadn't he would recover without help. I return to my search online search.

Wildbow ((Dex and Know checks))

It's a good night. Your search turns up several bounties. It's really your choice which you pursue.

Axehead is apparently a brute that's been moving about incessantly through the city's poorer areas. He doesn't sleep, doesn't stop - he's just roaming and causing trouble. It got worse a few nights ago, after he got someone's stash of drugs and started imbibing.

There's an entire neighborhood that's scared to leave their homes because of a sniper that's active in the area. He's never seen, but he shoots to wound, then robs people.

The cops have effectively cordoned off a factory where a breaker that is described as 'unusual' is lurking. They don't have the manpower to stop the thing, and the people who own the land really want it gone in time for a possible land sale. Good pay, but a little less of a 'do-gooder' task, you wouldn't be helping the city.

A preliminary search of the bounty number suggests there aren't any more details.

The fourth bounty looks somewhat more doable, an ice-based shaker/brute is altering their surroundings, plunging it into deep winter. He's apparently loud, boisterous, and is challenging all comers.

The fifth is distant - a blaster. You could look into it more, but there's a very good chance the bounty would be gone by the time you arrived. A coin flip at best.

Ace Axehead and Ice dude seem to be her kind of guys. If Axehead leave any rumble she can use it against him, and she can probably use ice and stuff from the other's shaker power to bulk herself... She'll do Axehead, then if she has time and it's not done yet Ice dude. She look at the weather outside and sigh before putting a vest with sleeves on top of her

costume and grabbing a flask of the good stuff to keep herself warm, taking a sip before going out and firing up the Harley.

Wildbow ((Willpower check))

The engine takes a little while to warm up, given the cold weather. The streets aren't entirely clear of snow, either. The engine purrs. Your laptop said you were supposed to head to Pully, which means heading down the highway.

Ace I'll have to be a bit carefull but hey it's not like I'm not going directly into a fight so it's not a snowy road that will frighten me. As soon as the engine is started she get on it and drive toward Pully, taking the highway, going fast but not to much. Now is not the time to get in an accident or get pulled over. Bounties are time sensitive.

Wildbow The way to the highway is quiet. Only the highway itself is busier. It's late enough it's not stop and go, and you're able to enjoy the ride.

As you pull off to visit Pully, the attitude gets more somber. You see damage to the landscape here and there. Deep, wedge-shaped furrows that are very hard not to attribute to the villain.

There's no address to head to - only the area. The noise your bike makes is a consideration, should you want to surprise the man.

Ace Damn being able to enjoy the ride felt good! She couldn't go out

like she used too and she had to watch her fuel consumption. She parked her motorcycle, stopped the engine and

(oops)

Damn being able to enjoy the ride felt good! I couldn't go out like I used too and I had to watch my fuel consumption. I parked my motorcycle, stopped the engine and put on the padlock before walking in the area. I took another sip to keep the cold out and started to look and listen around with all three eyes and both ears, letting the tentacles out to

collect some good debris and wrecks.

Wildbow ((Wits check))

There's some chunks of wood where one of the poles for the phone line have been damaged to the point that only suspension keeps it up. You wrap one arm around the wood, and your arm effectively extends to be twice the size, though you lose the benefit of having a hand. There aren't enough large, solid pieces of material for you to really bulk yourself out, however.

((and again))

You wander the streets, keeping an eye out for places with more damage. You're readily able to follow the trail, veering more in the direction where the damage is greater. As you get closer, it gets easier to find such areas, and then easier still. You have to be approaching the area where he's most active.

Ace As I keep going I keep collecting debris. I don't know that guys power exactly but he his certainly powerful, I can probably use all the mass I can get. I'm on my guards though, it wouldn't do to bet surprised by him.

Wildbow ((wlts check))

As you draw nearer to the scene, you can hear boisterous yelling. It takes you a moment to figure out what language he's speaking in. It appears to be German - a language you

know only a smattering of. If you had to guess, given the obscene words he's belting out at the top of his lungs, it's a drinking song.

Someone calls out from a nearby house, a woman screaming for him to shut the fuck up - lapsing from French to English just for the 'fuck'.

Your search proves fruitful. There's a chunk of wall missing, and you find it lying on the far side of the damaged wall, inside someone's backyard. It's large enough to be useful, unlike most of what you grabbed already. You could draw it into your body, or wrap your limbs around it to have a club. Given a bit of opportunity, you could change your decision.

In a nearby tree, crows caw at you. They take to the air as you lift the chunk or rubble with your tentacles.

Ace Club it is, worse case scenario she could use it as an impromptu shield. As soon as I'm done I hurry toward the german drinking song. Even if it did not turn out to be Axehead the noise could attract him too. Even with my limp I do my best to hurry. If it was Axehead he might lash out at the desperate woman.

Wildbow ((Sneak check; Dex roll))

Your approach is silent, and you have an opportunity to study the man.

It's hard to tell if he's a mutant like you or if it's just what his power does, but he has a very strange appearance - his head is so narrow that it's hard to believe there's a brain in there, and it narrows to an irregular, gleaming blade's edge, without apparent eye sockets, nose, mouth, or anything. His body, shoulders, arms and legs all have mass, but the blades recur, all of them...

...pointing forward. He might as well be wearing plate mail.

He's half-sitting, half-lying down on a side street without sidewalks, only wide enough for a single car to pass, his

back to a wall, a cardboard box filled with various bottles of booze inside.

((Wits check))

He shakes his head, and the effect around his head falls away. Long, blond hair, and what appears to be warpaint in lieu of a mask. He tips his head back, and upends part of a bottle into his mouth.

Ace Might be the best time to attack, he's probably a changer, maybe a breaker. But here his head is left unprotected. I get closer, close enough to strike. Without protection he might be too squishy for a direct blow so instead I use my club arm to strike his torso, hammering him into the sidewalk. He would probably bump his head on the way and lose consciousness

or at least be confused enough for another blow.

Wildbow ((Dex roll - sneak))

((make attack roll))

You catch him off guard - a fire engine with sirens going, barreling straight for him with a minute's warning would probably catch him off guard. Hefting your rock-fist, you slam it down on him- and you feel pain. The rock splits in two, and your attempts to keep hold of it fail. The two halves fall to either side.

Axehead blinks. He grins. "Ayyyyy!"

He proceeds to spew out a mess of German words. "Fight" and "friend" are among them.

He lurches to his feet, swaying on the spot.

Ace Well crap, no time for elaborate strategy or take the rocks back, I coil together the already extended tentacles and swing for the side of his unprotected head. The tentacles should be soft enough not to brain him. Hopefully. "Sorry pickaxehead, no friend, just doing my job".

Wildbow **Your attack just barely makes contact, as he blocks enough of the blow with his arms to dampen its effect**

As hits go, it's a pretty good one. If he was insensate before, a light concussion seems like it's going to be especially effective.

He backs away a few steps, trying to get a hold of himself, before he transforms his head into its namesake form.

He spreads his arms, ready to charge- and staggers a short distance toward a point about five feet to your left.

Ace Will he's going in the wrong direction I quickly go collect the two half rocks, one for each arm, double the clubs double the fun. Then if he's still stumbling in the wrong direction I will be able to it him from behind. Can't dodge or block what you can't see coming.

Wildbow **Still dazed and confused, the inebriated villain charges for you - this time veering too far to the left. He crashes into the wall, and you see the air blur, mirage-like, around every point of impact. The wall is shredded, and flecks of shrapnel fly in your general direction.**

((Guts check))

The shrapnel isn't fierce or dangerous enough to do any meaningful harm.

Ace God daaaaamn I'm lucky I found him while he was drunk off his ass. I get behind him and reach through the wall to hit the side of his axehead with my rock club arm. The sides aren't sharp, they should destroy my rock right?

Wildbow **You swing, aiming for the blades, and he reacts, bringing his arm up. Momentum has already taken over- and you bring your boulder-fist directly into the blade. He moves his arm, cutting.**

Tentacles are opened up and nearly severed, and the rock tumbles to the ground. You feel an extraordinary amount of pain, and your attempts to move the tentacle aren't working

like they should.

He spreads his arms, apparently making himself as wide as possible before lunging at you-

-and still misses, only shouldering into you before he stumbles into the middle of the street.

Ace The fucker keep blocking with his stupid blade arms. And these hurt. I try to pull back the shortened tentacles to get undamaged ones out instead. No idea if it will work since it's the first time they get cut off. I keep all my eyes on him, trying to gauge another attack angle.

Wildbow **He stands a little straighter, touching the wall to right himself. You're not entirely sure, but it looks like he's not as dazed as he was. The fight now begins in earnest.**

He charges you, and there's no stumbling this time-

((Defensive roll))

His movements aren't entirely coordinated, but he caught you off guard by moving as well as he did, this time around. The axe blade sets deep into your shoulder- close to the eyeball. He hauls it out and kicks you back a few feet. There's some martial arts training buried in there.

((Moderate & minor wound - butchered; scars))

Ace As if I needed more scars... I sneer. "You really think that papercut hurt?" Time to hit again. But this time I remember that all of his friggin' blades point forward, so his back is exposed, I feint another blow to the head but attack the legs, curving the tentacles to strike the back of the knees to make him fall on his ass.

Wildbow **((attack roll, -1 to hit))**

The incoming blow gets kicked aside fairly handily, but you at least manage to avoid getting cut on the blades.

He lowers his head, and charges at you again. It seems that it's not just mindless attacking - he knows some martial art, with

an emphasis on tackling and grappling.

((Defensive roll))

((Knowledge check to place the martial art.))

Krav Maga, the thought crosses your mind, before he uses the martial art to strike you knocking you just off balance enough for a headbutt - with his axe of a face.

It knocks you off guard enough that he gets another hit in-

((Roll defensive))

And only lightly rakes your ribs. Close enough to bone to make blood start shedding openly from the wound.

It's very possible that keeping up this exchange of blows isn't going to work.

((Guts check to stay conscious))

((You're good))

Ace Fuck that's not going to work. I step back, maintaining the distance. I need a new plan fast. What do I know? He uses the edge of his blade for his power so he should be vulnerable from behind. And he liked to party. Maybe I can ask for a rest? Fuck it's worth a shot. "Pause! I'm not invincible." I start retracting the tentacles, not doing it completely as

long as I'm not sure that he will allow me to get a rest.

Wildbow **((In what language?))**

Ace (Pause in german, the rest in french)

Wildbow **((You're not fluent - knowledge roll))**

Ace (actually pause is the same in both)

Wildbow **((Roll social))**

((Three more knowledge rolls, for brevity's sake))

He shouts something that sounds vaguely obscene, then follows up with a string of blather you can't make out

He stabs his finger at you threateningly, before transforming his head back. Your wound is bleeding badly - you probably want to look after it soon.

Ace "Aw come on..." I try something, making tentacles right at the edge of the wound and knotting them together to keep it closed. Now it probably would be a good idea to go full tentacle monster but I would need a good source of debris, enough to really bulk myself.

Wildbow ((Wits check to look))

Your attempt to glance around and see what you could use is interrupted as he starts stalking in your direction. You have only one apparent option - rubble from where he crashed into the wall. That means getting past him, however.

((Dex check for wound closing - seems fair enough that you could do it, or at least stall the bleed until it can be looked after))

((All good - you're holding off the bleeding. The problem isn't fixed, however. Go ahead with your turn))

Ace Time for another gambit. I pull out my flask, take a quick sip and hold it in front of me toward Axehead, offering him to partake too. I tell him "It's the good stuff" in a mix of french of german, he should get the "gut" part at least.

Wildbow ((roll social))

((And knowledge))

He stalks toward you, not slowing in the slightest.

One fist raised, he closes the distance, and snatches the flask from your outstretched hand.

His head changes back, and he tips the thing back.

He says something in German you don't understand, but he

doesn't look or sound like he's going to cut you to pieces anymore.

Ace Okay, attacking him now really doesn't seem like it's a good idea. It'll probably piss him off again and even faster. How can she bring him in? He's too good at blocking, even with his back turned. "Thanks." She get her pipe out and start stuffing it. Not a combat action, that should help him relax. She can probably at last get away, maybe make him relax enough for a sneak attack.

Wildbow He rambles on in German, and you don't understand what he's saying. He finishes off your flask, then wanders off over to his crate of booze and grabs two bottles. He heads back toward you, extending one. He barks an order.

Ace I'm pretty sure I know what he mean, even if I did not understand it. I take the bottle and open it to drink with him. I can use all the time I get, and he may recover from booze fast but maybe I can act more coherently while inebriated. That's another possible gambit.

Wildbow ((Willpower roll -1))
"Name?" he asks. Gesturing at you. "Huh? Name!"

He thumps his chest, sparks flying as blades touch each other. "Axtkopf! Head of axe!"

Ace I point at myself "Cuttlefish. Like small octopus.". I take another sip then wrap a tentacle around the bottle while I get my matchbox out to lit my pipe, grabbing the bottle with my hand once again once it's done.

Wildbow "Fish? Is crab? Noooo," he says. He takes another drink.

Ace "Not crab." I take the time to take the smoke in "Fish swim in sea." I follow taking a swig of the bottle. Then I point at the destruction around. "Why?" Godamn I need a plan to neutralize him... maybe I could stun gun his exposed face face? If it fail I would be dead because nobody like a stun gun to the face. I need him drunk and

distracted.

Wildbow ((Social roll))

((knowledge roll))

((Do 5 so I can just draw on 'em as I need 'em))

"Bored!" he says in German. "Armor!"

Then he says something you can't make out.

"No sleep! Only fight! Raah! Yes? Raah!?"

Ace "Not yet. You strong." I touched the closed wound with my free hand. Very carefully I try to extend a tentacle from behind me to grab my stun gun. "Booze first." I show the bottle and take another swig.

Wildbow ((Willpower check -2))

((And social roll))

"Arrgabrg," he says- you don't understand what he's saying. You're definitely feeling the effects of prior blood loss, fading shock, and a day's on-and-off drinking.

((Roll dex, -2))

Your arm is cut up, the pain problematic, but you still try to be subtle, reaching for the taser, favoring the less hurt tentacles of that arm.

You draw the taser, and the pain is too much - the weapon falls to the ground behind you.

"Hanh?" Axehead makes a sound. He tries to look past you-

((Dex roll))

He sees the weapon on the ground.

"Hanh!?"

He spits out an invective.

He hurls the bottle in your general direction, and then transforms his head.

Ace Yep fuck that plan. Time to run like a little bitch. I turn around and run as fast as possible.

Wildbow ((Roll ath))

Your sudden sprint in the opposite direction catches him off guard. He runs, but he isn't fast, and he's inebriated. You manage to put two dozen feet of distance between you.

He smashes a car in passing.

Ace If I was still in the mood to fight the wreckage would probably be good weapons but right now I'm in running away mode. I have a headstart, no sense in losing it. I can use all the advantage I can get with my limp. First intersection I see I'll turn, better to get out of his view.

Wildbow ((Athletic roll))

He's catching up, now that he's got his eyes on you - you're making your way down the long, narrow, sidewalk-less street, and a quick glance around shows some small pieces of rubble off to the side. It would take time to grab them, possibly giving him an opportunity, but it could help a great deal. The other alternative is to keep running, and hope he tires before you do.

((Can take a penalty of your choice on next athletic roll to pick up a corresponding amount of rubble - he's about 10' behind you and closing))

Ace Fuck he's probably got a lot more stamina than me. At the very least he doesn't have a gaping wound. I slow down grab some of that rubble just in case. This situation is shitty.

Wildbow You stop to pick up some moderate-sized chunks. With them safely in your grasp, you're nonetheless a sitting duck as he closes the distance to you.

((Defensive roll))

((add up to +3 to roll; what you don't add can augment Brawn))

He strikes you, and your attempt to put a piece of rubble between him and you isn't wholly successful. You feel a blade bite into the shoulder, where you were already wounded. It digs deep enough to cleave through muscle and at least one lung.

((Roll guts x2))

You collapse flat on your back, as he pulls the blade free with a sucking sound, and you have nothing left to keep you standing. He doesn't press the attack.

"Why?" he asks. "Hunh? We drinking! Good times! No boredom!"

You're bleeding out, again, and you're not in quite a good enough state to look after yourself, even with your tentacles.

He says an invective. Then switches to clumsy English again. "Dirty! While I'm sitting! Then the- Blitz box? Dirty! Pagh!"

He spits on the ground

Ace I try to close the wound with the tentacle. At least try to keep everything inside. And try to talk, pointing around speaking in english so he understand. "You fight. You destroy. People afraid. You destroy home. You destroy car. Destroy lives. I wanted to stop you destroying." Technically true. She could have mentionned the money but that did not seem like a good time.

Wildbow **((Social roll))**

"All is destroyed, now or later," he says, shaking his head. "There fighting, there drinking, there women, or, uh, there cock for women, if they are cock-hungry women, I am making sense?"

He sighs, haggard. "Head hurts. Now I have deciding. Do I call the, ah," he makes a siren noise, "Wee-oo-wee-oo? Or do I take fourth place, huh? Maybe fourth armor? Hunh?"

Ace I would shrug if I wasn't almost bisected. I was in pain and I had no idea what he was talking about. I was only this clear because I had known pain that was even worse. "You care about fun. Is armor more fun? I'm bad fighter, but if I live maybe become good fighter, and then come back, no dirty tricks, fight like fighter. Your choice."

Wildbow ((Social roll))

"Mmm," he says. "We see, we see. Later then. I call. We have good fight. Or going having problems."

He makes the armor around his upper body de-materialize, revealing a heavy jacket and tank top. He reaches into his pocket to call, as he walks away.

((Guts roll to stay conscious))

You lie there, struggling to breathe, trying to use your tentacles to keep the wound from bleeding too badly, until the help arrives. Paramedics. They hesitate to approach, seeing how disturbing you look, but finally push themselves to draw nearer and start giving you medical care.

There are cops in the background, watching, and the paramedic seems to note your recognition of the officers.

"Are you hero or villain?" the paramedic asks.

Ace "Hero" I get the tentacles out of the way when they need access to treat my wounds.

Wildbow "What the shit were you doing here?"

Ace "Hero stuff? I tried to stop Axehead. He did not want to get stopped. He let me live in case I was able to put up a better fight in the future. I think. Not sure, he was hesitating to call help for me, I'm guessing the other option was to finish me off for that

armor stuff he was going on about."

Wildbow "Axehead, ugh," one of the paramedics says.

"You smell like alcohol. Was this a drunken brawl?" the other asks. "It's important. The police may want to arrest you."

Ace "After he got me one time I realized he was a way better fighter and tried to get him to lower his guard. I asked for a time out, shared a drink with him, tried to get my tazer out while he was distracter but it fell to the ground. After that I ran but he caught up to me."

Wildbow "Uh huh," the paramedic says.

((Social roll))

((last one))

"We tell them that you're no trouble, you don't make us liars, right?" he asks.

He indicates the officers.

"Need people on the ground, to keep the dangerous ones down, oui?"

Ace "Oh yeah don't worry I want the city cleaned as much as anyone without power. I can't hide behind a secret identity." I grimace indicating the big eye. "That's permanent. No choice."

Wildbow They nod.

The police approach, and the paramedics give their input. That you're not dangerous, however you may look. The police seem to be on the fence, until the radio goes off. There's more trouble happening elsewhere in the city.

Too much on their plate to deal with you, they move on. The paramedics tend to the wound, and as they hold stuff in place, you're able to draw tentacles closed and hold the gap sealed.

"Do you want a hospital?" one asks. A hospital means trouble, but it also means enough medical care that the wounds might not scar as badly.

((time lost vs. possible reputation shift))

Ace "Hospital. The faster I'm healed the faster I'll be out here to help keep the bad guys in check." Reputation be damned right now. At last some of the medical staff will know she's one of the good guy, if not actually and effective one. She'll also have to hold off on smoking and drinking and the meals will probably be crap but she want to be done with the

injury as soon as possible.

Wildbow The paramedics nod, and they load you up into the ambulance. Tough as you are, even with your power sealing the gap, a partially collapsed lung is no joke.

The night is over, and the next two days as well. They keep you as long as is possible, but there's an influx of the injured coming through, and your presence unnerves.

At the very least, the work of the doctors seems to have patched up the scar. The wounds are healing neatly, with no sign of puckering.

You make your way out of the hospital, and head on home, taking the bus. The police took your bike and you'll have to travel to go collect it.

Returning to your apartment, you lock the door behind you, only to see a small scene.

The window the bird struck is broken, and the linoleum of the kitchen floor is spattered with blood.

Two birds apparently came through the glass cutting themselves up, and landed on the floor, their feeble struggles serving to dab the floor with an odd pattern of bloody featherprints and footprints.

You're halfway through cleaning it and looking around for something to pick up the two small pigeon corpses when you see the letter on your keyboard.

Ace I wash my and and go check the letter. Weird just got weirder. There was a power involved. That had to explain the mass bird suicide. The fact that somebody had purposefully killed three birds just to deliver a message in her apartment was... freaky. Better to know what such a person wanted.

my hands*

Wildbow You read the letter.

((For Ace's eyes only, sent via. private message))

Fyf/Dune - Lausanne

‘Down’ Arc - 1.3

Fyfsixseven (referred to as Fyf pretty much everywhere in this doc & related docs) was in last place in the draft, which is to say he never won any of the cape auctions, instead getting the choice of either being utterly unpowered with no chance of triggering, or taking the second least desired trigger (players ordered them by preference, they were given values - he got the one that was only slightly more popular than #1, which nobody ended up with). His trigger was as such:

2. There was someone you liked who you were trying to impress. You knew they skateboarded, you picked it up, devoted yourself to it. Got good. You did videos with them, laughed when you got hurt, laughed when your friends did. Never anything too serious. Parkour stunts, falling down stairs. Then they wanted to try something with more speed. Grabbing onto the back of a car, hitching a ride. When the car turned, you could let go and fly forward. Except you fucked up. You picked a van, one without a rear window. There was a loop of something sticking out. Just as you get ready to take advantage of the turn, it catches you. You go down, skateboard gone. Dragged, fighting to try and keep your skin from touching the road, you feel the van go over a bump. You're tossed into the air, and as you come down, knowing your face is about to meet asphalt at high speeds, you trigger.

He got a shaker power, capable of covering any amount of area. The smaller the area, the more intense the effect - which is best described as a ‘sandpaper treadmill’. A high friction effect that deals abrasion damage to things in contact with it, while dragging them in one direction.

Having spent no points in the draft, he got to roll three perks and pick two. He rolled up Power Perk 30 (Counter), which makes the power counter one of the twelve classifications very effectively, Life Perk 59 (Deep Thought), which gives him more skill points for points in his Knowledge stat but stalls/slows learning, and Life Perk 77 (Soma), which grants +1 to his choice of Brawn (raw strength), Athletics (stamina &

full-body movement), or Guts (Durability) at the cost of being slightly slower to learn/adapt new skills.

He picked Soma (boosting Athletics) and Deep Thought, before deciding to change Deep Thought out for Counter, when a skill he'd wanted didn't work the way he thought it did.

Keep this in mind for later.

Fyf is a relatively new player, and this might have been one of his first-ever sessions. I liked his character - he went out on a limb and made his character Didier/Dune gay, with an interest in his classmate Nicholas. One of his character goals was to resolve the romantic subplot. Otherwise, he was simply a Lausanne resident, at the time things started getting hairier in the city:

Wildbow The clock ticks. Every eye in the high school classroom is glancing at it, or they're peeking at phones. The end of the school day. When the moment comes, everyone moves - only to be stopped when the bell doesn't ring.

Instead, an announcement comes over the classroom speakers in FrenchL:

"Remain where you are. A final word before you go on to enjoy your weekend. We have been in talks with the local police, and many parents have expressed concerns about the dangers. The city is dangerous right now, there are many heroes and villains causing chaos. Your homeroom teachers have talked to you about the dangers of being too close to any of these fights, or being...

...in the wrong places. For further security, we are gathering students into groups and escorting them home."

Beside you, your friends make faces. You'd collectively hoped to do something about it.

Nicholas leans closer. "What do you think?"

Fyf I blush a little at the proximity of Nicholas' face to mine. I stutter

a little, "Err... I g... I guess we can go back together? Maybe go to the park some other day?"

As much as I love to hang out with Nicholas, I need to work on my cape skills a little. When I get good, I really hope Nicholas would be impressed.

Wildbow The announcement continues, "If you'll please progress to the front of the school, you'll find the school buses there."

With a fraction of the enthusiasm they'd had as they prepared to leave earlier, students make their way to their feet, collecting their things.

Kimmi joins you two from the seat behind Nicholas. Her brown hair is bleached and dyed at the ends, her face freckled, eyes surrounded with eyeliner. She's never one to smile. "It's like we're in kindergarten again. Do you think this is going to end any time soon? A month from now, we might still be riding home on the yellow bus."

The last member of your friend group, Alvi, is brown haired and fit, but short with a dumpy face and thick eyebrows, he remarks, "The MSBA is going to like the safety of this. They won't want to let go, once they have us in the clutches of their manicured nails."

He's referring to the local equivalent of the parent teacher association, which actually has a small amount of political clout.

His mom is treasurer.

Fyf "Well, we can certainly take a little break. We've been going a little crazy with our stunts lately. Plus, the mid-term exams are coming up. We should study."

Wildbow "You're so boring, Didi," Kimmi mutters.

Nicholas shakes his head.

As you file out of the hallway and into the front yard of the

school, you can see that buses have been lined up, and police officers are at the gates with office staff, making sure that everyone either gets handed off to parents or gets on the bus - nobody slips the net.

"Guess I'll see you guys later," Nicholas says.

Fyf

I never liked being called Didi. That is a little child's name. I didn't say anything to Kimmi, and just waved goodbye to Nicholas. As I get on the bus, the key problem that I am thinking about is how to sneak out of the house.

My mom should be home. Maybe I can convince her I need to go study at the library.

Wildbow

The bus travels a route that winds far too much for your liking. It's a five minute drive to your house, but you aren't dropped off for twenty.

The kids are antsy and anxious, they're annoyed at this condescending safety measure, and they act out. It doesn't help that some are half your age. It's chaos.

The chaos stills as the bus rolls over a series of bumps, the driver cursing under his breath in a language you don't know. Sitting toward the middle of the bus, you're able to see out the back window. A smear of bloody tire tracks, and a few loose feathers.

It's a small death, but it brings the chaos to a momentary stop. A small child cries.

You have to endure his wailing for five more minutes before you're finally dropped off. You let yourself inside, and note that the door is locked. That means your mother isn't home, and you have free reign.

A quick look around confirms that this is the case.

Fyf

Lucky! I can avoid trying to talk my way past my mom. She has a great sense of humor, so I never know when she's on to me and just indulging me.

I quickly run upstairs to my room, and put on my costume. It is nothing too fancy, just a long sleeved black T-shirt with yellow sun motif sewn on.

I've never worked with a needle before, so that took me days and many ruined T-shirts. Still, I am pleased with the final product. Maybe someday I can afford to get something better.

Wildbow ((As you don't have it on your gear list, let's see how well you did putting it together. Roll Dex & Knowledge))

((Go ahead))

Fyf I throw a balaclava and some change into my backpack, and grabbed my sandboard. I still don't know how that is really different from a regular snowboard, so I hope I didn't waste my money on it.

I decided to head over to a parking lot about 2km away. It is usually pretty empty. I'll do some test runs on my board before heading out to patrol.

On my way out of the door, I scribbled a quick note to my parents, "Out to library. Need book."

Wildbow ((knowledge check))

It's odd to be out at four o'clock in the afternoon, and not see people your age out and about, or at least, to see far fewer. You steer clear of a gang of troublemakers who have found a nook to sit and smoke in, and make your way to the parking lot. Your earlier scouting of the location was on target. It's out of the way, down a hill, and the way nearby buildings and construction are...

...laid out, it's not the sort of place where you might be seen doing your practice.

((Wits & Knowledge check))

You're apparently free and clear to give your power a test run.

Fyf I put on my balaclava and my sandboard, hoping that I don't look too weird. Then I focus my new found power on the ground beneath me, and give it a slight push forward.

Wildbow ((Ath check))

The ground shimmers, then blurs, a fog rising up from the surface, fragments of pavement flying into the air at an angle. Standing there, using only your power to push, you can't truly accelerate. You move about ten feet in five seconds, wobble, and fall, canceling your power to catch yourself rather than wiping out.

You get the impression this is doable ((prior knowledge check)), but it's going to take some effort to get good.

Fyf I felt a little silly expecting to get this on my first day. It took me at least a month to get decent on skateboarding, so why should this be any different.

Well, I could stay here and practice, but the buildup of expectation for this has left me very restless.

Maybe I can try out how my power works on people. I decide to head back to the group of troublemakers I spotted earlier. If they are up to something, I can try to stop them. Then I'll be on my way to being awesome.

Wildbow ((Mask on?))

Fyf ((Yes))

Wildbow The number of people on the streets is what you'd normally expect late at night - not in the middle of the afternoon. You're a little disappointed in the lack of success with your sandboard, but a few hours of effort put into it every day, and you might have a sense of it after a couple of weeks.

((Wits check))

The nook where the kids were is empty, but you do manage to spot them heading down the street. Something about their

attitude is offputting. They're big for their age and they're older, and you know from word of mouth and one or two passing experiences that they're the type to shake down smaller and weaker kids who cross paths with them after school.

There are three of them, two boys and a girl, and the girl elbows the lead boy, saying something quiet that she apparently doesn't want a nearby old man to hear. The three of them enter a clothing store for teens. Trash polka designs mark the window, and an electric guitar sits in the display, to give a sense of the store's image. The stuff in there is about twice as expensive as anything...

...the kids have ever been seen wearing - and they'll steal sweatshirts and jackets off richer kids if they can get away with it.

Fyf

Seeing the group enter the store made me suspicious. By all accounts, these kids are up to no good.

However, I am also keenly aware that my mask makes me look like I'm about to rob a bank or kidnap someone. I can't exactly march right into the store. So I stay to the side while keeping a line of sight on the entrance of the store.

Wildbow

You can see the three of them gathering clothes in their arms. They're subtle about it, keeping their heads down. Nearly ten minutes pass, and one of them even enters the change room to try stuff on, perhaps to deflect attention.

As a woman approaches the counter, however, there's a signal you don't recognize. The three of them bolt for the exit - the boy in the changeroom shirtless, with a pile of clothes tossed over one shoulder.

The girl's eyes widen as she sees you, but she's got forward momentum driving her out, and it's not like there's anywhere else for her to go but forward.

Fyf

At the sight of them running, my heart skipped a beat and a half.

Without even thinking, I aim my power at the entrance to the store, and directed the flow back into the store.

Wildbow **((When you use your power, dictate dimensions; it impacts how effective it is.))**

Fyf *I aim my power at the store entrance, target the patch of ground 2m long, and wide enough to cover the entire door.

Wildbow **The path you chose is fairly contained, the effect violent, the flecks and spray rising up to knee height, flying violently in the direction of the three delinquents-**

The girl stumbles into it, flips forward, and lands in the midst of the stuff, shrieking as she's rolled back into the store, slamming into the legs of the third one, the boy.

The ringleader, shirtless, clothes over one shoulder, however, manages to dodge her flying body, steps onto the ground in front of the effect, and then leaps diagonally. He lands at a patch of ground to the side of the door.

"The hell?" he asks, staring at you. He casts a nervous look back at his buddies.

Fyf I cancel my power at the door, and look at the shirtless boy. I realized that I really should have rehearsed some awesome line to say at this point, but my brain is simply blanking.

All I can come up with is, "S...Surrender!"

As I say that I prepare to use my power on the 2 meter by 2 meter patch of ground beneath him as soon as he moves.

Wildbow **It takes your power a fraction of a second to kick into effect, and he sees the space warping, leaping to one side. He lets clothes fall to the ground, and they get caught by the effect, ripped, torn, abraded. He closes the distance to you, though not so quickly that he can do anything - he's only a foot or two away, and seems intent on tackling you**

The strip of stores in front of you is set on a hillside, a railing

is behind you, tall and strong enough to catch any cars that hit it, a slope behind. To your left, there's an incline, leading up the hill, and to your right, there's a slope leading down.

The girl is screaming, howling in pain. The skin of her face and neck is ragged, some of her scalp scraped away.

Fyf I've been in one or two fights before, but still I'm not used to see someone charging straight at me. Forgetting my power, I dart off to my right, deaf to the screams of the girl.

Wildbow ((Roll ath))

You manage to stay just ahead of him, but only barely. He's on your heels, and he's angry enough to hurt you. His buddy has exited the store, but is about ten feet away. Shirtless lunges and grabs for you.

((Roll 1d6, add combined bonuses from highest of two of the following: Brawn, Dex, Ath))

He grips your costume front, and hauls you down to the ground, his weight on top of you.

"Fucker! Fuck you!"

The girl continues to scream in the background. It's a ragged, piteous scream. The shoplifting forgotten, you can see people rushing to her aid.

((You're in a grapple, you need to make a brawn roll to take any physical actions))

Fyf Panic rises in my head as I found myself on the ground. I target my power at the left foot of the shirtless boy, aiming the 2 foot by 1 foot patch of ground up the hill.

Wildbow The guy isn't in heavy contact with the ground - your power is intense as it flares up, but while you shove his foot aside, kicking it up and away, and apparently cut through the toe of his shoe, making him wince, it's not something that's going to dislodge him.

"Bastard!" he shouts. He lifts you up and slams your head down against the ground.

((Brawn roll))

Your thoughts are scattered as stars flash behind your eyes with the impact. He's strong, he knows how to knock people around, it seems.

((Confused, 1 round))

((Also minor wound))

Fyf Completely disoriented, I lash out with my power, trying my best to push the 5 yard circle of ground under me down the hill.

Wildbow **((Roll wits))**

Your choice of location is off-center. You fling the two of you into the railing, in the general direction of the slope. The two of you roll, and your attempt to break away fails, as he maintains his grip on you. You teeter at the brink of a long, shallow slope. If you start rolling, you'll probably keep rolling, without some effort on either of your parts to stop.

Disoriented as he is, he manages to heave you up, then tries to slam you down again. You manage to avoid having your head smashed this time around.

The other kid is catching up with you.

Fyf Slightly regaining my senses, I realize that I am not strong enough to beat him in a tussle. I try to time his actions, waiting for him to try to heave me up again before using my power on the 2 feet patch of ground beneath his foot. I hope that this will work better this time.

Wildbow **He's watching for further shenanigans. He pulls his foot back out of the way, then reasserts his grip-**

You're caught in a perpetual tussle now, his weight pinning you down, body pressed against yours, face inches from yours, both of you trying to hurt the other and failing, beyond

the initial scrapes and bangs.

His friend appears at your side, and takes a kick at your head.

You pull away enough to avoid getting more than a boot-mark on your balaclava.

Fyf "Shit!" I cursed as the boot scrapped my mask. There is no way that I can fend off the two of them. I begin to push the 5 yard patch of ground under us down the hill, while trying to roll along with it.

Wildbow The guy who was standing by your head has his feet knocked out from under him. He goes down, landing on the patch, yelping, before he tumbles down the hill. The shirtless bully, however, manages to control your mutual fall, keeping you on the bottom as you ride through the patch, rolling as you hit the slope.

((roll brawn & guts))

The slide down the hill didn't hurt you, thanks to your personal protection from your own power, and he attempts to get a grip on you. This time, you find the leverage to fight him off. You've reached the base of the hill.

((To clarify: he's still on top of you, but you kept him from hurting you again or getting an attack in))

Fyf With the boy still on top of me, I can't move away. In my desperation, I reached out to grab his head with my hands and tried to headbutt him in the face.

Wildbow ((Roll brawn))

He pulls his head away as you make the attempt, and you barely graze him. He takes advantage of your shifted position, then slams your head down hard against the ground.

Again, stars explode behind your eyes. It hurts twice as

much because it's a second time it's happened.

((confused, 3 rounds this time))

((2nd minor wound))

The kid who'd fallen and skidded down the hill a distance away flips himself over, sitting on his ass, trying to get his bearings. His buddy and the group ringleader, with back and body covered in scrapes, seems to have the edge for the moment.

A car appears on the street you're fighting on, wanting to go up the hill. It stops a distance away from you, pointed your way. The horn honks.

Fyf **The pain in my head is so sharp that I can't see straight. But I realized that I'm not in any shape to try to fight the boy off. So I forced my body to go limp against the ground.**

Wildbow **He takes advantage of your weakness to lift your head up and slam it down again.**

((roll guts))

The pain in your head redoubles.

((roll guts to stay conscious))

A man gets out of the car. "Hey! You brats! Out of the way! Fight somewhere else! I almost ran you over!"

((You manage to stay conscious.))

Fyf **Hoping that the man can distract my assailant for a moment while I recover, I close my eyes and pretend to unconscious.**

Wildbow **((Roll social))**

"This masked fucker hurt my friend! He messed up her face!" the shirtless boy says, pointing up the hill.

You can't see the reaction of the man by the car.

Fyf For the moment at least, I'm not being attacked. I open my eyes just a crack to get a sense of how the shirtless boy is standing.

Wildbow **He's straddling your lower body, hands on your shoulders, one knee on your stomach and one foot on the ground. Were you to use your power alone on the foot, as you've tried before, you probably wouldn't dislodge him.**

"I got him pinned. If I let him up he might get away," Shirtless says. There's some emotion in his voice. "Go up, go see, she's fucking messed up!"

The emotion seems to be the wrong sort, though. The man in the car doesn't seem like he's buying it or interested.

"I want to get home," he says.

Fyf "He's a shoplifter." I croaked. "Tried to steal, and I tried to stop him."

Wildbow ((Roll social))

"He hurt my friend!" Shirtless cuts in.

The man by the car seems to lose patience. As another car pulls up behind, he strides toward you two, somewhat menacingly. Shirtless backs off, getting off you.

He stands, leaving you on the ground, backing off ten feet, glaring.

Fyf I climb to my feet. "We'll get out of your way." I turn back to look at the shirtless boy, gauging what he's going to do.

Wildbow **He's standing by the railing, clenching his fists, muscles in his arms and shoulders (he actually has muscles) standing out. You aren't positive that he won't charge you the second the cars are out of the way.**

Fyf I move to the side of the road and back away from the boy slowly. If he charges me, fine. I have some payback to offer. I prepare to use my power on the 3 yard wide by 3 yard long patch of ground the moment he starts to move towards me.

Wildbow He looks like he's getting the courage to move. The moment it seems like he might, the car screeches to a stop at the top of the hill, where you were fighting before tumbling down the hill.

Your head and Shirtless' head turn- and in the next moment, your mind is blasted with images. Everything disappears, dwindling away.

You see darkness, deeper and thicker and emptier than anything you've ever experienced... yet it somehow feels familiar.

There are things in the darkness, not swimming, not floating, but drifting, empty, colliding with one another.

Your perspective shifts. You're moving, flying through that darkness. The only way you can tell you're moving is that you're moving past the things that float in it. Past others like you, past rock and fragment and dust.

When you come to, you stagger, the shift in momentum too much to wrap your head around. You're still a bit out of it from the cracks to your head.

The guy is charging, halfway across the street, past the patch of ground you'd hoped to hit, taking advantage of your moment of weakness.

You can hear the girl above, screaming. Except it's an angry scream now.

Fyf Out of balance, I crouch on the ground, and use my power to push me backwards instead. I target the strip of ground starting beneath my feet and ending 5 yards behind me.

I prepare to jump to the side the moment the boy got too close.

Wildbow ((roll athletic x2))

Still wobbly, you use your power. You lose your balance, but you move away. The boy stops shy of following you or

stepping on the treadmill.

His head turns. At the top of the hill, the girl has appeared. She's rippling, skin flowing and sloughing, pouring off her but not running out or flaying her. The wound seems to be the source of the outpouring. She's still screaming, clutching at herself, and periodically thrashing.

Fyf I stop for a moment to catch my balance, trying my best not to stare at the girl. I really don't like where this is going, or what she could possibly do.

But first, the closest threat is the shirtless boy. Again, I prepare to use my power the moment he tries to move towards me.

Wildbow He bolts for you.

The ground sweeps his feet out from under him. He tumbles hard.

As with his friend, it's his face that connects with the ground. The effect is less pronounced, unpleasant to be sure, but less pronounced. He's cast back and away from you.

The girl begins making her way down the hill. You can see how the flesh is spilling out around her feet, forming a growing puddle beneath her.

((Wits check))

Your focus is on Shirtless and the girl, and you miss the third one, the one that's fallen at virtually every opportunity. He throws himself at you, and you notice too late to do much about it, except try and defend yourself.

((Defensive roll))

He drives his knee into you as you're getting up from the ground. He knocks you back, and leaves you reeling for further footing.

He's only a few feet away to your left, shirtless is across the road in front of you, and the girl is coming down the hill, sixty

or seventy feet to your left. Storefronts stand behind you. None of the three can be totally ignored.

Fyf At this point, despair is creeping into my mind. Running away seems like an increasingly tempting idea.

I follow the momentum of the strike and fall to the ground. I target the ground right beneath me and push myself to my right for 10 yards to get away.

Wildbow ((guts roll))

Wildbow Darkness shifts at the edges of your vision. You're on your last legs.

Wildbow The three advance, very carefully, Shirtless with one hand to his bleeding face, weight close to the ground, to better have his balance if you use your power again.

Fyf I continue to use my power on the ground beneath me to push myself away from the group. I target one 5 yard strip at a time to move away faster.

Wildbow The girl screams, breaking into a run. She seems to be figuring out how to move with this puddle of flesh around her, gradually picking up speed, until she's moving a little faster than someone can while running.

She pulls ahead of the others, but you pull ahead of her.

You're faster, more mobile, and are soon able to round a corner, putting distance between yourself and the group.

You flee the situation, and make a ready escape

Fyf Even after I lose sight of them, I continue to use my power. The fear from almost dying continues to haunt me.

Before I realize it, I am in Nicholas' neighborhood. I stop by the curb outside his house and take off my mask.

I don't know why I came here, and I certainly don't know what to do next.

Wildbow ((you're still wearing your costume shirt, btw))

Fyf I sit down on the curb and put on my jacket. Then I just start to stare off into space.

Wildbow Time passes, cars pass. You can hear conversation from inside Nicholas' place. It's a house, two stories but narrow, in a very quaint style. There's no car in the driveway, but there is a garage that could be housing one.

It's winter, after all. It's likely.

Fyf I take out my phone from my bag and texted Nicholas, "Hey"

Wildbow A minute passes before Nicholas responds. -Hey-.

Fyf Indecision wells up inside me. What can I say? That I am a total failure?

That I need some assurance?

Wildbow ((interrupting))

He texts.

-Was hoping someone would have the courage to ditch the bus and the people at the gate. We could've all hung out.-

Fyf Courage. The words sends a sting straight to my heart. Today, I fought like a coward, and ran away like a coward.

I texted back -Sorry. I'll try to be better-

With that, I came to a resolution. I need to get better. I need to improve. I need to figure out how to be a hero and fight effectively.

I stand up and started to walk home.

Wildbow -lol don't be lame- he texts you

((anything you want to do with your evening?))

Fyf ((patch myself up without alerting parents. Not sure if that is worth doing?))

Wildbow You make your way home. You turn the knob prior to putting the key in the lock, and you note that it's open

Your parents are home. You still have your stuff with you

Fyf I sigh to myself. One more thing that I have to deal with.

I walk around to the back of the house, and stashed my sandboard away behind some shrubs.

I'll come back to get it later in the night. Then I zipped up my jacket to cover up my costume. Hopefully, this will be good enough.

I walk back to the front door and walk in, ducking into the bathroom as quickly as I can.

Wildbow ((Dex check))

You open the door a crack, see your mom in the kitchen, and dart up the stairs to the bathroom the moment she's out of sight. She calls your name, but she didn't apparently get a good look. "Didier!"

Stepping into the bathroom, shutting and locking the door, you get a glimpse of yourself in the mirror

There are dark bruises around your eyes, akin to black eyes, but not from a direct blow. Your eyes are bloodshot, your nose, lips and ears discolored.

Too many blows to the head. You look like an alcoholic after a binge drink.

Smaller scrapes cover the rest of you.

Fyf I shouted back, "Need to use the bathroom!" I hope this will buy me sometime.

Well, first things first, I need to disinfect the scrapes. I open the medicine cabinet and start working on the biggest wounds.

Wildbow ((roll dex x3 and know x3 for brevity's sake))

The work is quick, if nothing else. You tend to the scrapes, you pop some pills, checking the labels, and do what you can so your entire head won't swell up tomorrow.

The black circles around your eyes, however, are harder to fix. You don't know what you can really do about them. Whatever you do, you're going to have to face the music with your parents.

Fyf I take a deep breath to compose myself. I walk out of the bathroom, and called out, "Is dinner ready?"

*call

Wildbow "Soon!" your mom responds. She's clattering in the kitchen. "Can you set the table? Your dad will be home any minute."

Fyf "Sure!" I walk to the cabinet to grab the plates and utensils, casually facing away from my mom.

Wildbow It would be ridiculous to assume that you can keep it from your parents indefinitely. Your mom gets a look at your face, then does a double take. She grabs your chin and moves your head to get a better look.

"What happened!?"

Fyf I jerk away from her touch. "Nothing. Slipped on something and hit my head. No big deal."

Wildbow ((Social roll))

You have a quiet and reserved personality, and your parents are the same. Your mother's concern is apparent, but she doesn't say a word.

Your father arrives, and you note how she meets him in the hallway, to speak with him in hushed, concerned tones, but neither confront you directly. You eat dinner, and then go to bed as you normally might.

Sleep goes a long way to mend the aches in your head. It's the weekend, your day is free, but you know the parents of

the MSBA - the 'mafia' of the parent-teacher association - have been calling around, warning parents. It's up to you what you want to do with your weekend.

((Minor wounds healed, parental relationship down, some bruises remain))

Fyf I haven't forgotten the girl with the pooling flesh. I check the internet for any news regarding her or the incident yesterday.

Wildbow ((Knowledge roll))

A search of parahumans in your area suggests that someone bearing her general description attacked some people in the evening after you got away. Things quieted down for a stretch, then there was a ruckus at the school. Authorities and teachers are trying to decide what to do if she isn't gone by the time the weekend comes to a close.

Fyf I am highly reluctant to head into a fight without figuring out a few things first. I reflect on how I did in the debacle yesterday.

First, I am not strong enough to hold my own in a scrap. Given that my power doesn't have a short range limit as far as I can tell, I should definitely try to keep my distance.

Second, moving is my strong suit. I should definitely moving on my power, be it on a sandboard or on foot. I should definitely practice that for a few hours each day.

Third, protective gear for skateboarding would have helped me yesterday. I will bring them the next time I go adventuring.

No. I will not confront the girl today. I need practice.

I head out to the same parking lot as I did the last time, bring my sandboard and my costume in my backpack.

Wildbow ((Wits check))

((Any particular plans or techniques you have in terms of your exercises here?))

Fyf ((Coordinating my power with my movement on a sandboard. Just moving forward at first, then controlling speed and direction.))

Wildbow ((Athletics rolls x4))

It's doable, you're certain, but in terms of learning, a full two hours spent is not making much headway. You can make it a short distance, but you inevitably fall. You try adjusting speed, relying on forward momentum to keep you upright, but even that fails when you try to chain fields together. There's a way to 'get' this, but it's eluding you for the moment.

Movement in the corner of your eye makes you startle. Your feet are in the sandboard, you've just lost your balance, and you hit the ground.

The building in construction next door is surrounded by fence and boards.

The girl hops down from the top of the fence, touching the ground.

Her face is still torn up.

"They said you were here," she calls out.

Her body language screams hostility, but she's not using her power.

Fyf I curse at myself. Of course I am going to get spotted if I keep returning to the same place.

No use talking to her. If I were in her position, I wouldn't let me go easily. I use my power on the ground beneath to push myself back as fast as I can, so I can get sometime to get the sandboard off my feet.

Wildbow You put considerable distance between you, but only after you arrive do you see the other two. Approaching at an angle. They've formed a triangle around you, and now you're between the two, a looming building barring any further

progression in getting away.

Fyf As fast as I can, I try to unclip my shoes from the sandboard. The moment they come too close I'll use my power to push myself forward again.

Wildbow ((Doing what with the sandboard?))

Fyf ((Removing the clips that strap the board to my feet))

Wildbow ((No, are you leaving it behind, carrying it? Taking a second to strap it onto your back?))

Fyf ((oh, carrying it))

Wildbow The boys charge, you zip away, moving closer to the girl. As you do, she uses her power. She's better at it now. She spreads out, extending skin to fill a 100-foot radius, still expanding. It looks like you might slide right into it.

((Athletics check, whatever else you do))

Fyf I have no idea what the skin does, and I do not want to find out by rushing into it. I change directions on my power and move directly toward the smaller of the two boys.

*extending my power past his feet.

Wildbow You're zig-zagging back and forth, trying to keep your distance while they close in on you, and you make your way toward the boy who'd been knocked around the most. Shirtless' pal. He doesn't look as strong. You see he has a makeshift weapon.

As the power reaches his feet, he moves-

and isn't strong or fast enough to fight the 'current'. He tumbles, and flesh tears on contact with the surface. He's down, and the initiative is yours as you draw close to him.

The pool of flesh is extending to cover the entire surface of the parking lot.

((Another scarring wound for one of the kids))

((Except shirt protects))

((Partially, now that I reread))

Fyf My top priority is not being cornered or trapped so I direct myself toward the street. As I move past the boy on the ground, I take a swipe at his face with the edge of my sandboard.

Wildbow ((Roll brawn, flip a coin))

He sees the board coming, and kicks at it, knocking it away before it can slash at him. You slide past him.

The girl is in the center of the parking lot now, and the flesh has extended around, sweeping past you.

You hear a crunch, a violent rumble, and she hauls up chunks of pavement bigger around than you are tall, one half of their surface covered in flesh, the other half pavement, with uneven tar and grit and rocky bits stuck to them. As she raises them into the air - five individual pieces, one of which stands between you and your exit from the lot, you notice that you have company.

On the building under construction, and atop the building just beside you, opposite that building, and even atop a truck on the street, there are individuals. Standing, watching.

Three of them have power armor. Four of them don't.

You realize who the 'they' is that she mentioned.

Who told her where you were.

Fyf Power armor?! Aren't some of them being given out to capes for some reason?

I really don't think I can fight off 7 people, at least 4 of whom have powers. I stop using my power and raise my hands into the air.
"Ok. I'm willing to talk."

Wildbow She lobbs a chunk through the air in your general direction.

((Defensive roll))

The section of pavement shatters, cracking into a hundred pieces. You thought you were safe, but the collision was violent enough that flecks flew through the air. Even a near-miss could do some damage.

It doesn't seem like she's willing to talk.

Fyf Fear and adrenaline course through my veins at the chuck of concrete flew past me.

I can't let her throw the projectile around freely. I use my power to move back toward the boy I knocked down, again extending the effect past the ground under him.

If I get close to him, perhaps she wouldn't dare throw the rocks.

Wildbow He tries to move, but his balance is poor. He staggers, moving away from you as he's pushed by the effect.

The distance between you two aside, she seems confident enough to try hurling another piece of rock at you

((Defensive roll - failed. Her attack roll was horrible, but his dodge roll was as bad as it gets.))

The missile sails through the air. Your footing is off, given your slide, and in your effort to move in haste, you move directly into the path of the projectile, which almost inevitably would have missed anyway.

[At this point I roll a d3 to determine the damage severity. 1 = moderate wound, 2 = two moderates, and 3 = critical. I roll a 3.]

It catches you in the side. Heart, lungs, back, ribs, everything hurts in a way that blows any other pain you've felt out of the water.

You collapse. You're conscious but you wish you weren't. You'd heard you were supposed to go in shock after taking

damage this serious, but you're not feeling it. There's just unbelievable pain.

She lifts herself up, on a pillar of her own skin, and draws closer. Apparently she wants to look in your eyes as she finishes you off.

((Caved in chest - Athletics, Brawn, Dex, set to 0. Can't move. Can sort of speak & can use power. Dying.))

Fyf They say that when you are dying, your life flashes past your eyes. There is no such reprieve for me. There is only pain.

There is no room for any other emotion. Anger, hatred, regret, shame, none of that matters.

I can only feel pain, as I am sure she felt when I attacked her yesterday. As I look into her eyes, I mouth the word, "Sorry"

Wildbow "I'm not," she says.

Something big comes down on top of you, and all goes dark.

////

Afterword: Characters who die in my campaigns fall into one of two categories: the first group is the one that performs suicidal actions. Trying to run past the guy you know has some Thinker thing going on with his baseball bat, trying to run past the guy with giant scythes on his arms. Trying to fly over the group of 12+ men, most of whom have guns. Thwack, shwack, bang bang x8, respectively, character injured (or left reeling) and summarily finished off.

The second group runs. They try to avoid the conflict, but they forget to solve it. Weaver Dice (and combat in Worm) is fundamentally about problem solving. The second group avoids the problem until the problem solves -them-. Panic, try to run, avoid, avoid, until the enemy catches up with them and they get taken down.

Remember how I said to pay attention to the 'Counter' perk? I expected this particular parahuman to be a chance for Fyf/Dune to show off. He's a shaker that counters shakers, and had he used his power on her once, he would have discovered that his power effectively removes other shakers' power over an area. Grue's darkness gets

swallowed up/pushed away, Skidmark's skids get wiped out, Annex's control gets forced off an area, and Miss Skincrawl here loses her grip on whatever she's holding. But he never used his power on her. He never fought back.

I brought her close to him at the end, one last shot, in hopes that he'd try to hurt her, realize what he could do, and even take her out before he died, with three or more rounds to do it, depending on how lucky he was with his rolls (and once he beat her, bystanders could rescue him). But no.

A missed opportunity.

First character dead in this version of Lausanne.

SCG/Armada - Lausanne

‘Down’ Arc - 1.4

SCG is a veteran member of Weaversdice (and a channel mod), and a returning member from the old Lausanne campaign, where he had a single session, by my recollection. He takes a role as someone with a little bit more background; he’s been in Lausanne for a while, and he’s only just hitting his stride as the campaign restarts, with some tinkering done and the starting point of a workshop built. His trigger event is as follows:

A long time business owner from a family of traders, you are forced to ship vital machinery across the ocean. Again and again your ships are sunk, Leviathan they say... but you cannot help but grow paranoid, surely an Endbringer couldn't be the cause, not so often, not when so many others got the goods they shipped though. So many ships you've sent, so many men sent to their deaths for equipment that you need, your business running down as time after time you try. And time after time, you fail. Until the day you are forced to file bankruptcy, and all your business prospects crash into fine dust. You trigger during the nervous breakdown which ensues.

He developed into a tinker, as mentioned above, with a specialty on ‘toy soldiers’. Except these soldiers are far from being toys, and are effectively humanoid drones, life-sized, largely restricted to medieval equipment. He can build some stuff outside of the drones - simple guns and bodysuits, as well as workstations and the like to augment his duties. As a beginning tinker, however, he’s got to unlock options, and he’s got to get over the hump when it comes to the issue of resources - until he surpasses it, he’s working with subpar creations and gear.

He’s convinced it wasn’t Leviathan, but sabotage, and perhaps a touch unhinged, too prone to take extreme measures, he’s got a running subplot of trying to get answers and revenge. In theme and style, he’s taking after Napoleon, except he’s 6’1” and heavysset.

SCG has the power flaw 'Wheel', from the old list (22 options, I'm working on 78 for the new list, more than halfway through); it didn't come up this session, but inspiration can fail him, he can sit down to work, and instead of building something new, he ends up building more of whatever it was he built most recently. I sorta want to reroll/redo it, now that I think about it, if I can figure out a good way to approach it. Hm...

This session doesn't touch on any of that, though, instead, we find him in his workshop, contemplating his next step...

Wildbow

The machines march on. Metal slides against metal, in precise fittings and cusps, engines whirring. It's the drone of a hive, but your 'bees' are mechanical men, faces overly simple, bodies long and narrow, naked. Here and there, you see where metal is scuffed and scratched. Some of it is incidental - falls and damage undertaken when busy at work. Some seems more intentional. A bullet hole.

You sent fifteen of your soldiers from the empty boathouse-turned-workshop to the city, collecting scrap and odd pieces of junk. The metal scrap collects in one corner of your workshop, and you look up from your work to observe, making note. Three of your machines are out of circulation. They haven't returned from their trip out into the city.

[SCG takes 30 minutes to notice I started the session]

SCG

((...I am so sorry.))

I look over my materials. Someone is attacking my drones, and that takes priority over other plans. I need them to be able to defend themselves.

Weapons.

They need weapons.

Wildbow

You have twelve soldiers, and you have your tinker workbench, which is tilted toward metalworking, long

and flat enough for a single soldier to lay across it, with arms to move them to and from adjoining counters. The pile of metal rises up to your shoulder, two strides across. Each returning trip is an armload and some have bags for more. It's been tireless days for them. You try to...

...assess the metal, lifting the occasional piece to get a better look underneath.

The higher technology is set to one side. Microwaves, old laptops, discarded burner phones, and calculators, among other things. Circuits, circuit boards, and the occasional precious data storage unit.

The trick with building weapons isn't just creating tools in the right shapes, but adding something to each soldier's head to enable it to use that weapon with any facility at all. You'd go through as much as a fifth of the raw metal you have on hand and half of the circuit components, simply eyeballing it.

SCG ((just one weapon and one head add-on uses that much? Just to clarify))

Wildbow ((the numbers above would be to outfit all your existing soldiers))

SCG ((Thanks.))

Outfitting all of the soldiers would be problematic. A waste of resources.

It might actually be more beneficial to make guards. Combat drones with weapons, as escorts.

4 escorts, 2 with sabers and 2 with bows.

Hopefully, I have the resources.

Wildbow Extrapolating into raw terms, making notes on your sheet, you have fifty 'scrap' and ten 'circuits'. Two separate sets of weapons is harder to make than one larger set, and would cost 5

scrap and 2 circuits each. The soldiers would be 2 circuits total, and 5x4 scrap - 20 in all. To total it all up, ballparking, you estimate 30 scrap and 6 circuits.

SCG Expensive, but probably necessary. But to make it all work...a bodysuit. One capable of controlling the drones in line of sight. If he's using this many resources...he's going to have to make sure they're utilized properly. It might be time to enter the field.

Wildbow Gauging, 15 scrap, 5 circuits. Quality would depend on your personal craftsmanship, and you're suspicious you'd need something more particular to express the broadcasts. A more expensive component, something radioactive, which you could tune for wavelengths. You could do without, but quality would suffer.

((Exact component needed depends which suit, since you weren't clear))

SCG ((Tactician))

Wildbow ((Then something radioactive, yes))

SCG ((Tried to be clear via details, sorry about that.))

SCG ((Can I roll know to try to figure out where I could even find a component like that?))

Wildbow ((Knowledge))

The first option would be to make your own - Uranium or the like could be found anywhere, then refined, if you were willing to buy or make the tools to find it and refine it. The other option... perhaps a school or particular business. It's not exactly common knowledge.

SCG He looks at his workbench, assessing the cost of something that could refine Uranium, using both his savings and the materials here.

Wildbow ((knowledge check))

SCG ((failure ;_:))

Wildbow **It's hard to gauge. This isn't your field of expertise. You could check more specific resources, but for obvious reasons, the resources online for refining radioactive material are restricted to schools, if available at all.**

Wildbow **You -could- build the initial bodysuit and adjust it later, at a higher overall cost in scrap.**

SCG Luckily, most schools have shitty security. As long as I can gain access to their network, I should be able to gain access to the information that I need.

Maybe a data-trinket would do the trick.

Wildbow **2 circuits, 2 scrap, same as the other trinkets**

SCG He'll fake being a technician at one of the schools. He's too old to be a student, after all.

He starts looking into the schools, to figure out which one has the worst overall security.

((Internet research))

Wildbow **((Dex & Knowledge roll))**

A trio of machines return, adding some scrap to the pile. It's up to you if they go out again, and whether they should travel the same path to do so.

((Your research doesn't turn up anything. You'd be flying blind - security is an obscure subject anyway))

SCG The machines are done, for now. In fact...this whole setup is making less and less sense, the more Armada thinks about it.

He has a tractor trailer, a possible mobile command center.

Why should he be staying in one place, when he's constantly sending out collectors that could be followed?

It's time to pack it all up. Move to a new location. No need to escalate and waste resources, when he can simply move for now.

He gets to work re-making the tractor trailer into a mobile command center.

Wildbow ((What modifications, specifically?))

SCG ((Making sure the trailer itself is powered enough for his needs, can be used to create more drones. Maybe something that allows him to disguise the trailer better, if he can.))

Wildbow **A quick investigation of the trailer suggests it could house a generator and the workbench created earlier could be moved within. The trick comes with the management of scrap and resources - it's not cramped within, not exactly, but it's not spacious enough for drones to be marching in and out with loads of scrap or other resources, and more resources will be needed sooner or later. The...**

...outside is disguised enough by virtue of being unchanged at this point, barring any further modifications and perhaps a need to hide any exhaust from the generator, but it would be cold, and a space heater would be needed too.

SCG ((Could he elongate it with the scrap?))

Wildbow **((Yes, but that's a craft check, and failure would impugn privacy/disguisability.))**

SCG ((Sorry, I might drop this too if it becomes too obviously expensive/difficult to manage. I don't want that to become a theme, asking about ideas then quickly abandoning them once they seem untenable, but that kind of seems to be what tinkers do...))

If he can't make the trailer a fully functioning base, he can still at least use it as a temporary one when his drones are collecting. The resources will be brought back to this more permanent base afterwards.

He gets to work on 4 saber using combat drones, and his tactician-styled bodysuit.

Wildbow **((Craft check for bodysuit))**

SCG ((assuming dex))

Wildbow ((Dex & Know))

SCG ((kk))

Wildbow The work on the bodysuit goes quickly, but the quality is not entirely what you'd want. The saber-using combat drones are a little slower to build, but the workbench helps, sliding them out of the way and helping to shape the metal and keep them uniform in shape and style.

You take a moment to pull your head out of the tinkerstate, and muse over what exactly you want your suit and drones to look like.

SCG The drones should be pirate themed. They are made for plunder, after all.

For the suit...Something akin to Napoleon's typical battlewear, with a facemask to obscure his identity.

((<http://img.radio.cz/pictures/osobnosti/napoleon.jpg>))

((The hat is necessary))

((Assume welder's mask for the face-obscuring))

((For the record, I know Spanish and English, as a character.))

And finally, if I have the resources...

One more saber, for myself.

Wildbow The saber design that rolls around in your head is different from the sabers you'd be equipping them with. Those weapons would be keenly honed melee weapons, while the more complex saber would house energies and elements that could charge it up and make it more than your typical weapon.

Out of the 53 scrap and 11 circuits, you've used 51 scrap, and all but a lone set of circuitboards, not enough for the more complex saber, though you could try your hand at crafting an ordinary

one. The drones lie on the various tables, once places for boats to be set down on, racked up floor to ceiling, now modified into crude counters. While letting the workstation computers boot up and...

...load up the prompts, you check the status on your suit. It extends out to 100', line of sight only. It's up to you to decide what their priorities are for determining what an enemy is, how they operate. Simple rules for when they're not in your range.

SCG An enemy is someone who attacks a drone, or myself. Or whoever I say it is. I am never an enemy, no matter what. For now, an ordinary saber is fine for myself. [and the creations]

The phrase [censored] overrides these settings, and gives me full control of enemies again. After one time, the codeword changes to [redacted], with the same effect. After that, no more overrides.

Wildbow The commands are put in, spilling from your brain to the terminal in a language you don't understand, that you're not sure even a programmer would get. You hit the button, unplug the wires, and step back as the set of combat drones stand, hopping down from the table. They move experimentally, slashing at the air, before settling into a simple standing posture.

((Let me know what costume traits you chose for your bodysuit - it's tier 2.))

SCG ((Flashy disadvantage))

((Major Armor, Minor Influence + Fearsome))

The first thing I do is find out where my units were shot from. Then, we load up all of the drones and my suit in the trailer, and get close to the area before continuing.

Wildbow It's unfortunate that you don't have any of the scanning, database, or data augmentations or devices, because it leaves you largely blind in how you're operating and figuring out where your drones were hurt. You're left to use basic reasoning...

((Know roll))

You roam the area you know your drones were active, driving in circles, before you stop. You can see some tipped over trash cans and trash around dumpsters, where they were active. You could make another go of it, but at a certain point a truck passing by more than a few times might draw some attention.

SCG He stops and parks the truck, putting it in an inconspicuous location, before climbing in the back and getting his gear on and heading out with his full cadre of drones.

((Also I really hope it's night))

Wildbow ((Tis, sorry for not clarifying))

You're near the harbor. Buildings are large and traffic is scarce, foot traffic in particular. You note the presence of graffiti, a large spray painted 'z' on a wall, crossed out.

The drones file out of the back of the truck. Thirteen workers and your four combat drones. They await orders, servos, fans and systems faintly humming, eyes lit up.

SCG **((Audio or can I do it via suit?))**

Wildbow ((Suit))

SCG He instructs them to fan out, surrounding him in a V formation with him at the center. Collectors make up the bulk of it, but the second to the last drone of each of the two wings will be a combat droid. The other two are both next to me, on opposite sides.

All are instructed to point out anyone that appears to Armada, immediately.

Wildbow You move out into the harbor area. Drones move in jerky ways as they track motion, noting the presence of seagulls, perched on fenceposts and along the sides of the dock. The birds are silent, presumably sleeping, but even the tramp of feet nearby doesn't seem to disturb them.

There's a group of people on the dock, presumably workers.

People like those who worked under you, once. Back when you were an ordinary citizen. One cranes his neck to look at your regiment of machines, peering hard, as if trying to figure something out.

SCG Not who we're looking for. We move away from them and let them do their work. We're looking for the people that shot my drones. It's about time we had a parlay.

Wildbow ((Wits roll))

The streets appear to be empty. You note more of the 'z' symbols scrawled onto walls, fresher, these ones not scratched out. The villains aren't hanging out in the streets, not in winter, but if the Z signs mean anything, there might be a gang or group nearby.

Rooting out whoever did it, and it's hard not to think of them as villains, is a question of perhaps kicking up more of a fuss, knocking down doors, or asking around.

SCG They go into the building with the freshest Z, a collector first.

((Actually, scratch that.))

They go to the building with the freshest Z, and a collector knocks.

Wildbow A metal fist pounds a metal door. The sound rings out, and no reply is forthcoming. Further down the street, past a narrow lot, and at another door, someone steps out of the building, looking your way.

SCG We collectively turn towards him, all at the same time for effect. Once we're in speaking range, Armada speaks up. "I would appreciate it if we could parley."

((forgot to note we start walking towards the person stepping out.))

Wildbow ((Social roll))

Wildbow The man looks a little intimidated by the size of the mob surrounding you. He ducks back indoors.

Wildbow ((Wits roll))

Wildbow You hear running footsteps. He's bolting.

Wildbow The door slams shut before any of your people can get there. It's metal, like so many of the doors on the industrial buildings around here. There -are- windows.

SCG We knock on the door. "We mean you no harm, but ask that you meet with us, concerning a recent hostile action."

Wildbow ((Wits check))

You hear a door bang, on the far side of the building you're near. There's no response to your attempt at parley.

SCG We give chase, as a unit.

Wildbow The door locked when it closed. You could circle around, or either left or right, or use a window to try and enter.

SCG We circle around to the right.

Wildbow ((Athletics check))

You realize fairly quickly that a chase isn't going to get you anywhere. You circle around to the back of the building, and see that they went left. You're a fair distance behind a group of five grown men who are bolting in the opposite direction, and they all look fairly fit. This isn't a chase you're going to win, as it stands.

Your drones are faster, but sending them forward means they leave your range.

SCG I send five collector drones to slow them down, one per grown man. The rest of us will catch up.

Wildbow Your drones break from your triangle formation, charging, your new orders shifting in their internal priority lists. Your bodysuit broadcasts data straight to your eye, though you haven't augmented it to load up the HUD with

anything additional. You can see the drones shift to an all-out sprint. One catches a straggler, while the others charge ahead, catching all but one of the men.

Catching up isn't quite enough, however-

Two of the men are seized, tackled to the ground, while the rest pull away, kicking at the weaker drones and then scrambling away.

The drones pick themselves up, then give chase once more, disappearing from sight.

SCG Walking to the two seized men, I begin. "You might want to call your friends back, or those drones will follow them forever, or until destroyed. Probably not helpful"

"In the meantime, can I assume I have your attention?"

Wildbow ((Social roll))

One man nods, then the other.

The first shouts, calling after his buddies, but they're too far away at this point.

SCG "I'm assuming you guys have phones...Maybe try them?"

Wildbow The second man reaches into a pocket and pulls out a flip phone. He dials and raises it to his ear.

"Come on, come on," he mutters in French. He looks at you and shakes his head.

SCG "Oh well. You can text them later. In the meantime...I think we should have a little chat."

"You were the ones that shot at my drones. I have proof, so don't bother denying it. Explain."

Wildbow ((Subterfuge roll))

The man frowns, shaking his head. "We didn't! I don't know what you're talking about!"

SCG "Uhuh. For now, we're moving back to your place." The drones are commanded to drag them back to the warehouse they ran from, and we go inside via the door they bolted from.

Wildbow Overpowered by sheer numbers, they're dragged into the building.

It's a boat garage, with a focus on what seems to be fiberglass repair and glasswork. A smaller room at the back serves as a lunch room, but it seems they were drinking and playing cards before the noise you made got their attention. Cigarettes still smoulder in ashtrays.

SCG One of the drones brings them an ashtray, cigarettes still in it. "If you guys want to smoke, go ahead. I don't mind."

""I think we should start with something simple. What is it you guys do, here?"

Wildbow "We work during the day. Some nights, we drink at the bars. Some nights, we play poker here. Relax."

SCG Three of the collector bots are set to task finding illicit drugs, looking in any possible hiding places, upstairs, etc.

((Can I roll to figure out if they're bullshitting me?))

Wildbow ((Roll social & wits))

((Apparently not))

SCG "Stop bullshitting me. These are your Z's all over the place, aren't they?"

Wildbow "No," the man says. "They're all over the city. Marks. For newcomers to declare they're around, I think? Challenges. We- I thought you were one of them. We ran. There's a group up the road, who we're supposed to call if there's a problem with any of them. Vigilantes. Good guys, bought them drinks."

SCG "Obviously, I'm not one of them."

"These Vigilantes, how likely is it one of them would shoot at my drones?"

Wildbow **"I don't know?"**

SCG "Hrm."

"Your friends are likely going to them, then. Might as well cut out the middleman. Dial the number for the Vigilantes, then hand me the phone, please."

Wildbow **"If we had the number, we would have called them instead of running to go get them," he says.**

SCG "Problematic. I didn't come here for a fight, I came here to talk. I dislike using these kinds of methods."

"We'll wait for your friends and the Vigilantes. In the meantime, do you need anything? Food, water? Can I trust you not to run or try anything if I stop having my drones hold you?"

Wildbow **((Social roll))**

"Sure," the man says, warily. his buddy nods. "I'll have my drink?"

He points across the table.

SCG A drone brings him his drink. The others let go, but still surround them. It would be foolish to let down my guard completely, but autonomy of movement, with limitations, should improve things for them.

Wildbow Drones return from around the building. One carries a small baggie of weed, another a pair of bottles.

SCG Armada tosses them their weed. "Feel free to partake. I don't really judge. Doesn't seem like there would be enough to deal, here. Seems like you were telling the truth."

"You'll be free to go, once the Vigilantes get here."

Wildbow **((Wits check))**

There's a crash upstairs. Several drones raise their heads, making noises as they seem to track further noise on the upper floor. Something louder sounds outside, toward the back corner of the building.

SCG "I believe that's them arriving." The drones move aside.
"Please tell them i would appreciate a meeting."

Wildbow ((Aside from?))

SCG ((Giving the two guys a path to leave.))

Wildbow ((Social roll))

The men eye you warily, then take the offered exit.

The noise continues upstairs, and various drones of yours note the movement, heads raising and following, before returning to a resting position.

There's more noise toward the front of the building.

((Wits check))

SCG He continues to wait. "I mean no harm, and am unaffiliated.
Just here to have a meeting."

Wildbow A lance of black energy strikes down from above like a lightning bolt, very narrowly missing one of your combat drones. A second follows, a split-second later, and spears one of your worker drones, catching it down the middle, impaling it.

looking up, you see that the ceiling is riddled with portals. Each one has a spear emerging from it, matching the ones that just fell. Another opens, closer to the stairs, as you watch.

It's pretty apparent it's about to start raining.

Whoever's upstairs, he hasn't heard your call for peaceful negotiation, or he doesn't care.

SCG We leave through the same route as the two guys we let escape. If these guys want a fight, they're going to get one.

Wildbow As you make your retreat, more of the spears lance down from the ceiling. They catch your crowd of workers, impaling four and lightly damaging one.

Stepping out into the alley, you see another one of the vigilantes, a big man, with the two people you freed standing by him, talking.

SCG "Gonna level with you. If I see one more bolt or portal, I'm going to stop playing nice." 2 workers and 2 combat drones stay next to me, whereas the rest of my drones fan out, surrounding the three in a semicircle.

"Can we agree to a ceasefire?"

Wildbow ((roll social))

The big man pushes the two other fellows behind him, as the drones approach. You might have underestimated how intimidating an army might be, as it surrounds people. It doesn't help that your costume was accented to look just a touch more threatening.

"I don't know," the big man speaks in French. "It doesn't look like you have anything but fighting on your mind."

He raises a hand. "I would take cover."

He's pointing at a portal with a spear sticking out of it, at the side of the building.

SCG We all run towards the man, in different directions. Combat drones are to kill them all.

((Obviously focusing on the man))

Wildbow ((The big man?))

SCG ((yep.))

((Non combat drones are attacking in a way that should block combat drones from attacks, and my drones are staying in a square around me so I don't get hit while we all run.))

Wildbow **"Oh?" the man raises his voice, as the drones draw closer, sabers raised. "We're fighting after all?"**

He smacks one fist into his palm, then meets them head on-

SCG ((Interrupt.))

((Would like to say something while he's doing that))

Wildbow **((go ahead))**

SCG "I told you very clearly I was attacking if I saw another portal. Fuck you. All I wanted was a meeting, but you tried to kill me, even after I let these guys go."

Wildbow **((Four attack rolls, with +1 each, unless you're calling them off. Also, dodge/guts roll))**

One of your drones beside you takes the spear from the side of the building. Your drones hurl themselves at the man, who blocks sword strikes with overly muscled arms. He throws them off, with only scratches for his trouble.

"I know your type!" the man raises his voice. He kicks one of the combat drones-

The drone collapses to the ground, hard, chest dented.

"You get your powers, and your head works differently. You work with these machines, you start to think we can all magically communicate with each other!? Fio went ahead, he went up to the top floor, and only way he's going to hear me is if he stops to listen, and that's not how he operates!"

SCG "That's your fucking fault for sending a loose cannon against me. Quite literally."

All the drones are converging on him, trying to kill him.

Wildbow ((if you're not taking an action, you can use Command to give a drone an extra attack))

SCG ((I'm also converging on him.))

((Sword in hand ofc))

Wildbow ((roll 1d4, then 4 attack drone attack rolls and 1d4 regular drone attack rolls at -2))

The combat drones manage to get their blades in deeper this time, but not enough to do significant damage. The man is seven feet tall and bristling with muscles. You might imagine he'd be tougher than he seems, considering the clumsy, still-working-out-the-kinks attacks, but you actually did some minor damage there.

He picks up two drones-

-one wrestling its way free before he can do anything, and hurls it at you.

((dodge or guts roll))

It sails past you, dropping to the ground, lightly damaged.

Two bolts from behind spear into the crowd.

Your drones aren't touched - it's blind fire into a mob, and some shots are simply bound to land in between drones instead of striking them down.

SCG The regular drones give up attacking, grabbing at his limbs and are just content to hold him down as best they can, while the combat drones and Armada himself aim for the man's neck with their respective sabers.

Wildbow (specifically going for the head?)

SCG (Fucking ayy right.))

Wildbow ((Ok. Roll your attack roll, then combat drones, then 1d4+1

lesser drones' brawn rolls))

Two drones latch onto him, hampering his movements, while sabers swing for his head and neck-

And one of the drones steps onto his stomach, catching him right under the chin. It presses the attack, driving his head up and back as he tries to avoid having his throat slashed, and in that moment, he's left entirely open.

You're not a fighter, but you can see the vulnerability. You and every able drone get another shot at attacking him, and he's not in a position to defend himself.

((Make attack rolls))

As he thrashes and flails, you and the drones lunge in. Two strike home in ways that count. The drone at his throat twists the blade and cuts out the side, and one catches him in the exposed stomach, opening it up, sword digging into what lies beneath.

The man gurgles and topples. Without being asked, a drone cuts his throat, finishing him.

A barrage of the black spears spit out of the building behind you - three this time. One strikes down one of your worker drones.

You've got the fiberglass building behind you, and the two scared employees in front.

SCG "We're leaving, now." Armada chops off the man's head with his saber, picking it up by the hair.

Wildbow **((Brawn roll))**

Heads prove harder to chop off than you'd thought. You hack deep, but it doesn't separate.

SCG ...The drones assist, this time.

Wildbow **One drone seizes the man by the hair, the other severs it.**

The head is promptly handed to you.

More spears fly into your crowd from behind-

One worker drone falls, impaled.

SCG "Spread the fucking word. If you attack Armada, someone pays with their head. If Armada requests a friendly meeting, you give it to him."

We all run off, heading for the trailer.

Wildbow ((Roll athletics))

((And wits))

Drones notify you of movement to your left. Someone's coming, and they're fast enough that they're getting ahead of you, circling around to cut you off.

There are three vigilantes working as a team, it appears.

SCG Worker drones disperse in all directions, with the directive to distract the vigilantes and attack to kill.

Wildbow ((Roll Wits, apply Command))

SCG Combat drones follow Armada, circling around to the trailer, the long way.

Wildbow ((Roll athletic))

You reach the car, and your worker drones are scattered throughout the area. You note a blip on your radar, the HUD feeding into the lens telling you that a drone is trying and failing to take a different course of action, and turn to look and try to find it.

At the very edge of your range, a man stands, with a cowl and clawed hands that scrape the ground on either side of him. He has the remains of a drone at his feet.

SCG A combat drone is sent to kill him, while the rest of us pile into the car and leave.

Wildbow ((Roll dex -1 and attack +1))

He gets the initiative on the drone, stepping close, almost casually moving to attack, striking it down with a single swing of the claw. As a drone pulls the back door of the vehicle closed, you put your foot to the gas.

A glance in the rearview mirror suggest that the clawed, cowed man is keeping up with the vehicle.

SCG Another combat drone leaps after him, out of the moving vehicle. Lunging for a kill.

Wildbow ((Ath roll -1, dex roll -1, then attack roll +1))

The drone hits the ground running, lunging for the enemy. The cape is faster, swiping at it, knocking it to the ground.

It's a soft fall, however, and the drone moves, reaching out with blade extended, catching the cape in the ankle.

He stumbles but doesn't fall, as you and he speed away from the damaged but not defeated drone.

He's close enough that the back of the vehicle blocks your view of him.

SCG ((I have two drones left, right?))

Wildbow ((Combat drones? Yes.))

SCG The damaged drone gets the command to follow and kill the cape. A second combat drone climbs over the back of the truck, ready to pull the same maneuver as the first as soon as it sees the cape.

((Obviously smashing down on the accelerator here))

Wildbow ((I was assuming the drones were all inside the back compartment))

((Clarify what they're doing?))

SCG ((One stays, the other is tacking the guy with the saber.))

((tackling*))

Wildbow **You're not sure what's going on, but your drone remains at the back, unmoving. You can't see through its eyes, but the datafeed, scrolling text in tinkertalk, tells you that it's searching, searching...**

Is the vigilante gone?

SCG **Armada guns the accelerator. The other drone is to crawl on top of the trailer, look for this freakshow, and join Armada in the front.**

Wildbow **((Roll drone's Athletics))**

The drone reaches out for a surface to hold onto, grabs the door, weapon in its other hand, and as the door swings wide, it swings to its limit, jarring, and the drone is bounced off, sent down to the roadtop, rolling head over heels. You watch it in your side-view mirror.

You hear sounds atop the vehicle.

SCG **I dive out of the vehicle, saber and head in hand, tuck and roll while twisting the wheel in the opposite direction, into a building.**

Wildbow **((Roll athletics))**

It's a less than graceful fall, but you built armor into your bodysuit, and it catches the worst of the blow. The truck veers to the right, quickly losing speed, before colliding with a brick wall.

((Wits check))

As the dust settles, you pick yourself up. You can see the cape atop the vehicle. He apparently used his claws to hold on, and wasn't knocked aside or included in the collision. He looks rattled and lightly injured, however, and is taking a second to pick himself up, far more slowly than you are.

SCG ~~I go over to him and stab him as quickly as I can, as deep as I can.~~

((Actually, Scratch that.))

((Just realized my fat ass is not getting on top a vehicle.))

((Can I see my drones?))

Wildbow ((They're inside the cab, you can see some.))

((Also, I completely forgot the LoS restriction, haha))

SCG KILL. HIM.

((also armada is running away like a bitch.))

((I figured since I could see them in the mirror...))

Wildbow Three of your noncombat drones begin to scale the outside of the vehicle. The cape doesn't react, waiting and watching, as they make the climb-

((Roll 3x athletics, no penalty))

One reaches the top and lunges for him-

((roll attack, -2))

He elbows it aside. It falls to the street beside the truck.

The other two are making their way up. He doesn't seem committed to doing more than staying where he is.

Watching you as you run.

SCG I duck between the nearest alleyway, and keep on running.

Wildbow The head swings in your hand as you grip the hair, putting some distance between yourself and the clawed cape.

((Roll athletics))

((go ahead))

SCG He keeps dodging, changing his route with each alleyway he sees, running.

Wildbow **((Destination?))**

SCG ((Home.))

((Changing out of his gear in the alleyway before going inside))

Wildbow **There's a limit to how long you can run, and you aren't the most athletic individual. It turns out to be about five minutes. You switch to a brisk walk, pausing when your legs cramp, then switch between the running, walking, and pausing, as you make your way back to the boathouse.**

You've got virtually no scrap, only a few piecemeal bits of circuitboards, and all of your remaining drones were left behind. The ones you scattered and the ones in the back of the truck are either dead at the hands of the vigilante or making their way back here by way of their navigation systems.

You're finally able to sit down and stop, resting your legs, when you notice that the head you have is moving.

SCG I place it on the work bench. "Are you still a-fucking-live?"

Wildbow **The mouth moves, but it can't talk. No lungs.**

SCG "Blink if you understand me."

Wildbow **He blinks.**

SCG He places the head on the ground, before hacking it apart with his saber.

Wildbow **((Brawn rolls))**

You hack the head into pieces small enough that they shouldn't be able to move.

You have the remainder of the evening at your disposal,

but with your drones due to come back as their navigation allows, it's likely best you stay behind.

SCG I do so, after flushing the remains down the toilet.

Wildbow One by one, drones return. Of the twelve workers you brought, and the four warrior drones, only half return, and of those, half of -those- are damaged enough to need scrap and patching up.

The surprise comes later in the evening, as the last two damaged workers make their way back.

They drag a body with them. A glance at their running logs suggests they're trying to bring back -claws.- Metal blades attached to the hands of the vigilante cape from the truck.

Already at the table, running diagnostics on injured drones at the workbench, you feel your tinker brain at work, connecting dots, thinking. If you developed a scanner, and it's a damn shame you're out of scrap, you could run something involving the claws, seeing if there's anything special you could use.

A glance at the puddle of blood fills you with momentary disappointment. An immortal man... that was something too. Opportunity for scanning and research, inspiring better tinkering. You already know what it might have been.

Skin, at the very least. To stretch over and mask the appearance of your drones.

SCG It wasn't worth the risk. If his head was alive, his body likely was too. I definitely didn't want to deal with that knocking on my door at night.

I can try to recover the body later, if the opportunity comes up, but the important thing right now is that I got away.

"Great job, bots."

"Don't worry, I'll repair you, and build you some friends, later."

"For now...I need to gather some materials."

Wildbow **The clawed cape stirs slightly.**

SCG "...Kill him NOW."

I join in, attacking with my saber.

Wildbow **The blades sink into his back and neck. Blood pools out beneath him, soaking into the concrete of the boathouse floor.**

SCG "Too close."

SCG "Anyway, I'm going to shower, and then get some materials."

SCG "We have some work to do."

(Session end)

Antioch/Reimann - Lausanne

‘Down’ Arc - 1.5

In the Pregame session ([Session 0.0](#)), Reimann was a cape enthusiast and intern at the PRT, buckling under jealousy for the capes he’d surrounded himself with. He was scouted out to receive a Cauldron vial, visited by two Cauldron employees. There was some talk of alternate worlds and Cauldron’s plans and hopes, with the idea being that Reimann would serve in a direct or indirect position to support the new cape group, the Suits.

On choosing and drinking his vial (deciding on tinker vials, then on the biotinker vial of the ones offered), he met with an unfortunate fate, reserved for only one in twenty vial imbibers. He mutated, rolling results that were ‘severe’ and ‘horrific’, to chest, mouth, hands, shoulders, and gaining extra limbs. His stats shift, hampering his already poor Athletic ability (the stat that governs full-body movement, stamina, agility, long distance sprinting) and dialing back his Guts stat (the stat that deals with durability, willpower, ability to take damage and keep going), while boosting Brawn (raw strength).

Worst of all for our twenty-something intellectual, Reimann lost his mind. Not even needing the attention of Cauldron’s slug, he lost all of his learned skills and knowledge, and all memory of the person he used to be. The slate is wiped clean, and his wealth of learned skills in computers and other things are lost, though that is something he can rebuild.

The last thing the real ‘Reimann’ heard was Cauldron’s decision. He’d be sent to Lausanne after all, with some countermeasures to serve as a tool Cauldron could use to handle him, should he become too much of a problem.

WD_Lausanne

Wildbow The air is stale, the surroundings dark. You stir to find yourself lying prone on a tiled floor. As you rise, your body feels strange, too light, the surroundings alien.

It's a hospital, you realize, but the walls are scrawled with graffiti, and old condoms and bottles lie here and there, suggesting signs of partying. There are no lights, but

candles are melted onto every other surface.

None are lit.

A sound catches your attention, regular, hoarse, ragged. You realize it's your own breathing.

Reimann ... where am I? I need to get my bearings.

Standing on uncertain, unsteady legs, I focus on my surroundings as best I can with the inadequate lighting.

I peer closer, attempting to read the scrawl of graffiti, hopefully to find words in a familiar tongue.

Wildbow The graffiti is French, scrawls of names, random words and dates. The dates... it's only when reading them that it dawns on you that you don't know what the date is supposed to be. As you wrack your brain for reference points, something to grasp onto to give you a foothold in figuring out where you are, or even who you are, your brain instead supplies chemical chains for acids to melt...

...flesh, and designs for weapons to deliver those acids.

With your rising emotion, the ragged breathing gets louder and quicker, to the point that it belongs to something feral and twice the size of a person.

Reimann I need to control myself, tamp down the rising sense of displacement, uncertainty, and shock - find something to focus on.

Reference points.

Some kind of foothold, however unsteady.

I try to seek out the most recent painted graffiti, the freshest coat, reading it over and over again, pushing aside unwanted thoughts as best I can.

Wildbow 'Je t'aime' is written on the wall above a large, detailed stencil of a heart. Paying attention to the heart, you feel ideas

rattle through your mind, making you feel less steady, rather than more.

You instinctively raise a hand to block your view of the images and your visions of all of the devices and chemicals that would cause bleeding, and what you see is overlarge. Bone is exposed, warped and hooked, with muscle wrapped haphazardly around it, ligaments in view. The bare arm it is connected to is larger, stripped of body fat, with the muscle configuration looking wrong, an...

...excess. The tips of each finger are clawed.

Reimann I recoil at the sight, unable to suppress disgust and revulsion, unable to stop the constant inflow of devices, mechanisms, chemistries, invading my mind.

There's little I can do here, and panic begins setting in, as I search the room almost frantically for an exit.

Wildbow The door is no longer on the hinges. The way is clear, or so it seems - you feel limbs that aren't your arms touch the top of the frame, and reflexively move them back and out of the way. It takes seconds to get a glimpse of them, as they move in reaction to your body twisting and flexing. A pair of multi-jointed limbs, like a scorpion's tail, but wrapped in flesh and tipped with bone...

...spikes, jutting out from your back and shoulders.

Standing in the hallway, panting hoarsely, you see more trash, bottles, candles, and graffiti. Every other window has plywood screwed over it, and the ones that don't are dark. Thick wet flakes pound the glass, accumulating at the lower half of the panes. You shiver - you're not wearing a shirt, and the place isn't heated.

Reimann Stumbling down the hallway, I'm subconsciously grateful for an immediate, and hopefully solvable goal, as I open door after door in search of something to cover me, something to keep me warm.

Wildbow Once a hospital, the place has become a hangout for teens, and none of the teens are here tonight. You see a ward with gross blankets strewn here and there, the rooms smelling like sex, with a fainter hint of vomit and urine, that might date back to the days the hospital served its purpose, or mark the occasion of a party not so long ago.

The inside of your chest feels cold, as you draw in air. Something's wrong with your mouth and chest. You see a men's bathroom beside the ward.

Reimann I enter the bathroom, looking for a mirror of some sorts, bracing myself for the inevitable. Best to get this over with quickly.

Wildbow You pass by several mirrors which are too scratched up or painted-over to see anything in. You reach the one at the end of the row, close to the window. You make out your reflection in the gloom.



Reimann Almost immediately I react, one of the bone spikes at the tip of the extra limbs lashing out, striking the mirror.

**Wildbow Glass breaks and falls into the sink and onto the floor, around your bare feet. The moment of aggression and panic leaves you panting, the massive mouth-chest cavity rip in your face and chest expanding and contracting, but never closing completely. You can see your lungs, modified, sucking in and outputting air directly. You can see your heart beat, and you can feel the cold air washing...

...over the organs and against your bones.**

Reimann I need to cover this, I think to myself. Organs shouldn't be out in the open like this, right?

I exit the bathroom, heading back to the ward, settling for the filthy blankets, at least for now.

Wildbow You wrap the blankets around yourself, though it's hard with the limbs jutting out your back, and it's harder to breathe with the blankets in the way of your 'mouth'. Images move through your head, about masks, systems that could cover the gap and filter the air. It's oddly insistent, pressuring you in equal proportion to the confusion and fear you feel.

Reimann At this point, the pressing, continuous intrusive thoughts are far preferable to the panic and disorientation I'm feeling.

An anchor, a foothold of sorts. Something to focus on.

Let's start by putting together some kind of mask.

Wildbow You need components, but components are abundant here. It depends on the type of mask you want to build. At the core level, you'd need scrap metal, chemicals to treat it, and possibly something like a battery that you could tear apart, to get to the acids.

Reimann I start by searching the hospital for chemicals, raiding closets and

other rooms, both for medical and cleaning supplies.

Wildbow ((3x wits check)) - Reimann gets two successes and a fail.

You can find the basics of what you need, the problem is that you have trouble finding good quality versions of what you need. Building like this would get the work done, but it would be lower quality, prone to falling apart, and/or it would serve only its most basic purpose.

Reimann A plain, functional mask should do for now. Creating an improved replacement can come later, once circumstances aren't so... extenuating.

Wildbow **The plain, functional mask serves to filter the air and, as you find and disassemble an old, water-damaged laptop, you put together a crude synthesizer. Four hours pass as you do the work with substandard tools, your clawed fingertips and extra limbs serving as tools to bend and shape metal as often as anything....**

((Roll Dex & Know; Craft check)) - Reimann gets two fails.

It'll do you for a day, maybe two, but it's crude work, it's barely holding together, and it takes you time to learn to work with your altered, unfamiliar limbs. Still, there's a comfort in the building, in stepping outside yourself.

It's late in the night, and you judge that hours have passed. Given how hamhanded the work was, you gauge you took far longer than you otherwise might have.

You put the mask in place, adjust a few parts, and then connect it, clipping and hooking it onto the toothy ribs that jut out from your mangled chest. Your hoarse, ragged breathing is silenced. Air whooshes in, and the smell and taste of the filthy blankets is filtered out. Clean air.

Reimann Blessed relief of proper respiration, intermingled with the dull, comforting feeling of steady work, construction.

On to the next project, but rather than considering an end

product, I ransack the hospital for as many raw materials I can feasibly acquire, and survey the results to gauge potential projects, built from the higher-quality materials scavenged.

Wildbow ((Roll wits x5 - first three are for raw components, last two are for advanced)) - Reimann gets four successes, fails on last.

A more careful search turns up a bounty of raw materials; scrap, chemicals, and stuff you can use to synthesize advanced batteries. In terms of more advanced materials, you find things you can disassemble for circuit boards, but rare minerals are harder to come by. Figuring out what you can do, you scratch off the idea of creating life, or devising concoctions, and the various energy weapons.

Reimann Hmmm. Synthesizing toxins, acids, constructing a weapon to fire projectiles laced with the aforementioned.

Or some metallic carapace, exo-armor, protecting the vulnerable flesh beneath.

I remember the revulsion, the fear that came with seeing my reflection in the now-ruined mirror.

Perhaps an artificial exterior would do well to put the physical disfigurement out of mind.

With that thought considered, I begin construction on a protective layer of armor.

Wildbow **The initial construction goes fine, but as you get into the build you take note of the options before you. More than one design rattles through your head, some more geared for combat, some for utility. It's going to need power, as well, and there's room for modifications there, too, a defensive feature.**

Reimann For the moment, raw physical strength seems like a definite concept to head towards, to better facilitate the acquisition of further materials.

And, perhaps, as far as modifications go, imparting some of the

corrosive substances travelling through my mind - a defensive countermeasure, possibly?

Wildbow You sit down to work, rigging tubing and finding containers to distill the chemicals. The cleaner tubing you rig into the armor. You use a metal bin filled with chemicals to heat the metal from hospital beds and shelving units, and treat it with chemicals, before acid-washing it further. Layering the metal over itself, you see it start to take shape, with joints and added mechanical power.

You're three-quarters of the way done when you hear noise downstairs. A violent rapping, metal against metal.

A man's voice hollers.

((Wits check to make it out)) - Success

"Wake up, kiddos!" the man bellows. "If you're there when we find you, we're bringing you in for trespassing! Spare us the trouble!"

Reimann I give my partially finished armor a quick once-over. Is it functional, at the very least?

Wildbow The armor is functional. You estimate you could work on finishing the armor, the chemical inject, or you could leave sooner with the armor and find a better hiding place or escape route - though the latter might hamper attempts to finish up the armor, breaking stride and letting chemicals set.

Reimann I glance at the door and the room, searching for potential delays, means to stall for time - objects to be piled into a makeshift barricade, if nothing else.

Wildbow There are shelves and cabinets, it would require a little elbow grease, but you could push them across the floor.

Reimann I try to haul them over to the door, trying to avoid making as much noise as possible - drawing their attention would only serve to reduce the time it takes for them to find me, after all.

Wildbow ((Armor on or no?))

Reimann ((If I used the armor to facilitate me moving the shelves, would it disrupt the construction process? If it does, then I'd prefer to do it unaided.))

Wildbow You elect to do it unaided.

((Brawn check)) - Tied.

((Choose; make noise or don't move shelves))

Reimann ((The latter.))

Wildbow Unable to lift the shelves off the ground enough to take the weight off the little metal feet, you hear the screech of metal against tile and elect to leave it be. The attempt cost you time.

You hear more shouts, as well as bangs of what are presumably flashlights or other blunt weapons against doors or plywood.

They're moving through the building.

Reimann I continue work on the armor, as quickly and quietly as possible - electing to hop into the armor, finished or no, once the sounds of footsteps draws close.

Wildbow You tighten the joints and check the actuators before setting the onboard system to full power. It's time to see how good your work was.

((Dex and Know check; Crafting)) - one pass, one fail

They're moving through the building, banging as they go, which does you the service of informing you exactly where they are. There's at least six of them, and at least one has reached the floor you're on.

You plug the tubes into the holes in your shoulders, and feel your altered organs open up and suckle for the tubes, sphincter-like mouths in lung and heart accommodating the

medical tubing and drawing them in.

The armor locks into place, connecting to your mask.

((Tier 3 armor, +1 Brawn, +1 Athletic +1 Guts, has Armor and Heavy qualities, plus one minor advantage of your choice, you decide appearance. The chemical injectors can grant you +1 to one of the aforementioned stats, on two separate occasions. The armor is not complete.))

Aside:

Antioch was building from tables I provided. His character has ideas in his head, Antioch chooses which ones to use and how to put them together. In this case he was using...

Power Armor: Muscle

Power armor specializing on raw armor and strength.

Big + to armor, weight, boosts physical stats, tier 2 to 4 armor based on craft check, Heavy and Armor qualities predetermined, can add other features if tier 3 or 4. Can have defensive modification applied

with

Toxic Modification

Defensive gear can be activated to temporarily boost Brawn, Athletics and/or Guts, but affects long-term appearance and may cause acid burn damage to the wearer if the obvious weak spots are exploited, or when severely damaged or misfiring.

To make the Toxic Muscle power armor.

I'm a big fan of this sort of mixing and matching sort of design. There were five other power armor variants, eight weapons, and six modifications with both offensive and defensive potential (Toxic does something different when applied to offensive gear, for example). With research he can expand his repertoire.

((Tell me what it looks like))

Reimann The armor is designed to be sleek, all-covering, a far smoother and more appealing aesthetic, as far as I can get from my own disfigured, grotesque appearance.

Small fluorescent strips of light accentuate the lines of the armor, drawing attention to the body, the frame, rather than the individual within.

The armor housing the additional limbs intentionally has external actuators, pistons, so as to suggest artificiality, rather than a physical mutation.

((Privacy minor advantage)) - [conceals secret identity better, helps hide mutations in this case]

Wildbow You see the glow of the flashlight in the hallway. It disappears, presumably as he turns into an adjacent room.

His voice calls out in French, "Someone's been here! Very recent! Keep an eye out, doesn't look like the usual kids! Get upstairs!"

Reimann I walk towards the source of the voice, now clad in my newly-constructed armor, until the man enters my line of sight.

Wildbow The man was -is- a police officer, and as you step into view, he raises a gun, pointing it in your direction. More appear at the far end of the hallway, and still others are tramping up the stairs to the end of the hall behind you.

"Jean," the man closest to you says. "You have the gun?"

Another cop, apparently 'Jean', raises a rifle, aiming it at you.

((Wits check)) - Pass

Your eye for mechanics -the same eye that let you build your armor- tells you there's something unusual about the gun. It's above and beyond the usual technology.

Reimann I stand there, hands up. Let's hope this synthesizer does the trick.

"Sorry for trespassing, guys. Just scavenging for some parts."

"If it helps, I haven't seen any kids in here since I arrived."

An afterthought. "Which was, uh... about twelve hours ago, give or take?"

Wildbow ((Social roll -1)) - Gets a 0.

The synthesizer produces a scratchy, distorted voice, hard-edged in the wrong places. The man visibly flinches as you start speaking.

Small fortune the guy with the gun didn't flinch too, and squeeze the trigger in the process.

"You're trespassing, and admitting to theft," the cop closest to you says. "We've got too many of your kind running around this city."

At the mention of the word 'city', you see his badge. They're police of Lausanne, it seems.

Reimann "Okay, okay, I can see how the theft thing is a sore point, but I figured with the whole 'abandoned hospital' thing it wouldn't be such a huge issue."

"I don't have any kind of beef with you guys, and I sure don't want this to become a problem."

"Anything I can do for you? To make amends?"

Knowing & seeing how much Antioch is inclined to just steamroll past & put huge speeches out there, I remind him that his character isn't supposed to be a diplomat - he as a mutation of the mouth and a -1 to his Social stat even before the deformities.
--

Wildbow The more you speak, the worse the distortion gets. It's fine if you stop for breath, but it seems that anything longer than a

statement or two devolves into violent noise.

((Roll Social -1)) - pass.

The words are still clear, but the men don't seem particularly inclined to listen.

"Return what you took," the cop says. "Walk away."

Reimann "I'd like to patch things up between us." Stop for breath.

"But believe you me." Another pause.

"If I stepped outta this armor." Huff, puff.

Wildbow ...

RP shorthand here for 'my turn, I'm interrupting'
--

((Social roll))

Reimann "This conversation."

"Would go right down the shitter."

Wildbow ((-2 penalty, as you kept going))

Reimann ((Finally rolls, then asks - Should I reroll, or apply the penalty to the one already rolled?))

Wildbow (Apply))

Reimann ((ok))

Wildbow The men tense as you deliver each statement, the cop closest to you backs away, and the one with the rifle steps closer. You realize they're interpreting what you say as threats more than anything, as sure as if you were growling the words in their face while tapping an oversized, clawed fingertip against their chest.

((Wits check)) - passed

You spot one of the policemen in the back tapping the button on the intercom at his belt. He's trying to be surreptitious, but there's a pattern to the presses.

Reimann Doubt I can salvage this.

Oh well.

With the rifle-toting man now drawn closer, I bull towards him, hoping to take out the greatest threat from the beginning.

Wildbow He takes the opportunity to shoot-

((Defensive roll, Ath only)) - Dodge fails, armor roll succeeds

The bullet is powerful and augmented, and your armor tanks the hit. The impact is such that it would knock a grown man to the ground, but for you, it only interrupts your forward charge, leaving you to take a heavy step backward.

The other cops open fire.

Of the hail of bullets, two punch past the armor; a graze and a shot through the shoulder, which is absorbed by the armor, sparking violently, while fluids leak out. Your armor can't take any more hits like that.

((Minor wound & armor takes 1/1 moderate wound, you're personally unharmed))

Reimann For now, my priority of eliminating the man with the rifle remains the same, hoping to, if nothing else, put him out of the fight with a single blow.

Wildbow ((Roll Brawn x2)) - Pass & pass.

Seeing what you're doing, the cop you'd just been talking to intercepts you as you run past him, trying to shove you into a wall, break your stride, or just create another opportunity for his allies to shoot. You shrug him off with an almost ludicrous ease, knocking him on his ass, and close in on the rifleman. He scrambles back, moving as you swing your fists his way, hard and violently...

...enough that the air whistles.

Caught up in the melee, he's unable to get a bead on you to shoot again, but he's trying to beat a retreat, and in the process, he's blocking his allies' shots.

There are men running up the hallway behind you, but carefully so - they don't want to be in the line of fire if more shots are delivered.

Reimann I continue my forward assault, pressing through, advancing viciously, a guttural scream escaping my throat, translated by the synthesizer into an oppressive, crackling howl, fists bearing down against the fleeing rifleman.

Wildbow ((Social roll, Brawn roll))

You press the attack, and your target throws himself through a doorway, out of your line of sight. It leaves you exposed to more gunfire, though not everyone in the hallway is quick or positioned well enough to shoot

Bullets punch past armor to catch flesh as you follow the rifleman into the other room, taking cover from the gunfire.

((roll Guts))

It hurts, but you're able to hold it together. You loom over the rifleman, who has yet to get in position to fire again. He scrambles back. The cops behind you are closing in, approaching the doorway.

Reimann I lunge towards the rifleman, this time intending to leave him wounded, but intact and in my grasp - taking a hostage might be the safer way out of this situation.

((Using the chemical injectors for +1 guts.))

Wildbow ((Brawn roll))

You strike him, a large metal gauntlet straight to the chest, and take advantage of his pain and disorientation to get a firm grip on him, wrestling him around so he stands between

you and the people in the hallway.

They approach, and they stop when they see.

Reimann ((Any means of escape besides the door?))

Wildbow The room is a doctor's office, with a disused padded table (with pornography plastering the wall above it), cabinets, a shelf that once held medical supplies, now holding little of use, and a few stray bits of clothing here and there. The only light is from the windows behind you, moonlight filtered through frost and snow. The only exits are the door and the 2nd floor windows behind you.

Reimann Holding the man between myself and the other cops, I back towards the window slowly, his neck in my hands, ready to hurl myself and him out of the window at a moment's notice.

Wildbow "Think about what you're doing," the lead cop speaks, voice calm, "There is no way you look at all of this and think it is okay."

Reimann "No choice."

"Sorry about this."

"But good or no."

"It's your choice whether this guy dies."

Wildbow The cop raises his hands, the gun now dangling from the triggerguard. "We can let you go, but you have to let him go. We can't let you take him."

Reimann ((Can I Soc roll to glean some of his intentions?))

Wildbow ((Sure, use your nat penalties))

Reimann ((Rolls & fails))

Wildbow You don't glean anything.

Reimann "Can't trust you."

"Sorry."

To the guy I'm holding, to the guys facing me down, and to myself as well.

I hurl myself out of the window.

Wildbow ((Ath roll)) - Fail

((Guts roll)) - Pass

You throw yourself through glass and windowframe, fall the 15 or so feet to the ground, and land hard amid wet snow. The wind is knocked out of you as you land flat on your back, your hostage tumbling from your arms. You're unscathed, but your victim isn't.

You had his neck in an iron-gauntlet grip when you fell, and wrenched it hard when the two of you landed. He screams, the rifle spilling out of his grasp, back arching and fingers curling in a spasmodic way.

Reimann I snatch up the rifle from the ground as I rise, catching my breath, inhaling as deeply as I can through the mask, and escape into the night, seeking out poorly-lit areas.

Wildbow ((Wits check)) - Pass

With your hostage left behind, the police apparently opt to save their buddy rather than give chase. You catch a glimpse of them raising their walkie-talkies to their mouths. Presumably to call for help. It reminds you of the signal the other officer gave, that tipped you off that the situation was going sour.

Try as you might, you're not a capable runner, and you have almost no lung capacity. You don't make it far at all before you run out of breath, even with the armor facilitating your movements.

You stop for a rest in the shadows, and you see a police car creep down the street, a block over.

A sound gets your attention - a pigeon is fluttering in snow. Its neck is broken, head bent over at a right angle, and it's apparently unable to fly. It reminds you of the man you just critically injured. Jean, was it?

Reimann I spare a glance for a pigeon, but have more pressing matters on my mind - escape, namely. I hide in the shadows, catching my breath until I feel up for running again, idly watching the pathetic creature.

Wildbow **As you watch, you see the blueprints unfurl around the pigeon, the lines, the components, the effects, numbers, and mechanisms. You think of the man, and the same lines appear. They're only theory. If you only had a device to scan them as they were in this wretched agony, you could build something to capitalize on it.**

Another cop car rolls past. No doubt now. They have an idea of where you went, and they called in help.

The net is closing around you, and there's no telling what the 'help' constitutes - if it means more of these rifles, or if they're bringing in people with powers.

Either way, as someone who maimed or killed a cop, you've become priority one here.

Took a break here as it was getting late, planning another session for soon after, but then I got particularly busy/distracted. The next half of the session came three weeks later or something.

#WD_Lausanne

Wildbow Your breath rattles through your mask as you stand with your back to a wall. watching as a cop car rolls by, very slowly. The two cops inside scan the surroundings with their eyes, but give no sign that they've seen you.

It's dark, and snow is drifting down around you, the flakes thick and wet, settling on your sleek new armor. A moment's attention to

your armor makes the blueprints unspool around it, ideas and thoughts on what you need to finish it.

But to finish it, you need a workshop, and that means a place where you won't be bothered. A place where you can eat, sleep, and stop to heal the gunshot wounds and minor harm from the fall. To do that, you need to escape the authorities that are drawing the net closed on you now.

Residential streets and homes form a maze around you, you're a monster, and for the time being, this is the labyrinth you're trapped within.

Reimann I glimpse past the wall, trying to get a better picture of my pursuers, their movements, hoping to find a gap in their patrol so I can slip the figurative noose.

My attention, however, is partially focused on the firearm stolen from my former hostage - now likely deceased, I briefly think, before putting the thought out of mind.

Another Tinker's work, I'm assuming, and though I might not be able to pick up on the specifics, I'm hoping to see if I can't make use of its firepower for myself, in a pinch.

Relying on violence, I fear, isn't going to get me as far as I want, but it's a threat I can leverage, and a last resort, if nothing else.

Wildbow ((Wits and Knowledge rolls)) - Pass and fail.

Observation tells you that the only cars on the road are the police cars; you watch for not just the cars themselves, but the headlights of the cars that have such turned on, and the shadows of the ones that don't, and see an opportunity to cross the street. More than that, however, you're aware that they're covering a lot of ground around you - there's a wide perimeter, and you're not far...

...from the center. You'll need to have a plan if you're going to make your way through this.

As the gun goes, well, you know you probably need to pull the trigger. It looks like it fires single shots, and there's one shot

loaded inside. With a workbench and some tools, you might be able to take it apart and find inspiration in it, but that's a ways off.

Reimann I cross the street when I see the chance - best not to stay in one place for too long.

If I'm going to capitalize on an opportunity to sneak through the gaps, though, I'd best create that opportunity myself.

I lean on my power and my immediate surroundings, looking for resources I could potentially use to fabricate some form of distraction.

Wildbow You focus on that part of your mind that is making blueprint ideas spill out into your mind's eye, even into the surroundings, a kind of hallucination, and slowly scan the area. Parked Cars disassemble in your mind's eye, suggesting parts for power armor, and you see a stationary box that would have wiring inside, likely controlling television, phone or internet for nearby houses. Doing...

...anything would require tools and time, and at this moment you have neither. You had your chance to build earlier, and you're going to have to either make do or make a better opportunity.

Reimann Damn and blast. Looks like I'll be relying on wits rather than technology to get out of this one.

I stalk through the shadows, making my way towards where I perceive the perimeter of their search is.

Perhaps a better idea will occur to me as I move, but actually moving is the priority - as I make my way through the residential districts, I keep my eyes peeled for hidey-holes, crannies in which I might be able to evade attention.

Wildbow The houses nearby are long and joined together. You feel as though you should know the locality or style, but as your mind reaches for it, it finds that particular file in your mental filing cabinet to be empty. Moving along the length of the street, you see a sort of park, set between two sets of row houses that sit perpendicular to the street. It's dark, but many windows look out

onto...

...the grass and the sparse trees.

Further along, you see behind one of the rowhouses - the back yards are fenced in, and the street running behind those fences is a long one, only broad enough for a single car to pass down, and unlit.

Reimann I make my way towards the dark, unlit street, keeping my eyes peeled, making doubly sure that no car with its headlights off lies in ambush.

Wildbow You step into darkness, and your suit and mask don't afford you any special sight in the gloom. It's a moment's respite, not just from pursuit, but for your mind and your spirit. You're tired and hurt.

A cop car rolls down the street, but the driver doesn't even look your direction.

Reimann I pause to catch my breath, but not for long. I've got to walk it off, operative word being walk. Can't afford to stay still for long.

I travel down the unlit street at a more sedate pace, giving myself enough of a reprieve to allow my stilted breathing to regulate.

Wildbow You recover your energy, but your wounds continue to ache. It's cold, and your armor doesn't wholly protect against that cold, letting air filter through to touch your bare skin and reach into your open chest cavity.

Making your way to the end of the street, you take a peek around the corner and see a police blockade. It looks like a major street, and a number of other nearby streets and alleys feed into it. The traffic lights at the center have been set to flash red, and the lights on the police cars are going, though the sirens are off. Six men with coffee and walkie talkies, , two cars.

Reimann The faster I get to safety the less I'll have to deal with the bitter cold.

Unslinging the firearm, I sight down it, keeping still, lining up a shot intended for one of the police cars - specifically, the fuel tank.

Wildbow ((Knowledge check)) - Pass

Reimann ((Should I keep going?))

Wildbow ((Yes))

Reimann I swallow, half out of nervousness, half reflexively trying to warm the back of my throat.

It sucks, playing a trump card this early, but I'm not doing myself any favors keeping still.

Once I'm satisfied with the shot I've lined up, I pull the trigger.

Wildbow ((Take your attack roll)) - Horrible miss.

The gunshot cracks loud, and cops drop their coffee as they move to take cover behind the cars.

They shout in french into walkie-talkies.

It's clear they're working to identify the direction the shot came from. They seem to know your general location, and are looking to find you.

Reimann ((I pop my ath buff for this roll)) - uses second of the two stat-boost charges for armor to boost Athletics, enabling better sneaking and faster movement.

Wildbow **One points, shouting in French, "Over there!"**

He then pulls his head back into cover. His voice continues, however, and it's fairly clear he's talking into his walkie talkie.

Reimann With a newfound burst of speed, I sprint away from them, hopefully before the rest can get a proper glimpse of me. Shit. That couldn't have gone more poorly. So much for that ploy.

Wildbow **Your escape route is a long, dark street, tall fences on one side of you, vertical wall on the other. You're only partway down the alley when headlights illuminate the path in front of you.**

Reimann Fuck that. I bull through the fence. I'm not about to face a car head on.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll)) - Massive success.

You tear through the wooden fence with ease, and find yourself in a backyard, lightly covered with snow. Similar fences to either side bar the way to the neighbors' property, and a shallow patio backs onto the house in front of you. There's a glass patio door on the two-floor house.

Voices suggest that people are filing into the alleyway, giving chase.

Reimann I'm rushing the patio. door, trying it first to see if it's unlocked, shattering the glass otherwise.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll, Guts roll)) - Success & success

Glass shatters as you plunge through it, stumbling into a back hallway so narrow your armored arms scrape either side. Large shards of glass slide off your armor and onto the floor. You weren't harmed.

A quick glance backward suggests there are people with flashlights making their way toward you. They still haven't reached the point of the back street where you broke the fence.

Reimann I force my way through the house, hoping to find an alternative exit. A side window, the front door, whatever. The latter is preferable, but I'm not picky.

Wildbow ((Wits check)) - Pass

You wind your way through the house, stepping into a kitchen, which, but for an island countertop, opens onto a large living room. A fireplace sits at one end by a television. Kitty-corner to the door you just passed through to enter the kitchen is the front door. A window above the fireplace gives a view of the street.

Stairs to your left, just a few paces from the front door, suddenly light up as a light goes on on the floor above.

Reimann I head up the stairs quickly, hoping to catch the occupant by surprise.

Wildbow **As you round the top of the stairs, you come face to face with a**

skinny, middle-aged man in pyjamas. He's holding a handgun.

((Dex roll))

You're faster to react - there are ten feet of stairs between you and him.

Reimann I rush towards him, limbs scraping the wall, barreling towards him with pure brute force before he can hopefully collect himself enough for retaliation.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll))

The man decides not to shoot, and instead hurls himself back and out of the way, around one corner. You hear a door slam as you reach the top of the stairs.

He shouts something in a language you don't understand.

Reimann I chase him around the corner, destroying whatever door might be in my way.

**Wildbow ((Brawn roll)) - Pass.
((Old man shoots)) - two horrible misses.**

As the door cracks beneath your gauntlets, he opens fire, shooting through the door and at you.

If any of the bullets touch you, you don't feel it, you shrug off the remains of the door and stare down the man. His wife is still in bed, covers pulled up, a very heavy woman.

Reimann I lunge forward, grabbing for him - as I do so, I exhale violently, filling the room with the crackle of frenzied static.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll)) - Success

You grab him firmly by the upper arm. Only partially in your hold, he swings his other arm around, pointing the gun toward your head.

((Defense roll - can choose either)) - doesn't wind up mattering, old man gets a -1 as the result.

A miserable, frantic shot, he puts a hole through the ceiling above you. You catch his other arm and he seems to give up, sagging slightly, mumbling under his breath.

Reimann I wrest the gun from his grip, slinging him over my shoulder. No time to waste - I drag him out the room and down the stairs as I do so.

Wildbow As you make your way down the stairs, you see two things.

The front window and the glass of the front door are tinkling with the blue and red lights of the police vehicles out front, and the beams of flashlights stab into the kitchen from the back hallway.

They've caught up with you.

Reimann With the hostage over my shoulder, I level the Tinker gun at the policemen.

"BACK OFF," I growl, relying on the vocal filter to distort my voice into something more threatening.

Wildbow The first cop to enter the kitchen sees you, then immediately backpedals, taking cover against the doorframe or wall.

The man slung over your shoulder is mewling, likely asking for mercy.

Rather than talk to you, the police are talking among themselves, no doubt strategizing. You hear the crackle of a walkie-talkie.

Reimann I'm not going to give them time to formulate a plan.

I push my way through then police, screaming, hearing my voice crackle into unintelligibility, shoving them violently with one hand, the hostage grappled in a bone-cracking vise in the other.

Wildbow There is no being quiet with your heavy armor and thudding footsteps, so you don't even try. Shock and awe. You cross living room and kitchen, and round the corner to the back hallway. Most are already clearing out of your way, as you charge into the backyard. One in the front hallway, hugging the wall, gun in hand, two more on the back patio, and three more in the back yard. The six...

...you'd shot at and more from the headlights you'd seen.

Reimann "FUCK WITH ME, HUH?!"

"YOU WANNA DIE TONIGHT?"

I plow through the cops, aiming a kick or punch at any still in my way.

Wildbow They don't stand in your way, but they do take it on themselves to step back, then lunge at you, reaching for arms and for your waist, aiming to dogpile. One or two seem to be reaching for the injector tubes.

((rolls 3 Brawn rolls for the men to tackle)) - Get 5, 4, 6

((Roll Brawn or Athletics to counter)) -Anti rolls 7, 4, 4

You manage to shove two of them aside, but one finds a grip, and latches onto your back, holding onto the power armor. His weight joins the weight of your hostage, burdening you, and slowing your efforts. Three more officers stand before you, and two more are picking themselves up off the ground behind you.

((-1 to Brawn rolls as long as you've got the guy clinging to you))

Reimann I take the hostage's handgun, firing indiscriminately into the three cops in front of me, running, shaking violently, hoping to break the clinging man's grip.

"BAD DECISION."

((How many times can I shoot?))

Wildbow ((Half of dex, so 2))

Reimann shoots, the soldiers dodge.

They only barely avoid the shots. The third one hesitates, but on seeing you aren't aiming in his direction, musters courage and hurls himself at your gun arm, aiming to cling to it.

((Roll brawn or dodge)) - Anti does, fails to beat the man's roll.

Wildbow He manages to weigh you down. The one on your back takes advantage of the distraction and reaches up-

((Man rolls & succeeds))

Seizing one of the injector tubes that feeds into your neck and shoulders. He pulls it free.

It's not a smart action, as it turns out. The toxic sludge spills out, covering both you and him.

((Minor wound to your torso - burn))

He falls off.

Reimann I growl at the cop clinging to my arm.

"Let go, or I kill the old-timer and you're my new hostage."

I keep forcing my way through, trying to pick up speed.

Wildbow ((Social roll))

Reimann ((Rolls)) - succeeds

Wildbow He shifts his grip, trying to keep from falling, and places one hand on the gun. There's little chance he'll be able to wrest it from you, but he seems insistent on taking it.

"Give... gun," he grunts, "I let go!"

Reimann ((The handgun, or the Tinker gun?))

Wildbow ((The one you just used to shoot.))

Reimann I wait for him to get a good grasp on the handgun, before saying, "Deal."

I let go of the gun, hoping to let him drop to the ground along with it - and follow it up by bringing my boots heavily down on his arm, to curtail retaliation with the retrieved firearm.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll)) - Reimann attacks, other guy dodges, despite high roll

He pulls his arm away just in time. A quick glance shows the others are catching up with you. The hole in the fence is just a few

paces ahead.

Reimann No time to dally. I make a break for the hole, roaring "ONE WRONG MOVE AND I TEAR THIS ASSHOLE'S HEAD OFF."

Wildbow ((Wits check)) - passed

Wildbow A quick glance down both ends of the alleyway suggest the cars are still parked there, headlights still on in one car to your right, the ones at your left are off and dark. A quick double-check confirms that there are cops by the car with the headlights on.

Reimann I turn, hostage slung over my shoulder, hustling towards the darkness, away from the cops and the illuminated car.

Wildbow There's a cop in the car with its engine off, you see, and his eyes go wide as you pass. A quick glance around shows that there are more cars to your left. Probably watching the street out front of the house, or backing up the people who are there.

On the far side of the street you just entered, you can see a row of shops.

They know where you are, the net is closing, and a hostage alone isn't going to be enough, here.

Reimann ((Are the shops multi-story?))

Wildbow ((The ground floor is dedicated to shops, the upper floors appear to be apartments; some are two story, some are three))

Reimann I attempt to cross the street at speed, hustling, attempting to bust into an entrance that allows access to the upper floors.

Wildbow Grabbing one door handle, you haul it open with enough force to rend the lock, only for the door to open on its own, glass cracking as it swings to its limit, the frame warping. An elderly or disabled person's walker is sitting by the foot of the stairs, which lead straight up to the second and third floor.

Wildbow The man on your shoulder starts fighting you, wrestling to try and get free. It's not very effective.

Reimann I run up the stairs, smacking the walker down, knocking over whatever furniture to obstruct the path of my pursuers.

Wildbow ((There is no furniture, there's just stairs leading up to a landing with one apartment door, more stairs leading up to the landing with the next apartment door))

Reimann Damn. With nothing to slow down the cops on my tail, I merely book it to the top floor, slamming through the door as fast as I can.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll)) - huge success

Wildbow You crash into the apartment, and find yourself in a hallway, extending to the right to a kitchen and back door, the left seems to lead to other rooms. Just across from you is a bedroom, and a man is sitting up in shock, staring.

Reimann I waste no time, barreling forward, punching the man full-force before he can respond.

Wildbow ((Roll attack)) - huge success

Your gauntlet cracks into his head, knocking him clean out.

Reimann I drag his unconscious body out of the bedroom, near the window, as I attempt to smear his face and upper torso with the toxic sludge leaking from my armor.

Wildbow ((The sludge is leaking down your back. Doing anything with that is going to require putting down your other hostage.))

Reimann I slam down the other hostage, sharp and into the ground, gauntleted hand around his neck.

With both hands free, I get to work.

Wildbow Unconscious, the younger man stirs as you move him, pushing him against the back of your power armor. Shirtless, wearing only pyjama bottoms, he has no defenses against the acid. His hands reach out to grab your wrist, he makes small pained sounds, and then he wakes, screaming frantically.

He thrashes, grabbing and tugging helplessly and uselessly

against your armored fist and arm.

When you pull him away, his face and skin is scratched, bruised, but more than anything, it's blistering, skin burning, melting, and turning black where the substance made contact.

Reimann I punch the window, climbing onto the threshold, grasping the older hostage by the hair once I'm visible to those outside.

As loud as possible, "GET YOUR COPS OUT OF THE BUILDING. IF I HEAR STEPS COMING UP, I DROP THE POOR SHIT, NO QUESTIONS, NO NEGOTIATIONS."

Wildbow The cops you'd charged past and several more now stand around the cars you'd passed, and you can see cars coming from either end of the street. Large numbers are gathering, some with different uniforms. They stand on the street, staring up at you. Nobody makes an attempt to call back, speak, or ask questions.

Reimann I disengage the back plating on my armor, leaving the mask on, continuing to speak. "THAT'S RIGHT. STAY FUCKING STILL."

I shimmy out of the armor as I speak, keeping the joints locked in place.

As I exit the armor, the cool winter air on my skin and in my chest cavity, I attempt to surreptitiously cram the acid-scarred man into the armor, closing him back in.

"IT DIDN'T HAVE TO COME TO THIS, YOU KNOW."

"I AM - WAS, REALLY, A TINKER."

"PUTTING TOGETHER SOMETHING TO KEEP ME ALIVE."

I seal the man into the armor, refitting the back plate.

Wildbow He struggles, partially blind, his hand reaching out, his wrist in the way of the panel closing.

Reimann I grab his wrist, twisting it into place, closing the panel before he can try to fuck around more.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll)) - passed

((Carry on))

Reimann "WELL, THAT'S A WASH."

"IT'S WELL PAST THAT POINT NOW, ASSHOLES."

"NOTHING— NOTHING TO LOSE NOW." I break into a fit of coughing, hoping the digitization of the mask disguises the artificial hacking and wheezing.

As I do so, I disengage the tubing, flooding the interior of the armor with the remaining reserves of toxic chemicals.

Wildbow ((Social roll for the acting))

Reimann Hoooooboy

((Rolls)) - success

Wildbow As you pull the tubes free, the toxic fluids pour in. They won't fill the suit, but there'll be a lot of it. At the very least, his feet are likely to melt.

((Rolls Knowledge; can man figure out how to operate the suit?)) - fail

((Rolls 1d100 for man's trigger event, typically a 3-5% chance)) - fail

The man screams, thrashing helplessly within his makeshift sarcophagus, and the sound is very normal, without the digitization your mask would create.

Reimann I throw my full weight into the armor, sending it toppling out of the window, taking cover as soon as I feel its weight shift.

As I shove, I shout through the mask -

"WANNA KNOW WHAT MY LAST WORDS ARE, SHITBAGS?"

Wildbow ((Brawn roll)) - slight success.

The suit tilts, but doesn't quite fall. It's a lot of metal, it's heavy,

and it was poised to keep it from falling while you put a full grown man inside.

Reimann I keep shoving, roaring out "FUCK YOU!"

The expletive, the fury behind it, both genuine.

With all my rage and frustration, I put all my strength into the push.

((Tries again; fails with a 2))

((embarrassing.))

Wildbow People are shouting. Some are getting closer to the building itself. The hostage who is being strangled in the machine's grip looks past the suit's armpit to stare at you, horrified at both your appearance and the realization of what you're doing.

If he says something- well, you have a chance to make another go at it.

Reimann "HA. HAHA. THIS IS EMBARRASSING."

I speak loudly, drowning out anything the hostage might say.

"LOOK AT ME. I DON'T EVEN HAVE THE STRENGTH TO TAKE MY LAST STEP."

As I speak, I disengage the joints one by one, letting the suit slowly slump over, fall limp piece by piece.

"YOUR FAULT, ASSHOLES."

I give the suit one last heave, after the knees unlock.

((Rolls)) - gets a 6.

Wildbow This time you find your leverage. It falls from the window, and you even manage to throw yourself back so you're well out of sight if anyone still happens to be looking at the window. The suit crashes to ground, and the hostage falls with it, no doubt crushed beneath.

One person screams, and a number of people shout, calling out.

As you stand, carefully staying to shadow, you peer below. Among

the cops is a woman in costume. Much of the costume hugs her body, clinging to legs, hips, and upper body, but she wears a flowing combination of coat and cape that trails to the ground, with high boots, and her mask has a crown built into it.

On one breast is the playing card suit, clubs, and the number seven.

As she raises her head suddenly, looking up at the window, you pull back out of sight.

The symbol and the number makes for something of a glimmer, a hazy recall, not familiar, but somehow important to your old self.

Reimann Now's my best (and likely only) chance.

While they're distracted by the commotion, I've got to get out.

I search for a rear entrance, or a fire escape, to slink off through

*through.

No time for rubbernecking. Let's move.

Wildbow Backtracking through the apartment, you make your way to the kitchen. One door leads out the back, to a fire escape at the back of the building. It looks like yards and fences beyond. You stand in the open doorway, your naked, wounded chest open to the cold, and shiver.

Wildbow Escaping is one thing, but you need sanctuary. From the higher vantage point, you can see some of the city. This might be the last time you have the lay of the land.

Reimann I glance at the skyline, grabbing a blanket from the bed as I go, wrapping it around me for some meager additional warmth.

I make a cursory sweep of my surroundings, trying to surmise a better place which to flee - one where, I pray, I might be overlooked.

Wildbow You see large blocky apartment buildings, houses, stores, and more. It's a jumble of buildings, with some features throughout. Nothing stands out as a truly good hiding place - you're in the

middle of a metropolitan area. It really depends on what you're considering in terms of hiding spots.

Reimann My first priority is lower scrutiny. Poorer areas, the shoddier, more run-down areas might have some better options for skulking. Abandoned residences, and the like.

Wildbow ((Wits and Knowledge checks)) - Pass, fail, respectively

It's hard to make things out with the gloom, but you're able to see the buildings in one area. Lawn furniture on balconies, buildings looking a little bit more disused with cracks here and there. It seems like a starting point, if you're looking for a run down area where hiding spots might be evident.

Reimann I fix the direction of the location in my mind's eye, skulking off towards it, clinging to the walls and shadows.

Wildbow Police cars are still in the area, moving to and from the scene of the incident. The blanket clutched close for warmth, you make your way to the poorer area of town. You glance over the buildings nearby, gauging them for potential. A tenement, a grocery store, a closed storefront with large display windows, a park with a shack in the center of it. An abandoned gas station.

Every option has its strengths and weaknesses.

((Up to you if you want to investigate one or keep looking - keeping in mind you're cold and there's a chance of being caught as you prolong your search))

Reimann The gas station seems like the best option. Worse, for shelter, but better for potential components. If I can get armor cobbled together, warmth will be less of a problem.

I approach it, going for a more thorough investigation.

Wildbow The lot is isolated, with lots of open space surrounding it. Approaching, you find the glass of the doors has paper hung over it, and where the paper droops, you can make out the interior. Shelves, counters, refrigerators, all devoid of products.

Reimann I glance at the surroundings, looking for abandoned vehicles, letting my power sweep over the refrigerators and metal shelving, seeing if the components pass muster for something I could cobble together.

Wildbow There is enough you could put together a fresh suit of armor, and something else besides, but the building is small, it looks like you might go wanting when it comes to comfort, and there is a dim possibility that someone could come looking if they wanted to buy.

Dim, but the possibility does exist.

Reimann I'm uncertain if any of the others might pass more scrutiny.

I could go to the tenements, scour for an abandoned home, or, barring that, displace one of the occupants, but I can't guarantee the ensuing struggle will be quiet.

I think back to the grocery store - it seemed closed, not abandoned, right?

Wildbow Thinking back, you recall that the interior was dark. There were no cars in the lot, and it didn't look well looked after. It could be either.

Reimann Better not get greedy. I'll stick around here, long enough to replace my now long-gone armor, and keep moving after.

I'm hoping I don't get interrupted, this time around, and possibly have the chance to work on something with offensive possibilities besides.

Wildbow Circling the building, you check the doors and find them all locked. You lack the tools to let yourself in, and doing any damage to the building increases chances you'll be noticed.

Reimann Damn, damn, damn and blast.

I can't imagine the other locations will be easier to infiltrate.

I lift up one of the pieces of paper, considering if I can shatter one of the panes, open the door, and replace the paper.

Wildbow ((The paper is on the inside))

Reimann Augh. Fine.

I stalk over to the grocery store, keeping my head low where I can.

Maybe I'll have better luck, there.

Wildbow ((Rolls for random encounter))

The walk to the grocery store appears uneventful. The metropolitan area around the store is denser, there's less open space, and less room to see trouble or guests making their approach.

It's a large building, as large as any four houses put together, and like the gas station, it sits empty, the shelves bare.

Unlike the gas station, it doesn't seem as though it's been empty for quite so long. The exterior is less worn and faded, the lines on the parking lot are new.

Or new enough - it's hard to tell with the snow.

There seem to be multiple doors, and some area off around the side and back.

Reimann I try a few of the doors, making my way to the area, to see what it contains.

Wildbow The doors are locked. The situation is the same as the gas station, but at the very least, damage to one door isn't going to draw attention from a distance - someone would have to circle around to the back of the building.

Reimann I approach one of the more out-of-the-way doors, trying to finagle it open without messing it up too badly.

Wildbow ((Dex and Brawn rolls)) - fail and fail

Wildbow The metal guard that prevents jimmying of the door is bent awry and slightly torn as you exert strength, and when you try the knob again, you find you've failed to open the door.

Wildbow ((Can try again - you've already made visible damage, making

more hurts only so much))

Reimann ((Tries again)) - pass and pass.

I try again, this time less concerned about causing dents, tears, and scuffs.

Wildbow Some more effort, working around the already damaged piece, causes only a small amount of added damage, and you succeed in wresting the door open. You find your way inside, into the back rooms that once served as storage for the goods before they went out to the shelves.

There's a little room in the corner, likely a manager's office, and a large fridge, as well as a back door access to the coolers for milk and meats.

No food is within, it's all scrap and goods, but a quick perusal finds some old cleaning chemicals.

((knowledge check)) - passed

From the way things are laid out, you surmise the store closed only recently. Were things done differently, you might think that it had only just been touched up with hope of reopening it.

Still, a large lot like this is bound to have some buyers come eventually. It's questionable how permanent a workshop it will be.

//

((Looking to wrap up soon))

Reimann No need to worry about the long term.

The future is uncertain enough as it is.

Gathering as many materials from the store, I set in, throwing myself into work to push away the exhaustion, fatigue, and adrenaline.

--- Session end ---

Wildbow ((Okay, get back to me with what you're aiming to craft in the interim))

Reimann ((no problem.))

Shemz/Archival - Lausanne

‘Down’ Arc - 1.6

Shemetz (typically Shem or The Shemz, Shemz hereafter) drafted the ‘God of Taxes’ trigger:

You worked your ass off to get into the class with the god of taxes, a joking name for the number one professor in the world for tax law, business and accounting. Getting through a set of his notoriously difficult classes is said to be a virtually automatic in with one of the top 200 international business. But oh man, it's hard. You were the best, each and every year, up until you were in the God's class. He pits you against each other, and you cope. He never promises, only ever implies, when it comes to the bonus marks and projects. Then he drops the bomb. No bonus marks. It all comes down to the final paper and final exam. Your confidence plummets in a matter of hours. Your paper is covered in red ink. Okay. Okay. You can still salvage this. You put the paper aside, and sit down for the Final exam. You sit down to write it, and experience quiet horror. You chose this school to get a class with this guy, you won't get a second chance, and you're about to flunk the exam. You're not the only one to trigger - the preppy girl who's had a hard time from the start snaps, too, frustration and panic built up over months overwhelming her. Multi-trigger.

Being a multi-trigger, akin to Flechette's or Circus', the character got a set of very distinct powers, rather than one power or two interrelated powers. Having written the trigger, I let the chatroom devise the power - giving commentary here and there. Normally a multi-trigger would be more, smaller powers, but as is, this sort of worked. In this case, the cape has a thinker power that grants clairvoyant scanning of a 20' radius area, primarily gaining knowledge of things that have been in that area a lot - people and transient objects are blurry, while solid objects are easily visible. Detailed awareness allows for quick evidence gathering within scanned areas. When finding areas where people have spent a lot of time, gets very detailed information about them. No range limit - he can target any point in the city, but can't just find people blindly, needs to know the location in general.

The secondary power is fairly simple - the power is a tinker one, fairly minor, and is limited to the 'core list' of things, in that it doesn't go much further than weapons, armor, and computer stuff with a tinker twist. That twist is that the gear can be highly

customized to counter specific enemies' powers or methodologies, a form of nemesis tinkering. The scanning power -can- be used to gather data to inform this tinkering.

Archival, as the character was named, fell midway in the draft, rolling both a Perk and a Flaw. The Perk was the life perk Stubborn - this character doesn't get tired in prolonged engagements. They can scrap that bonus for a time to get a free reroll at something they've tried and failed to do recently (but not in the same turn they failed).

The Flaw, as it happened, was the life drawback 'Nemesis'. Archival has an enemy to start with, someone with a vendetta against him.

Archival dropped out of business school to be a private investigator, but his arrogant, abrasive personality drove customers away, and he became a robber instead. That went well enough, until he ran into a superheroine, one with powers oddly reminiscent of his own. Their cat and mouse game got heated, and recently reached the point where Archival threatened the woman's family. Rather than back down, she doubled up on her efforts, switching her weapons over to the lethal sort and making threats against his life.

Eager to get away, he made his way to Lausanne.

Wildbow

The landlord lurks in the entryway of the apartment, as you inspect the surroundings. The apartment is serviceable, three and a half rooms, admittedly with a small bathroom, but it's clean, and it's set at a corner, with windows giving a somewhat unremarkable view of ongoing construction, a pharmacy across the street, and some trees. The landlord is a young woman, younger than thirty, and pretty in a knee-length dress with a flower pattern and a cardigan, though she seems shy or reserved.

She fidgets somewhat as you look over the apartment you arranged online, turning the keen eyes that helped you be an investigator and a burglar to the task of identifying any imminent issues.

"Is it alright?" she asks, in French.

Shemz

"Yes, I like that. I assume everything is already installed? Electricity, internet, water?"

Wildbow **"Of course, yes. The construction out there did cut the phone lines, last week, but it was a quick fix. There have been no other problems," she says. She seems glad you like the place.**

Shemz I nod once, enter, and close the door.

 I approach the computer and turn it on, inspecting the rest of the apartment meanwhile. Checking if anything looks out of the ordinary.

Wildbow **((Enter? You were doing a walk-through, checking the interior))**

Shemz ((Thought we were in the entryway, sorry.))

 I set up the computer, transferring my documents and the like. While it's working, I'll attempt to use my power on the room I'm in, looking for anything interesting.

Wildbow **As the hard drive whirrs, you close your eyes, focusing your power. Your mind's eye opens, and you see the room in an entirely new way, at first like a bird's eye view, looking down from the ceiling, then from the sides, then the floor, and every angle. The surfaces and surroundings seem to take on an exaggerated sharpness, every bump in the paint highlighted five times over.**

You see it as it was in the past, over days, weeks, and months, the movement of the sunlight across the floor, the shadows of nighttime and where the sunlight doesn't reach, exaggerated.

And, wispy, ill-defined, you see the figures of previous tenants, home between nine at night and seven in the morning, eating, sleeping, talking, cooking. They were messy, they smoked, and smoked weed, and they drank, and they fucked on the regular. You can see the arguments over financial matters, the frustration, on faces that are distorted, like pictures taken a half-second apart from one another, the features stretched from one image to the next, mouths yawning, expressions contorting, ghostly caricatures of people.

And you see the landlady, moving through the space over the weeks prior, at first to clean and paint, then to stop in the apartment every day, around the same time, wiping the windowsill where water leaked through the window.

It's clean, with a bit of water damage in the bathroom by the foot of the tub, and a spider web the landlady's dusting missed in the top shelf of the linen cupboard.

Shemz Good. Nothing out of the ordinary, and not a place anyone would take interest in. Landlady seems like a decent person, and it's good that she is consistent. Wouldn't want her to barge in while I'm busy.

I open the browser, and begin searching the web for the basic information about the suits I've heard about. They sound appealing, and useful.

Would want to know how to get one, and how many there are, first of all.

Wildbow ((Knowledge check, dex check))

The computer is unfamiliar, and it takes you a while to find your way and get all the little bits and bobs installed. The day gets late and progress is slow - the suits you heard about are popping up here and there, as part of an ongoing crime wave, and there isn't, as far as you can tell, so much as a hint as to where you could go or who you could ask to get one.

Shemz That's disappointing. I shouldn't have even bothered.

On the other hand, if there's so little info it might not be such an important thing to get, right now.

Next on the list - heros. I should work far from their base of operations, or the police. Information regarding their powers would be excellent, too, but if everything works out I wouldn't encounter them anyways. I try not to spend too much time searching, this time.

Wildbow ((Same rolls))

Shemz ((Looking to know where they are on the map, where I am, and basic info))

Wildbow The discouragement from the prior searches doesn't help - the searches are slow, broken up by the fact that the heroes here haven't unified, there's mention of a new group, the Suits, but overall, very little to be found but a few mentions of powers on various news articles, which you can't really pull together to figure out any one particular individual.

Your stomach growls. It's six in the evening, and you drove for most of the day. The cupboards are empty, and the moving boxes you have in the back seat of the car have only the food staples that would survive the journey. You could go shopping for

essentials, or stick to a simple, bland dinner and continue searching or preparing.

Shemz Well. I'll have to trust my power when it comes to getting info. I finish setting up my stuff, and prepare to go to sleep. Watching the history of this place, I'm quite content that I have a new mattress.

 Tomorrow morning looks like a good time to start my work.

 I eat quick dinner, and go to sleep early.

Wildbow The meal is entirely underwhelming, but it quells the hunger pangs. You dig out sheets from a box, and make the bed, before settling in. Without curtains and other amenities, sleeping at a different temperature and ambient noise than you're used to, at a rather early hour, it could have been a restless night. You manage, and rise in the morning, more prepared to get to work.

Shemz Okay. I get up, and go to a nearby cafe, to eat breakfast.

 My plan is to find an empty house, get in and out without being seen, and take what I can find. Private houses will be easier to find empty, and noise will attract less attention.

 I shouldn't get too greedy the first time. No stores, or secure places.

 When I'm done with my coffee, I get back to the apartment and pack my costume and tools into a large bag, also taking extra bags for the loot. I get into the car and start driving around town, looking for suburbs.

Wildbow The nearest cafe is just a short walk away, and the cold winter climate necessitates a jacket and boots. Snow is falling, and traffic crawls - one of the two lanes of traffic is taken up with construction work, dug up with machines and workers in heavy winter clothing and orange vests doing what they can in the cold.

The buildings to the far side of the construction are homes, apartment buildings and houses, and the buildings to your right, the cafe included, are businesses, more contemporary than the quaint Lausanne style of some of the downtown areas.

You finish your meal and start back to get your tools, and pause as you see a spot of blood on snow. You spy the shadows under some branches and above a hedge, where a bird of prey is busy taking apart... another bird of prey, tearing at feathers and flesh and taking its sibling to pieces.

Shemz That's...interesting. And concerning.
Stay away from birds. I'll keep that in mind.

Wildbow **With your tools loaded up in the car, you start your drive through the city, looking for possible targets.**
((Roll Street Smarts))
This is more comfortable terrain than the computer business. You find the higher income area, but not so high income that the homeowners don't have to go to work. Making your way down the street, you find a good target, a three-story building with tall glass windows, in a very modern style. There's a patch on the driveway where the snow isn't as high, and tire treads suggest the homeowner pulled out an hour or two ago.

Shemz ((Is there a backyard? A fence?))

Wildbow **A narrow alley extends along the right side of the house, leading through a gate to what might be a long backyard, extending perhaps 100' back behind the property. Fences separate the backyard from the neighboring properties.**

Shemz I turn on my power for a few moments, using it on the house, and then on the backyard behind it. I need to make sure there's nobody home. Dogs, especially, would be problematic. I can't outsmart dogs, and I forgot to bring a convenient piece of steak to lure them away.

Wildbow **You feel your power kick in, like the tunnel vision one experiences when they're driving and accelerate rapidly, everything around the edges blurring as your mind's eye opens.**
Sound equipment in the basement, with a collection of guitars, a widescreen television with a surround sound system, the individual pieces of equipment blurry where they get used more, moved from place to place.
Further down the basement, a teenager's room, empty. A small dog sleeps in a locked kennel, the bedroom door closed. The ground floor has some nice kitchen stuff, but nothing worth taking. Upstairs, however, you get to the bedrooms, you locate jewelry and artwork that might be worth something.

Shemz That's excellent. Let's go.

Door is almost definitely locked, and I am no good at lockpicking. Windows might be left open, or unlocked. I walk around the house, searching for any open windows.

Before entering, though, I'll need to go to the backyard and change to my costume, of course.

Wildbow

The space between houses where a narrow path leads around the side of the house seems to be the best bet for getting changed, but it's the middle of winter. The cold takes a little bit out of you as you quickly don your costume.

The information provided by your power tells you that the kitchen window is frequently cracked to allow smoke to ventilate. You walk around to approach it and ease it open.

Shemz

I should probably pad the costume some time, make it more comfortable for this weather. It was warmer when I started doing this.

I climb through the window carefully.

I'll head to the bedroom first.

If the dog is indeed locked, there's no need to be especially silent while going up the stairs, though I shouldn't make too much noise in any case. Might be people outside, walking nearby.

I enter the bedroom and look around.

Wildbow

It's hard to be entirely positive the place is empty - your power focuses largely on the inanimate, things that remain in one place, and people are wisps, abstract, hard to define. It's a relief to find the room empty. A crimson bedspread and picture above the four-poster bed suggest a degree of class. Three different antique dressers have things collected atop them; one has the amassed collection of jewelry. It ranges in quality from the cheap to the higher quality stuff. One box has diamond studs - unfortunately low resale value, but better than some things.

Shemz

I grab the jewelry and put all of it into a bag. All of it.

Now, the painting might be valuable. I take a closer look at it.

Wildbow

The painting is likely done by a local artist, purchased at a gallery. A pale woman reclines on a couch outdoors, painted in oils, face skyward, while swans surround her, wings spread.

You hear a voice from down the hall. A shout. "Officer!"

Shemz

Shit.

Who is that? I should have noticed them, or heard them at least.

I move to the corner of the room, away from the entrance, and use my power on the place the voice came from, and then the house entrance. Making sure it's me who caused this.

And "Officer"? Is there a cop nearby?

Wildbow

You take cover, and focus on your power, zooming in on the direction of the sound. You see human shapes, wispy, but they're from hours ago, and if there are any now, they're too hard to make out in the storm of moving images, too new to the room, and too transient. This is the weakness of your particular form of clairvoyance.

Footsteps tromp, echoing oddly. Then silence.

Shemz

I've only been here for a few minutes. There must have been somebody still inside who heard me.

I peek beyond the wall, through the doorway, for a split second. If nobody is in the hall, I try to quickly and silently close the door.

Wildbow

((Roll thievery))

((Roll Wits))

You find the hallway empty and shut the door without incident, silence looming in the wake of it. You hear nothing and see nothing, but for a car passing on the road outside.

Shemz

Alright. Need to get out, fast. It's second floor, I might be able to leave through the window.

((There's a window, right?))

Wildbow

The bedroom has a little balcony. A glance down and out suggests the house was built on a slope. It's an effective three-story drop to the stone patio, which is dusted in an inch or two of snow.

Shemz

((Does the window face the front or the back (or the sides); Do I see any police car parked, or lights reflecting from walls and trees?))

Wildbow ((Faces the back - you see only the backyard and the neighbor's))

Shemz Okay. I can do this. I open the window, and take out my rope. I'll climb down with it.

I tie the rope in a strong knot to a fixed object in the room, and start climbing down silently.

Wildbow **As you work, getting the rope out and preparing the hook at the window, you hear gunshots from down the hall. Tinny, false-sounding gunshots with none of the visceral impact a real gun would have. Tires screech, in much that same manner.**

Shemz ...What is going on? Is this anything real, even?

It sounds like I'm not related to this, which is good. Excellent, even.

...is this just a loud television?

Before climbing out the window, I try to lock the door (if it has an inner, no-key-needed type of lock). Then I get out.

Wildbow **The door isn't lockable, as it happens. You straddle the balcony, preparing to climb down, and you hear the tire screeching stop. A commercial starts playing.**

Shemz Suspicions confirmed. Good thing I didn't do anything stupid.

Well, I got most of what I wanted here. Painting probably isn't worth taking.

Too big to carry around or hide easily, and the fact it could be local means it could be traced back here with ease.

I'll leave the rope here, and try to get to the television and turn it off.

I'd like to take a look at the basement before leaving.

Wildbow **You open the door and make your way down the hall. The room appears to be an office, with a television set in the corner, volume turned nearly to the maximum, commercials ongoing.**

As you spot and reach for the power switch, it turns off on its own, your fingers an inch from the button.

Shemz I widen my eyes, and quickly turn around.

Is there another person in the room? A camera, maybe?

Wildbow **The room is empty, the hallway vacant.**
As you turn toward the corner of the office, however, you see that the computer monitor is on.

Shemz Feeling uneasy. I pull the power cable out of the television.
Was this computer on when I entered?

Wildbow **((Know check to remember))**
You remember the computer being off. You're pretty sure the television was off as you came up the stairs as well - it's certainly off now. The screen is black now that you've pulled the cord.

Shemz Fuck me. This must be some cape, or maybe the lingering effects of one.

I look at the monitor. Is the mouse moving? Is there some program that started running?

Wildbow **((Thievery check))**
As you approach the computer, you catch a glimpse of the movement on the screen. Too slow to get out of the way. There's a camera embedded in the monitor, and the image on the screen is the feed from the camera, black and white and not the highest of resolutions, but it's an image of you, including your masked face looking at and recognizing the camera.
The image changes, going still. You see the still images being sorted and moved into a folder.

Shemz Well, that's crappy. But I can handle this.

I hold the power button down for several seconds, and then unplug the computer.

I wonder if I should break the computer, but that might make some noise. I settle for breaking the camera in the monitor, with my knife.

Wildbow **You finish gouging the lens, then step away from the computer. You can hear a phone ringing downstairs.**

Shemz Okay. This is almost definitely a cape messing with me. Shutting off things one at a time doesn't seem to make it stop.

That phone could be a lure, a trap. I shouldn't come down.

I take a long look at the office. I should get a screwdriver and erase the data on that computer.

Wildbow **Your power informs you of the contents of the drawers, including a screwdriver meant for computers.**
While you look, you hear the phone below. The ringing stops, and what you hear is a voice, loud, talking over the phone.
In French, a woman speaks, "Emergency services. How may I help you?"
You recognize the voice that speaks next. "Yes, I'd like to report a robbery in progress, at 108, Avenue de Chailly. The robber has powers."

Shemz Nevermind. Bad idea. I'm out. I abandon the fucking computer, stop trying to be silent, and run into the hallway.
Nobody's home but that freaky tech entity, I don't have to worry about anyone coming. I have at least five minutes to get away.
Should I take the car? Will it be controlled too?

Wildbow **"He's leaving the hosue now, I think through the back. I can lead you to him, but you'll want help," Bette Noire tells the emergency responder.**

Shemz Her. Of course. Why not her.
She probably can't see me anymore, though.
I grab my rope, head downstairs full speed, take the phone and smash it on the floor a few times.

Wildbow **While making your approach to the phone, you note that the sound is coming from the little television at one corner of the kitchen. Rerouted.**

Shemz I keep holding on to the phone, putting it in my pocket. I head out the door, leaving it open, and run to my car.
I try to turn on the car and drive.

Wildbow **The car turns on without difficulty. You pull away from the house.**

Shemz I drive for two minutes, turn a corner, and park in any available spot.

I leave the phone inside, and get out along with my bag.

((Anywhere people can't see me))

After getting out, I find the closest garbage bin and put the bag inside, careful to not let anything spill out.

Wildbow **The neighborhood seems to be predominantly houses here, the only available spots to turn into are driveways. No garbage bins seem apparent - it's not trash day.**

Shemz Oh, dang it. Well, then, I'll find the closest thing to it. A bush?

Wildbow **((Hedge))**

Shemz Argh. I use my power on nearby houses. Maybe there's a vacant house somewhere around, and nobody will notice a black bag on the inner side of the hedge.

I try not to waste time doing this, though.

Wildbow **You stow the bag in a hedge, and snow falls from the top as you move the lower branches. Closing your eyes, you focus on the surroundings. A quick glance inside. Most of the houses are empty, but not truly 'vacant'.**

The owners are simply off to work.

Shemz God damn it! Argh. I look at the street, remembering the name, so that I could come back here later to retrieve the bag.

How long will it take to walk home, from here?

Wildbow **Chemin de Fontanettaz, you note. At your best guess, it's a twenty to thirty minute walk.**

Shemz That's not that bad. I get back into the car.

I'll drive half the way to the house, and then get back on foot.

Wildbow **((Are you costumed?))**

Shemz ((Right now, yes))

((Was about to wait to see if I'm interrupted, otherwise I'd get off, leave my costume inside and walk home))

Wildbow	((Get off?))
Shemz	((get out of the vehicle))
Wildbow	You start the drive back to your apartment. Traffic is slow, with the construction taking up half of it, forcing you to move in fits and starts, with you having to pull off to the side to let incoming traffic pass, and vice versa. There's an eerie moment as the person in the car ahead of you, while stopped, twists around and looks directly at you, expression concerned.
Shemz	I smile and wave back.
Wildbow	The incoming traffic passes, and you start to resume forward movement. Abruptly, the person ahead of you stops. His car bars the way.
Shemz	Gah. I hoped that would work. I try to see if there are cars behind me. Can I reverse? Am I blocking others?
Wildbow	((It appears there's room to reverse, but it's an awkward thing to manage. Dex & Wits checks if you want to attempt it.))
Shemz	I use the horn twice, hoping that he'd move aside. Expecting nothing to happen, I take off my goggles, but leave them hanging on my neck.
Wildbow	The horn blares. He doesn't budge. What's curious, and concerning as well, is that none of the cars behind you are leaning on the horns.
Shemz	I open the door and get out, still costumed. I keep my toolbelt on me, but leave the bag and phone in the car. I walk towards the man who stopped and knock on the driver side window, as calmly as I can.
Wildbow	The eyes of people in the cars follow you as you walk. As you pass by the car that had blocked your way, the man within stares. You knock, and he jumps. He doesn't open the door or roll down

the frost-glazed window. You can hear, muted through the door and the windows, the voice of Bête Noire, talking through the radios.

Shemz As I expected. I'm pretty much doomed. I look around me, searching for an escape route.

Wildbow The area is littered with side streets, but it's all residential lots, most of it apartment blocks and homes, in the mid-to-high end.

Shemz Running away from the road is probably the best course of action.
I silently curse, and run into the closest side street.

Wildbow Fences and hedges stand tall to either side of you as you make your way down the street. A car behind you slows as it passes, the driver watching you, before it continues on its way.

Shemz Noire must be talking with everyone nearby and getting updated about my actions. I need to get the heck away from the cars. I search for a sideroad where cars would see me the least, and head there.

I could take off my costume, but if anyone knows where I am and I don't escape quickly enough it's game over. Not now.

Stay out of the eyes of the drivers, find a place to hide.

Wildbow At the end of the street you're traveling, you find a more commercial area. Stores, streets, and shops, with the occasional restaurant. For a moment, you feel free and clear. Then, as a nearby light turns red, and cars stop, you see head turning, the car's occupants looking, eyes settling on you.

Shemz I curse loudly.

Then I find the closest apartment building and enter it, if the door is unlocked.

Wildbow The door leading into one set of apartments is open. A central set of stairs has doors on either side of the stairwell, leading to the apartments on either side of the building.

Shemz No, on second thought, breaking into an apartment would be harder with no windows. That's a waste of time.

I can't stop her from watching me if she knows where I am, too.

Fuck. I try to think for a moment if I can get back to the car without being in any main street.

Also, I look back out and check if people are watching me.

Wildbow **From your vantage point, there's nobody on the street looking into the apartment building.**

Further up the stairwell, a door opens. An older woman steps out, holding a phone to her ear.

You can just barely make out what she's saying, in French, "Yes, yes. I see him."

Shemz Back to the car it is.

I sprint.

Don't care if people watch me, unless they actively try to block me.

Wildbow **"Sir!" the woman calls out behind you, as you head back to the front of the apartment door.**

Shemz Not answering. Would waste my time.

Wildbow **As you make your way out onto the street and get your bearings, identifying the road you used to get here, you see police cars on the road. You'll have to pass in front of them to head back to your car.**

Shemz I could turn myself in. I'm tempted to do so. What have I done? Burgled a few houses and ruined a webcam?

If it weren't for Noire I'd probably do that. But she won't let it happen that easily.

Can't go to car, probably can't enter apartments. Probably.

I should have changed out of costume. Should've done this in night, too. Stupid, stupid.

I get where the cops can't see me, and enter a stairwell

*enter it, and go up the stairs

Wildbow **((The apartment building?))**

Shemz ((A different one))

((whoops))

Wildbow **You make your way a few buildings down. As you do so, you see a store selling electronics. The televisions are on, and your face is on some. Security footage from a nearby traffic-light camera is on others, everyone but you obscured.**

***masked face**

You reach the door to the apartment building and let yourself in.

Shemz I pull out my phone, and dial the emergency number, while ascending the stairwell.

Wildbow **The phone rings once.**
"Hello, Archival," Bête Noire says. "I've been trying to get someone to give you a phone."

Shemz "What's the matter, Bête? Wanted to hear me talk while the cops chain me?"

Wildbow **"How optimistic, Archival," she says. "I specifically told the cops to stay out of your way, that you were armed and dangerous and you had a close-range power. A simple arrest is too good for you."**

Shemz While speaking through the phone, I start silently pulling door handles on each floor, hoping for an unlocked door. "I'm glad you care that much about me. Why aren't you here yourself? Would have gone a lot quicker. Wouldn't have irritated so many people."

Wildbow **"Because I know how this works. Whichever one of us takes the upper hand keeps it. If one of us sees the other, we can track them. As much as I'd like to end you, Archival, I'm not stupid. That's why I contracted out."**
The doors you're trying are all locked.

Shemz "Well, you can keep your upper hand. But when I get away and all of your effort has been for nothing, we'll see if you're still that smug." I take out my lockpicks, start working on the door in front of me.

Wildbow **((Thievery roll))**

"If not today, then tomorrow. Or the day after, Archival. I'm patient. Just curious, do you have any idea how many capes there are in Lausanne right now?"

Shemz "Twenty? Thirty?"

Wildbow Managing the phone and the lockpicks at the same time is limiting your abilities. Your first attempt at lockpicking is unsuccessful, and the pressbar slips free, virtually setting you back to square one.

Shemz ((Can I try again, or have I lost it?))

Wildbow ((You can try again))

Shemz "How did you plan on following me now, then? Don't have cameras in the sewers."

I keep trying the same lock. Have to succeed.

Wildbow ((Roll))

"Almost a hundred, at last count, Archival. I wanted you to know just what it means when I say I've hired the most vicious of them. Trust me, I know where you are, I can find you at any time, knowing full well that you're not anywhere near the sewers, I didn't even have to pick them for their ability to track you down. I picked them because they're as sadistic and vicious as killers get Well, two of them are. The third is just really, really good at what she does."

The lockpick clicks, and the door opens. You're inside the apartment.

Shemz I enter, close the door behind me, and look around to see if anyone is there.

"Who?"

Wildbow The apartment is small, one bedroom that sort of doubles as a living room, a separate kitchen and bathroom. There's a back door.

"You'll meet one of them shortly. I should get on the other line to point them in the right direction. I just wanted you to know, when

they've got you, that it's really me, and that I'm listening to every word that's coming out of your mouth, and watching your expression. You threatened to kill my family, Archival. You die the worst death."

She hangs up.

- | | |
|---------|--|
| Shemz | <p>I take off my costume as fast as I can, keeping only my knife and the lockpicks. I dump it on the floor and slide it under the bed.</p> <p>I try to find a coat in the wardrobe, so that I don't freeze to death.</p> <p>Then I open the back door.</p> <p>((well, try to open it))</p> |
| Wildbow | <p>Opening the back door from the inside is no difficulty at all. Stairs lead down to the ground level. A maze of backyards, homes, fences, and streets sprawl before you.</p> <p>The coat around your shoulders, you make your way down.</p> |
| Shemz | <p>I pull out my phone, take out the batteries, and put back the battery case.</p> <p>I keep the phone held to my ear, and walk away from the building, back to the street.</p> <p>I fake talking on the phone, in case anyone looks.</p> |
| Wildbow | <p>((Bluff check; Social roll))</p> <p>Acting as naturally as you can, you keep the fake phone conversation ongoing.</p> <p>You can see people actively looking for you. Here and there, some eyes of people in cars and people on the street do settle on you. You can intuit that they have an up-to-date description.</p> <p>But the act and the less distinct appearance are keeping them from easily finding you as easily.</p> |
| Shemz | <p>I walk away from the crowd, the police, the attention. Moving slowly, blending in. Goal right now is to get someplace where people aren't looking for me, and figure out how to get my stuff later.</p> <p>While walking, I use my power on my apartment. Have to be sure nobody found it.</p> |

Wildbow **Walking while using your power is tricky. You nearly stumble into somebody.**

As your mind's eye opens and you get the view of the distant location, you see the wisps of two figures standing within your apartment. Your furniture, which should be at least a little more coherent, is tossed.

Shemz No apartment. No car. No costume.

 Damn it....Damn it all. Noire won, no matter how this goes.

 I return walking, cursing into the phone.

 Maybe...maybe I could find some temporary shelter, in the city. For the rest of the day.

 ((Waiting to get out of the danger zone))

Wildbow **((Roll Wits & Dex))**

The eyes on you continue to track your movement, and as you step off the busier street and onto a residential one, a pair of people turn off as well, following. You turn the next available corner to break line of sight, and manage to put some distance between yourself and the pursuers before you again notice some people looking your way. These ones don't deign to follow you, however,though they talk into phones.

Shemz I stop, turn, and approach them directly. Putting the phone back in my coat pocket.

 "Excuse me, where can I find the train station? I'm a bit lost."

 Keeping the hand in my pocket, being prepared to draw my knife.

Wildbow **They stop as they see you turn around. One speaks into his phone. Collectively, they begin to back away.**

They're pursuing, but they aren't looking for a confrontation, it seems.

Shemz I pull out my knife, aiming it at them. "Drop the phones. Now." I say loudly, "Put them on the ground."

Wildbow **Of the three, two bend down. One pulls off his hat and puts the phone down on top of it, so it won't get snow on it. The other**

simply places the phone in the snow. The third seems unwilling to drop the phone, but is holding it out to one side.

Shemz "NOW." I shout. "Or I'll put you down with it!"

Wildbow Rather than listen, he runs, straight in the other direction, the phone going straight back to his ear. The others, seeing the third member of the group bolt, seem inclined to do the same, backing away a little. It seems they don't want to leave their phones.
One speaks, "She said, online, we just had to follow. That's all. I'm sorry."

Shemz "Don't touch your phones. She's a mind controller, she can work through voice only. Leave them there, or take them but remove the batteries like I did."
I lower the knife.
"Tell everyone else. Please. I'm trying to stop her."

Wildbow ((Social roll))
"She said you were the killer," the man says. "She had a recording, of a meeting between you and other people. Saying you'd find and hurt her family if she kept getting in your way. She keeps playing it on the radios and on the television."
Further down the street, the one who bolted starts to turn the corner to the right, seems to jump out of his skin, and starts running to the left instead.

Shemz I shake my head, and then dash away. The opposite direction from where the third person is.
I look back once every few seconds, but try not to stop.

Wildbow ((Roll Ath))
You're put in mind of the sight earlier in the day, of the bird tearing apart its kin, as you put some distance between yourself and your pursuer. A quick glance over your shoulder suggests a figure seven feet tall and very wide at the shoulder, with a billowing black cape flapping behind them as they run in your direction. A bird mask covers their face, and you see the flash of blades, though the type and nature of those blades eludes you as you turn your focus back to where you're going.

The initial gap aside, it's looking like he's gaining on you over the longer-term, albeit a slow gain. From the looks of it, he's not the super competent one Noire mentioned, he's one of the sadistic bastards.

Wildbow's Comments:

At this point I call for a stop to the session. I'm a little frustrated at how things are going, and it's fairly clear that Shemz is panicking. There's little strategy behind what he's doing, the tension is getting to him, and under the justification that his character has Knowledge 4 and Wits 4, (above average depth of knowledge/skills, quickness of thought) I think it's fair to give him a bit of time to consider his options, look over his character sheet and decide what to do.

The Christmas holidays hit, and it winds up being a few weeks. When I reach out to him after the New Year, however, Shemz doesn't sound very confident or happy with the strategy/strategies he's come up with.

Let's recap, and go into detail with his character. Archival has fairly skewed stats, with:

- Lower Brawn - he's not strong and struggles to hurt others in a contest of strength.
- Lower Athletics - he's slower on foot (despite doing well in contested Athletics roll vs. pursuer just above, buying him a head start), less agile, and has poorer balance. This would also mean lower overall stamina, but take note of the Stubborn perk below.
- Normal Dexterity - no bonuses or penalties to accuracy, aim, hand-eye coordination.
- High Wits - Reflexes, speed of thought, perception, all above average.
- Low Social - he struggles in negotiation, debate, charm, reputation.
- High Knowledge - more skill points, learns faster
- High Guts - he's tough, can take more damage, keep going when others would collapse, etc.

He has the Stubborn perk, impacting how fast he gets tired - he gets two free points in

the Endurance skill (on top of his high # of skill points from his Knowledge stat) - while his low Athletics would negatively impact his stamina and ability to run longer distances for long times (or keep up any exhausting activity), the Endurance skill counters this. He can forego this bonus to get a free reroll at retrying something he just failed at.

He also has the Nemesis flaw, which we've gone into.

Further, he has four points in the Investigate skill (not useful here; helping with detecting lies and finding evidence), three points in thievery (sleight of hand, hiding evidence, not too useful) and one point in street smarts, a broad knowledge skill covering gangs, drugs, fences, illicit goods, etc.

His tinker power isn't too useful in this situation, given that he needs ten or more minutes to put something together, but it's a minor power. His primary power gives him the ability to clairvoyantly scan a wide area, getting exact, detailed and complete knowledge about that area on the fly, with clearer awareness about static things - things with a *history* within the aforementioned area. Transient things, like people, don't come across very clearly unless they have historically spent a great deal of time in that area.

Such are the tools he has in dealing with the current problem.

Wildbow

Last time, in Weaver Dice Lausanne: Burglar villain 'Archival' arrived in a new city, inspecting his apartment and struggling to gather information on the chaotic local scene, before going to earn a living doing what he does. Scouting out a nice building, he set to work, breaking in and perusing it for valuables, before strange things began unfolding around him - devices turning on and...

...spooking him, and voices. It was quickly revealed to be his archrival Bête Noire. She's both communicating and scouting his location through communications devices and dialogues with nearby civilians. Archival calls for help, and gets Bête Noire instead, taunting him with the fact that she's hired some very scary people to chase him down. As we wrapped up the last partial session, one...

...of those very scary people turned up, hot on his heels, and as fast as he runs, it looks as if they may catch up.

Shemz I keep running, as fast as I can. There's no way I can take him without any good tools or information. I focus all of my efforts on running forward, looking if there's anyone else approaching or watching.

Wildbow It's an uphill run, taking you up a one-lane street with driveways, fences, hedges, and impressive homes on either side. You see trash cans, the occasional car, and gardens. You know you can't keep this up forever. He's faster than you are.

Shemz I should probably conserve my strength, then. I stop, turn around and shout. "Hey! What's your name?". I steady the grip on my knife. Fuck.

Wildbow He slows as he closes the distance. "Rapere."
Behind his bird mask, his eye is on your knife. He touches his cape, which is festooned with blades. He's not slowing to a stop. He looks intent on getting in close.

Shemz "Rapere. I know she sent you after me. Stop, I have a deal to offer you.". I take a step forward, showing that I'm not planning to back off.

Wildbow ((Social roll))
Shemz fails miserably.

Raising the corner of his cape, he touches his bird mask with the blade at the cape's edge. "So says the bird in the hand?"

Shemz "So says the guy who has ten thousand Euros in cash, that could be yours if you stop and listen." I reply.

I try to assess him. Would I be able to pay my way out of this? Is he even here for the money, or just for the excuse

to slaughter somebody?

Wildbow ((Social roll & Empathy/Social roll))

Shemz gets two great successes

"I listen to ten thousand euros," he says. But your sense of things suggests he's enjoying this, his tone is amused, he has you in the palm of his hand. Your offer might appeal to him, but it won't satisfy him at the end of the day.

Shemz "It's not on my body, obviously. It's hidden in a bag, in a safe place, fifteen walking minutes away from here. I can tell you how to find it. Is Bête listening? You wouldn't want her to get there first."

Wildbow ((Social roll any time you dialogue & end your turn, for expediency's sake - one is needed here too))

"I hear a lot of people beg and scream and try to buy me off," he says. He steps closer, looming, intimidating you, still holding the end of his cape with the blade attached to it. "No, she's not listening. How about you tell me where it is, and I tell you what I know, and we go from there?"

Shemz ((What's the address where I stowed the bag with the jewelry?))

Wildbow ((Knowledge check to recall))

[Success]

((You recall the street name, but not the specific address - Chemin de Fontanettaz))

Shemz "It's in Chemin de Fontanettaz. Black bag, under one of the hedges. Dig a bit and you'll find it."

Wildbow He shakes his head, the beak of his mask swaying left to right. Then he lunges, holding the blade at his cape's edge-

((Decide dodge/block & roll it))

Shemz ((Block))

[Wild success]

Wildbow You're able to react, getting your arms up in time, the blade runs along your forearms, cutting sleeve more than flesh. He pulls the cape with him, and the blades affixed to the ends of it fly at you. With the worst of the initial blow deflected, they don't have the momentum to cut you.

In the next moment, he disappears with a heavy sound, more a thump than anything else, a miniature thunderclap. You feel more blades from the cape raking against your back. Superficial damage, scratches shredding cloth and leaving thin lines of blood against skin, but doing no damage that matters..

A foot strikes out, staggering you, making you stumble away from him.

Shemz I maintain my distance, and point my knife at him, but make no attempt at attacking. "I'm giving you a second chance. I'll tell you the full address, and you'll go and collect it. No need to help me or stop the others. Just stop what you're doing, and forget about me and her."

Wildbow **"What's the full address?" he asks.**

Shemz "Chemin de Fontanettaz, ninth house from the main road. Don't know the house number."

Wildbow **"Bird in the hand, versus one in the bush," he says. "It's not worth the hit to my reputation to let you go."**

He advances on you, holding the knife out toward your throat, "Keep retreating, walk backward, up that driveway there. Let's do this someplace more discreet."

Shemz I follow his commands. I walk backwards, and try to catch

my breath. Maybe this will work.

Wildbow

"She told me to take you to pieces. Emasculate you, take your fingers, toes, all the vital parts of your face that let you taste, hear, see. Finish you with a gut wound, so you die slow, dead to the world except for the pain," he says. "Given this is my field of expertise, I had suggestions on how to embellish the process, draw it out. She approved them. Now, I'm trying to decide if...

...you're telling the truth about the money. Last words from a dying man. The best compromise I can decide is that I'll make your death quick, instead of drawing it out. How's that?"

Shemz

"Sorry, I'd rather keep my neck. If you keep me alive, I could get you additional money. My power's pretty good for that. And I can take you there, if you want. Not lying about the place."

I glance around us while walking backwards. Making sure no other civilians are reporting to Bete Noire anymore.

Wildbow

Standing in the driveway, the fence and hedges nearby block your view of the street and much of the street's view of you. A path slopes up from the empty driveway toward a narrow house that likely costs millions. As you back up, you are approaching a point where even people in the house wouldn't be able to see far enough down and back to make you out.

"It's alright," he says, "I'll go look after we're done."

Shemz

"If that's what you wish, bird-brain. I won't go down easily."

I stop and prepare to attack him.

Wildbow

"They so rarely do," he said. "You were so damn close, you know. So close. You lost the phone, you tossed the costume she put a tracer on at your last encounter,

back in Paris. She was genuinely concerned when you stopped moving inside the apartment building, and she found that tracer."

He feints, testing you, but maintains the distance between you.

"Then you went back to the street. Back where she could see you, talking to people on the radio. If you'd escaped then, if you'd escaped -me-, then that would be that."

Shemz I lunge forward and slice with my knife at him.

I keep his teleportation power in mind, trying to be wary of him teleporting behind me again.

Wildbow ((Roll attack))

He feints again, and you seize the opportunity, catching him across the chest. It's a nasty cut, one that slices past costume to rake at ribs and scrape against bone. He lashes out in return, stabbing-

-and missing, with the pain of your initial hit. Much as he did before, he disappears.

Shemz I quickly spin around, and duck. I hold my knife forward in case he appears there, but brace for impact.

Wildbow No attack appears to be incoming. He's gone, completely.

Shemz I stand up, and throw a few quick glances around. He's escaped. Or is he still around, out of sight?

Wildbow ((Wits roll))

A check around you confirms, he's not in the driveway, there's no sight of him on the street, or in the narrow alley that runs between the house you're in front of and the neighbor's.

As you cast your eyes around, however, you see falling snow.

Looking up, you see him on the rooftop. He's got something in hand.

Shemz ~~I open my mind's eye, use my power to scan the area around me. He could be invisible. Or he could have escaped into the house with his power.~~

~~I take my time, and scan the house too.~~

~~oh, whoops! sorry~~

<scratch that>

What's the thing in his hand? I take a closer look. It could be a gun.

I aim the knife at him again.

Wildbow It looks to be a first aid kit. He splits his attention between you and his wound as he starts to patch himself up.

Shemz "What's that? Taking a break in your nest?" I shout, mocking him. I stand in place, and use my power on the house. 0x1dIs there any way for me to climb it, a ladder, a window I could climb?0x1d

Wildbow He doesn't respond. He continues to look after his wound. His breath fogs beneath his mask as he works.

Your power scans the house. Transient objects are harder to see, blurry, but you can see that the back door is unlocked. If you didn't want to go around the back, you could try breaking a window and going through.

((Should you go in, you can access the roof through an attic window))

Shemz I run to the back of the house and enter it.

I'll search the kitchen for some more knives, first.

Wildbow **Your power is a good enough means to help you find just what you're looking for. You let your self in and go straight to the kitchen, grabbing more knives. The way is clear, up a flight and a half of stairs to get to the rooftop.**

Shemz I keep the new knives in one hand, and go to the staircase. I use my power again, on the roof, trying to figure out if he jumped off. In any case, I'll ascend the stairs.

Wildbow **Your power works only on static things, things that don't move or that have history in a location. You're going in blind. You find the attic with no problem, pulling the stairs down from overhead. The window is off to one side.**

The view from the window is narrow, snow already covering the lower half.

Shemz I silently open the window, and climb up to the roof.

Wildbow **((Roll Sneak/Dex))**

Your skills lend themselves more to breaking in cleanly than to actually sneaking around with people listening and watching, but for now, with soft snow layering the roof and nothing really impeding you, you manage to slide the window open and set foot on the roof.

He's not where he was, before. He's crossed the rooftop, so he can look down at the back of the house. He would have tracked your movements as you went inside. Where he stands now, you face the option of either approaching from one side, facing a higher risk of being seen, or taking a more circumnavigatous route to approach him from behind.

Shemz I'll take the short route. I try to stay steady on the roof, while walking, and that might make some noise if I slip. Before

reaching the other side, I raise my right arm with the knife and shift my hold, preparing to throw it and grab one of the others.

Wildbow ((Roll sneak / dex))

[Shemz fails]

Shemz I shift my grip back and crouch, preparing for the hit.

Wildbow **The hit doesn't come. A full second passes.**

Then he lands on you. An attack from high above. His full weight hits you, followed by the blades.

((roll guts x2))

[Fail, fail]

At this point I roll for a bashing wound and a slashing wound, rolling on the tables for results. I get 'Walloped' (knocked away & fall to the ground) and 'Sliced' (you're left open for a follow-up attack).

The attack knocks the wind out of you, and drives your feet down and out from under you, slipping on the frost-slick rooftop beneath the snow. You tumble, rolling down the roof, and in the midst of it, he finds the opportunity to shiv you again.

((Moderate x2, minor wound))

((Roll Athletics to see if you roll off the rooftop))

[Shemz fails]

You hit soft snow, which is a plus, but you hit it hard enough you practically bounce. You would have been dazed as it was, but you lose all sense of direction, be it up or down, left or right. All you see is snow, stars in your eyes, and Rapere's feet, as he rather adroitly lands a matter of feet from you.

"I teleport," he says, as he dusts himself off. "But my

range is only up to five feet, horizontally. Vertically, no limit, for what that's worth."

((Roll Guts vs. unconsciousness))

[Shemz fails]

The pain is adding up, you can feel yourself bleeding warm blood into cold snow, as the body heat leeches out of you. You're passing out.

Shemz ((What happened to the knives?))

Wildbow ((You're holding one))

Shemz I take a deep breath and try to keep going. If I pass out, there's no chance for me to wake up. Simple as that.

Shemz "Fuck...You should have taken the deal, dammit." I groan, and try to rise. I still have the knife.

Shemz One last stab, maybe. I can't go down like this.

Wildbow ((You failed your guts check re: falling unconscious. I'm forcing you to use your Stubborn perk reroll at this point))

Shemz ((yes, am doing that))

Wildbow You teeter, but you manage to stand on your feet. You're still slightly stunned, your vision wavering, but it is what it is. He stands tall, a bandage plastered over the deep wound you delivered to his side.

Shemz I feint a slice, and then lunge forward with the knife. Aiming for his chest, this time.

Wildbow ((Make yer rolls))

((-2 penalty for stagger))

[Shemz gets a zero, with accumulated penalties]

You stumble at him, blade in hand, and he catches you, almost as gently as someone might embrace a family

member.

He lets you go, then teleports, appearing behind you. Your reactions are slow as you move to defend yourself-

((Roll defenses))

[Shemz succeeds]

-but you manage to get your arms up to deflect yet another stab. Another shallow wound, this one to the back of your hands, as he goes for the throat. You stumble back.

((No damage - only superficial harm))

"If I'd known you had this much fight in you, I might have been more inclined to take the deal," he observes.

Shemz "No," I cough, "You won. I tried, but you won." I lean back and collapse into the snow. Too tired to fight back.

"Please make this...quick."

Wildbow He nods. "Throw the knife away."

Shemz I let go of the knife, leaving it lying next to me, and fold my arm back.

Wildbow "Throw it away," he says. "You've tried my patience enough this morning."

Shemz I reach and grab the knife again, and throw it directly at him.

Wildbow ((Roll Dex))

[Fails]

He sidesteps easily as the knife flies through the air. Even if he hadn't moved, it likely wouldn't have done substantial damage.

"Right," he says. He doesn't sound surprised or angry.

"We do this the hard way."

He approaches at a swift pace, and before you can get your bearings, kicks your head.

((Roll Guts))

[Fail]

((And again, vs. unconsciousness.))

[Fails]

Your head cracks against the wall you were resting against. Stars explode across your vision, and you feel yourself passing out. No fighting your way to a waking state, not this time.

"She wanted photographs as I worked," he said, "so don't go dying on me just yet."

He starts to drag you

"We'll see how long you last before the homeowners get home. Assuming a nine to five, we've got at least six hours."

////

Session End

////

Wildbow Commentary:

Shemetz was the last of the players to have their first session. Like other players, he faced a high intensity situation, testing his limits. My goal, with Shemz and all the other players, was to test their abilities, with the situation proving tough enough that they had to stretch themselves or exercise some problem solving to make it through.

I found he struggled with that here. Shemz himself admitted he made some mistakes, and after he spent some time running around somewhat aimlessly, with no apparent plan in mind, I called a halt to things to try and give him time to get his head on right. Rather than play to his strengths, he played more to his weaknesses, which was more apparent with him when he didn't have a strong combat power.

I feel some of the fault lies with me - Shemz apparently came away from the description of Rapere's chase thinking he couldn't/wouldn't get away, (Shemz had the advantage of stamina, but not foot speed, so it's questionable - doable with successful dice rolls or lucky dodges/time). It wasn't a good option, but it wasn't the worst option either, and I inadvertently steered him away from it. I could have emphasized the distance between them. Perhaps I could have given him more cues in terms of environment too, with his environment-driven power.

That said, after having weeks to consider the problem, he didn't problem-solve. Instead he (with a penalty to social) tried and failed to talk/negotiate his way out of it, tried (with no combat power, versus a cape wearing a cloak/cape covered in blades) to brute force his way through with a knife in hand, had a particularly lucky hit, and rather than take the opportunity of his opponent sitting back and healing to put some distance between them, pressed the attack, giving chase through a house, onto (with low athletics; agility/balance) a snowy rooftop. Unfortunate dice rolls did the rest, with his enemy landing a particularly savage blow, knocking him from the roof.

It was frustrating to GM, to put it lightly.

Interlude 1 - Lausanne

‘Down’ Arc - 1.x

Claude Wicht leaves the television on as she dons her costume. It's not a particularly fancy one, but she's not a particularly fancy woman. The mutation of a large eyeball at her shoulder makes getting dressed hard, as she pulls on a black leather motorcycle vest, modified with a motorcycle visor and metal sheets to cover her mutation, and both a shirt and pants with patches only partially stitched on, so that the tentacles from her power can snake through. She's not in a particular rush.

A fire blazes at an apartment building across the city. If Claude wanted, she could look out her window and see the flare of light and the plume of smoke against the early dawn. The television shows the fire up close, the cameras working to zoom in and track some heroes working to save those on the upper floors. A great stone hoop stands at one corner of the roof, and people leap through, appearing on the ground a distance away.

Another casualty of recent fights, probably. People fighting among themselves, starting something, with too many getting caught in the aftermath.

She takes a moment to pen out a note. Walking to her front door, she affixes the note beneath the knocker, the words facing the door.

The city is in bad shape, but she can at least police a small portion of it, while she waits for a response.

By the time she returns to her living room, the tone of the discussion on the television has changed. It's excited, hopeful, not speaking in tones appropriate to disaster and tragedy.

Claude looks at the screen, and she sees the golden man, captured on camera by the news crew. Scion. She stops and watches, because Scion always warrants paying attention to, especially when he's in your city.

Even with the volume from the camera crews reduced so the news anchors can be heard, Claude hears the cheering of the people on the street.

Hope.

The fires go out, quieted by a golden light. The smoke, even, dies down. Scion passes into the building, collecting two people, and carries them down to the ground. The building creaks, and he turns, raising a hand. The light he casts is faint, but it solidifies ice around the most damaged part of the building, supporting it.

Claude looks away as the golden man rises to give assistance to others. She takes a moment to get her things in order. Donning her mask, she becomes her costumed persona, for what little it's worth. She's fairly recognizable as it stands, whether she's Claude or Cuttlefish.

But she soon looks back to the television as the sound of the crowd takes on another tone. News anchors are left speechless, and, belated, the studio shifts the audio so that the television echoes the noise of the gathered crowd and camera crew.

This cry is one of *wonder*.

The camera wobbles as it rises to center on a silver-white figure, floating in the sky.



Another night spent working, Robert muses, as the light comes to shine through the window and into his abandoned-boathouse-turned-workshop. At least the repairs for the life-sized toy soldiers damaged in last week's incident are finished.

He stands and stretches, a hand resting on his belly as he walks to the window. Having spent so much time lost in his tinkering, he has shed at least ten kilos since he gained his power. Still, he has a way to go.

Old drones repaired, some new work done, a lot more work yet to be finished.

He washes his hands free of grease and then washes his face, the scruff on his cheeks scraping at his palms. Only a little bit refreshed, he turns his mind to food, issuing an idle order to one of his drones to turn on the radio.

What he hears is interesting enough to make him stride to his tinker workbench. He sits in his chair and fiddles until he has a reception on the display screen.

A silver woman floats in the air, framed by vast angelic wings. She moves as Scion does, cutting him off. The golden man stops in his tracks, staring at her.

She is two-and-a-half times as tall as he is, and her wings make her seem much greater, arranged in a circle behind her, making her appear to be more a flower than an angel. The figure almost dwarfed by her wings, the largest of which are three or four times as long as she is tall. Her long, silvery hair blows behind her.

Robert Pelle, Armada, moves his fingers above the interface of the worktable, bring up the volume controls and turning on the sound. He is just in time to hear the noise of the crowd fade. The outcry dies down, becoming something very near to silence.

The two's body language is similar, their moods not so different. It's a somber scene.

There is emotion in her action as she raises a hand, hesitating to the point of pausing for a full second, before she reaches out. Her hand touches the side of his face, long silver fingers resting against golden beard and cheek.

Then he flies, directly skyward, and she flies after him, a corkscrew flight, centered around his straight line. Where he leaves a streak of golden light behind him, she leaves a tight flurry of collected snowflakes, her wings and hair straight out behind her, purely for display.

Even if she were to fly in a straight line, he would be faster. She falls behind as he reaches the cloud layer, and then spreads her wings, as if they could help stall her flight and bring her to a stop.

Armada leans forward, both elbows resting on his workbench, and steeples his fingers as he watches the footage from the news. Crowd, news crews and news anchors are silent as they observe the silver angel's flight, moving only a short distance to position her above the tallest building in Lausanne, Taoua Tower.

Her body language mirrors the golden man's, on the day he first appeared. As he had hovered lost and dejected, above the ocean waves, she hovers over the city, dangling toetips barely making contact with the surface of the roof, if at all.

Armada peers past steepled fingers to watch as the silence is broken, the questions overlapping one another.

■

The rat squeals as a claw-like member spears through it.

Reimann -who no longer has the memory to call himself by such- straightens. The mutant limb that stretches overhead, like a flesh-covered scorpion tail, holds the dead rat at the end. He catches the leaking blood in a piece of bent sheet metal.

Breath hisses and wheezes from his cavernous mouth. He has no chin, no throat, only an open chamber, organs visible at the bottom end, ribs and teeth intermingled and indistinguishable from one another, a great fanged maw.

The eyes above that maw are human, however, sharp and scrutinizing.

This rat is fatter than the usual.

His tinker's eye evaluates it, measures it in terms of the raw components it could provide. Blood, fat, bone, brain. Was it better to sate his hunger, or for his work? With each and every rat, he had to make the same call.

A golden light streaks across the colorful sky, tinted peach by the sunrise. It is Scion, going more *up* than over. Reimann steps further into the shadows of the alleyway, wary.

As he watches, a larger figure follows, before revealing the bulk of its form to be vast wings.

He tracks the figure as it stops, then changes direction, finding a roost on a nearby building.

Two rats in hand, makeshift pan in the other, and a rat speared on one of his extraneous limbs, he hurries back indoors. In here, it isn't necessarily *warm*, but it isn't nearly so cold or exposed to the wind, either.

The old grocery store serves as a workshop, though it was liable to be a temporary one. He'd produced surprisingly little mess over the last week and a half, with dozens of rat corpses being rendered down into constituent parts, ground down, distilled, and refined into other elements with the help of his power. Tin cans, emptied of food, now serve as

opaque beakers for a concoction he is brewing. Other pieces of armor and a weapon would eventually be complete, but for the time being lay on the floor, the individual parts neatly set down in very intentional locations.

As he looks, he sees how they would come together, and he sees a hundred small things he needed to do to fix something, make that piece more usable, make this piece serve. He carefully sets down the rats and the pan. Two fingers pry the rat from his mutant limb, letting it fall roughly where it should be. His toe nudges it over.

All of that can wait.

The floor is the messiest part of the building. Oils, fats, chemicals and bodily fluids stain it. He walks between the worst stains, knowing he could dissolve the sole of his boot if he isn't careful. In the corner of the building is a security office, one that once held a single employee, some radios, and a set of television screens. The store had been cheap, the televisions are long out of date; each of the screens is small enough to cover with both hands pressed flat against them.

He has put off dismantling the screens, because he has figured out a way to get reception, and sometimes he likes to hear voices, even if the feed is plagued with the crackle of static.

That crackle makes it hard to hear the voices as he listens to the Newscasters. They compare this woman to the golden man. Some worry, they talk about dangers, and revisit long-asked questions about who Scion is and where he comes from.

Reimann, no longer truly the bookish PRT intern with a fascination for capes, closes his eyes and listens. He tries to ignore the rasp of his own breathing, and as he follows the discussion and thinks about the questions, he feels more like himself than he has in a long time.

It's almost enough to make him doze off. It has been a long night, and he is somewhat nocturnal now. He's tired.

But then he hears. Amid the crackling, or *in* the crackling, a distortion, a pattern.

He reaches for the toggles and the box he attached to the television to get a reception, and as he fiddles, it becomes clearer. As he *listens*, however, it dissolves, escaping him. For two or three minutes, he wrestles with his own perception and the tinkering -

getting further away from the television signal and closer to the tinker side of the signal makes the distortion clearer. Focusing on the task makes it fade away, almost as if it is aware he is aware of it. It is only when he is lost in the tinkering or thinking about other things that it is clearest. It reverberates in the place where his memories once were.

And then it is gone. He continues to work, but it is as if the signal was never there. He sits back, puzzled and vaguely concerned. That concern stays with him as he crosses the back of the grocery store to get to his supper.

It sounded like *singing*, of all things.

Arc 1 End

SCG/Armada & Antioch/Reimann

Lausanne 'Albatross' Arc - 2.1

Table of Contents

[Recap](#) - [A note on Weaverdice Tinkering](#) - [Session 2.1.A](#) - [Session 2.1.B](#) - [Session 2.1.C](#)

Recap

To recap: SCG plays 'Armada', who is tall, rotund, and who has a nice napoleon-style hat. He was a business owner, and, ostensibly due to the second of the two Endbringers, his shipping business failed, driving him and all of his employees to ruin. He triggered to get a tinker ability, the ability to make mechanical, humanoid drones capable of using medieval weapons. His other gear complements or augments his ability to utilize them. When we last left off, he'd been sending his drones off to collect scrap where they could, and one returned damaged. He went out to find the individual who damaged his drone, and ran into some capes instead, cutting them down, beheading one muscular brute of a man (the head would later be minced and the pieces flushed down a toilet), escaping the group's ranged attacker and crashing his van to buy himself an opportunity to flee the third, a clawed attacker, leaving his remaining drones to fight the man. It was a coin toss whether the cape would win or lose the fight, and in the end, Armada's drones came home, dragging the clawed cape with them.

Antioch, meanwhile, was a Cauldron cape, who got a bad roll of the dice, both literally and figuratively. He became a monster, with extra limbs jutting out of his shoulders, his chin, the front of his neck, and his upper chest forming one gaping, fanged maw. His tinker powers are somewhat more direct, with an emphasis on short ranged weapons, heavy armor, and biotinkering, with a great deal of crossover. He drew the ire of local police and made a break for it, ultimately using a ruse to fake his own death, putting an unconscious man in his power armor, dousing him in flesh-melting acid, and pushing him (and the armor) out a second-floor window. He then set up shop in an abandoned grocery store.

Both took note of the news as the 'angel' appeared, dancing with Scion before setting down on a building overlooking the city.

A note on Weaverdice Tinkering

A note on two things, before I get underway, for mechanics...

First off, between the first and the second session, I told players to give me a set of actions they were undertaking between sessions. For the tinkers, this time is invaluable, as it determines what they bring into their next session.

Second off, a bit on how they build, and how they each work...

SCG/Armada opted to emphasize research, repairing his existing drones, buying a truck to get around with, building a scanning bench to better analyze subjects and improve his work, while opening the way for new ideas.

When Armada builds, he can pick a drone type (at present, only 'simple soldiers' with bad stats and dog-like intelligence), a pattern to map onto the drones (one gives + to Brawn and a side bonus of added combat awareness, another makes them faster and more agile), and a weapon set to give to those drones, being limited to fairly standard swords, axes, spears, bows, etc. Because it's very mix and match, the number of options are fairly diverse, though Armada has a power flaw that limits him and makes his initial list fairly *dry*. For now, however, it's one type of drone (simple soldiers), eight types of pattern/augmentation, and either melee or ranged weapons for the drones. He can sit down and research any one of these areas and expand a given list of options.

Conversely, however, he (and Anti) can use scanning devices (handheld, consumable) or take stuff back to his scanning bench and get detailed data, feeding his shard details that it can use to inspire his particular fields of work. Not everything will work, but the corpse of the clawed cape does. Had he not flushed it down the toilet, the head of the brute would have worked too. It might not surprise avid Worm fans, but the shard rewards these sorts of research (that is, research conducted via. proximity to conflict, if not via. conflict, violence and death itself) with more ideas, faster.

Meanwhile, Antioch, having lost his armor, built a new set. He also built a weapon, a lens (upper face), a mask (covers his gaping maw & enables speech, some side benefits), and brewed a concoction. When Antioch builds armor or weapons, he picks a base suit of armor (of six, each with unique functions) or a base weapon (eight options; most are very short range/melee), and then applies one of six patterns/element to that armor/weapon.

Here's the catch, though. Tinker lists aren't always very clear. Some items aren't detailed in full, and the tinker has the idea, but needs to figure it out in the field or with an excess of time at the research bench. Antioch went *ham* on this stuff. He brewed a 'concoction' - a consumable that would turn out something in his field of specialty, but would require field testing to actually figure out. His lens and mask, he had no idea what the full use of the things were, beyond the fact that they had a HUD and some beneficial side effect, respectively. His weapon? He built a Blood Gauntlet, knowing that Blood could make enemies bleed excessively, but that there was more to it that only field testing would reveal, and that the Gauntlet had an added function when grappling an enemy that, again, he wouldn't fully grasp until he tested it. His armor had the more mysterious Blood quality as well.

SCG had a similar affair with the 'Reception' pattern for his drones. It's a big question mark for him, and one that he looks to answer.

The 'angel' arrived less than twelve hours ago, as we start...

Session 2.1.A

Wildbow The truck pops and rattles as you test the engine. Your eye for tinkering is as much hindrance as help as you let it rove over the vehicle. You can see the individual components, you have a sense of the materials, and you know how you could use it to put together a squadron of your toy soldiers.

It's a pretty shoddy truck, but it's going to get you from A to B. The state of it suggests it's probably going to break down in the next couple of months, and you'll probably pay what this guy is asking for twice over in repair costs before the year is over. For now, however, it's doable. The seller is a kid who probably doesn't know how to take care of a truck. Twenty-something, a scarf worn for decoration rather than warmth, even though he's very

clearly cold, his hands jammed into his pockets as he shuffles his weight from one foot to the other. Impatient, he asks, "Well?"

SCG ((Asking price?))

Wildbow ((1k))

SCG Robert cuts the engine, before stepping out and gently closing the door of the truck. He looks the kid in the eye. "It'll have to do.", he says, pulling out his wallet. "This is the third truck I've looked at today, remind me, it was \$900, right?"

Wildbow "One thousand," he says, sounding unimpressed. ((Feel free to Social))

SCG Robert shrugs. It's not worth the hassle. "Works for me.", he says, fishing the money out of his wallet.

Wildbow He hands over the keys and paperwork, signs where appropriate, and then turns to make his way back to his house. You're on the outskirts of Lausanne. You wave at your taxi driver to let him know you're fine, and then climb into your van.

It's snowing a fair amount, but the wind is more hassle than the snow is, moving the snow more horizontally than it falls vertically. The time on the dash reads 10am.

SCG It's not as nice as his old semi, but it's a start. Time to pick up the parts. It's time for some new projects, as well as some repair.

Wildbow ((Let's assume that's all covered at this stage, don't want to bog down the session intro. You managed to get the other stuff, but now you've got the truck, to make stuff

easier in the future. Research projects & repairs are done))

SCG Robert still has the angel on his mind. His feelings on the matter are complex, but one thing is certain. That thing...whatever or whoever it is, it's powerful enough to get the attention of Scion. It's even mimicking his behavior, when he first showed up. This is an opportunity. Nobody was smart enough to get a scan of Scion, when he appeared. He will not make that same mistake.
He goes back home. It's time to build something special.

Wildbow It's a winding path to the boathouse that you turned into a workshop, one that takes you first through the downtown area. Sure enough, as you turn your head, you can see the tower, and you can make out the vague shape of the angel, stationary above the building, backlit by sun and a patchwork of blue sky and heavy clouds that move with surprising speed along the horizon.

You leave it behind as you turn toward the harbor, then make your way further down, to the building. One floor, long and long abandoned, with multiple shutter doors, dating back to when people would store their personal-use boats there for the winter.

You let yourself in, past minor security measures, and lock the door behind you. Rank and file of drone, many freshly repaired, stand at the ready - six runners, laborers to help him with his work, and two with swords, more combat oriented. A new scanning bench sits beside the workbench, and the corpse of the man with the claws floats above it, held in the air as the scanner does

sweeps, tracing him in red and blue lines, painting lines where the man's nervous system is, and paying particular attention to claws.

You look at the data, and it's customized to your own particular tinker sense. You can intuitively understand what it's telling you, and ideas flood into your mind. A partial idea for better drones. Ways to outfit your drones with claws. Ways to use this altered nervous structure as a wiring frame and joint system for bodysuit or drone.

SCG He looks at the man who had been foolish enough to attack him. At least he was useful in death.
He stares at the screens, lost in thought.
An idea strikes. The angel is directly above a radio tower. With all of that equipment there...maybe he could get a scan remotely? Hack in somehow?

Wildbow Activating the workstation gives a limited connection to the internet - thanks to a connection to a laptop, inserted into a slot below. A search and attempt to get a closer view of things suggests that the tower is a high-rise, a 24-floor apartment complex in Lausanne downtown. With current tech, you would have to get to the top floor if you wanted to achieve anything.

SCG Dangerous. His last outing had resulted in the loss of soldiers and his semi. And he doubted the community would appreciate his killings, however justified. He could very well be a target.

He's had an idea for an antennae for a while now. Something that could help him to control his soldiers from afar. Maybe he

could tweak that in some way, to give him access from somewhere closer? If not, things might have to get dicey. Workable, but not ideal.

Wildbow Your ideas for an antennae stand - it was always a consideration when you thought about extending the operating range of your drones in the vicinity of your workshop. The problem would be getting it into the building, as it would weigh four hundred pounds, give or take a hundred, and for optimal signal strength...

You tap away on the keyboard. 300 feet. You would need to get the thing at least halfway up the building and installed. After that, it would just be a question of fixing a scanning device to it and getting it there for long enough - a matter of one or two minutes.

SCG Another wasted train of thought. He discards the idea. Too much that can go wrong.

He runs some quick tests. Would a Skulk drone be able to operate a scanning trinket?

Wildbow In terms of mental capacity, the standard drones aren't much smarter than a dog, though they're far more obedient. After installing the hardware, inspired by the clawed cape, stronger limbs, stronger joints, better facility of movement... not quite enough room for human intelligence. The scanning device would have to be set to a switch, made simple enough to be flicked on. It wouldn't be fancy, and the drone would not only have to get up close - top floor or roof - but make its way back with the retrieved data.

SCG

Wildbow ((5 lbs))

SCG Good enough. He gets to work on the single drone and trinket. This will be a low-risk, high reward scenario. Not his main mission.

He sets his data terminal to research local gangs, capes, and their territories, while he goes about his work. It's about time he had a successful meeting.

Wildbow The terminal whirs as you do internet search - it's not a data terminal, the screens are for x-rays and logs as you put components together, so it's not nearly as fancy as it might otherwise be. Still, you turn your focus to the goings-on in Lausanne.

A new team, sponsored by international parties, has taken up partial residence in Lausanne, aiming to clean up the streets. Territory: ambiguous. They call themselves the Suits, and virtually every name that comes up in association with them is a heavy hitter.

The group termed 'Z', for lack of a better name, exists as more mystery than substance. They're associated with the bulk of the infighting in Lausanne, and with the production of massive suits of power armor that they've been handing out to criminal and hero alike. They're based somewhere in the downtown area, it seems.

((Knowledge roll x3))

You dig for more details on local mysteries and threats, hoping to turn up more on Z, and instead, all you turn up is strange notes on the behavior of wildlife, particularly birds and fish owned as pets, and a higher reporting of dog bites.

Other gangs, powers... possible vigilante going after the power suits, you click for the article and instead get a noisy pop-up.

And, perhaps more importantly, you take note of the collection of individuals near the tower with the angel. The Suits, which is information you already had, and a group of heroes. A picture shows an aerokinetic flier and a woman wreathed in lightning, among others. Guarding the building and managing the crowds.

SCG

He immediately stops work on the drone.

No use for that, now. There's no chance in hell he'd be able to get in range. His drone would be easily picked off, if his last experience with lightning was anything to go by.

Fucking bullshit.

He steeples his fingers for a few moments, collecting himself, before getting to more research. He can't keep going against people alone, even with his soldiers. There are too many capes out there, people that could single-handedly ruin him. As it stands, his latest 'victory' costed him far more than he had gained.

He needs allies. He searches.

Wildbow A few searches get you to back-channel forums. You're not streetwise enough to know the legitimate from the jokes, but you can see options in terms of mercenaries and the like, and you can narrow those options down to Lausanne and the surrounding area. It's a question of what you're looking for.

SCG He isn't looking for mercenaries. He's looking for the dregs. The desperate. People on the outside of the system, as he is. He isn't looking to get on the inside of a gang, here. That comes with gang politics, and he'd be sucked into their petty issues. He wants to stay outside of that system as much as possible.

Wildbow ((Knowledge check, again))
It's a narrow selection of people, who have both an internet connection and qualify as a dreg. A search in the drug sale sub-forums of the darker side of the internet turn up more complaints and accusations of sting operations than actual desperate sorts. You're forced to scratch that option from your list.

SCG He shifts his attention to news reports. People that have arrived on the scene recently, like him? Outside of Z or the Suits. Both sound like trouble. While he's at it, he also looks himself up.

Wildbow A kid killed by a thrown chunk of concrete. A man butchered and left on display. A gang of teenage hooligans. More mentions of the Suits...

The workstation beeps to alert you that the internal microforge has reached a set temperature. You dismiss the notification absently.

That project is on hold for the time being.

((Knowledge check))

The internet is too fiddly a thing. Too new to the public, too slow. You're not getting the results you need. A better option might be to find a newspaper, or reach out and ask someone... returning to the forums, you find suggestions of a 'villain bar' in Lausanne

SCG He sighs. It'll have to do.

((I -do- know that the Z's trade suits for bodies right?))

Wildbow ((Knowledge roll))

The results from the search and the articles on Z suggest they reward violence and a pattern of behavior with suits. At least one instance of someone defeating a suit-wearer and later being seen wearing one.

SCG Hrm. He doesn't really plan to continue killing people. It's messy and costly. All the more reason to find this 'villain bar'.

But his suit is still incomplete. He decides to finish it, build the final components and install them. Beyond that, he decides to go with what he knows works, for now. Combat drones. Four more. Archers, this time. After he's done the construction, he's gonna find himself some information.

Wildbow ((A full day's work))

SCG ((That's fine. No rush, since the angel is inaccessible))

Wildbow ((What augment for the bodysuit?))

SCG ((Runner.))
((ER. Make that Data.))

Wildbow You get underway with the work, getting the suit out and laying it flat, before making use of purchased supplies. The data-focused augment is quickly wired to allow easier access to notes and records, an eye's glance over to pull up recorded notes and particulars.

It's something of an unknown, forging forward, but as you pass the point of no return, the blurry mental pictures become clear. The suit connects to the workstation, the laptop, and the scanning bench automatically. While worn, complete with a laser feeding into the eye from the fantastic hat you created, the suit provides free access to the internet and all existing databases and systems. It can't scan, unfortunately, but it does allow remote uploads and downloads of scans.

It's interesting to experiment with, while you piece together your archers. You'll be more free to expand your breadth of skill while wearing the suit, but it will take time to get used to and get up to speed with it. You hesitate as you debate what augmentation, if any, to add to your archers.

SCG On the first three archers, Labor augmentations will do just fine. On the last...He's been meaning to test Reception. Might as well do it now.

Wildbow For the first three, enhanced coordination, aim, and facility with tools. Good for archers, they're not at least as competent with a bow as an unpracticed human would be

- enough to operate the weapons and hit a target with fair accuracy, but not quite talented. The other augmentation, a blur in your mind's eye, ends up connecting to your thoughts on the antennae. It's a receptor, transmitting and extending signal, and...

The drone swings its legs over the end of the table and hops down. It salutes. "Reporting for duty, sir."

SCG Oh Jesus.

Armada stands there, tools in hand, frozen for a moment.

"Fuck. Okay. Welcome aboard."

He immediately starts testing the drone, putting the scanner on it. What were its capabilities? Was it more intelligent?

Wildbow The scanning workbench opens a map of the brain infrastructure. Still about as smart as a dog when operating on its own, but it's mapped with basic commands, ability to take more complicated commands, and to relate those commands. In the loosest sense, it's a functional squad captain and/or general.

SCG Well, that's useful. As long as he can keep this one in sight...he'll be able to have it control others. Hell, he can use voice commands if necessary. -VERY- useful.

He looks at the clock.

Wildbow ((Roll dex))

**The work ran long, and it's late at night - it's midnight.
You're tired, you've barely eaten, but you can tend to
both, albeit with most of the evening gone in the process.**

SCG He tends to both, before heading out. He takes the truck closer to the city, drones hidden in the back, before abandoning it in a safe, out of the way place. He avoids the area he went to before, in favor of the downtown area.

Wildbow ((To clarify, you're wearing your costume or no? And which drones? You have a lot and a pickup can only carry ~6 or so, 7 if the passenger seat is occupied))

SCG ((Squad leader is bringing most of them to meet me, taking a different path. Leaving one athletic drone in the warehouse with orders to restrain anyone coming in that isn't me. Bringing all the combat drones except one melee that will stay with the squad leader until meet up. Suit off, currently. Nobody in passenger seat.))

((suit is in the back))

Wildbow A row of small birds, akin to sparrows, are settled on a fence beside you, huddled together, as you pass by. Their heads don't turn and they don't take off as you pass them, despite your closer proximity.

You're downtown, and the area is both quaint and beautiful, an old fashioned city punctuated by highrises here and there. The angel is a matter of blocks away, watching over all.

Having lived in Lausanne much of your life, you can tell that the streets are busier than they usually are, and the

difference is especially pronounced after the past few weeks of disaster - people were staying away, and now they crowd closer, aiming to get a look at the figure above.

SCG ((for clarification, was just getting close to downtown before donning the suit))
((and abandoning things))

Wildbow ((Close enough, works))

SCG He searches the area for gang-signs and symbols, ordering his drones to do the same. He figures somebody will come to meet him soon enough. This -is- pretty obvious. This time, however, things will go differently. He hopes.

**Wildbow The 'z' recurs, but efforts seem to have been made to cover up or remove the worst of it. The civilians notice you before anyone else, and hurry on their way, to give you a wider berth.
((if you want to roll social!presentation, you can convey an image))**

SCG ((Strength. But he's not pushing people out of the way or saying anything. He lets people escape/move at their own pace.))
((Drone can repeat things like "We are not here to fight, carry on, etc."))

Wildbow ((roll))

The situation is chaotic and the attitudes of the public hard to read. People stay out of your way, and you make your way through the outskirts of downtown. More 'z'

signs mark the walls, and you see damage here and here, but there's a conspicuous lack of gang tags.

A cape advances, dressed in crimson robes. The shoulders have rocks embedded in them.

"What are you doing?"

SCG Armada looks at the cape. "Looking around.", he says simply.

"I'm not here to cause any trouble. Thank you for asking, by the way. You have good manners."

Wildbow She doesn't give you the impression she's very impressed. Her white mask, also studded with rocks and gems, hides her expression. "There's been too much violence as of late. Tensions are high, and people are scared. Walking around with a small army of armed... tin men, you're going to start something, and with this area already more crowded than usual, people are going to get hurt."

SCG "Hrm. Understood. I can respect that."
"I'm just here to talk. To gather information. Not to get people hurt. Is there somewhere better, where we could talk?"

Wildbow "Are you on the side of the angels, or are you walking a more dangerous path, Mr...?"

((Social roll))

SCG "Armada."

He cracks his neck.

"I don't know anymore."

Wildbow "I'm going to give you the benefit of a doubt, and suggest that you're not like the other ominously neutral tinkers we've been hearing about. This 'z'," she says.

"If you'd told me you were a villain, I'd be telling you there's a place to go talk. The people gathering there have been more disciplined than some of the, ah, free roaming criminal elements that we've seen lately. If you'd told me you were a hero, I could have taken you to meet the Suits at the tower. They're trying to coordinate local heroes so we can be as effective as possible. Without a straight answer, I'm left suspicious and unsure what to do with you. If we're going to talk somewhere off the beaten track, I'd want to call friends, so I have backup. Even with them..."

She eyes your creations

"...I imagine I'd be outnumbered."

SCG "Discipline...That's promising. I very much doubt that the Suits would want me. Where is this meeting place, for the villains?

Wildbow Her attitude shifts visibly at the question. "They used to meet at a barbershop. With the influx of new visitors, they've relocated."

She gives you directions. It's not terribly far. Your suit lets you log the details without writing anything down.

"It's known as the Lodge. Bring weapons if you have them, don't dare to use them," she tells you.

SCG "Thank you. Please let the Suits know I might be sending a simple drone down to communicate with them, later."

"Oh, and what was your name?"

Wildbow "Calcaire," she tells you. "I'm with the Patrol."

She indicates the general direction of the tower. "I'll let the Suits know. They're set up in the tower, top floor. We're in a neighboring building, and we're offering our assistance, protecting the area and managing the crowd."

SCG "I appreciate it. Thank you."

"I owe you one, Calcaire," he says, before moving on.

Wildbow You walk along the downtown area, observing the crowds, who rubberneck and gawk.

The Lodge is just that. It's a large, ostentatious looking building, old fashioned and very much done up in the local style, set at the side of a hill-

((Wits check - failed))

You make your way up to the building without incident. Bouncers with guns in holsters stand on either side of the door.

SCG Armada keeps his hands to his side, approaching the door. He has the squad leader speak for him. "May we enter?", it asks.

Wildbow **He nods, not moving, leaving you to open the door yourself.**

SCG Armada has a runner drone open the door for him, slowly.

Wildbow **No less than twenty costumed individuals are within. None wear the large suits of power armor you read about. They come in all shapes and sizes, man and woman, but there's something of a more -elegant- vibe to them, if you had to lean one way or the other. Only a small handful of the type that give off the psychopath vibe. A preponderance of villains who wear fur collars or heavier coats as their costumes. One woman, slender, with pale hair, in the company of teenagers, and a man in a suit of armor that looks tinker made, but nowhere similar to the suits of armor made by 'Z'.**

It's all oak, polished to a buttery glow with metal trim, built to last and to endure a brawl. You notice one table, where the wood once splintered from a bullet hole, and the crack and damage were filled in with what looks to be gold, before being lacquered over. Too fancy a thing to be anything but a memorial, or a warning.

SCG "What a beautiful place.", Armada remarks.

He heads in.

Wildbow **((Social!Presentation roll if you want to convey an image))**

SCG ((STRONG - [roll succeeds]))

Wildbow The soldiers that accompany you march in step, footfalls joining together into a cohesive sound, with you at the fore.

The interior layout is that of a hotel lobby, with a bar off to one side, and a preponderance of tables, booths, chairs and couches. Two different fires rage in two different fireplaces. You need to get the lay of the land, a sense of who you're dealing with, which means picking who you approach.

SCG He decides to approach the tinker. Teenagers and elegance... Not exactly what he's looking for. At the very least, a fellow tinker might appreciate his work. He sends most of the drones to their own booth, besides two combat drones, the archer-squad leader and one of the saber-carriers.

Wildbow He sees you approach, and gestures for you to sit. He gives you a nod, "I'm jealous. An army at your disposal?"

SCG ((What do I notice about his armor/gear?))

Wildbow He's wearing armor reminiscent of medieval style, but the mask is peculiar - closer to a bird skull than anything else, particularly long. Vials and containers festoon his waist and bandoleer, and the fuller of his sword has what looks to be a spring-loaded syringe within.

SCG Armada happily takes the offered seat.

"I'm sure I'd be equally jealous, if I knew what was in those vials.

I'm very proud of my work...but it's very obvious what they're

for. Subtlety is definitely not my specialty.", he says with a chuckle.

He holds out a hand to shake. "The name's Armada."

Wildbow **"Leperous," he names himself. He stops short of taking hold of your hand, "If my name scares you, you don't have to touch me."**

SCG He shakes the proffered hand, in a firm manner.
"Fear of a name would be a poor reason to lose one's manners, I think."

Wildbow **"Perhaps. A better reason when it's an apt name. What brings you to Lausanne, Armada?"**

SCG "Right to the point, huh? I like that."

"Someone has wronged me, and I intend to see them pay."

"That being said, I don't mean to make undue trouble for anyone that isn't involved. In fact, I think I'll be an asset to many, if things go well."

Wildbow **"Are you hiring or looking to be hired? There's a lack of the latter. Too many doing the former... not that I'm not available, if you have a job."**

SCG "The latter. As you can see..." He motions at his army, "I'm able to make troops. I could easily swell the ranks of any organization. I can make couriers, soldiers, laborers, whatever is necessary."

"Dead drops, anonymous communication, search and rescue... Too many possibilities to count, really. I would very much like to be a facilitator of that sort."

Wildbow He nods. "I produce nanomachines." He holds up a vial. "While we're sharing our specialties, mine is flesh to machine alterations. Before you ask, no, you don't want to study my work, and you don't want to experience it. Chances are you don't want to work with me. I'm... dangerous when riled." He leans back, and his chair creaks.

"Over there, you'll see the woman in fox fur and the long dress. She was one of the top dogs, she would welcome help, but she's vicious, and tends to react badly to failure on her underlings' part."

"With her is the short fat man with the skull mask. He was her husband, they broke apart, but remain amicable. Be warned, he and that fellow over there in the suit, with hair on his face and arms like a yeti's? A rivalry. Picking one or the other would be taking a side."

"The woman in the black uniform is here from an English speaking area. She's here on a vendetta, like you. Based on what she's said, you wouldn't have common goals, and based on your appearance, she wouldn't take to you very easily. Too tall, too old, I would guess."

"Stop me if you have questions."

SCG He shakes his head. "I appreciate the heads up. Especially concerning the rivalry." He makes sure his suit is adding all of this to his database. All -very- useful. "Please, go on."

Wildbow "Over there," he indicates the ones with the wilder, more dangerous vibe, the ones you mentally noted as

psychopaths, "The Marque. Anarchists. Beside them you'll see another tinker. This one, like me, works with flesh, but he devises grafts and implants. He hasn't been communicating as of late. You may wish to steer clear. Others will arrive as the day gets on, but most are keeping their heads down, protecting what they have instead of grabbing for more. Too few people willing to hire their services, and many are gunshy, because some offer their services and then betray as a matter of course."

He gives you a slow but pointed look as he says that last bit.

SCG "Disappointing. Others have muddied the waters."

Wildbow "Too many others. You can't walk ten paces without running into someone in a costume."

SCG He nods. "I've experienced that."

"Just in trying to find a place like this..." he motions to the room, "A group attempted to murder me, last week. Speaking of...you wouldn't happen to know of a group containing someone who shoots lightning, a man with claws, and a muscled regenerator, would you?"

Wildbow He gives you a long, careful look.

"I would," he says. "They were heroes. Vigilantes, but heroes. Word is getting around certain circles. One is reporting that someone tried to kill him, he's rallying help to get revenge. Or so I hear. More details would come at a price."

SCG "I was attempting to meet with them, and they decided to open fire after I released their men unmolested. Lightning bolts everywhere. A few of my soldiers blown to shit. I gave them one last chance to stand down, and they didn't take it."

Wildbow ((Roll social - fail))

"Language," he reprimands. "The lodge tries to maintain standards. Being crude will lower you in people's estimation," he says. "As for your circumstances, I know all too well how things can get out of control, before it all starts falling apart."

SCG "Noted, thank you."
"Regarding the price, I do have some scans you might be interested in. The clawed man."

Wildbow "A file with the scans... maybe, if done discreetly."

He leans forward, planting two armored elbows on the table. You can see where similar actions have scuffed the lacquer.

"There's a bounty. Not like what you're asking for, I don't think. Not what -she- is asking for..."

He indicates the blonde woman in the flowing black costume. "It's for another sort of scan. Mention of it is the only thing that has made the graft tinker over there perk up, and it's something that interests me too. I don't think I even need to say what it is."

SCG "Sorry to tell you...but it's impossible, at this point.", He says simply. "Unless the body is still viable."

Wildbow "I'll take the scans, and take you at your word that you'll provide them, if you don't have them with you. The man who is hunting you is large, strong, and angry. He's still recovering from the treatment of his head. The heroes have agreed to target select individuals who've crossed lines or killed others, and the man has argued to have you put on that list."

SCG "Disappointing, but not unmanageable. Concerning the scans, I won't keep you waiting. Especially after your repeated kindness. How should I transmit them?"

Wildbow **He reaches down to a bag and retrieves a laptop, very boxy, and pushes it across the table. "The port there is my technology. Don't ask what it was before it was a port, it will take any kind of input."**

SCG Armada transmits the scans, now very curious as to what it was, before a port.

"I hope you find it very useful."

"Is there anything else I should know?"

Wildbow **"Mm hmm," he murmurs, distracted. His eyes are on the data. It's clear he's experiencing much of what you've experienced in the past. "And I wish you luck with your new, immortal enemy."**

SCG With the data, Armada includes a Cryptomail address. "In case you ever need me, I've included some contact info. Thank you again, Leperous."

Wildbow **He nods, acknowledging the notepad file with the email in it.**

SCG "Unless there's anything else, I think I'll leave it at this. I know better than to get in between a tinker and new data." He moves to get up, and join the rest of his armada.

Wildbow Eyes track you as you approach the table with your drones, curious and wary.

SCG "Relax, guys. It's all good."

He starts image searching on all of the villains. He's definitely collected enough images, by now. Time to put names to faces, and find out more. For now, he'll wait here.

Session 2.1.B

Wildbow "It's been too long," the woman tells you. She sets the kettle down on the stove, then crosses the room, rapping her knuckles against a bald pate. The man that sits on the couch makes a noise of complaint. "Both of you, sit down at the breakfast table like a proper family."

Her eyes turn to you, "Have you eaten?"

Anti I shake my head instinctively, before tilting my head in confusion, shaking my head again as if to break whatever fugue I seem to be in.

Who... who are these people?

A second, quieter thought intrudes. Why aren't they trying to kill me?

Wildbow "Sit," she urges. "We haven't seen nearly enough of you lately."

"He's been working hard at school," the man says. "Even if it's nonsense."

Anti I take my seat at the table, still wary, afraid.

The sight and scent of food makes me lower my guard.

Food... I remember eating nothing but refuse and vermin. What is this?

Wildbow More food gets placed on the table. French toast, covered in maple syrup, sprinkled with a light dusting of icing sugar. An empty bowl with a spoon gets placed down, with silent urging from the woman to partake of fruit salad. The only reason she doesn't say anything aloud is that the man is talking.

The man keeps talking, "Your brother went into medicine. If you wanted to busy yourself with bodysuits and masks, you went down the wrong path. He was just saying last week-"

"Month," the woman corrects him.

"-Last month, sure, he got called into a hospital, to look after one of the most famous heroes in America. Real problem solving exercise, he said it was."

Anti Curiosity trumps confusion. A hero. That word used to mean something...

"Who... who was it?"

Wildbow Your voice seems oddly familiar, yet entirely alien.
-Normal-.

"Dunno," the man says. "Healed faster than the scalpel could cut, your brother was saying, but that didn't fix the problem."

The television is playing music, too loud, the high notes sharp enough it's painful, as if you're unused to using your own ears.

Anti "The... problem?" I speak slowly, at first, listening to my strange voice, focusing on my cadence and tone, feeling the sensation of forming words with my tongue and lips.

"How did he fix it? If he fixed it."

The mention of a brother makes me recall emotions unbidden. Jealousy. Competition.

Wildbow "Don't know, didn't ask. I was more interested in his fiancée," the man says. "She's an amazing girl. A good match for your brother."

"Have you been seeing anyone?" the woman asks. Her voice is hard to hear over the television.

Anti "Seeing... anyone?" The premise of a relationship seems more alien than my own voice.

People are to be pushed away, avoided... right?

"No," I say, wincing at the sound of the television.

I gesture towards the television, realizing the limbs jutting from my shoulders are missing, their use now instinctive and honed through construction and design.

"Could you- uh, could you turn that down?"

Wildbow They ignore the request.

"You know," the woman says, "When your brother was your age, he was already halfway through medical school

on a scholarship. He had connections, and he was dating. Your program has to be so much easier, but you're not doing anything with the time you have."

Anti Jealousy again.

"It's about finding answers. Answers to questions not enough people are asking..."

My explanation peters off. I don't think that's the right response.

Wildbow The kettle goes off. Another shrill sound, extending into upper registers, joining the music, which seems to have more long, high notes as seconds pass.

Anti "It's not about achievements, moving up," I mutter halfheartedly, not quite knowing what I'm saying.

Wildbow "Come on, speak up. It's that lack of confidence that's holding you back. You jumped into a fad field that far too many kids are latching on to because it's 'cool', you should at least make yourself heard and stand out."

Anti The high-pitched whine of the TV supersedes the content it's providing, another tone in the upper register forcibly driving its way into my perception.

I try to sit up a little straighter.

I nod. "I'll get published this year. There are journals. Plenty of untapped avenues of research for me to focus on."

Wildbow "Fad science in a fad field," the man says. He goes on to say something else you don't hear over the noise. The

woman adds something, and you know it sounds condescending, even if you don't catch the words.

Anti I close my eyes, trying to shut everything out.

Without the stimuli of sight, the shrill sounds get worse, though.

Odd, I think to myself, my power isn't supplying me with diagrams, blueprints, data.

Wildbow The murmur of conversation, lecturing, all fails to cut through the incessant noise.

Anti I screw my already-closed eyes shut, jamming my fingers into my ears.

Wildbow The use of your hands and fingers does nothing to shut out the noise.

Anti Unable to hear the conversation, I stand up and shove the chair back in one fluid motion, lurching over to unplug the television.

Wildbow The noise doesn't stop as the television is unplugged. Blood wells from the outlet as the connection is severed.

In the midst of your reaction, you turn, and you see the pair at the table, now bound there, locked into cages of metal, more sarcophagus than anything else, heads and shoulders exposed. Her face is caved, in, jaw working to try and meet an upper row of teeth that is no longer there. He, conversely, is silently thrashing, fighting in reaction to a corrosive acid that dissolves his skin and muscle.

Everywhere you look, you see more details. Crude technology, twisted metal, scraps of meat, organs.

Though your eyes are already open, you find yourself opening them again. The shrill singing becomes a memory.

You're in your lab, resting.

Anti ... ugh.

I shake my head, clearing my mind, hoping to shake the lingering headache.

I glance outside, gauging the time of day by the amount of remaining sunlight. With my sleeping pattern shifted towards nocturnal habits in mind, I hope it's dim enough for me to go outside.

Wildbow It's later in the day. The sky is partially cloudy, the sky a patchwork of light and heavy clouds. The snow is coming down a fair bit.

Your work sits across the lab. A chemical concoction, brewed and ready but not yet tested, sits in a container, periodically popping as bubbles reach the surface of the lavender fluid. A suit of power armor is built, and the crude switch you set down to track the programming and calibration of the headwear you put together is glowing green, suggesting the data is finished loading.

Anti I stagger towards the mask and lens, trying to calm myself down and put the dream, hallucination, whatever it was out of mind.

Overwrite it with an inflow of data.

Wildbow The mask, built to cover your gaping maw, has needles poised and ready to slide into flesh as it is pulled on, ostensibly to access spine, thyroid, and other glands, with tubes set to run into gaps in your shoulder and various bodily fluids in cartridges, to restore biological processes in a hurry, should you be poisoned or experience negative effects of drugs.

The lens fits it perfectly, with a scanning device attached, keyed for biological signatures and chemistry.

Anti A quick test run. I turn the eye of the lens upon the lavender concoction, beginning a trial scan.

Wildbow **The concoction wildly multiplies biological material, prompted by detection of damage or injury via hormones. There are side effects, however.**

Anti I nod in satisfaction, fitting myself into the new suit of power armor. Since I lost the old one, I've felt naked, exposed. Now I have a measure of safety, of anonymity, enough to venture out without skulking through shadows and dumpsters.

Wildbow **The armor could be machined better, the individual pieces fit together with a touch more finesse. You had limited materials and virtually no tools to start with, and the end result suffered. That said, you don't think you could have done better, given the situation. It works, it's complete, and you have a suit of proper armor with a large**

chemically-brewed crystal at the center of the chest. You can feel it echo your heartbeat, and the echo carries along your arm to the gauntlet you fashioned. A smaller receptor crystal thrums at the palm.

A gesture of the hand will prime it for combat use, though it needs field testing.

Anti ... Field testing.

Let's go find some test subjects.

Wildbow You take the time to get used to the armor as you walk out into the winter. The armor glows red from ports, but the machinery is warm enough to heat the parts of you that are touched by the outside cold, the gnarled and altered flesh that is visible through the gaps in the construction. You head toward the downtown area, and are struck by how many people are gathered, especially as you draw closer to the tower where the angel hovers. The wind drives down, and birds huddle, utterly still, on the walls and eaves around you.

Anti I make my way through the throng, taking note of the ones turning to notice me. I approach the angel, listening hopefully for the song.

Wildbow **All you hear is the whistle of the wind and the whirl of machinery. Civilians step well out of your way as you make your way down the street. You don't see anyone in costume until you draw closer to the neighborhood where the tower is situated. Downtown, but more in the business sense than in the tourist or shopping sense that so many associate 'downtown' with. The buildings here**

are quaint, the skyscrapers muted in style, so as not to distract or take away from the aesthetic.

There are police and costumed figures alike gathered in a loose perimeter around the building, keeping the crowds from pressing in too close. A large number of figures have playing cards stylized into high quality costumes. A share of others seem to have a cloud or weather theme to their costumes.

Anti I approach the tower and the impromptu cordon around it, eyes more on the angel than them, not stopping unless stopped.

Wildbow The crowd takes notice of you and moves out of the way, while the police and heroes react by doing the opposite - a collection of four police officers and three costumed heroes put themselves in your way.

Two are women, one is a man. One woman has a playing card worked into her costume, with the spade featuring prominently, the other has a wand, and carries a staff with a green crystal worked into a branch-style working at the end. The man is thin, dressed in black, with a stormcloud at the breast.

Anti I nod at them vaguely, trying to catch the angel in the eye of my lens. How visible is she, from my vantage point?

Wildbow She's not terribly visible - she's eighteen floors up and slightly obscured by the building below her.

"What's your business here?" the woman with the spades asks.

Anti "I want to see her," I say, listening to my voice echo through the mask. "The angel."

Wildbow "A lot of people do," she says. You get the impression she's the 'take charge' type. Even the cut of her jacket seems reminiscent of a military jacket, though she carries no gun. "She seems content to stay where she is, unmolested. Scholars and experts on parahuman studies are making scheduled visits to try to study what they can without scaring her off."

Anti Scholar. Experts on parahuman studies.

The words resonate with me.

"You could call me a scholar of the parahuman."

"How can I schedule access?"

Wildbow ((Social roll))

The woman gives you a suspicious look.

"There's a long line of people wanting access. You could get a turn in..." she pauses, turning to the woman with the staff.

"Eight days," the woman with the staff says.

Anti "Who dictates the queue? I have services I can offer."

Wildbow "We have headquarters upstairs," Ms. Spades says. Her eyes rove over your armor, lingering at points. She's

clearly getting less comfortable with you as time passes.
"What services?"

Anti I unlatch the flask of lavender fluid from my armor, indicating it.

"Reactive, rapid regeneration."

Wildbow "Things have been quiet. We've made a show of strength without having to demonstrate it. Nobody's hurt or dying just yet," she says. But she eyes the vial, interested.

Anti "Even so, insurance. A measure of safety. Something worthwhile to hold onto, perhaps."

Wildbow **"Perhaps," she says. "Tensions are high. There could be a war soon. Healing could be useful."**

((Social roll))

"...If that is healing," she says.

Anti "I understand. I wouldn't be against leaving you with a sample and means to contact me, as a precaution."

Wildbow **She hesitates, then holds out a hand for the sample.**
"How do we contact you?"

Anti "Ask around for... Templar de Sang. Templar works. I'll meet you at your headquarters, if called."

Wildbow **"Are you hero or villain?" she asks.**

Anti "A scholar. As I said before."

Wildbow "I only ask because we need to know who to ask, if we're going to 'ask around'," she says. She levels another suspicious look at you. "Things break down to heroes and villains, and I don't know if I get a heroic vibe from you."

Anti "Villain, then. My appearance and disposition isn't well suited for heroics. But I'm willing to play ball, for a chance to see the angel."

Wildbow She nods, frowning slightly. She turns to her colleague, "Matraque?"

((Roll social))

The staff-wielder seems to consider, then makes an offer in a very rich, 'hoity-toity' sort of French, "We have paperwork, compiled notes that the scholars are sharing between them. As a halfway offer, in exchange for the vial, we'll give you a copy. If you're true to your word and if you prove your ability to stay out of trouble in the meantime, we can schedule an appointment for you.

I'll give you information on a gathering point for the more law-abiding villains of Lausanne, and we'll use them to reach out to you, should an opening come about... if you think you'll be ready at a moment's notice?"

Anti "I should be," I reply, handing over the vial.

"Thank you, by the way."

Wildbow It takes a few minutes for Matraque to collect the papers. You wait, the crowd still giving you a wider berth. It's up

to you if you want to step back for a better view, or if you want to converse, or do something else.

Anti I scan the crowd, picking out a handful of faces that don't recoil my appearance and bearing, occasionally closing my eyes, listening for the song.

Wildbow Nobody in particular stands out to you. The song isn't audible, being limited to dreams and the patterns in your tinkerings.

Standing there, with a wide berth given to you, you're very alone. Even the heroes seem to be looking at you differently, after your declaration as a villain.

Anti I content myself with gazing at the angel from afar, trying to focus on her with my lens.

Wildbow The lens, turned on, gives you a view of red lines extending out, sweeping left and right and up and down. Long-ranged scans do work, but the more detailed images do not.

The feed begins to log, very slowly, data on the angel's internal makeup. Density, crystalline structures with splining, very similar between wing, hair, and 'flesh'...

"Here," Matraque interrupts you, extending the papers in your direction.

Anti I accept the papers offhandedly, continuing my gaze at the angel. Her makeup, her physique... it's captivating, otherworldly.

"Look at her," I say, hushed.

Wildbow **She does, standing beside you, looking up.**

"Two Endbringers, monsters, two celestial figures," she says. "If there's a balance, there's a chance."

Anti "Thank you again for the papers," I say, before asking, "You mentioned a gathering point for the villains?"

"I'll be able to better keep in touch, through them."

Wildbow She nods, and she gives you the address. "They call it the Lodge. Looking at you, I imagine you can handle yourself, but you'd be wise to be careful. Even here, with only two large teams, it's something of a powderkeg. There, with villains? More so."

Anti "I appreciate the warning. I'll be wary."

I turn to leave. "Farewell, Matraque."

Before I walk away, I pause. A parting thought.

"... have you heard her sing?"

Wildbow **"Sing? No," she says. Then she frowns, concerned. "You mean the signal."**

Anti "The song in the static...?"

Wildbow **"In the radio static, yes, though we haven't called it a song. There's a frequency you can turn to, it brings up a peculiar noise," she says. "Some find it comforting. I have colleagues who have it tuned in all the time."**

Anti "It reminds me of something I've lost."

Wildbow She nods, as if she knows exactly what you're talking about. "A colleague of mine, he went a little mad when he got his powers. He's never been better. Another had issues controlling his abilities. He keeps the sound on headphones, and his control improves by the hour. We talked with some others, like you, who came to investigate, and before we turned them away, they said their alcoholism was better, or they finally had peace from a rage that was with them for a decade."

Anti I nod, slowly. "Why don't you listen, yourself?"

Wildbow "I was more fortunate than some. Nothing haunts me. My powers didn't give me anything, nor did they take it away. I don't need it for anything."

Anti "The song heals, Matraque. Perhaps you'll hear a miracle?"

Wildbow "The golden man healed others of the body. If she heals others of their afflictions of the mind, then I'll leave the miracles to those in more need of them," she says. "Have a good evening... Templar de Sang."

Anti "Good evening to you as well," I reply, leaving the crowd congregating beneath the tower behind.

I follow Matraque's directions to the Lodge, leafing through the documents handed to me.

Wildbow The documents touch on things you saw in the long-ranged scans. Physical composition, density, the cell structure, and

physiology. She's possessed of massive amounts of latent energy, but after seeing the golden man, that is little surprise.

There's mention of the signal, and the bandwidths it occupies, moving through space, time, and various means of communication. Only the radio signal remains a constant. Brain scans have been done of people measuring the signal, only to find nothing conclusive. The word 'magic' comes up in relation to how they find symptoms of various mental and emotional problems easing.

Matraque's instructions were clear enough - the Lodge stands at the end of the road. A classy building in the old fashioned Swiss style, large, set on the side of a hill.

Anti I approach the door, uncertain of which niceties to observe. Do I knock? Probably not. I open it, striding in.

Wildbow

Anti

Wildbow There are guards by the door, but they don't seem willing to deal with a guy in heavy armor. More for show than substance, perhaps.

You push your way inside, and you survey the situation. The room is nice, with rich wood and gold highlights. It's laid out like a hotel lobby, with seats and booths, and a bar off to one side.

No less than thirty people in costume are within, and it's not even crowded. What you heard about this being a place for more law-abiding, cooperative villains is being called into doubt, however.

A fairly round man with a napoleon-style hat and a military-uniform themed tinker bodysuit, backed by a squadron of drones, is staring down the barrel of a gun.

Session 2.1.C

Wildbow Last time, on WD_Lausanne... Armada wrapped up research on claws and set to work, his eyes on the 'Angel' that hovers over the city. After abandoning his initial plans, he went looking for contacts, and found his way to the Lodge. A gathering place for local villains of the organized variety, it has several villains within: Armada's facial recognition scans name them Malin, the fox, Petit Morty, Croquer, Crane the Harmonious, Masque, Black Rabbit, Brew, Weep, Nightingale, and Leperous, the last of which is a tinker who Armada sat down with and traded details with. On receiving details of scans and data, Leperous offers details on Armada's general situation - the people he attacked a week ago have been looking for him, and in particular, one of those people is the man that Armada beheaded, who is now pissed and looking for vengeance.

Armada resolves to wait for more people to turn up, when the doors open, and a new group enters. Villains of the higher-class variety, to look at them, with fine cloth and fur ruff collars, they let the people guarding the doors close the doors behind them, and stride straight to the bar (nevermind that it's noon). Their eyes fall on you, and

a murmured exchange of words passes between them, their eyes not leaving you in the process.

SCG Either they've heard of him, or they're shocked at the presence of a new tinker with a veritable robot army. Most likely the former, from what Leperous said.

These people might have a very low opinion of him. Best to allow them the first chance to approach, then.

Wildbow ((You stand around then?))

SCG ((Image searching again, watching them, and others reaction to them. Feeling the situation out.))

Wildbow One member of the group, who you scan as Fusilier, signals the short man in the skull mask your mask caught as 'Petit Morty', beckoning him over. Morty talks to Fusilier's gang, glancing over your way.

Two others read as Parfait and Mr. Formidable.

SCG They are obviously discussing him, which is, considering his reputation is built by a man he beheaded, not a good thing. Armada decides to take the initiative, leaving his bots behind at the table, and approaching the group.

Wildbow ((Roll presentation))

The group parts to face you. The three new people, Petit Morty, and Masque, a little to one side.

SCG "I can see my reputation precedes me, in a most unfavorable way. A man has been spreading tales about me, omitting key context."

"I would appreciate it if I could have a few moments of your time. I think you'll find me far more reasonable than has been reported."

Wildbow ((Roll social))

"It's been reported," Fusilier says, he's a well-groomed man in a leather coat with a fur collar, with guns at the hips, "That you attacked a group of local heroes, vigilantes who already were ruthless enough, and you gave them reason to be upset. They're saying some of their members never returned after you attacked them, and they're rallying lesser heroes and vigilantes to organize. So please, take a moment of our time."

SCG "Half-truths. I was attempting to speak with them, after one of my soldiers returned with a bullet hole. I came knocking at the door of what appeared to be a safehouse for a smaller local gang, searching for information. They attempted to run, and I apprehended a couple. I released them as soon as the heroes arrived, with instructions to ask for a meeting. Trying to be reasonable. Instead, I was assaulted with lightning repeatedly. I gave them multiple chances, before the fight ensued."

Wildbow "A half-truth is bad enough," Fusilier says. "Whether you're lying or telling the truth, you created this situation, and dealing with you is the answer to the problem. Perhaps..."

He draws his gun, pointing it at your forehead. "We should step outside?"

In the background, the door opens. A man in power armor enters the room.

((Enter Antioch))

Anti The power-armor clad Tinker strides into the room, expression indiscernible beneath the mask.

...A civilized location for the less 'volatile' villains this is not.

Perhaps there's a way to defuse this situation. He needs... a radio, or something similar, scanning the room for anything that might fit the bill.

Wildbow There is a radio behind the bar, not playing any sound, and there is a computer at one corner, it appears to be borrowed. This isn't the kind of place where people have radios out and playing.

Anti He walks to the bar, gesturing at the radio. "... do you mind if I borrow this?"

Wildbow ((Approaching the bar means approaching the fight in question, including both the gunman and the rotund tinker with the fantastic hat))

Anti ((Aye.))

Wildbow ((roll social, then - Anti rolls well, but result tanks to the point of a fail because of mutation/social penalty & circumstance))

The bartender looks uncomfortable - the situation and your eerie voice seem to put him off, and he seems to decide it's not worth the risk. He shakes his head, stepping back, remaining silent and detached from the proceedings.

SCG "It is my understanding that this is a neutral place. Drawing a gun and firing upon a newcomer will probably reflect very badly upon you, regardless of the circumstances. It makes people less likely to play ball, and we have very few doing so already. Secondly, the vigilantes, and others, are already attacking people to kill, with very little reason. You truly think my death would change that? How many bodies have come up in the last week?"

Wildbow "I don't think your death would change that. I'm thinking it would take their focus off of ~us~," he says. "The members of the Lodge rely on the good graces of the community to continue. We did before everyone came to the city. We don't cause trouble for them or draw undue attention, and they don't give us too much trouble. This -is- a nonviolent place, but that's why I'm asking you to step outside."

Antioch [Cut some redacted text due to misinterpretation]

((Can I reach over the bar and grab [the radio] with my cool extra arms?))

Wildbow ((You can try, but that means getting even closer to the ongoing confrontation))

Antioch ((Yeah.))

Wildbow As you approach the bar, a short man in a skull mask puts himself between you and the radio. He speaks to you in French, "Perhaps you should step back, stranger."

Antioch I stop. "I have no intent of interfering with your... conversation."

"Could you pass me the radio behind you?"

Wildbow "I think handing technology to someone like you... or -him- would be akin to handing a gun to someone else. Considering the situation," the man in the skull mask's voice gets harder, "That would be a bad idea."

The tension of the situation seems to escalate a fair bit, not just with him, but with the others in the immediate area.

SCG "It seems I can't dissuade you. Very well, let's step outside."

Armada signals his bots to go outside as well, and makes sure they're set to 'maim, not kill', unless he dies.

Antioch The Tinker starts as a small squad of robots begins to move. He backs away from the bar for a moment, observing the soldiers with an analytic eye.

Wildbow The group moves not to the street outside the front, but toward a space behind the Lodge. Trees mark the area, and it seems in the springtime it's a mini-park, secluded from the public eye, where villains can go on short walks with some privacy. A table and chairs sit off to the side center, where many a deal is likely conducted in the warmer months.

Reimann, you watch as the soldiers move. They're entirely mechanical, each outfitted with a set of medieval weapons, with six lacking the weapons but wearing bags and satchels, four archers, and three swordsmen. One of the archers gives an order, directing them through the door.

Antioch A unit capable of giving orders? Frankly, I'm impressed.

No longer obstructed by the nasty little man, I go to acquire the radio.

Wildbow Reimann finds the radio and collects it.

Armada, makes his way outside. His squad stands ready, facing the door.

[Map](#)

((Cue 'so cute!' in OOC chat, among people watching the session))

SCG "And here I was thinking this was between you and I. However, I appreciate your not firing upon me mid-talk. Are you ready?" He has two movers step in front of him, as he steps behind behind them, archers backing up and drawing, swordsmen moving to the sides, along with the rest of the movers. (line of 7 in front)

Antioch Reimann pockets the radio. The idea can wait for later. He steps out back, following the gunman and the other rude villains at a distance.

Wildbow **"And I appreciate your being polite enough to take this outside," Fusilier says. He raises a hand, and the one called Masque gestures at him. He disappears from sight.**

Mr. Formidable, a large fellow with muscles that strain at his fur-lined jacket and costume, steps forward in much the same way you'd had your soldiers step forward, putting himself between you and Masque.

SCG The movers (besides the two in front of Armada) splay out forward, searching for Fusilier and making a bot-barrier. The archers fire upon Mr. Formidable and Masque, trying to find a way around Formidable if possible. Two combat drones head straight for Mr. Formidable, while Armada draws his saber.

Anti As Reimann walks out, he mutters under his breath, "The first thing I see when I first enter the Lodge is heavy-handed threats and violence."

He turns the eye of his lens onto the combatants, trying to seek out the diminutive jackass.

Wildbow The line of runner-bots advances in a half circle, and one reacts to something. It turns, moving to act, and proceeds to have its head blown to smithereens. Snow stirs in a miniature whirlwind around a point a matter of feet away.

SCG ((Interrupt?))

((Go ahead))

All of the archers suddenly focus around the point where the whirlwind started, firing to cover the area, and hopefully hit the hidden man.

Wildbow ((Roll for archers, SCG))

Reimann uses his lens to scan Petit Morty, and the little man is brimming with a another sort of energy, something very, very interesting to Reimann's eye for frequencies and lifesigns. He has an idea for a concoction that is likely very antithetical to the general processes of being alive. That force and energy seems to concentrate in the shorter man's hands.

The archers turn and fire. Arrow stick to snow and disappear into the hedge to the side. Armada's sword-wielding soldiers advance roughly half the distance to the enemy.

Map [With small error re: combat drones not being far enough up]

SCG The movers move to cut off the area where morty was last seen. One archer (tactician) moves on top of the table, while two fire at Formidable and one takes aim at Masque. Armada moves back, trying to find the man.

((as in, moves backwards, eyes scanning))

Anti Reimann unsbtly stomps towards the cape nearest to him.

"Is this how things are handled at the Lodge?" he spits, dissatisfaction in his tone.

Wildbow ((Your sword-wielding drones attack Mr. Formidable?))

((From the direction arrows aren't coming from, yes.))

"Formidable!" Masque calls out, giving 'Formidable' a very French pronunciation as she catches sight of Reimann/Templar De Sang's approach, "I'm gone!"

She starts to dart to one side, and disappears mid-step.

((Attack rolls for Sword drones. One archer fires at Formidable, as well, all +0 to hit))

One sword-wielding drone stabs Mr. Formidable, who lashes out-

The attack is solid and powerful enough the drone has no chance to dodge, and is smashed to pieces with a backhand strike.

Petit Morty , feeling the pressure from advancing drones, retreats, circling around in the direction of Templar and the place where Masque was, wary, with his hands out to the sides.

[Map](#)

SCG ((I can see him?))

((Yes))

The archers all fire upon Petit Morty, the two combat drones attacking Formidable. Meanwhile, two mover drones move to the right flank, searching for Masque. Armada continues to back up, searching for Masque.

Anti "Look at you," Reimann says, sneering. "Attempting to browbeat a single cape /and/ losing ground?"

"The Lodge continues to disappoint."

[Declares combat turn over]

((Taking no action?))

((Still don't feel like I have IC justification to beat the tar out of these clowns.))

Wildbow ((Attack rolls for archers, soldiers))

SCG "I -did- warn Fusilier about that. By the way, I think they're trying to kill me, not browbeat me."

Wildbow The archers fire, unleashing a barrage in Petit Morty's general direction. Two arrows strike, one only a graze, the other catching him in the chest, apparently not enough to end his existence- had he been a hair slower to move, it could have.

The sword wielder strikes Mr. Formidable, who retaliates, a heavy blow- [rolls] The sword wielder is dashed to pieces. Only one remains.

"No comments, bystander. He crossed the line, he put us all in danger, the savage. Go inside now, or I'll consider you an enemy, and I could really do with someone to hit right now."

His hand flickers with dark energy, and his legs tense, as if he's readying to lunge.

((Wits check, SCG))

Armada scans the environment, looking for whirls of snow or footprints, and sees nothing. He backs further away, so his archers are between him and the battlefield.

[Map](#)

SCG ((What's that in the very back?))

((Green thing? Tree))

((No, Pink bubble))

((Table & chairs))

Anti "Ha," Reimann laughs, a single barked syllable. "I'm scanning valuable data here, and you're not going to stop me."

"You want to pick a fight? Be my guest."

"You're already losing -" Reimann gestures to the arrow jutting from Morty's chest "- and I don't think the fellow with the hat needs any help."

"If you want to worsen the odds..."

I clench my gauntleted fist, sending crimson energy sparking in the palm, a counterpoint to his.

"... I've been meaning to find a test subject."

Wildbow **As the gauntlet is activated, red crystals collect and bind to the metal, Arcs of red energy bounce from the crystal in the palm to the ones in the fingertip.**

SCG Meanwhile, Armada dashes forward, his tactician turning around to scan for Masque. His archers attack Morty, other than the tactician. Two movers break from the group to grab the fallen sabers from the combat drones, and attack Formidable, as the singular combat drone stabs at the man. The rest of the movers attempt to encircle Armada, in case of attack.

Wildbow **Petit Morty takes Templar's aggression as cause to lunge. He attempts a grapple-**

((Response?))

Anti ...and Templar swings down with a sparking, gauntleted fist, attempting to beat the little man out of the air.

As he swings, he tries out the untested 'blood' components in his armor, drawing on his own life to empower the suit.

Wildbow **Energy thrums through the suit, and you experience agonizing pain as the suit tears open a wound in your back and side, gouging you and sucking up blood and flesh. The HUD in your visor flashes with information that your reactor has a charge, which you summarily spend... to patch up the wounds you just created.**

((Brawn roll))

In the midst of the pain and all of the processing, you realize that your attack faltered, the imminent 'threat' nearly forgotten. Petit Morty has latched on to you. He doesn't have a firm grip, but his attempt to grab hold of you was largely unopposed. His hand crackles, and black energy lashes out to disappear past armor and clutch at your heart.

He starts visibly -changing-. Petit Morty is no longer as 'Petit' as he was.

((SCG, now the ranged attack rolls))

Two arrows sink into his back as he swells in size. A carapace of bone is encapsulating the outside of his body, now.

His voice is guttural as he calls out to Formidable - "Hurry up and get them!"

((Attack roll for combat drones, SCG))

Formidable smashes the last combat drone, as the two lesser drones grab up sabers and slash ineffectually in his direction.

((Wits rolls, Anti [Fails], SCG [Passes]))

((And dodge roll, SCG - [Fails]))

A movement in the corner of the eye and a reaction of one of the drones surrounding him draws Armada's attention, another small swirl of snow, the appearance of a portal, and, a moment later, the flash of a gunshot.

The bullet penetrates Armada's side, but doesn't hit anything vital. ((Moderate wound to Armada, minor wound to Templar De Sang))

Map

SCG ((surprised my turned around drone doesn't see. hrm.))

Armada sends the command to the movers with sabers to attack Formidable, the tactician and one bowman to search and destroy masque, and the rest of the movers to take the tacticians orders, cornering the area the shot came from. Meanwhile, he himself heads to help against Formidable.

Wildbow ((Antioch - your turn. You're in a grapple, for the record))

Antioch Templar retaliates, both gauntlets grabbing onto the clinging Morty, attempting to assert his grip and channel the crimson energy through his aggressor.

((Struggle, as per the grapple table))

Wildbow ((Roll brawn))

((Armada, 2 melee attack rolls at -1 for non-combat drones, 2 ranged attack rolls))

One arrow strikes Formidable, and he staggers, nearly at the end of his rope. He strikes at the nearest minor drone, clearly frustrated at the unending supply of them-

He lands a glancing hit and destroys one more.

Still gripping Templar de Sang, Petit Mort unleashes another burst of dark energy, and grows further, covering himself in more bone. ((Minor wound to Templar)) He tries to get in position to attack-

((Roll Brawn, Anti))

Leveraging his strength versus yours, he knocks one gauntleted hand away and slams a fist into armor, denting metal ((one wound, armor absorbs))

Map

SCG Two movers are sent forward to hold/occupy the mans arms, while the two with sabers, and armada, stab him in the chest.

((The other actions are up to tactician))

((er, have one mover pick up a saber. If it takes too long oh well))

Antioch Templar continues wailing on the growing Morty, clubbing viciously at the man as his gauntlets writhe, hoping to charge his armor.

Wildbow ((Roll Brawn))

With deft movements, Mr. Formidable works to slap aside the two robots that are attempting to grab him. Sufficiently mobbed, however, he misses one, and has his arm seized.

His attempt to bring both arms around to block the incoming saber thrusts is hampered by the hold, and Armada steps in to attack in concert with the two runners, lancing the man in the chest three times over.

He slumps over, collapsing to the ground.

In the meantime, Templar de Sang uses his blood gauntlet, managing to grab and hit Petit Morty.

The gauntlet manages more than a moment's contact, and as the crystal at the palm makes contact, it flares with red light. The suit registers another charge, and, as he pulls his hand away, an ethereal connection seems to reach from the gauntlet's palm to Morty, like a ghostly tether, crimson in shade.

Seizing the advantage, Templar de Sang manages to club Morty across the face, cracking bone with the gauntlet of his power armor.

As energy from the conduit feeds into the system, he can feel his less severe wounds mending. Morty's retaliatory lash with his dark energy cancels out that mending, leaving Templar no better or worse off.

From the doorway, another cape speaks. "Enough!"

It's up to you if you want to listen or take initiative for a final set of blows.

SCG Armada stops, and listens. "I will acquiesce, if they agree to do the same."

((also stopping bots))

Antioch "I haven't had enough yet," he growls.

[Lost details in the course of copying stuff over, but Templar smashes Petit Morty across the face, delivering a wound.]

SCG "God damn it, there's been enough violence. If we can stop, do it now." Armada spits at the newcomer. "They were HONORABLE, at the very least."

Antioch "He gets the first blow, I get the last," Reimann spits.

Wildbow Petit Morty leverages his strength and size, aiming to throw Reimann-

((roll Brawn))

He hefts Reimann over his head. He speaks in guttural French, "Shut off that beam, or I'm putting you through the wall!"

The beam continues to draw power, patching up your wounds.

Anti Reimann powers down his gauntlet grudgingly.

SCG "All bots are to cease fighting, and form up behind me. Do not engage."

Wildbow More roughly than strictly necessary, Morty places Reimann on the ground.

Above Formidable's body, there is a shimmer. Fusilier, who hadn't moved from where he stood, holsters his gun, and makes the portals that surround him pop out of existence, conjuring up flurries of snow as each one collapses.

He would have had to be fighting back to back with Formidable protecting him from incoming attackers,

there. He'd never moved from his location from the point combat started.

Masque, who had also remained where she was, still maintaining a stance as if she was mid-stride reappears as well, standing straight and bringing her hands up and out to the sides.

SCG "Please pardon my earlier language, first off."

Anti Reimann looks to the source of the voice, picking himself off the ground and giving his wounds a once-over, getting a better idea of how Morty's dark energy damaged his body.

Wildbow The wounds are hard to gauge, as he is clad in armor, but a scan suggests he has only one serious injury that might require medical attention, and one he'll probably want to suture. ((one moderate, one minor - still one charge in armor from gauntlet use))

"I think," Fusilier says, "That you should leave. Both of you. You showed your strength, but perhaps its best if you stay out of our way, and we stay out of yours? Honorable enough?"

SCG "Acceptable. Assuming you allow me to gather the materials from my broken bots. Am I to understand that we will be banned from this lodge, in the future?"

Wildbow "Yes. Before all the people arrived, it was our place. It remains our place," Fusilier says.

SCG "I see. Unfortunate, but unavoidable. I am sorry about any ill effects my actions have had on you, for the record. In the case of any Endbringer attack, or the like, I would ask that we put aside our differences for any meetings necessary, but other than that, I will not return." He holds out a hand, to shake. "I appreciate both your candor and your honor, and hope we will not cross paths in such a way ever again."

Wildbow **They glance at Reimann**

Anti Templar looks to Fusilier, shrugging uncertainly.

"I came here to offer services. Healing, mental and physical."

"First impression in mind, the way you appear to handle situations here... grates at me."

"I won't be coming back."

Wildbow **The crowd within the building parts, giving you an avenue to make your exit.**

"If you could," one member of the Lodge says, "Leave the radio?"

SCG ((ignored [my offer for a] handshake))

((fucking lol))

Wildbow **((actually didn't see the offer for handshake, but it works as is))**

Anti Reimann pauses for a moment, forgetting about the radio in the heat of combat.

"Ah, right."

"Irony, that I was going to repurpose it into a gift for the Lodge."

Wildbow **"Gift?" one of the bystanders asks. You watch as Leperous steps outside, pulling a trinket from his pocket as he kneels by Mr. Formidable.**

((Go on, sorry to interrupt))

Anti "Like I said, I came to offer services. Healing of the body, healing of the mind, though I can't take credit for the latter."

Wildbow "You're talking about the benefit of the signal?" a bystander asks you. "Those who listen feel... better."

"Enough," Fusilier cuts in. "They should leave."

The people in the crowd don't disagree. The way is clear for you to exit.

Anti "If you already know that much, then I suppose there's less for me to be concerned about."

SCG Armada heads out. "If anyone has need for me, I will be putting something online later, easily found with a search. Goodbye."

((will be waiting for Reimann outside))

Anti Setting the radio back on the bar, checking to see if it hasn't been damaged by the scuffle with Morty, Reimann addresses the bystander. "You know the proper bandwidths and frequencies?"

Wildbow "There's a radio station," he says. He glances at Fusilier, clearly uncomfortable with prolonging the conversation.

Anti Reimann nods, satisfied. "I'd say I'm sorry for the trouble, but... I'm not the one who caused it. If you need healing, I won't be difficult to find."

Reimann turns to exit, walking past the Lodge members.

Wildbow As Reimann exits, he finds himself in Armada's company.

SCG "I appreciate the help, greatly. It seems I'm in your debt."

Anti "That's, uh... a pretty nice hat," Reimann says lamely.

He pauses, thinking for a bit. "What should I call you? I may have missed your name, with all the fighting."

SCG "The names Armada. Yours?" He says, tipping his hat as best he can.

Anti "Templar de Sang," he replies, still getting used to the name. Maybe he shouldn't have chosen something so wordy.

"So why were they after your throat, exactly?"

SCG "Some assholes attacked me during a meeting, and I killed one of them."

"There seems to be a pattern."

Anti Reimann begins walking away from the lodge, expecting Armada to follow, feeling awkward in the proximity of the building.

SCG ((he follows))

Anti "At least I got some worthwhile scans," he says. "I can't complain."

He pauses, for a moment, attempting to heal his wounds with the last of the energy drained from Morty.

Wildbow The armor hums to life, reacting to the subtle inputs in the gauntlet and tracked eye movements. The bar to the right that measures how many charges the armor has flashes, then begins to drain, as mechanisms on either side of the chest kick into motion. Spinning discs slide along slots in the armor to find the wound, and then begin feeding energy into them, stimulating growth.

The wounds close. A quick scan suggests that only bruising remains.

SCG "Probably not smart to stay in the open. And we've both gotten a bit hurt. I have a nice place, if you need it. The least I can do."

Anti "I..." Reimann hesitates, slightly wary at the gesture of goodwill, but concedes. "... yeah, that sounds good, actually. My lab is, well, a dump."

Thinking back, there was probably food at the Lodge.
Reimann feels more upset about getting kicked out.

SCG "Well, we're both exiles now. Would probably be smarter to stick together. And quite frankly, it would be nice to have some company, besides robots, however useful they may be. Especially if you can really heal."

Anti "Of course. I'm already back to new."

"You took a gunshot in that fight earlier, no? I can fix that."

SCG "Yeah, the bastard shot right through my armor. Thought it was better than that."

"I would definitely appreciate it. Gunshot wounds are...much more painful than I thought." He jokes.

Anti "Lead the way, then," Reimann says, adding an afterthought. "I'll need some chemicals, reagents and such for my concoctions."

"You wouldn't happen to have any...?"

SCG "Not yet, but there's no reason we can't buy some. I have some cash squared away, not much, but enough to get started."

"Before we get there...you wouldn't happen to be squeamish around bodies, would you? I...uh...didn't want to waste the research material..." There's no way he'll be able to hide that fucking body before they get there.

Anti An odd, distorted electronic sound comes through Reimann's mask. It's snorting.

"Are you kidding? I was hoping to bring back a body or two, when that fight started," the Tinker says regretfully.

((Is it worth it, going back to the grocery store, to scavenge what materials / equipment I have left? I can't imagine there's much left there.))

SCG ((Your scanning devices/databench would probably be useful))

Wildbow ((He doesn't have either))

((It's part of why his armor isn't as good as it could be))

Anti ((I've got a bunch of bloodstains on the ground and some cleaning supplies, I think. Probably not worth.))

((General tools, some materials, some chemicals, some rat soup))

((I may go back for the chemicals, if that's the case.))

((And the rat soup. Don't waste meals.))

SCG "Ha. I thought I was the only one."

((can send bots from a truck))

Wildbow ((Anything else you want to cover before session end?))

SCG ((Not that I can think of, atm.))

Anti ((Hmm, I think I'm good. We can get the move-in stuff squared away off-screen, I'm sure, and hash out a gameplan in the interim.))

SCG ((Have to send a bot to the heroes, but that can be done later.))

Wildbow ((Then one more thing first...))

The move goes well, with a few things and spare materials picked up. A concoction of the healing brew is whipped up as dinner is presumably ordered, and left for Armada to imbibe.

It's now late in the evening.

SCG Armada motions towards the base. "Hope you like the digs. Much better than an abandoned supermarket, I think."

Anti Reimann, attempting to get the gear he moved over squared away, pauses as he glances at his rudimentary setup for Armada's healing potion. What would it take to synthesize a concoction, drawing on Morty's necrotic energy as inspiration?

((It's already on your char sheet, btw, and yes))

He's broken from his thoughts by Armada's comment.

((It's a harborside warehouse, right? Want to make sure))

((Ah, thanks!))

"O-oh, oh, yeah. Living in that grocery store was... awful." Understatement of the century.

SCG "Good days ahead, my friend. Speaking of which...anything I should know before I take this?" He motions at the potion.

Anti "It duplicates flesh and other tissue, focusing on damaged areas, basically."

The question might have been answered in more detail, if Reimann wasn't so fixated on the prospect of dinner.

SCG Armada takes his helmet/mask off, putting it to the side. "Cheers." He says, before downing the potion.

Wildbow It's cool going down, but as it gets past the point of no return, Armada feels a pain deep inside his chest. That pain, in throbs and pulses, expands out through his entire chest, and into his limbs, and finally his head. The pain of the gunshot is quickly forgotten, because this is well above and beyond anything and everything that Armada has ever experienced, even the emotional pain of his business crumbling down around him, people who counted on him losing their jobs is distant and forgotten in comparison to this.

Standing on the sidelines, Reimann's scan shows what's happening - the concoction uses the nervous system to identify and 'feel out' what parts need healing. It does this through pain at the highest possible level.

((Guts roll, scraggy - failed))

Attempts to hold out fail, the pain seems to magnify, to the point where it's potentially psychology-altering.

((Again))

The pain goes on for what feels like hours. The wound closes, and Armada is left collapsed on the ground, gulping in air. Had he not been careful or if he'd been weaker, he knows, that agony could have done permanent psychological harm.

[Explained in OOC chat, two consecutive fails = a permanent Life Flaw; madness, mania, alcoholism, etc, etc]

SCG "AHHHHHHH."

"What the FUCK was that?" He asks, trying to clutch his chest through his armor.

Anti "Oh, the uh, way it detects wounds is by overstimulating the nervous system."

Hmm, he mentally notes. That means you can't cheat the system with anaesthesia. Good to know.

"Too intense? There might be a way to alter the sensation..."
The second part is trailed off, an idea being pursued by a distracted mind.

Remove the checks and limiters on the concoction, forcing flesh to multiply in the afflicted, forcing gruesome growths of tissue, tumors, with the debilitating pain left as is.

Which seems effective enough as is, Reimann thinks, looking at the panting form of Armada.

Wildbow ((If it's okay, we can wrap up here. I'll get in touch with each of you separately re: your plans for the interim, and how open you plan to be with your stuff/actions/methodology. We'll resume with a half session as the arc concludes?))

((Works for me. o7))

((Same. Thanks for running!))

// Session end //

Dolyn/Rainbow

Lausanne 'Albatross' Arc - 2.2A

Following the end of Arc 1, which saw only half of the original roster of players surviving, I held another draft, this one being a blind draft, with players bidding on a selection of options using up to 1000 points for each. The options were then given out to the players who bid the most for them, as is natural and fair. The controlling factor at play was the fact that the players who spent the most for what they got more flaws.

Dolyn bid 600-some points for 'Little Bo(y?) Peep', the highest bid for any character. The trigger as written was long, but can be summarized as a teenager who was having a hard time getting on with her mother, tracked down her dad, who she hadn't seen for much of her life, and started emulating his bohemian artist style, which only made things tenser between her and her mom. In the end, she ran away to go live with her dad, and the parents ended up striking a deal, with the character staying with dad for the summer.

Things fell to pieces, however, when she found hidden cameras throughout her room and the bathroom. She realized her dad never got permission from mom, her mom's vehement hatred of dad had a reason, and there were a whole mess of other disgusted, betrayed, ashamed emotions that drove her to trigger.

The character, 'Sylvi', gained a stranger/changer power that enables her to create blobs of hologram, which explode into the form of fragile images on impact with a surface. She can disguise herself with them, but the disguises don't last long, and last an even shorter time if she's active while wearing them. She can pass through her own illusions with ease, while others find them about as fragile as sugar glass. It's possible to walk on them, but it requires a steady foot and great care.

Dolyn's character, named Rainbow Idol when in costume, got two flaws due to the amount she spent to bid, the worst option possible. The first flaw is 'Power Incontinence', which essentially means that any time she tries to use her hands to manipulate an object, she'll produce spurts and slicks of her power. Mechanically, it's a penalty to her Dexterity stat (hand-eye coordination, accuracy, fine manipulation, careful item/tool use, etc), she has to make a Dex check for even mundane actions like getting dressed or eating, and a failure means using her power. To top it off, she got a *second*

stat penalty in a hit to her Knowledge score, the stat that determines her skill points, memory and general depth of knowledge.

I'd love to be able to say that the stat penalties were why she struggled so much, but the reality is that the dice hated Dol more than I've ever seen them hate a player. At one point, something like 27 out of 33 rolls she'd made were a 3 or lower on a d6. Keep in mind not all of the rolls are noted in the log below.

Session 2.2A

Wildbow **Your mother knocks on your door and opens it at the same time. The smell of dinner floods into your bedroom - fish, with a strong citrus smell to go with it. "Silvi."**

Dolyn I snatched the dazzled juggling ball out of the air, the illusory colors shattering at the impact, then offered Mom an awkward smile. "Hi Mom! Is dinner ready?"

Wildbow **She eyes the juggling balls warily, "It's in the oven. Use oven mitts to take the plate out, it will be hot. I've got to run to work. Don't make a mess, okay? Get your homework done. Just because you're not in school right now, it doesn't mean you can be lazy about it."**

Dolyn I nodded affirmation, setting the juggling balls on the bed next to me. "Still hot in the oven, do homework, no messes. Got it. How late will you be at work tonight?"

Wildbow **"I don't know. I want to say I'll be back at midnight, but... I might be later. Things have been hectic at the hospital, people who think the angel might heal them like Scion healed some others are coming to the city, and a lot of them need treatment. Add the fighting and the fact that so many of the tourists don't have any place to go, and it's messy."**

"Be good," she says, giving you a concerned look.

Dolyn "The best!" I replied, offering her a cheerful grin. It faltered, though, as I thought about the rest of what she said. "Be safe, alright? And thank you for the dinner."

Wildbow **She nods. She seems wary of your excess cheer and obedience. It wasn't so long ago your relationship with her was strained to the point of breaking.**

She leaves your room, leaving your door wide open. You can hear her rummaging around for her things before she exits the house.

Dolyn I made my way to the kitchen with a degree of haste, easily warranted by the rare opportunity I had tonight. Mom cooked a really delicious fish.

Wildbow **((Any time you use your hands, you have to roll Dex, that includes eating))**

Dolyn I also had at least a couple hours for heroism, or, at the very least, wandering around prepared for potential need of heroism. It would be wrong to not help someone if I could do so.

I grabbed the oven mitts, putting them on to pull the food from the oven.

(Dol rolls Dex, passes)

Wildbow **Your power remains quiet as you set the food on the counter. Is it the promise of activity and use that keeps it at bay? ((Three more dex rolls))**

(Dol rolls Dex 3x, fail fail fail)

Apparently not. The actual act of eating is a difficult and frustrating one. The manipulation of utensils is awkward, and more awkward still as your power kicks to life, images spilling forth and covering fork and food, the thrust of it even knocking food from the end of the fork, to send it spinning over the countertop and onto the floor.

The images themselves take the form of costume elements, of faces, and of weapons, littering plate and countertop, like a dozen half-sculpted objects surrounded by spatters of rainbow paint, textures and patterns.

Dolyn I lightly bashed my forehead against the counter, frustrated over my inability to manage my powers. They weren't even subtle, a blatant expression of what I wanted to do with myself. Apparently more than I wanted to eat, regardless of how delicious the fish was.

I knew that I was going to go out looking for crime to fight tonight, and would definitely be wearing my costume to do so. I'd put too much effort into the thing for it to just hang around unused. I wanted to finish this meal first, though. What kind of an example could I be if I skipped proper nutrition, interfering powers or no?

Wildbow ((Three more rolls then))

Dolyn ((I'm going to defeat this fish mini-boss.))

(Rolls; fail fail pass)

Wildbow You fail for several long moments, and your frustration seems to feed into things, making them worse, until your plate and hands are crusted with images and holograms and you can't even see much of what you're doing.

In the background, your mom left the television on, the volume turned down low. Taking your mind off of the food for a moment, you watch as video feeds show an ongoing debate about the angel. A group of accomplished scholars sit around a table, talking, making their points, while feeds from Germany, France, the UK and the US show more dissenting voices.

The people from elsewhere in the world seem to be more skeptical or worried.

You raise your fork to your mouth and eat, and it works this time. You manage by way of fewer, bigger bites, but the food is already cold. You finish enough to know you won't be hungry.

Dolyn The angel, it was all people seemed to be talking about these

days. Very sensibly so, too, if she really is going to do the good that some people think she will. I couldn't really say one way or the other, though. All I really cared about was that my Mom and the city were struggling, and I had to do what I can to help with both.

A splash of excitement ran through me as I thought about being able to run around in my costume tonight, using my powers for more than just making my life harder. It was going to be great. First, though, I had to get these dishes to the sink without breaking anything.

Wildbow ((Roll))

(Dol rolls, fails)

The power leeches out to cover the plate, but doesn't knock it from your hands. You put a plate with a few pieces of gear on it into the sink and rinse it, the water shattering the image and rinsing fragments of hologram down the drain along with the remaining bits of food.

You're free to get ready.

Dolyn I smiled to myself, as I dashed back to my room and my secret cape gear. I really wanted to see some action tonight, I'd been prepping for this for so long. Hopefully my confounded power would get that and let me get dressed without incident, but it seemed really unlikely. One of these days I'd figure out how to work it, though!

I threw open my closet and looked at the hidden box of supplies within, readying myself to get ready for a night on the town.

Wildbow ((Roll, describe yourself, let me know how you're starting your night's patrol))

Dolyn ((How many?))

Wildbow ((Roll 3x, doesn't matter except for flavor at this point))

(Rolls: fail fail fail)

Dolyn I dressed, with a frustrating quantity of razzle and dazzle

coming from my hands, but managed to get everything on despite the difficulty. My costume went rather well with the spray of colors and images, if I do say so myself.

I had a pair of blue and yellow leggings which I wore beneath a white and pink tennis dress, and a pair of pink combat boots. I don't know whose idea it was to make leggings or combat boots in pastels, but I was certainly glad that they had done so.

I threw on a nice green scarf, covering the lower half of my face, and which I hoped would flap dramatically in any breezes I found myself posing in.

To finish the look, I put on some makeup and a purple domino mask. It was a nice mask, made me look very heroic, and it matched my eyeshadow! All in all, my costume was a horrible mish mesh of pastel colors. It was perfect.

I grabbed my things, ensuring my belt was properly filled and organized, with more splashes of razzle and dazzle to keep me good and frustrated, then grabbed my hooded longcoat.

Superhero or not, I didn't want to draw too much attention to myself while I was still near my house. I had to get to a bad neighborhood first!

Wildbow ((Knowledge roll))

(Rolls, Fails)

Wildbow You've lived in the city all your life, but there are only two areas you can really think of when it comes to figuring out where the 'bad' part of town might be. Your dad's neighborhood is poorer, a ways away, and would mean a less dignified bus ride to even get that far. Downtown is closer, crowded, but a little more unwieldy - you can imagine how things might be there, crowded and chaotic.

Dolyn I had to think about that for awhile. I'd really rather avoid the bus, who knows what could happen, and then I'd need to take the bus back to get home. It'd really cut into my crime fighting time.

Downtown, though, was a lot more dangerous. I suppose it was really a question of if I wanted to be a small time hero, bussing to and from her capely duties, or a big time hero, fighting loads of criminals at once.

My thoughts went back to Mom, and how worried she'd been about me. I wanted to be a big time hero, but she didn't want me to be a hero at all.

I nodded to myself, mind made up to go with the middle ground, swallow my pride, and take the bus. The justice bus!

I walked off in the direction of the bus, working to pull out enough cash for a day pass from my belt, justice wasn't free, after all, and readied myself to wait for my ride to glory.

Wildbow The bus pulls up on time, and you get more than a few stares as you make your way on. There are only a few people on the bus at this time of night, going to the outer edges of the city.

Dolyn I offered a cheery smile and wave to the people as I moved to my seat. I had a reputation to maintain! Well, a reputation to earn, but the idea was the same.

I made sure to check the schedule to see when the last returning bus would be, as I didn't want to get stranded in another part of town overnight. Mom would kill me.

Once I was assured I could get back home, I took a seat. I put on a smile, needing to keep up my image, and thought about what the night might be like.

Wildbow The last bus goes home at 11:30pm, which would be cutting it close with your mom potentially getting home at midnight. You watch as the city passes by, and you can see the glow of downtown from a distance as you move past a more industrial area, with harbor and warehouses. Your dad's neighborhood. It's a poorer area, with more foreigners, and more multiculturalism. The social standards...

...are different, were different, which was why the place was so tantalizing to you, before.

You see a dramatic, involved, and elaborate 'z' spray painted on the side of a building, and a moment later, the bus has carried on too far for you to see it anymore.

It takes twenty minutes for you to get there, and you exit to see a small crowd. People are gathered for a street party, it seems.

Dolyn I decided to edge my way around the party. I wasn't sure what manner of thing it was, but large groups of people usually attracted at least some of the less savory sorts. If nothing else, it would help to know what was happening around my way back home.

If there was nothing interesting about the party, I could leave with only having lost a few minutes of my time. If it proved to have what I was looking for, well, then I could finally fight some crime and maybe get a better grasp on my power, as I'd set out to do. Plus also the city would be better off for the lack of ruffians, can't forget that part.

Wildbow **All around you, people are dancing. Music pumps, but the music has an undercurrent, a singular high pitched note. While the music comes from one source, the higher pitched sound comes from others, including many radios scattered here and there, the volume set to the maximum.**

Many of the people dancing are your age.

((Wits roll, investigate))

(Dol rolls, passes)

You can remember the people your father hung out with and the people your father avoided. He, and everyone else you got to know, seemed to avoid one particular group of young twenty-somethings. In an area with so much of the bohemian style, with multicultural dress and celebration of different cultures, these people keep to themselves and a

very Western style.

Black jackets, button-up shirts, with or without ties. The gist of things, from what you heard, was that they were student activists, nationalists, with a more dangerous side when it came to getting what they wanted.

You recognize a group almost right away, and having done so, you're free to watch, or to position yourself better in relation to them. They sit on stairs and smoke, with a clear twenty feet separating them from the people dancing in the street.

Dolyn

I opted to resituate myself. I was at my best with every advantage I could muster, so I might as well start stacking them now. As I moved, I tried to subtly look around observing things, trying to spot any potential environmental hazards.

If a fight broke out, I wanted to know about where I was and how to get out.

Plus I really wanted to try filling a pothole with some cement dazzle, just to see what happens when people step on it.

Wildbow

The biggest hazard is the crowd, but it's also a potential benefit. The houses are small, most only one story tall, and the spaces between them are littered with small obstacles and hazards, from fences to bags of trash to bikes and barbecues.

((Roll sneak - Dex + Athletics))

(Rolls; pass & fail)

You circle around the group, doing what you can to stay out of sight, despite a costume that is all about bright, contrasting, eye-grabbing colors. A member of the group does look your way, but you can't tell if they actually saw you. At least your power seems to be behaving.

They're saying rude things about members of the crowd at the periphery, particularly about non-whites. A few heads

turn their way, as people get offended and angry, but for the moment, the party seems to hold more sway over the people being ridiculed and targeted than the young nationalists do.

Dolyn| I stayed in position for a little while, curious to see if this is going anywhere. The group seemed to have ill thoughts, but they aren't really moving for violence that I can see.

It seemed probable that a fight could break out at some point if the party died down, but I didn't really want to intrude on a minor scuffle where both sides were willing, especially if I was outnumbered.

If nothing came of this, I could keep poking around and looking for people who were looking for trouble.

Wildbow **Things continue for a couple of minutes longer. A woman approaches you, smiling, dancing, and invites you to join her, extending a hand.**

Dolyn| Crap! I hadn't considered something like this might happen. As much as I would have appreciated the offer a few months ago, now I couldn't help but be wary, and I had other things to do besides.

I held up both hands placatingly, giving the woman a sad smile. "Sorry, I can't dance."

Wildbow **Your voice is drowned out by the music. The woman smiles and turns away.**

In the midst of the blasting music, a group of older teenagers -older than you- make their way out of the crowd. One of their member is drunk enough that he needs help standing up. He and his friends stumble into the no-man's-land around the little collection of activists. You can see the tension mount as the activists notice, two of the five of them rising out of their seats.

Dolyn| I moved closer, trying to get in a position where my power was

usable in a potential conflict. A drunk getting beaten up for being drunk seemed criminal ish? This was a murky area for the heroics, but no harm in making sure I can do something if needed.

Thank goodness that woman didn't push the dancing thing, that could have been a spectacle.

Wildbow **As the one group approaches the other, some epithets are dropped by the nationalists. The drunkest of the group of partiers shouts something back that you can't hear over the music.**

It looks as though things are going to come to blows - and then the partiers move on, continuing to cuss out the young nationalists, who retort.

But after the drunk partiers leave, the nationalists remain standing. A member joins their group, another young nationalist, a woman, and she hands out objects.

Knives in sheaths.

Dolyn| Holy shit, I am not ready for a group of people with knives. But I can't just let people get stabbed, either.

Think, think, think. I can cause a distraction, bringing attention to the group, and hopefully bringing in a few of the partiers. I can't handle this group by myself, but maybe with support I could do something.

Good grief, this is exactly why I opted not to go to downtown!

I quickly decided to disguise myself, and then work on drawing attention to the now knife wielding nationalists.

I gathered some razzle, spreading it over myself. This wouldn't last very long, but I just needed to not be as obvious as I usually am and draw their ire immediately.

I attempted to form a dazzle of the woman who had asked me to dance, knowing that she was surrounded by a throng of

people and unlikely to suffer retaliation for this in the short term. To be safe, I changed the hair color and style, and my disguises weren't the best anyways.

I could only hope this would work.

Wildbow **You produce the images in your hands, and cast them down at your feet, letting them build up and encase you, an outer shell that resembles the woman you'd copied. Already, as you move, the seams crack and break away, while the larger image holds; you have only a short window in which to act.**

Dolyn| I gathered up razzle in my hands, hoping that all my practice with my aim would pay off. I then threw the amassed glob at the stairs beneath the nationalists, hoping to form a rainbow wall. Something very eye catching, that would both slow down the nationalists and draw the attention of the crowd.

Wildbow **The glob of your 'razzle' strikes the ground, and where a glob of paint would splash, the razzle instead rises up into an image, forming a wall in front of the stairs they are sitting on. They react with surprise, and a few people at the edge of the crowd make surprised sounds you can hear over the thumping of the dance music.**

Dolyn I cry out, as loudly as I can, "They've got knives!" I know my voice sounds nothing like how I look, and I probably won't be heard by the majority of the crowd, but a girl can hope.

I readied another glob of razzle, prepping myself for when the nationalists inevitably overcame my dazzle fortification.

Wildbow **It takes them only a few moments before they kick their way through the wall, shattering it like candy glass.**

They look around the crowd, searching for the instigator.

((Dex & Wits rolls))

(Fail, fail)

One of them identifies you, pointing and shouting. Your

disguise is already starting to flake away.

You're standing at one side of the street. The crowd of dancers and partiers is to your right, the maze of obstacle-ridden paths between buildings lay behind you, and the left end of the street breaks down to larger buildings and stores, with occasional traffic, most of the stores already closed in the early afternoon.

Dolyn I decided that I'd already performed adequate heroism and ran off through the almost obstacle course behind me. As I did, I threw the razzle I had gathered towards the crowd, willing it to become a dazzle of myself in full costume and a suitably heroic pose.

Probably not much of a distraction, but I'll take what I can get.

Wildbow ((Ath roll))

(Rolls, fails)

You make your way to the obstacle course of fences and trash. Your first attempt at getting over the stuff is a stumbling one, leaving you staggering and costing you precious time

The crowd behind you reacts with surprise and fear, and you glance quickly over your shoulder to see why as you regain your balance. One of them drew a knife and used it to stab your clone. It has a hole in its chest that is opening wider with every passing moment. The last thing you see before you turn back to more immediate matters is the top half breaking off and crashing to the ground.

Dolyn Oh good, their immediate reaction was to stab things that look like me. I quickly made some razzle, flinging it at the ground beneath me. I willed it to become a dazzle of a low platform, a large area of raised ground.

Hopefully the confusing footing would slow the group down slightly, and I had already learned that I could pass through my dazzles as though they weren't there.

I continued my efforts to flee, having no particular desire to be stabbed, and sincerely hoped that at least a few people in the crowd of dancers would be willing to help.

Wildbow ((Ath roll))

(Rolls, fails)

Dolyn Almost definitely not going to happen, but you never know.

Wildbow **Your own progress is slow, and the emotions that grip you now are perhaps not helping. Panic isn't conducive to moving fluidly and with confidence.**

Three of the gang members behind you reach the first gate and while two stumble, a third hurdles the gate, and lands atop the footing you created. He moves far enough along it before it breaks that he doesn't lose his footing or fall behind. He's gaining on you, and now stands about fifteen feet back. The others are roughly thirty feet back and struggling, or they haven't gotten that far yet.

Dolyn I kept running, performing a neat bit of multitasking. I had a bag filled with ball bearings that I'd brought for just such a situation, and I pulled it off my belt. Wasting no time on the finer things, I ripped it open with both hands, scattering the things behind me.

Hopefully that would slow the forefront guy down more than my dazzle had.

This was not going well.

Wildbow ((Dex roll))

(Rolls, passes, doesn't slime
ball bearings with power)

The gap between the one in the lead and the others grows as they continue to struggle with the landscape. The downside of this, however, is that the one in the lead isn't slowing down. He's found his stride, and as the ball bearings come loose, he changes his footing, moving along the trash to the sides rather than the ground.

((Roll ath))

You manage to keep your distance from him, and that little action with the ball bearings might have even helped in forcing him to make the detour. The gap grows.

((Roll wits))

(Rolls, passes)

You quickly assess the environment as you approach a four way intersection. To your left, tall fence with a fire escape behind it. Ahead of you, a straight, clear path leading to the next street over. To your right, more winding paths with debris.

Dolyn

I quickly prepared and flung a glob of razzle at the ground behind me, forming it into another large rainbow wall. Won't stall the man for long, but it will at least block his sight of which way I went.

I've never been much for climbing, so I opted to run down the debris riddled route. I might be able to hide in there, if I'm lucky.

Wildbow

((Ath again))

(Low roll, but enemy gets one too)

The wall seems to do its job of slowing him down. You pick your way through debris and old toys, past bikes and large, ramshackle lean-tos. A glance behind you shows that the coast is clear.

You have a chance to stop to breathe, which you need.

It's up to you to decide what to do at this stage.

Dolyn

I ducked behind a lean to, taking a moment to catch my breath while staying out of sight. Once I was a bit more pulled together, I pulled out the compact I use for touching up my makeup. I flipped it open, peering into the mirror, and angling it around the side, hoping to catch a glimpse of what the forerunner of the knifey nationalists was up to.

Wildbow **The light is dim, and the view in the compact isn't clear-
((Roll wits))**

(Rolls; fails)

You can make out figures, as the others catch up to the one in the lead, but you can't see what they're saying or doing. They've gathered at the intersection of the three paths.

Dolyn I folded the compact back up as I gathered some razzle into my free hand. I then spread the razzle along the side of the lean-to I was using for cover and crouched as it expanded into a dazzle of random detritus, such as the rest of the alley was filled with.

I did my best to listen, trying to make out what the nationalists were up to, as I stayed in my power made hiding place.

Wildbow **((Wits again))**

(Rolls, passes)

"Malin?" you catch one speaking.

"She's coming, Eric is waiting for her, in case she shows while we're here. Little brat, bad enough we have this disgusting display going on when the boss is visiting, but then this brat shows and makes us look bad."

Dolyn I quietly reached into my belt for my pepper spray. I wanted to keep listening, but I didn't want to be at a disadvantage when they started looking for me.

Wildbow **In reaching for the pepper spray, you feel your power start to act up, threatening to spill out and ruin your cover-**

And then it doesn't.

While you crouch there, perplexed, the group takes their time, spreading out and moving through the area two by two. The impression you get, peering through your hologram cover, is that they don't really want to find you at this point, and based on what they said, they're more concerned with looking good to their boss.

Dolyn Oh man, this is exactly the kind of situation I was hoping to find myself in. If I bided my time and found an opportunity to take even one of them out, I could make the whole group look bad to the boss just for having gotten away.

Hell, just getting away would achieve that. But I had an opportunity to do more!

I bided, keeping an eye out for an opportunity to catch one of them alone and unaware. The two by two thing might make this difficult, but maybe they'll drop it. People are weird sometimes.

Wildbow A pair make their way toward you, and one of them was the athletic one who managed to keep up with you earlier, the other is a girl with a black jacket and gray scarf, a cigarette clamped between thick lips.

They make their approach, and for a second, you think one might have seen you, or seen some flaw in the design. Then they make their way to you, and look as though they're going to walk past. The others have disappeared further in the opposite direction or went straight, respectively.

Dolyn I hold the pepper spray at the ready, and create a glob of razzle in my opposing hand.

Waiting this out seems to be the best plan so far, and hopefully it'll work.

Wildbow The pair continue further down the alley, until they reach the next intersection. Another member of the young nationalists greets them, having come from the street.

Dolyn Shit, it looked like they were grouping up with others.

Well, if nothing else, I'd kept a drunk from being stabbed. I continued hiding, frustrated with myself for not being able to do more.

I mean, I could certainly try, but Mom would be furious if I got myself stabbed. If I came out of this unscathed, maybe she'd be

more okay with heroics!

Hm, maybe I should acquire proof of what I've been up to. I'll have to think about that.

Wildbow **((Wits))**

(Rolls, fails)

They speak among one other, and the name Malin comes up for the second time, but you don't hear the context, or pick up anything else.

It dawns on you that with the group moving through the alleys the way they are, you're effectively surrounded. The group to your left isn't budging, and the area to your right has the others fanning out to find you.

Dolyn

Crap, this isn't good. Alright, I needed to come up with a ridiculous plan to get out of this.

I looked around, trying to see if I had any random junk lying in my immediate area. I could try throwing it and making a distracting noise, but I had no guarantee it would work. It would establish that something was in the alley to boot, rather than their current lack of knowledge that I'm here.

I figured I would just look for now, and keep myself ready to be found. Pepper spray and razzle should be a decent deterrent to small numbers.

Wildbow

Long minutes pass, and the group for the most part fails to move. Fat-lips and the running guy stay where they are as the third member of the little gang retreats back the way he came.

((<http://i.imgur.com/wwhyh8C.png>))

Dolyn

Alright, I had to get myself out of here. This situation wasn't going to go away by itself.

I took my time, thinking things through. The positions of the nationalists were fairly stationary, and I had three on either side

of me.

I decided to try something I had not yet tested.

I flipped the hood of my coat up, doing what I could to hide my outrageous color scheme from the back. My front would still be somewhat obvious, but I'd take whatever advantage I could get.

I then spread the razzle I still had prepared along the side of the lean to, willing it into the shape of a step ladder that could fit inside my current hologram.

If I could put my weight on it for just a moment, I should be able to reach the top of the lean to, and from there get to the roof.

It was a ridiculous plan, but it seemed like maybe something that would work. The man earlier had his full weight on one of my dazzles, and it had held. I had to weigh less than him.

Maybe I could make another dazzle on the roof of the lean to once I got there, to block the line of sight of the three goons I would be facing.

What the hell had I gotten myself into?

Wildbow **As the ladder bursts into existence, the cover you'd created breaks apart. Two of the thugs - one on each side of you - catches sight of the color and the motion, and call out to their buddies.**

The group converges on you, as you start to make your way up the ladder.

((Ath roll))

(Rolls, fails)

The first step shatters as your balance shifts too sharply, and your foot hews right through it. The thugs to your right are twenty feet away, the others thirty or forty feet away.

Dolyn **Shit! Getting away is the only reasonable reaction, they've already figured out most of my tricks. I made more razzle, doing what I could to reinforce the step ladder and tried to climb to the**

roof of the lean-to again. If I could get to the roof, life would be much easier, but I still had to get there.

Wildbow ((Ath roll again))

(Rolls, fails)

You find the first step solid enough after a spot repair, but the second step shatters. Obstacles in the way slow the others from getting to you, but they're a matter of feet away now. Fail here and you might well get hauled down to the ground, in the midst of a ring of knife-wielding political extremists.

Dolyn Fuck! This definitely was not going well for me. I reinforced the ladder again, hoping to be able to make it to the roof this time.

Based on my luck so far, I took a deep breath of air. If this failed, I was going to have to use a lot of pepper spray very quickly, and I didn't want to breathe that stuff in any more than these goons did.

Wildbow ((Roll ath))

(Rolls, fails)

The stepladder breaks around you, and the 'goons' tear at it further as they grab for you ((Roll Brawn x2))

(Rolls, fails & fails)

One seizes your arm and the other seizes your leg. They drag you back down toward the ground, and your weight continues to destroy the stepladder, until it lies in ruins. With the hold they have on your arm, your use of the pepper spray is somewhat limited, you might not be able to get all of them.

Dolyn I disregarded the bad angle, spraying the pepper spray anyways. As I did so, I formed a quick glob of razzle, willing it to become a dazzle sword in my hand. Won't do much, but intimidation counts for something!

Wildbow ((Roll social & guts))

(Rolls, succeed & fail,
respectively)

The intimidation doesn't seem to suffice, but in your struggle to get free, you at least manage to pepper spray them while avoiding getting sprayed with the stuff yourself.

One of the young men lets go of you, the group on your right side backing away from the cloud of spray- ((Brawn roll))

(Rolls, passes)

You wrest your arm free, and for the moment, you're free, but you remain largely surrounded.

Dolyn I quickly threw a glob of razzle at the ground, willing it into a dome of rainbow colors. I knew it wouldn't accomplish much, but it should momentarily block line of sight, giving me a chance to break thorough the group to my left. Their vision should still be blurred from the pepper spray, and a light shove from a dazzle couldn't hurt.

Wildbow ((Dex roll to hit with dazzle))

(Rolls, fails)

((Brawn + Ath roll to break through))

(Rolls, miraculous success
on hard roll)

Using the distraction of a burst of your power, an unfortunate miss, you still manage to duck low beneath grabbing arms and between two of the thugs. You put a short amount of distance between you and them. At the intersection, you have three paths available to you - a right turn, the shortest path available to the street, with short gates and fences in the way, further down the alley, or a left turn, putting you further from possible help.

Dolyn I decided to turn left, wanting to be able to just run straight away. None of these guys had guns that I could see, and running seemed like my best option at the moment. I'd probably

need to get to a different bus stop, but I should have time enough to find a thing if I can ditch these folks.

I made another glob of razzle, loving my powers, and flung it behind me to make another line of sight blocking wall.

If they can't see which way I turned, then it should buy me some time again.

Except this time I wouldn't wait where they could surround me.

Wildbow ((Ath roll))

(Rolls low, enemy beats)

Again, the one fellow who'd caught up with you before breaks through the wall. He closes the distance, shouting, and you hear people from behind him -not the group you were just answering- replying, one speaking rather than shouting.

((Wits check to hear))

(Rolls, fails)

You can't hear it, and only put the pieces together as a figure steps out in front of you, an arm extended to catch you at the throat-

((Roll dodge))

(Rolls, fails)

Caught unawares, you're clotheslined, and knocked flat onto your back.

Lying there, bruised, you make the mental connection to the voice saying they would cut you off, appearing well behind you, then the person appearing in front of you.

It's a woman, wearing a long black coat, with a fox-fur collar and a very detailed mask of a fox's face, more a blond-furred fox than a red furred one.

"Stay down," she says, in the sort of French the teachers at school expect, that nobody really uses, every word crisp

and perfect. "I'm willing to give you a chance if you don't make this a hassle."

Dolyn I laid on the ground, panting, as I looked up at the woman who had clotheslined me.

I still had my pepper spray in hand, and could use it again. If I combined that with some razzle, I could maybe fill her mask with pepper spray and let none of it out.

I knew I wasn't a very good shot, though, especially against moving targets, let alone teleporting targets.

I decided to hear her out, hoping to get out of this situation unstabbed.

"A chance at what?"

Wildbow "Escaping unscathed?" she suggests. "I'm a criminal, but I'm not the type of monster who hurts children without cause."

The rest of the group approaches. All of the nationalist thugs are present, some bleary-eyed, and there are at least, by your guess, three other capes in the bunch, one adult, swaddled in dark winter clothing, and two youths.

Dolyn "Oh," I panted out, my own French thickly accented by my preferred German. I looked around as much as I could without moving, fairly concerned about how much trouble I'd managed to stir up with my brilliant plan to avoid exactly this. "I can get behind that."

Wildbow "I'm disappointed by what I've seen so far, Malin," the adult in the group says.

"So am I," Malin says. She extends a hand to you.

Dolyn "Disappointed by who?" I asked warily, as I gingerly accepted the woman, Malin's, hand.

Wildbow ((Roll dex))

(Rolls, passes)

You manage to suppress your power. She helps you to your feet.

"By this handful of young men and women who are coughing and hacking with tears streaming down their faces," Malin clarifies. "My name is Malin the Fox. I'm one of Lausanne's capes, as opposed to one of her tourists, oui? These men and women you're running ragged, who are they to you?"

Dolyn "Um," I paused, taking a moment to think.

Wildbow "I would advise giving smart, quick answers," the other woman says. "Presenting yourself well here could make all of the difference."

Dolyn "Knackered, nationalistic knaves with knives?" I finished, grinning slightly at the alliteration.

Wildbow ((roll social))

(Rolls, fails)

"Well, she's at least got enough wits about her to alliterate," Malin comments. "But I was hoping for a smart answer, as my friend here said."

"These young men," she goes on to say, "Are a smaller group that want my patronage. In this, me and my friend are very different. They come to me, while /she/ goes looking. Because we don't tend to poach from one another, we find we get along better than some. We both came here looking, and our eyes are now on you. Now, pick yourself up, dust yourself off, and take a deep breath."

Dolyn I brought myself to my feet, not wanting to get stabbed if somewhat dreading the idea of having drawn the attention of multiple villainous, probably, capes. I then brushed the dust off of myself.

Finally, I took a deep breath, then looked back to Malin.

I raised my eyebrows to show that I was finished with her

instructions, as she hadn't said anything about questioning her. I felt better playing it safe for now.

Wildbow **She glances at her friend, who nods.**

"Good. That's what I hoped for," Malin said. "Now. Impress me."

Dolyn I decided that she wanted a smart answer to her earlier question, so I tried my best to give her one. Kinda wish I had done my homework now, maybe it would've helped.

"They're nationalists. They don't get along with folks in this area, and I saw them pulling out knives after a drunk insulted them." I paused, taking a deep breath, then continued.

Wildbow **She raises a hand to stop you.**

Dolyn Okay, I guess that's not what she wanted. I tilted my head a little, then gathered some razzle in my hand. Maybe she wanted a show of my power, so I opted to give it. I threw the glob at my feet, willing it to dazzle my appearance to Malin's.

Wildbow **"More what I was looking for. Actions, not words. But I know what you're capable of. I want you to prove yourself. You can pick anyone here, if you like. If you pick me, my friend, or her subordinates, then you should be prepared to come at us with intent to kill.**

I doubt you'll succeed at actually killing us, but the depth of your seriousness will say a lot."

Her friend comments, "I'd recommend going after these louts you were just running from with killer instinct too, but I'm gravely disappointed in them as is, so I might be biased."

She pauses. "Don't actually kill them."

Dolyn Huh, I honestly hadn't been expecting that. Well, I had already formed a plan, might as well make use of it.

I gathered another glob of razzle into my free hand, raising it up

to eye level as I did so.

I looked at Malin consideringly, and then looked back at my hand.

I then sprayed the pepper spray I was still holding in my other hand at her face as I flung the razzle in the same direction, hoping to seal in the supposedly nonlethal concoction.

Wildbow ((Roll Wits + Dex))

(Rolls, passes, passes)

You manage to form the razzle-bubble around the cloud of pepper spray. You hold it in your hand, yet to give it a shape.

Dolyn

I flung the concoction straight at Malin's head, willing it to encapsulate the whole thing as tightly as I could manage. If giving this my all would get me home safe to Mom, then give it my all I would.

Wildbow ((Dex roll))

(Rolls to attack, fails)

She easily sidesteps the orb.

She turns her head and covers one side of her face as the orb collides with one of her would-be underlings's faces.

((Roll social))

(Rolls, fails)

Malin turns to her friend. "What do you think?"

"She's creative. She's just terrible at everything else, it seems."

"You could take it as a challenge. I'd like to see what you could do with her," Malin says.

The friend seems to hem and haw for a few moments, then says, "The others, they can go."

Malin turns to the young nationalists, and she gestures. They shoot you glares of death as they retreat down the various alleys and pathways.

It seems you've made enemies.

"I like the creativity," the friend says to you, once the others are gone. "I want to see what you can do with it, with some honing of your talents. Would you be open to an offer?"

Dolyn "Sure?" I answered, really uncertain of where this was going. I had no intention of being a villain, but I was very aware of my own weaknesses. Who knows, maybe she was a good guy trying to redeem young children by testing their murder skills?

Wildbow **She lowers her hood. "The offer is simple, as these things go. I don't want you as a subordinate, unless you're in my classroom. You can come to me at any time, and I can give you lessons. I will give you food, shelter, lessons, and what little I can offer in costumes, weapons, and equipment..."**

"...But, I have rules."

"The first rule is that you listen to me when you are in my classroom. I will not be disrespected there, and I will not be disobeyed. If you walk away, and you can walk away at any time, then you cannot ever return."

"The second rule is that you will not cooperate with or help the power armor wearers in this city in any way. The 'z'. If you hurt them or hamper them, then you will have my gratitude, but that will not impact the training I give you."

She spreads her hands. "That is the extent of it. Questions?"

Dolyn "Yes, actually," I replied, deciding that I might as well ask the question that was on my mind. "Are you a villain? I'm going to be a hero, so, you know, that'd be important."

Wildbow **"I am neither hero nor villain. I'm a neutral party and work with both. You could kill people nightly, using what I teach**

you, or you could become the most famous hero in the world, and I wouldn't care either way, so long as you obeyed my rules. Malin is my friend, and she is a criminal, of the more organized variety, and I have other friends who are heroes."

Dolyn "Oh, huh," I answered, not sure where to go with that. Neutral parties didn't really fit into my ideals, and accepting would mean that I'd be 'learning' alongside villains, probably.

"So if you asked me something unreasonable, like, say, killing someone, I could decide instead to leave? Is that how that worked?"

Wildbow "I will not ask you to cross that sort of boundary. You'll be hurt, as anyone is during hard training, but you'll suffer no permanent damage. Just the opposite."

Dolyn "And you won't hunt me down and stab me if I walk away? I don't have to show up?" I asked, frankly surprised by how this was going. "All that comes out of tonight is that I've made enemies of some nationalists and I can learn from you if I want?"

Wildbow "Others would be very, very happy to study under me," she says. "Certainly not something to complain about."

Malin cocks her head to one side, and makes an amused sound, "She's proud, keep that in mind."

Dolyn I thought for awhile, going over tonight in my mind. What had started out as a simple goal to stop some muggings or such had gone very differently. My efforts to run away led to me hiding and surrounded, and I couldn't get out of that situation.

If Malin hadn't shown up, I might have been able to get away, but I was undoubtedly going to be facing larger trials than this, and I really quite badly wanted to be a hero people would be proud of and look up to.

And Mom, I knew she'd have a fit if she knew I was out fighting

people with knives, but would she object to my taking classes? I can't imagine she would, as it would be a controlled environment. Honestly, this seemed like an incredible situation to have fallen into.

I nodded, for my own sake, and asked a clarifying question. I already knew what my answer would be, but I still wanted to be sure.

"And the only catch is that I treat you as a teacher should be treated, exclusively while in your classroom which I can leave at any time, and that I avoid contact with Z and the power suits?"

Wildbow **"You can make contact with them, but give them nothing, in respect, parity, or trust," she says.**

Dolyn "But that's it? Nothing else?"

Wildbow **"There are no catches. Malin is the trickster, not me, and you're not dealing with her."**

Dolyn I looked at the fox masked woman, curious about the trickster comment, then decided to ask the woman a very important question.

"Do you think my Mom would be okay with it? She doesn't want me to get hurt."

Wildbow **"I don't know your mother. You -will- get hurt in my classroom, but it will be a temporary pain, and one you'll be happier for in retrospect."**

Dolyn I paused for a moment, then answered. "I'd like to accept, I think. Do you have any forms or anything I could give to my Mom? She'd be happier if she knew roughly what I was up to."

Wildbow **"I'm a cape, and I am someone with enemies. There are no forms, and I'd like to maintain my privacy. Tell her whatever you like, otherwise. If you prove yourself capable in the training, I may have dinner with you and her in a safe location. How does that sound?"**

Dolyn "Any suggestions on what I should tell her, then?" I smirked a little at the question. "As a first advice from teacher to student? I do love her, but she's not wild about my heroics."

Wildbow She shakes her head, then draws a piece of paper from her pocket. She writes something down. "This isn't heroics. It's not villainy. It's self-improvement."

She finishes writing, and she hands you the slip of paper. "My name is Crane the Harmonious. When you're ready, come here. In a matter of days, I can make you as good a hand to hand combatant as anyone your age, powers and my other students notwithstanding.

"If safety is your mother's concern, then tell her that after I've trained you for two weeks, nobody will lay a hand on you without your say-so, and even guns may be a much smaller concern."

Dolyn I couldn't help the startled expression that appeared on my face. It had taken me two weeks just to learn to juggle, but she thought I could learn, no, master hand to hand combat well enough to not worry about /guns/ in that time?

"I, wow," I stammered, somewhat astonished by the claims. "If you're for real, I'll definitely come by as soon as I can. I'm on break right now, so it should be fairly soon, I just have to do homework."

I offered her my hand, as heroes should be polite.

"My name's Rainbow Idol, and it's nice to meet you."

Wildbow "Of course. I have other students of varying ages at my headquarters. Some may be able to tutor you."

She shakes your hand, her grip firm.

She puts her hood back up, "I don't know about you, but I'm cold enough to want to go inside. It's, hm, an hour from midnight. Would you join us for tea?"

Dolyn "Um, sure," I replied, lack of confidence apparent in my voice. "I have to be home by midnight, though, and it's about half hour by bus."

Wildbow "I see," she says. "Our place is further away than that. Another time, then?"

Dolyn "Wait," I answered, curious to see what they were offering in tea, as I could honestly go for a cup. It had been one hell of a night so far. "Which direction? If it's close to where I live, we might be able to make it work. I do like tea."

Oh yes, social skills shining through.

Wildbow "Far enough away that you wouldn't be home by midnight," she says. She shoots Malin a look, while Malin makes another amused sound.

Dolyn I tilted my head, curiosity piqued. "How far away is it?"

At this point, I was very interested, and I might just be able to call Mom and leave a voice mail for her.

Wildbow "This one is going to be a trial, Fox," Crane tells her friend.

Wildbow "I had that instinct," Malin replies.

"It's why I challenged you."

"Good night," Crane says. "Find the answer to your question on your own. It won't take long to find it on a map."

Dolyn "Oh, alright," I answered, only just then remembering she'd given me a piece of paper with the address. So much for my situational awareness.

A thought occurred to me, as I remembered what else had happened in the recent past.

"Actually, I think I will take you up on the tea. I just remembered some people lurking nearby who I would prefer to avoid, if I can."

Wildbow **"As you wish," she says.**

She and Malin lead you further down the street, to where a long, sleek black car is parked. Each of you find seats in the back, and you enjoy a long, quiet ride across the city, passing through crowded downtown, beneath the tower where the angel roosts.

Crane talks about muscle groups and movement, and asks you for particulars of your power. Malin, for her part, interjects with periodic light jokes and mention of her business, which does make you uncomfortable, but also doubles as a lesson of sorts in how villains think and operate, something you're lacking awareness of.

You reach Crane's place, which is broad, with hardwood floors and walls, one room vast and empty, with youths ranging from ten to sixteen, all sleeping in sleeping bags in the near-darkness, with only light from the hallway filtering in. Crane and Malin lead you to a separate room, a kitchen, where they prepare tea, with Crane being very particular about the methods of warming the cup...

...first, with a spoon within, waiting until the tea has reached an exact temperature before pouring. She gives you your selection of about 90 herbal teas, many of which you've never heard of, and has opinions on the benefits of each.

((Comments, actions? Looking to wrap this up))

Dolyn **((I'm good, though I'd want to call my Mom and leave a voicemail saying that I'm at a friends' place and won't be back until late))**

Wildbow **For expediency's sake, Crane provides a set of civilian clothes and a jacket for you to wear home, and Malin instructs a driver to take you back. It's nearly one thirty by the time you make your way back.**

The car stops a distance from the house to let you out, then

drives off.

You're greeted by the sight of red and blue lights.

Dolyn Sweet mercy, this can't be good. I broke into a sprint, dashing home as quickly as I can manage.

Wildbow Two police cars are parked in front of the house. As you appear, a cop standing by one turns his attention to you, and shouts back at the house. You can see that even in the winter, they left the front door ajar.

Dolyn I ran towards the police officer, shouting when I had the breath for it.

"I live here! What happened?"

Wildbow The police officer catches you by the shoulders, stopping you in your tracks. "Stop, stop, nothing happened. Not like that. We were looking for you, as a favor."

Then, as you let your guard down a fraction, he says, "It's your mother."

Dolyn I stopped and stared at the officer.

"Nothing happened, this is a favor, it's my mother what? What happened?"

Wildbow "Nothing happened -here-. At the hospital, there was someone with powers, they lashed out, she was in the way. She got hurt, Silvia."

Dolyn "I, what? How? Will she be okay? Where is she?"

Wildbow "She's not okay, Silvia. Listen, we recognized her by name, and we tried to get in touch with you here, we couldn't find you. With how busy things are, we normally wouldn't, but when you know the people involved... Look, it's best if you have a family member take you to the hospital. If there's any time left, you should have someone you know with you."

As he speaks, he turns to the door. Another two police officers are making their way out. You recognize the man who stands between them, and you note the familiar gesture, the pat on the shoulder that one of the police officers gives him.

Your father fixes his eyes on you, and gives you a sad smile.

Devilman/Windy

Lausanne 'Albatross' Arc - 2.3

Devilman was a /r/Parahumans reader who wanted in. Somewhat inexperienced, he joined the blind draft and got the character he wanted for 9 points, only 3 more points than Nonagon spent for his. With the second least points spent, Devil got two perks. 'Jack of Trades' makes the character very good with skills, giving them more for the knowledge they have, while 'Win Scaling' means that for every victory, their power gets a little better, up to a point. If they lose, well, the power gets a little weaker, but only by one step. It makes it easier to snowball and go from victory to victory.

Here's the thing, Weaver Dice doesn't have 'level ups' in the typical sense. There is no experience counted, no bar that fills, nothing of the sort. Rather, we're testing a 'milestone' system, where the character has X major goals and for accomplishing those goals they get a little boost. It can be a stat point, reputation, skills, or a shot at figuring out another use or secondary benefit of their power.

I won't go into Devil's milestones in depth, because that could be a detriment to him if he winds up with other players as enemies and they use those milestones against him. I will say, however, that he had a trigger where his parents were devoted members of a new superteam where the leader had managed an almost cultish level of control over them. The character was the rebellious kid who was trying to pry the parents free, who realized they didn't have the ability.

In our discussion, Devil said that it was a forgone conclusion that he'd kill the leader of the team as he triggered, so that didn't work as a goal. I was curious, and suggested that we actually roleplay the scene, and Devil agreed. With that in mind, we started pre-trigger event.

Wildbow The television crackles briefly, eliciting a brief, high pitched squeal as the picture corrects. The other members of the Patrol are gathered throughout the room. Forked Lightning, Whitespark, Calcaire, Navigator, Trombe, Visage, Glance, and your parents Arcstar and Skybreak. Collectively you watch the video of the angel moving in concert with Scion, stopping, and then slowly floating over

to the tower. The movement of her wings, the tilt of her head, it looks briefly saddened, before she folds her wings around her as a kind of cocoon.

Staff members and other regulars of the Patrol, including Navigator's boyfriend, stand at the fringes of things. You're among them. Mr. Nordmann, your parents' boss, is on the far end of the room, back to the window, arms folded. Young, good looking, and sharply dressed, you can see the calculation in his eyes as he watches the television, and you know he's about to decide something.

The angel doesn't move for the ensuing minute. The news, fast paced as it might be, breaks form to keep the image centered on her, without commentary, throughout.

The moment the image shrinks and moves to the top right corner of the broadcast, the news anchor's face appearing, Mr. Nordmann points a remote at the screen and mutes it.

"Well have a team meeting about this shortly. Before we get that far, however, I want to make sure I have my ducks in a row. Senior staff, touch base with your teams. Check news, make sure there isn't anything we're missing at this early stage. Mika, get in touch with the Suits and with the local police. With the change in the current situation, they might bite at my earlier offer and take the Patrol on."

He glances out the window. The office is situated high in the building, and the view is spectacular. If you squint, you can almost make out the angel in the distance.

"Storm Patrol, get geared up. Make sure you look good. This is going to be where impressions count."

As the people start to move out of the room, everyone with a job to do he looks at you. "Ms. Robins. Stay, I want to have a word."

Devil ((are my parents still in the room?))

((They've vacated))

"sure." I look at him and around the room. "there's nothing I love more than hanging around with Mr. Nordmann"

I obnoxiously chew my gum

Wildbow The office is nice, professional, soft gray and hard blacks, with a framed, watercolor-splatter variant on the Patrol's logo (([Link](#))) above a long table to the side, with other merchandise placed across it, including folded pieces of casual clothing. Mr. Nordmann himself is tall, blond, and has his hair immaculately styled. His tie is the same red as the group's logo. In addition to his desk, computer, and chair at the one side, there's two couches, several soft chairs, and two televisions. A projector is mounted on the ceiling, aimed at a blank patch of wall.

He smiles, a little more at ease with your sarcasm than he usually is. He glances at the television, and you can see the excitement on his face.

"Two groups are tentatively interested in joining the Patrol. With their numbers added to ours, we could become a presence on par with any of the major teams, the American's big team notwithstanding," he says. "Your mother and father will be famous."

Devil "Cool. Wouldn't be the first time I heard that." I look at the television him, and wander around the room touching stuff to annoy him. I look for anything interesting and to see if he takes his eyes off me.

Wildbow You've been rebelling against the man for some time. He's wary enough he doesn't take his eyes off of you.

"I know how you think, Wendy. I know how you operate. You're a brat, and I just can't have a brat mess up this deal. Your parents can't have that. With that in mind, I've been thinking quite a bit about how to handle this situation."

Devil I take the gum out of my mouth and blow a raspberry at him. If I see the opportunity where's he's not looking I'll flick it onto his chair or somewhere else it will annoy him later. Still casually looking for anything valuable or important. "Is this the part where you have me killed?"

((What are the rough dimensions of the room and how far apart are we about?))

Wildbow "Shut that mouth of yours," he says. "Anything more out of you, and we'll have to put the conversation on hold until I get an apology out of you. With everything we have on the line, here, we're going to have to civilize you."

Devil "Send me to lady school? Might get me out of here at least." I give a short laugh. "Well, get to the point if it's important, then. I don't have all day."

Wildbow "Alright. I see you need a lesson in manners," he says. He walks around to the back of the desk without taking his eyes off you - the room is about 20' by 15', longer rather than wide, with windows at the far end. He touches a button on the side of the keyboard. "Ava? Would you send Arcstar and Skybreak into my office, please?"

Their arrival is quick enough you can guess they were only a short distance away. This scene might have been pre-prepared.

You can see tension in your parents' necks, and fear in their eyes as they look between you and Mr. Nordmann.

Your mother silently mouths the word 'please' to you.

Devil I look over at them. I fume with anger for a moment but try to keep my cool veneer. "Hi mom and dad. I didn't get to say goodbye. Will you home in time for dinner tDevilght? I hate eating alone." I look at Nordmann. "I said I would listen to you had to say. It's probably better to have parental supervision for this anyway. I'm still a minor, you know. I need them to sign my permission slip for any official business."

Wildbow "Arcstar," Andre Nordmann says, ignoring you. "Do you remember our discussions of your costume? There were several drafts, and you had one you liked? I agreed we could go with that one."

"Yes sir," she says.

"I have concerns about... other elements in the company-" He looks at you. "-that may hurt our numbers. To keep things in certain margins, we're going to need more direct appeal. We'll have you wear costume two. The one that shows more skin."

Her face pales.

He turns back to you. "For the raspberry, and the backtalk."

Devil "You know, you look great in a bikini. You're real fit. That costume shows less skin than my regular clothes anyway." I glance at him. "So, is that all you wanted to tell me? That you have a crush on my mom? Or was there a point?" I'm still glancing at him and around the room looking for something I can mess with.

Wildbow "Please, Wendy," your mother says. "He will make me change my costume. I want this to work out. Just... go along with what he says, please. Don't make it worse."

Devil I give a disgusted sigh, cross my arms, and put my nose in the air. "Fine." I look at him at him and try to keep a straight face.

Wildbow "Somehow I'm not convinced," he says. "But we'll see how this progresses. I have rules for you, Wendy. When the other teams visit, you're going to behave. There will be young men and women as part of those groups. You will make them feel welcome, you will be friendly, and you will have only nice things to say about the Patrol and about me. Now, I have some rules about how you should dress, and key points on what you should talk about..."

Devil I glance at my parents and back to him as he talks.

I keep quiet, waiting to get this over with.

Wildbow "Should any of the young men express interest in you, I would like you to reciprocate, in the interest of forming deeper bonds between

the teams. I would ask the same of you if you were a boy, and it was the young women," he says.

Devil "You're pimping me out?!"

I quickly laugh to cover any sign of surprise.

Wildbow "I have more respect for working girls who get 'pimped out' than I have for you. You're feral, disobedient, and destructive, Wendy Robins. To correct that, I will control your schedule, I will control what you say and do, I will decide where and how you work, how and who you date, and when you sleep."

Devil "This is so stupid." I turn to my parents. "Did he run this by you?" At any point during the conversation if I see he isn't looking I casually toss my gum into his immaculately styled hair.

Wildbow "He talked about it in a general sense," your father says. He averts his eyes.

"Your parents understand that we're engineering something greater," Nordmann says. "I see you still need correction, if you think this is 'stupid'. Skybreak. You're fired, until such a time as your daughter is acting like a decent human being."

Devil "Cool. We'll go form our own team. Without hookers!"

Wildbow "Wendy, -please-," your mother says.

Your father is pale, his hands shaking.

Nordmann talks, "Arcstar, you'll spend a few months operating on your own, then strike up a public, false relationship with another member of the team. You'll be publicly affectionate. It will go over well, for numbers with the media. I'll have to increase your hours too. You won't spend much time at home."

Nordmann turns his eyes to you. "Your mother will stay. She wants this too badly. Your father knows it, don't you, Skybreak?"

"If I beg you, will you let me stay?" Skybreak asks.

Nordmann waves him off.

Devil I look at my parents. "You guys are such pussies!" I shriek, my fists clenching. "Mom, let's walk."

Still looking for any sort of opening.

Wildbow She averts her eyes.

"If you walk away from me right now, Wendy Robins, then I will humiliate your mother. I will drive a wedge into your parent's relationship and break them up. Skybreak already knows I have the leverage, financial and otherwise, to keep him from ever putting a costume on again. He wants this just as badly as she does, and losing out on this because of -you- will break him. He knows it. You can see it in his eyes."

"Do you know why they'll let this happen? Because even after everything else comes to pass, they know I have the ability to make this team something truly *great*. They know I do this with not just the best interests of the business in mind, but with the desire to create something important, and they want *that* more than anything."

Devil I look at my parents. "Augh! I can't believe you! I'm the only one around here with any dignity!" ((What are the spatial relations of me in the room with Nordmann, the desk, TVs, etc.??))

Wildbow (([Link](#)))

"If you think there's anything dignified about the way you've been rebelling these past few weeks and months, Wendy," Nordmann says, very calm, "You're sadly mistaken. Even your tone right now, you're clearly hysterical. With my attention, I think you'll thrive as a human being."

Devil I quickly get my cool demeanor up and laugh. "You're the only thing that's hysterical. Well, and these 2." I casually pace around the office as I speak, in front of my parents then double back and make my way to the front of

his desk without arousing suspicion as best I can. "What is it you want me to do again?" ((What's on the desk?))

Wildbow Your mother appears in front of you, a flash of electricity crackling around her. She puts her hand out to stop you from crossing the room. As you look up, she refuses to meet your eyes.

((Computer mDeviltor, keyboard and mouse on the desk))

"You heard me. But let's start with a sincere apology, Wendy. For the way you've acted," Nordmann says.

Devil ((Is she between me and him?))

((yes))

Dangit. I look at her. "Oh, now you move?" I act casual. "I am soooooooooooooo sorry I called you a perverted asshole. I'm very very sorry I don't kiss your ass like everyone else around here. You know, you could really use a haircut." As I speak I need to try to feint one way or create a distraction, bob and weave around her, possibly over the chair there. If nothing else is at hand I'm gonna aim the gum at his hair when I have a clear shot.

Wildbow ((Roll Ath - Fails vs. mom's roll))

Your mother easily catches you by the wrist as you grab the gum. She plucks it from your fingers.

"Like I said," Nordmann says. "Feral. Perhaps this would move along more smoothly if you signed over your parental rights to me. I know the people to put it in motion."

Your mother snaps her head around, looking at him, shocked.

Devil "Let go of me!" I struggle around when she looks away.

Wildbow They're not about to take their attention off of you, especially after the latest stunt.

Nordmann gestures at your father, two fingers extended, indicating 'up'.

Wind swirls around you, lifting you clear of the ground, levitated by a gust of whirling wind. The minimalist decor and the weights on various objects in the room keep anything from flying around. You're immobilized.

"It would make things easier. You could focus on your careers."

"Careers?" Skybreak asks.

"I'd give you your job back for this concession. I would take full responsibility of her."

You can see that your parents are actually so broken as to be considering it. Your father's hands shake.

Devilman ((I basically can't move?))

Wildbow ((You can flail around, but you can't go anywhere))

Devilman "Put me down! This is crazy! Fucking asshole!" I basically just swear and flail. Not much else I can do.

Wildbow "Wendy, stop," your mother says, barely audible over the rush of wind. "Things are so good here when you're not poisoning things and making him act this way."

Devilman "Put me down, dad! Mom! I can't believe you would side with him over me!" I float helplessly in the air, flailing my limbs, wishing I could kill this man. Feeling my parents betrayal, tears well up in my eyes. I spit in his general direction. I try to kick off the ceiling towards him if I can reach it. I exert every muscle. I pee on myself a little from the strain, if I didn't go in a while.

Wildbow "I have papers here, from when I considered the possibility a few weeks ago," Nordmann says, calm and confident. He opens a drawer and lays them out on the desk. He puts a

hand on your mother's shoulder as he walks to her side, and puts a pen in her hand. "With your daughter handled, I'll have no reason to worry about you and your husband. Your costume, your patrols, everything will be fine, the way you've been talking about wanting."

"The costume you were going to make me wear?"

"That was about your daughter, not about you."

She hesitates, reading, then scribbles something down at the end of the paper.

Devilman I hysterically flail around. "Fucking bitch! Whore! Pussies! I'll kill you fucks! I'll kill myself! I'd rather die!
Fuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuck!" I shriek.

Wildbow Sparks flare behind your eyes. The sparks expand, and drown you out. You see darkness, and you see stars. You see latent energy, packed into the core of an object so massive you can't even conceive of it, writhing and struggling, and you realize that that energy is alive.

Around that object, clouds rise and begin to rotate around the sky. The energy builds, latent, and then detonates, casting out violence and ruin in every direction.

You hit the ground, landing on the floor on the other side of the desk. The images in your head begin to fade from mind and memory, leaving you only dimly aware of your parents, hunched over in what looks like pain, of the desk, and the other little details of the office. On the other side of the desk, out of view, is Nordmann.

Devilman I stand and test out my limbs.

Devilman ((What do I feel?))

Wildbow As you stand and find your center of balance again, you're aware of your power, bound within you like a spring, or a coil of raw energy, to be pulled together and released. You can see the air currents, both natural and the unnatural ones

your father created, from the gusts of wind he'd formed to levitate you above the ground, and you understand those air currents as well as you understand your own body.

Nordmann stands on the other side of the desk. He doesn't flinch as he stares you down.

The Power

Devilman got a mover power, one that lets his character launch herself in a straight line, ricocheting up to once per turn, striking anyone in the way. She can fly, too, which she'll wind up doing automatically if she doesn't end up on/near solid ground, but it's incredibly slow and clumsy.

Every time she makes contact with a surface, including during ricochets, she leaves a handprint behind. She can activate the handprints at will to detonate them as aerokinetic whirlwinds, tossing everything nearby away from the epicenter(s).

Finally, as a secondary power, she can read the wind. In execution, if she's thrown or tossed into the air, she'll practically always land on her feet, and can choose her landing point, based on how hard she was tossed/thrown. Tossing or throwing others, she has more choice over where they end up landing.

Devilman I glance back at my parents quickly, then default back to my last behavior. My hatred for Nordmann. I can't live with him, and want him dead. With my parents disabled, I quickly exert my power at him as best I can untested. Coil the spring and release. Use the wind.

Wildbow ((Roll Athletics))

You hurl yourself at him, a living projectile, and are nearly there when something collides with you. As you tumble through the air, currently right over the desk, you can decide where you end up landing, within 5 or so feet of the desk.

Devilman Behind him if I can. Or behind the desk at least.

Wildbow You land on the far side of the desk, practically at Nordmann's feet. The object that knocked you off course was your own mother. She seizes you-

((Roll Brawn))

-And succeeds in pinning you against the ground.

"Stop fighting," she says. "Please. Stop fighting him."

Devilman "Mom! Fuck! I have powers! Get off me!" I flail my limbs around, pushing my hands and feet off her and the floor. ((What do I feel?))

Wildbow **((What do you mean, what do you feel?))**

Devilman ((When I touch the floor))

Wildbow The coiled-spring energy travels along your arms and into your hands, leaving a mark on the floor. You can feel the coiled-spring energy in the same way you can feel the air currents.

Your mother clearly sees. She moves a hand, and brushes a thumb against the side of your face. You feel the static tingle you've always associated with your mom's touches and caresses, and you know that this time, for perhaps the first time in your life, she's left a glowing mark on you. One that she can electrify.

"Don't. Whatever it is you can do," she tells you, "Don't. Just surrender. Cooperate, please!"

Devilman I channel my desire into my power. Must get through her, must kill him. If he were to fly out the window, my problems would be over. I spring the coil.

Wildbow **((You activate the handprint?))**

Devilman ((Yes))

Wildbow The mark on the ground detonates, a rush of explosive wind and power. The next thing you know, you're crashing through plate glass-

((Roll Guts))

You feel the glass cut you as you tumble through the air. The coils let you slow how quickly and easily you move through the air, and with glass still raining down around you, you stop yourself from tumbling head over heels, then slow your fall. You start drifting slowly toward the ground, and you know you could move in another direction if you so chose.

Your mother, Nordmann--

You look, and you see them both, above you in the air, encapsulated in aerokinetic bubbles. Rescued by your father. Whatever sense that lets you see the air currents, it lets you see that he's reaching for you and being pushed away by your power. He knows you don't need a bubble, as he stands in the broken window, looking down at you.

As you drift down, he pulls them up.

Devilman "Why?! Fuck!" I channel my desire into my power. Escape Nordmann.

or harm him if I can

((Can I manipulate the wind he's in?))

Wildbow **((Who's in?))**

Devilman ((Nordmann. Can I knock him out of my dad's bubble towards the ground?))

Wildbow **((not one of your powers; you can touch a surface and fling yourself/ricochet, you can lay handprints down, and you can control the nuances of how you and enemies you're making contact with fall/tumble/get thrown))**

Devilman ((Ahh. I guess he's no longer considered puched by me. Just the first one then. Escape.))

Wildbow It's a long, slow journey down, as you effectively walk the distance. You could go down to the street, or onto a rooftop. You have nothing to your name and only the money in your wallet - enough to get a fast food meal. By the time you're getting close enough that you have to decide where you'll land, you can see the other heroes of the Patrol gathering around your mother, father, and Nordmann, looking down your way.

Devilman I land on a rooftop and use the spring of my power to go away
2 from them.

Whichever direction looks like it has the most cover.

Wildbow You bound away and deposit yourself in an alleyway. Your hair and your gaudy clothing is disheveled. It takes a long time for your heart to stop pounding.

Devilman I pant. "Idiots! Why?!" I look at my surroundings and try to decide
2 what to do.

//// Session End, more to come ////

#WD_Lausanne

-->| **YOU (Wildbow) have joined #WD_Lausanne**

-->| **Ridtom (Ridtom@net-rbipjp.fios.verizon.net) has joined #WD_Lausanne**

Wildbow waits for Windy.

-->| **Olivebirdy (Olivebirdy@net-oqbisf.netvision.net.il) has joined #WD_Lausanne**

-->| **Windy (Devilman@net-bnq.g99.254.155.IP) has joined #WD_Lausanne**

Wildbow Last time, on WD_Lausanne... Daughter of two capes who are headliners in an up and coming cape team, Wendy

Robins watched with the team and the team's founder, Nordmann, as the angel descended, coming to roost on a building. Eager to take advantage of the opportunity, Nordmann sent the team on their way, asking Wendy to stay...

Wildbow What became a stern discussion between Nordmann and the rebellious teen girl who didn't like how her parents were being treated turned ugly, as Nordmann demoted and demeaned Wendy's parents as punishment for her recalcitrance. The parents pleaded with their daughter to obey, to listen, and Wendy conceded, until Nordmann began outlining how she should date new teenage members, and how he...

Wildbow ...aimed to control her life to keep her rebellious tendencies from hurting the organization.

Wildbow Things turned ugly as she tried to attack Nordmann and was stopped by her parents - leading Nordmann to suggest that he would take custody of her. Wendy triggered as her mother signed, and used her new aerokinetic powers to assault Nordmann and throw him, herself, and her mother out the window. Allowed to float down to safe ground while her father saved the other two, she flees into the...

Wildbow ...streets of Lausanne, lacking jacket, money beyond mere pocket change, and a cell phone...

Wildbow //

Wildbow ** ((She has a cell phone, and pocket change, and the clothes on her back, nothing else))

Windy ((what's the weather like, and who are the contacts in my cell?))

Wildbow ((You're new in town, so no contacts you'd feel calling in a time of need. The weather is cold enough you'll get frostbitten if you don't get warm or covered up, and there's very light snow at present))

Windy **Hmm. Well, I'm homeless and have only a few franks, can't go back to the Patrol tower or I'll get pimped out by Nordmann, and my parent's just won't listen!**

Windy **There's not much I can do. No place to sleep, nothing to eat after my money's gone. No friends to go to. And I don't want to wander around begging and end up getting stabbed or pimped out. So, my plan is to to make my way to the angel, before the Patrol gets there hopefully. If she's anything like Scion, maybe talking to her or touching her will help me somehow.**

Windy **I can test my jumping power on the way there. Just gotta evade the Patrol**

Windy **//**

Wildbow **The wound 'spring' of your power unleashes, and you cast yourself out and up, moving down the streets and alleys in the general direction of the angel, making your way toward the appropriate part of downtown.**

Wildbow **The wind whistles around you, but your power keeps it from being too harsh against your skin or communicating too much of the cold. A good thing, too, because the windchill could otherwise have been incapacitating.**

Wildbow **The closer you get to downtown, the more you see the reaction. The video you watched with Nordmann and the others was live, and the conversation alongside the subsequent events took ten or fifteen minutes. Now your trip downtown is taking more time. It's enough for the people in the angel's direct vicinity to have emerged from within the homes and apartments, from businesses, forming a...**

Wildbow **...larger crowd. You're but one of a number of people who want to see her for yourself.**

Wildbow **As you draw closer, the mass of people on the street make it hard to stay close to the ground. You're going to have to make decisions about how to approach.**

Wildbow //

Windy ((what are my options?))

Wildbow ((Walk, ricochet above the crowd's heads, try floating, watch from a distance...))

Windy ((how far am I from the tower?))

Wildbow ((It might be a ten minute walk as is, but there's a bustling crowd in your way.))

Windy dang. well, Nordmann knows my face and pwer anyway so no use hiding my identity. I choose the bold route. ricochet above the crowd's heads. I'm gonna have to bound from building to building. when I get to the tower I'll use my power to ascend to the angel, assuming nothing goes wrong

Windy //

Windy *power

Wildbow ((Ath roll & then Guts roll))

== soulpelt|class is now known as soulpelt|nap

Wildbow The cold is getting to you, and your teeth chatter. The air you breathe, and there's no choice but to breathe it, regardless of what your power can do for you, is cold in your mouth, nose and lungs. All the same, you ricochet from building surface to building surface, avoiding throwing yourself at and through a window.

Wildbow Out of breath, nose, ears, and mouth stinging from the cold, you stop at the foot of the building. There are already capes present, working to keep the crowd back, and the crowd is something impressive- people standing shoulder to shoulder, pressing in toward the entrance from as far back as a block away.

Wildbow It's a straight shot up to the top of Taoua tower. Leaping from the nearest rooftop, you'd need to make your way up seventeen floors. You can bound part of the way, but the rest

of it would be a slow, floating ascent.

Wildbow //

Windy ((could I bound, grab a window, then bound again?))

-->| **Stoic** (Stoic@net-n3k0uk.nj.comcast.net) has joined
#WD_Lausanne

Wildbow ((You'd end up bounding up and away, at an angle, with barely any benefit))

Windy hmm. I have to make my way to that angel. I'll get as close as possible then float. unless... I can fly right in a window and run up the stairs

Windy ((what can I see of the capes already there?))

Wildbow There seem to be no less than twenty capes in the immediate region, assisted by police, half of whom are helping hold the line, and half are dragging away people who already made their way inside. There seems to be a strong red, black, and white color combination across the assembled capes. You recognize them as the Suits that Nordmann was talking about.

Wildbow //

Windy I'll probably just be dragged away if I do a slow ascent. from a rooftop, I rocket as high as I can, aiming for a window. If it looks like I'm heading for a wall, I'll slow my speed so i don't slam against it. if it looks like I'm heading for a window, I'll try to roll into a ball and cover my face to break through it.

Windy //

Wildbow ((Ath roll to make a break for the window))

Wildbow You plant your feet, and fixate on the window you want to pass through. A running start, a release of the coiled power within you, and you launch, straight for the window. You soon realize you're a foot to the side, and slow just enough to catch yourself, grabbing the windowsill and window while

using your ability to float to stop from falling.

Wildbow You can hear the protests and cries of the crowd below you as fingers are pointed. The heroes have taken notice.

Wildbow //

Windy shit shit shit

Windy ((how far am from the top?))

Wildbow ((15 floors))

|<-- Stoic has left irc.parahumans.net (Quit: <http://www.kiwiirc.com/> - A hand crafted IRC client)

Windy dang. I try to float up as fast as I can while waving to the crowd

Windy //

Wildbow ((Wits check))

Wildbow As you turn to wave at the crowd, you can see the crowd and the heroes backing away, forming an odd, vaguely circular clearing directly below you. A point of light flashes in the center of the clearing, growing in intensity.

Wildbow ((14 floors))

Wildbow //

-->| Stoic (Stoic@net-n3k0uk.nj.comcast.net) has joined #WD_Lausanne

Windy I leave some handprints on the wall as I go up, keeping a lookout on the light. Might as well test out my power. I smile, yelling as loud as I can. "Hi, I'm... Windy! I need to talk to the angel!"

Windy //

Wildbow Where there was light, there is now a beam, a shaft of light that catches and surrounds you, five feet across, spearing

skyward from the ground and into the clouds.

Wildbow ((Wits check to react))

Wildbow ((Reflexes apply))

Wildbow ((You can act))

Wildbow //

Windy ((what do I feel when it touches me?))

Wildbow ((Nothing))

Windy I'll try to kick through a window if I can. Otherwise I'll just keep floating up and try to dodge this beam

Windy //

Wildbow ((Brawn roll))

Wildbow Your foot slams into the glass, but fails to break it, especially without proper leverage and surfaces to brace against. You turn, ready to get out of the beam, when all of a sudden, you can't see, hear, or breathe.

Wildbow You feel a gritty texture over exposed skin and through hair, there's no air to work with, and you tumble, falling, pulled down with a weight that envelops you.

Wildbow *envelops you.

Wildbow ((Wits check))

Wildbow Head over heels, movements restricted, you notice a moment where there's a gap, the stuff surrounding you letting the air in. Too slow to react, you miss the window to escape.

Wildbow ((Sixteenth floor, roll again))

Wildbow The stuff around you, appearing to be -sand- is breaking up more as you get closer to the ground. You see a window of opportunity to act again, and hurl yourself out of the column

as -another- beam erupts. Much of the falling sand is encased in a column of ice.

Wildbow You're 15 feet above the heads of the capes below. A woman with a staff stands a little more inside the clearing than the rest, gripping it in both hands as she looks up at you.

Wildbow //

Windy I scream. "please stop attacking me! I don't want to fight anybody!"

Windy //

Wildbow "Come down," the woman with the staff says. "All the way to the ground."

-->| Zeikos (Zeikos@net-g3471a.ip128.fastwebnet.it) has joined #WD_Lausanne

Wildbow Traces of sand are still falling around you, mingling with the snow.

Wildbow //

Windy "come on! please let me see the angel! I just want to talk to her. I just triggered and I've been havijg the worst day!"

Windy //

Windy *having

Wildbow "Come down," the woman says, stern.

Wildbow //

Windy ((what's in front of me?))

-->| Words^3 (Words3@net-n2lbad.ma.comcast.net) has joined #WD_Lausanne

Wildbow Pillar of ice behind you, 5 feet across, a building behind that, 10 feet ahead of you and below you is the staff woman, and the crowd rings you.

Wildbow //

Windy ((so I'm no longer in reach of a window?))

Wildbow ((You moved away from the pillar and away from the building as a consequence. No))

Windy dang. "OK!" I slowly float down, looking dejected

Windy //

Wildbow She lets her guard down slightly as you descend, landing at the foot of the pillar. A row of glowing points of light appear behind her, without her even looking, and as she walks toward you, they erupt into columns of steel, blocking the approach of the crowd.

Wildbow "Let's go inside," she says, using her staff to point at the nearest door.

Wildbow //

Windy I nod and follow her

Windy //

Wildbow Passing inside the building, you see staff members of the Suits moving this way and that, men and women alike are in suits, half of the women wearing skirts and tights, the other half wearing suit-pants. The button-up shirts and blouses beneath the suit jackets are crimson. Every single one of them wear name tags.

Wildbow You're aware of your physical state. In your pell-mell movement to get to the tower and the angel, you let yourself get out of breath. The cold stings, but you can deal with it, but getting hit by the column also served to make you rather messy. Every article of clothing is dirty, and half of your hair isn't even in a ponytail anymore.

Wildbow "My name is Matraque," the woman with the staff says. "I need you to calm down, take a moment, and tell me how I can help you."

Wildbow //

-->| LexiSnore (uid137968@charlton.irccloud.com) has joined #WD_Lausanne

Windy I start to tear up. I tell her my story. "My name is Wendy. My mom and dad are Arcstar and Skybreak from Storm Patrol. Their boss is this guy Andre Nordmann. He treats them like crap. He hit my mom. He tried to pimp me out to guys from other teams. i triggerred and ran away. I'm broke and homelss and I don't know what to do. Please, I need to talk to the angel so I can make a wish."

Wildbow ((Social roll))

Windy *homeless

Windy //

Wildbow She hears your breathless explanation, then sighs, shaking her head a little, before raising a hand to pinch the bridge of her nose.

Wildbow She's silent for long enough that you get uncomfortable. Just as you think you should open your mouth to say something, she turns her head. She asks a staff member, "Where is the King of Clubs?"

Wildbow "Office upstairs."

Wildbow Matraque invites you to join her in heading up the nearest set of stairs, by the elevator.

Wildbow //

Windy I follow, trying to control my sobbing

Windy //

Wildbow "We've been talking with the Patrol," Matraque explains, as she walks beside you, one hand on your shoulder to steady you, so you don't trip on the stairs while your eyes are full of tears. "If what you say is true, then it's very disappointing

and very surprising. I'm going to take you to my superior. I want you to tell him what you told me."

Wildbow //

Windy "Ok." I continue with her

Windy //

Wildbow The second floor is more of an office than the lobby downstairs. It looks like a police station, if the staff of a whole station moved in within the span of a few hours. There are boxes everywhere and things seem disorganized, though computers are out and the walls throughout the space are glass, with blinds on the far side, so privacy can be maintained where necessary.

Wildbow Matraque leads you into an office, where a man stands over a desk, one hand firmly planted on the wood there, the other holding a phone to his ear. He's armored in black, rust red, and white, and has a stylized 'k' with the ♣ symbol from the suit of clubs beside it on the breast.

Wildbow He beckons for you two to come in, speaks, nods, and then hangs up. He looks at you and Matraque expectantly.

Wildbow "She says she's from the Patrol. We may have a bit of a mess to deal with," Matraque says, "On top of the issues with the angel."

Wildbow //

== EmpyZzZ is now known as Empy

Windy I try to control my tears and repeat the story I told to Matraque

Windy //

Wildbow "I don't suppose the Dogs of Valor are anywhere nearby?" he asks Matraque. She shakes her head, and he sighs. "It would be nice to be able to verify things. You, what's your name?"

Wildbow //

Windy ((I thought I told him as part of my story)) "Wendy Robbins." I repeat. "Please don't call my parents or Nordmann." ((Do I have their numbers on my cell?))

Wildbow ((You do))

Windy I show him the numbers on my phone as proof. "Look. How else would I have their numbers? Please don't tell them I'm here. My parents just signed custody of me over to Nordmann and he said he would make me his slave. Make me date boys. I don't want to go back." I start sobbing again.

Windy //

== LexiSnore is now known as Lexicon

Wildbow "I have to verify," he says. "Especially when the Patrol is one of our best options for supplementing our numbers and keeping the peace here. If I'm going to refuse to allow them to participate, then I have to be absolutely sure."

Wildbow That said, he pauses, taking a long look at the phone. "I'm going to need you to be quiet while I talk to them. Or do I need to have Matraque escort you from the room while I make the call?"

Wildbow //

Windy "I'll be quiet." I say. I compose myself. "Please, just tell them I already left or something?"

Windy //

Wildbow "We'll see," he says. He reaches down to the phone, presses a button, and then presses another. The speakerphone comes on. "Put me through to Andrew Nordmann from the Patrol."

Wildbow The phone rings, once, twice.

Wildbow "Hello, Factotum," Nordmann's voice comes through the

line. "I was just about to call you. We're getting all of our ducks in a row over here, after a bit of an incident. How can we help the King of Clubs?"

Wildbow ((Social roll))

Wildbow Factotum glances at you, then says, "A bit of an exceptional case over here. A young lady crossed our paths, seeming very out of sorts. She claimed abuse, some kind of prostitution, and other problematic behavior. She triggered and found her way here, looking very much like someone who has just had a trigger event, and the Suits now find themselves in a very awkward position when it comes...

Wildbow ...to our relationship with the Patrol."

Wildbow "Is she still there?"

Wildbow "No," Factotum lies.

Wildbow // ((Want to do anything in the meantime?))

Windy ((who and what are in the office? baic layout?))

Wildbow ((Desk, thick glass walls on 3 sides of you, complete with blinds, open. There are three chairs arranged for guests to sit at, and a chair behind Factotum. Matraque stands behind you.))

Windy ((so I can rocket out a window if need be can I see anything out the windows?)) I clasp my hands together and give Clubs a sad puppy I look

Windy *be?

Windy //

-->| JustLurking (JustLurking@net-d2vdf5.mn.comcast.net) has joined #WD_Lausanne

Wildbow You glance at the window, your escape route. It's behind Factotum, and it's not a particularly wide one. Anything else would involve trying to go through the thicker glass panes

around you.

Wildbow "I would be very, very careful, Factotum," Andrew Nordmann speaks. "I believe one of your many powers is the ability to see from a distance? If I remember from my last visit, you can see the Patrol's headquarters from there."

Wildbow Factotum walks over to the window, looking out. He nods slowly. "I see."

Wildbow Turning back toward you and Matraque, he explains to her, "Large window, shattered."

Wildbow "The girl in your office right now is an infiltrator. She's a power copier, taking advantage of the fast growth of our organization and the fact that so many of our employees are new to waltz in, professing relation to one of our members. If she was there, it's very possible she's trying to tap the powers of the angel."

Wildbow //

Windy I give a shocked look, tearing up again. I make the gesture for a pen and paper

Windy //

Wildbow "She had your phone numbers," Factotum says.

Wildbow "She had a lot of things, Factotum. She was looking at paperwork, digging for details on our capes, apparently for financial data. We cornered her in my office."

Wildbow //

Wildbow ((Also, redact earlier part about "In your office right now, if you please"))

Windy ((Did he see me make the pen and paper sign?))

Wildbow ((Social roll))

Wildbow He slides the paper and a pen closer to you. As you step

forward to take it, Matraque's staff touches your throat. Not to do anything, but merely as a warning.

Wildbow //

Windy I write. "He's using Navigator, his thinker to remote view this office. She can only keep this up for three minutes and thirty-five seconds. ((I write down details of my parents that only their daughter would know)). Please believe me." I slide it back to him.

Windy //

Wildbow ((Details such as...?))

Windy ((anything only I would know. my life before the Patrol. a birthmark one of them has maybe?))

Wildbow ((Knowledge roll))

Wildbow You jot down some particulars, including a chronology of your time with your parents.

Wildbow Factotum looks down at the sheet, giving it the same long look he gave your phone. "She left details that go beyond what mere paperwork would suggest. It makes for a fairly convincing picture."

Wildbow "Unconvincing infiltrators tend to be dead or imprisoned infiltrators," Nordmann says. He doesn't even sound particularly stressed. "I'll tell you what. I can do two things that will help set this picture straight. First off, when my team comes to help with the angel, I'll bring paperwork, and your staff can cross-check everything. Even if she's particularly skilled, you'll see the...

Wildbow ...holes here and there.

Wildbow "Second of all," Nordmann says. "Perhaps the biggest hole. Which of our capes did she say she was related to?"

Wildbow "Arcstar and Skybreak."

Wildbow "One second."

Wildbow There's a lengthy pause on the other end. Seconds pass.

Wildbow //

Windy ((I gesture for the paper if it's not within reach))

Windy *within

Wildbow He passes it to you.

Wildbow ((Dex roll to write fast enough))

Wildbow ((Go ahead))

Wildbow ((Keep it short and sweet))

Windy writing: "He just threatened to make my mom wear a hooker costume and fire my dad."

Windy //

Wildbow "Okay," Nordman speaks over the phone. "You met Arcstar the other day, if I remember right."

Wildbow "I did," Factotum says.

-->| Vern|GM (Kanna@net-feam0c.pools.vodafone-ip.de) has joined #WD_Lausanne

Wildbow "Hi, Factotum," your mother speaks, her voice on the line. "I've been listening in. Um. What Nordmann says is true. If you met a girl professing to be my daughter, then you were tricked. I-I-" She stutters.

Wildbow "-Sorry. It's a sensitive subject," she says, her voice dropping. "I don't have any children."

Wildbow //

Windy I tear up a bit and try to keep quiet. ((If I can still write)) "Ask her about the costume change. About being forced to break up with Skybreak and fake a relationship with anothehr

cape"

Windy //

Windy *another

=-= Vern|GM is now known as VernZzZ

Wildbow Factotum stares down at the paper. "Thank you, Andrew, Arcstar. I'm sorry for the trouble."

Wildbow "Not at all," Nordmann says. "I'm sorry our infiltrator problem landed on your doorstep. Can we consider this resolved? The Patrol can be there in a matter of minutes, to bolster your forces."

Wildbow "That would be excellent," Factotum says. "Bring the paperwork when you can, just to soothe any lingering concerns on my part."

Wildbow "I'll do that. Best of luck, Factotum, I'll see you soon," Nordmann says. He exhales, then chuckles slightly, "Exciting times!"

Wildbow "Exciting times," Factotum says, with none of the enthusiasm. He touches the button to hang up.

Wildbow //

Windy "You believe him?!" I exclaim. "He has my parents brainwashed! How am I supposed to prove my mother gave birth to me?"

Windy //

Wildbow "This would be far easier to resolve if it were the only crisis at hand," Factotum says. "But there's a crowd out there that is in an outright frenzy. At a time when things are at their most complicated, I have to be suspicious of a situation where someone shows up on our doorstep-"

Wildbow Matraque cuts in, "She didn't even come to us. She went straight for the angel. I had to bring her down."

|<-- Stoic has left irc.parahumans.net (Quit: <http://www.kiwiirc.com/> - A hand crafted IRC client)

Wildbow "-Not even on our doorstep, then, during a time of crisis."

Wildbow //

Windy I start crying a bit. "I told you, I have no other options right now and I was hoping the angel would help me. Look, if you don't believe me fine. I'm telling the truth if you have any thinkers or whatever. But I have barely any money. What am I supposed to eat? Where am I supposed to sleep tDevilght? I'm not going back to the Patrol tower. I don't even have a jacket. I'm freezing!"

Windy //

Wildbow "We'll get you a jacket. I don't think I can be sure about the claim of money," Factotum says. "Or much of anything, really."

Wildbow //

Windy I look at him. "So you're letting me go? Just back to the street?"

Windy //

Wildbow "I can't think of another option that doesn't put this organization at risk," he says. "There is word about the American teams getting involved. We'll be communicating with them in advance of any possible interaction with you, you have to understand, but they may be able or willing to help you in ways we can't."

Wildbow //

Windy I sigh. "OK. Well, if you want my number youo can contact me. Not sure how long I'll have service for." I show him the number. "Other than that, I'll... be around I guess. I have to find a place to stay tDevilght." I wait for them to show me out.

Windy //

Windy *you

Wildbow Matraque escorts you down to the ground floor ((anything you want to say before you part ways with her?))

Wildbow //

Windy "Sorry about this... I don't know what I'm supposed to do now."

Windy //

Wildbow "For now," she says, as she walks behind the front desk in the lobby, collecting one jacket from a box to one side of the desk, "Take this jacket. Keep a safe distance. If you bolt for the angel again, I'm going to have to hit you with something harder than sand."

Wildbow //

Windy "Do you know of any places a 16 year old girl can go without getting pimped out?"

Windy //

=-= soulpelt|nap is now known as soulpelt|

Wildbow She's silent as she marches you out, not even deigning to answer your question. You're fairly certain at this point that she doesn't believe you in the slightest. Your story was built around a central fact and identity, and that crumbled when your mother denied you as her child..

Wildbow As you pass through the doors, you can see the situation outside - and it's bad. The crowd before was riled, like people on a national holiday. Now, though, there seems to be an element of something else in the mix. Villains, pressing in, with the crowd so compacted that they can barely get out of the way.

Wildbow A man in armor, a younger girl in pink, and three women in

green and black.

Wildbow //

Windy ((Where am I in relation to them?))

Wildbow ((There's about 200' of distance, 75% of which is crowd, between you and them. They're spaced out in a rough line across the span of the street, equidistant from you. You stand at the top of the stairs leading into the tower's front door.))

Windy ((they're all together or apart from each other? relation to each other space wise?))

Wildbow ((In a rough line across the span of the street. 20' apart from whoever is to their left/right, all the same distance from you))

-->| **Stoic** (Stoic@net-n3k0uk.nj.comcast.net) has joined #WD_Lausanne

Windy I put on the jacket and walk a few feet away from Matraque. I rocket 20' pr so above the crowd, halfway between the girl in pink and the 3 in green, leaving a footprint behind, but not detonating it. I hover over the crowd and call out in the villains' direction. "My name is Windy! Anyone need a wind cape?!"

Windy //

Windy *or

Wildbow ((Wits roll))

Wildbow Something in their reaction seems off. A moment later, you realize why. The jacket you're wearing has the Suits' emblem on it.

Wildbow ((You're free to act/speak before they react))

Windy ((I look down and see the emblem. I quickly take it off, letting it drop to the crowd below and floating as proudly as I can.))

"Uhh, I'm not with the Suits! But I could use a new jacket!"

Windy //

Wildbow ((Social roll))

== Ridtom is now known as Rid|afk

**Wildbow The man in armor heaves a massive cannon, pointing it up
in your direction.**

**Wildbow The younger girl in pink, around your age, shouts out, "No!
Ironsides!"**

**Wildbow The cannon doesn't fire. People are still scrambling to get
away, while the villains seem unperturbed.**

**Wildbow "I'm Enfant Terrible," the one in pink calls out. "Can you
clear a path to the angel?"**

Wildbow //

**Windy I smile. "Now you're speaking my language!" I detonate the
wind mine**

Windy //

**-->| Dolyn (Dolyn@net-9pf5lr.mo.charter.com) has joined
#WD_Lausanne**

**Wildbow It crosses your mind that your reputation with the Suits is in
shambles and you likely just proved Nordmann right in their
eyes. They probably won't even look at the forged
paperwork, now. The explosion of wind topples and scatters
the perimeter of capes and police that are holding the crowd
back from the front door. In their effort to get away from the
villains and get to the angel, the...**

**Wildbow ...crowd between the villains and the door begins to make a
break for it, flowing in.**

== Rid|afk is now known as Ridtom

Wildbow Ironsides and the three women in green and black move with

the crowd, the women coordinating to throw people aside and out of the way, Ironside simply shoving them.

Wildbow There's more breathing room around **Enfant Terrible**, who walks, looking up at you, a grin on her face. She's filed all of her teeth down to points. "Have you seen the angel?"

Wildbow //

Windy "Not yet, sis!" I wink

Windy "What's tha plan?"

Windy //

Wildbow "Get inside. Most of the heroes are at the perimeter, right? We get inside, we make it hard to follow us, and go say hi to the angel! Can't be any major capes still inside, if they're stretched this thin outside!"

Wildbow //

Windy I briefly reflect on my life an hour ago. "Let's do it! got an weapons?" I lower myself to her

Windy //

Windy *any

Wildbow "I *am* a weapon, you goof!" she says. She starts running for a break in the line. It looks like the heroes are starting to rally, though they're hampered by the flow of the crowd. It may be why **Matraque** hasn't used her power yet.

Wildbow //

Windy "I mean for me!" If she doesn't have one I'll land and rocket through the crowd towards the tower, curling up in a ball and plowing people aside if possible. I'll leave a wind mine behind and when my new team is clear, I'll detonate it.

Windy //

Wildbow ((Ath roll x2))

Wildbow You unleash your power, barreling through people in the way, sending many toppling, at times face first toward the ground.

Wildbow You make it about halfway to the door before you've lost your momentum and find yourself floating above people's heads. People heard the noise and are clearing out of the way, which gives Matraque the freedom to act. The ground between you and her glows with a half-circle of glowing points of light. The light, you see, actually originates from deep beneath the ground, so bright it shines...

Wildbow ...through concrete.

Wildbow //

Windy I scream out. "Cover me enfant!" I try to maneuver away, looking back and detonating the mine if my allies are clear.

Windy //

Wildbow The mine you left near Enfant detonates behind her. She's not as fast as you are, and is only a third of the way to you from your starting point.

Wildbow Pillars of iron rise, close enough that a person couldn't pass between, forming a barricade around the front door, cutting off access. Ironside and the women are within.

Wildbow //

Windy ((what shape is the barricade?))

Wildbow ((Semicircle, around the stairs leading up to the door, 50' high))

Windy ((and the 4 villains are inside the building?))

Wildbow ((Ironside and the women are within the building, yes))

Windy I yell out. "Enfant, to me! Our buddies are inside. Let's go join em!" I try to fall to the ground as fast as possible, catching myself before hitting the ground.

Windy avoinding the light if I can

Windy //

Windy *avoiding

Wildbow ((roll Athletics, no skill applies. You can set the target number yourself - between 2 and 6, higher it is, the higher up a distance you're dropping from))

Windy ((how high am I now?))

Wildbow ((~12 feet up))

Windy ((I mean in terms of 1-6))

Wildbow ((Nevermind. Just roll 1d6))

|<-- Olivebirdy has left irc.parahumans.net (Quit: <http://www.kiwiirc.com/> - A hand crafted IRC client)

Wildbow You cancel out your floating to drop faster, touch ground and stumble. It costs you time. Ahead of you, another pillar rises, higher than the ones that formed the semicircle. Matraque actually rides this pillar, standing at the top of it, now able to look over the wall.

Wildbow Enfant is 2/3rds of the distance to you, now.

Wildbow //

Windy I leave behind a print if possible and make my way to Enfant

Windy //

Wildbow ((retreating back away from Matraque?))

Wildbow ((On foot or otherwise?))

Windy ((Can I make a short leap?))

Wildbow ((yep))

Windy Get as close to Enfant as possible

Windy //

Wildbow ((Ath roll))

Wildbow You come to a stop just ahead of Enfant.

Wildbow Around you, in every space where the crowd isn't, you can see more points of light appearing. Matraque appears to be going all-out, this time. You count no less than twelve points of light, glowing.

Wildbow //

-->| Devilman (Devilman@net-bnq.g99.254.155.IP) has joined #WD_Lausanne

Devilman I detonate the mine. "Hop on. We're going see the angel. Cover us!" I wait for her to mount then leap towards the tower in a direction Matraque hasn't covered, leaving behind another mine

Devilman //
n

Wildbow ((Wits check x3))

-->| Baker (Baker@net-5qs7qu.as13285.net) has joined #WD_Lausanne

|<-- Stoic has left irc.parahumans.net (Quit: <http://www.kiwiirc.com/> - A hand crafted IRC client)

Wildbow The shifting mass of the remaining members of the crowd mask the view of the mines. No sooner do you launch than you find yourself directly above a point of light. The beam appears, and then translates from light to water, enveloping you. Half of your momentum is lost-

Wildbow ((Roll Brawn))

|<-- Windy has left irc.parahumans.net (Ping timeout: 181 seconds)

Devilma ((is enfant on my back?))
n

Wildbow ((That's what we're rolling to see))

Wildbow and you very nearly lose your passenger, but you manage to hold on to her. You approach the semicircle of pillars that block approach to the entrance. Capes appear to either side of you, one conjuring two massive stone rings in the air above her. The other is a man, wearing a leering mask.

Wildbow //

-->| Cxaxakluth (uid126610@brockwell.irccloud.com) has joined #WD_Lausanne

Wildbow ((You're in the air, floating, and completely soaked in winter))

Wildbow ((The pillars are 10' in front of you. Matraque is 20' from you, and the door is nearer ground level.))

Devilma "Fire, Enfant!" I try to steer us towards the tower, landing
n then rocketing up towards the window again

Devilma *try
n

Devilma //
n

Devilma ((Oh, and I detonate the mine i left again))
n

|<-- ThalAI has left irc.parahumans.net (Quit:
<http://www.kiwiirc.com/> - A hand crafted IRC client)

|<-- Zeikos has left irc.parahumans.net (Quit:
<http://www.kiwiirc.com/> - A hand crafted IRC client)

Wildbow ((<http://i.imgur.com/f999tiX.png>)) ((Clarify your actions/direction?))

|<-- Words^3 has left irc.parahumans.net (Quit:

<http://www.kiwiirc.com/> - A hand crafted IRC client)

Wildbow "I'm a hand to hand fighter!" Enfant tells you, as you drift toward the ground. It looks as though more points of light are appearing around you. The stone rings conjured by the other cape veer in your direction.

Wildbow ((Roll ath, if you still want to rocket to the window))

Wildbow //

Devilman "Now you tell me! Get in my arms!" ((Can I grab her in a hug?))

Wildbow ((She's still piggybacking you, I thought. Also, tell me if you're going left, right, or trying to go over the wall with Matraque))

Devilman ((I'm still in the air? how high?))

Wildbow ((You're just landing now))

Devilman ((how high is the wall?))

Wildbow //

Wildbow ...

Wildbow The points of light around you detonate. ((Roll Brawn))

Devilman I leap over it if I can and deposit her

Wildbow Still my turn.

Wildbow You only barely manage to hold on to Enfant Terrible. Your hesitation as you gauged the walls and your trajectory cost you, and the torrent of water soaks you again. It's freezing, and seems to suck the strength right out of you. ((Ath & Guts rolls))

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seconds)

Wildbow ((Lesser wound, cold damage.)) - the slosh of cold water leaves you senseless and breathless, your extremities numbing.

Wildbow Matraque conjures another point of light directly beneath you, and you don't have the wherewithal to act or react. Enfant Terrible grabs you and throws you to the ground at the base of the wall, out of reach of the next jet of water.

Wildbow ((<http://i.imgur.com/9vFctnM.png>)) - you can act normally now that you've recovered))

Wildbow //

Devilman "Thanks, Enfant! Let's go up and over!" I grab her and try to leap over it again

=-= Thaliaway is now known as Thalia

Devilman //

Wildbow ((Ath roll))

Wildbow It's a high angle, to go over the wall and hit the other side. You end up clipping the wall on your way up and bouncing off. Enfant Terrible takes the opportunity to grab the edge, hauling herself over. She hurls herself the rest of the distance, and begins to climb the pillar that Matraque is standing on top of.

Wildbow You float in the air near the top of the leftmost pillars, stone rings now looming 15' away. ((They're going to reach you next turn if you stand still.))

Wildbow //

Devilman I maneuver out of the way as fast as I can, trying to follow Enfant if possible

Devilman .//

n

Wildbow You climb onto the top of the nearest pillar at the semicircle wall. Enfant Terrible hurls herself from Matraque's pillar to the nearest windowsill, grabbing it, and avoids an appearing pillar of sand in the process.

Wildbow You back away from the rings - they're cutting you off from Enfant. It's starting to dawn on you that in any situation where you're forced to rely on the flight, your movements are restricted - in another situation, you'd have been able to fling yourself toward your new ally and offer some help.

Wildbow //

Devilman mas as well. I try to short leap towards her if I can clear the rings. otherwise I'll drop down and assis the other inside

Devilman *may

Devilman //

Wildbow ((Dropping down will be slow. Unless you want to fall the full 50'))

Devilman I can try to fall then catch myself at 10'

Wildbow ((Ath roll if you do, last time you got a 1))

Wildbow You let yourself drop from the tower, and use your flight to slow your descent as you near the ground. You catch yourself at the foot of the stairs. Above you, Enfant Terrible has reached Matraque. You can't see the fight, but you see one half of Matraque's mangled staff drop to the ground near you.

Wildbow //

Devilman ((is the door clear?))
n

Wildbow ((Looks like - and it's ajar))

Devilman if it's clear I go in the door, following the armor guy and 3 women

Devilman //

Wildbow Striding into the ground floor lobby, you can see a gathered crowd, now huddling to either side of the room, leaving the middle clear. The front desk is in shambles, and the four capes who entered the room are now lying on the ground. Three women, and a struggling Ironside, who seems to be having trouble moving.

Wildbow A short distance from them is the man you talked to earlier. The King of Clubs.

Wildbow "Really?" he says, as he fixes his eyes on you.

Wildbow //

Devilman "Hey, they looked tougher before."

Devilman ((Is he near a wall?))

Wildbow ((He's in the middle of a larger room

Devilman hmm. I leap at each wall, planting a mine and detonating it then hovering in the middle away from him. using my wind direction power, I throw the crowd at him

Devilman //

Devilman *power

Lexicon Wildbow:

|<-- VernZzZ has left irc.parahumans.net (Connection closed)

Wildbow The explosion isn't sufficient to throw people quite far enough. You do succeed in scattering the people at the room's edge and putting them between you and the King of Clubs.

Wildbow ((<http://i.imgur.com/shx9QM1.png>))

Wildbow "The Patrol is on their way. If you did your research, you should know they specialize in fast response," the King of Clubs tells you. "There are twenty other capes on their way inside, through the side and back doors. Then... there is me. Take my word for it when I say that you would be better off fighting all of them than one of me."

Wildbow //

Devilman "Let me see the damn angel and I'll leave!" I look for the doorway up the stairs. I rocket off the wall, grabbing the nearest standing person (not Ironside) and hurl them at King, then ricochet into the door upstairs

Devilman //

Devilman ((oh, and I leave mines))

Wildbow ((Brawn check))

Wildbow ((And again, for the throw))

Devilman ((I use my wind redirect power if it applies))

Wildbow You grab someone and throw them as best as you're able, which isn't very able, with the strength of a not-fully-grown teenage girl. You use your wind power to push them a little further, but it's not far enough for them to collide with the King of Clubs.

Wildbow ((roll Dex & Wits))

Wildbow Your lunge for the stairs is sudden, and catches him off

guard. He raises a hand, conjuring a forcefield to bar your way, but you're just quick enough that it appears behind you, not in front.

Wildbow You're in the first floor stairwell, now.

Wildbow //

Devilman I leap my way up, ricocheting back and up the other stairs at the top. i'll continue this process to get to the top of the tower, stopping to open doors, etc.

Devilman and I leave mines, detonating them behind me

Devilman *leave

Devilman //

Wildbow ((6x ath roll))

Wildbow You can hear a dull thunder behind you, echoing your movements, coming not from the stairwell, but from the center of each floor. It's very possible that the King of Clubs is following you somehow.

Wildbow Still, you manage to keep ahead of him, and make your way up. You reach the point where you're far enough ahead that you can't even hear his pursuit anymore.

Wildbow Panting for breath, still cold and soaking wet, you make your way up toward the top floor.

Wildbow The door to the roof is locked.

Wildbow //

Devilman back down to the previous floor and launch out a window

Devilman //

n

Devilma ((unless this door is made of something I can launch
n through))

Wildbow ((Most such doors usually aren't. Doors inside, made of
hollow cardboard-ish material, mebbe.))

Devilma ((first option then))
n

Wildbow You have to go down a flight of stairs and exit the stairwell.
You find yourself in what seems to be a business office.

Wildbow You can hear the dull thunder approach as you look and
locate the nearest window. You still have some minor cuts
from when you last launched through a window.

Wildbow ((Launch?))

Wildbow //

Devilma (anything else in this room?)
n

Devilma I slam the door if there is one. i launch out, trying to plant a
n mine and launch a desk inti the door or something.

Devilma //
n

Wildbow ((Desks, computers, people.))

Devilma *into
n

Devilma ((ok, beeline for the window, launch, detonate mine and send
n stuff towards the door))

Wildbow You crash through the glass. This time you don't have the
benefit of Nordmann's body to help cushion the impact-

Wildbow The glass gashes you, slicing deep. You flip head over heels
as you recover, catching yourself, and blood pours out of

the slices, falling eighteen floors down to the ground.

Wildbow You float up to the roof, where you can see the silver woman, standing with her wings folded tightly around her, like a cocoon.

Wildbow She's taller than she looked to be on the television, her skin a burnished silver. Something about her makes you feel like she's even larger than she seems. It reminds you of the coiled spring of your power, tightly bound inside you, waiting to be released... except far, far greater in magnitude.

Wildbow //

Devilman I aim for her face and rocket towards her in a short leap. I stop myself short, floating over to hug her around the neck. I speak. "Help me angel! My name is Wendy Robins." ((I tell her my story as fast as I can))

Wildbow ...

Devilman "My mom and dad are Arcstar and Skybreak from Storm Patrol. Their boss is this guy Andre Nordmann. He treats them like crap. He hit my mom. He tried to pimp me out to guys from other teams. I triggered and ran away. I'm broke and homeless and I don't know what to do. Grant me a wish!"

Wildbow You rise, floating up, but the firm cocoon of her wings doesn't give you an avenue to see her face or head, let alone her neck. She's a turtle inside her shell, a bird inside an egg.

Wildbow ((You gotta stop & lemme interrupt if I need to, see the ... ?))

Devilman ((as above, but as close to where her head would be))

Devilman //

Wildbow The bleeding from your wounds continues, and drips down onto the outside of her wings, running between silver

feathers.

Wildbow There's no response, nothing evoked. Nothing to suggest she even hears you. The cold is getting to you, and what first felt like relief becomes dizziness and a profound exhaustion, too swift to be comfortable.

Wildbow You're passing out - within the next minute.

Wildbow //

Devilman I float down at her feet as fast as possible. "Please, free me and my parents from Nordmann..."

Devilman I lay down and curl up in a ball

Devilman //

Wildbow You hear a dull rumble of thunder behind you.

Wildbow "You bloody idiot," the King of Cups says. "You stupid, stupid girl."

Wildbow *Clubs

Wildbow Your vision blurs.

Wildbow "Let's get you some first aid," he says. "I wonder if there's a prison cell that can even hold you, slippery brat."

Wildbow He makes his approach. You can see his legs and feet, but even that scene steadily goes dark.

Wildbow Your view of the surroundings changes, and the shadows move, a pattern across the rooftop, almost criss-crossing. The wind stirs around you, kicking up snow.

Wildbow ~Feathers~, you think, as you recognize the shape of the shadows. You blink, watching the feet in front of you you step back a little.

Wildbow You blink again, and somehow you're standing. Seconds

have passed. Something invisible presses your wounds shut.

Wildbow Another blink, and you're staring down at the King of Clubs' body. Blood covers your arms from fingertip to elbow, and the glass you're holding like a knife is digging into your fingers, deep as the bone. The point, meanwhile, is buried in the middle of a ragged wound in the King of Clubs' throat. A crowd of people stand in a circle around you. Matraque, other suits, employees.

Wildbow //

Devilman ((The angel is still floating above?))

Wildbow ((Behind you))

Devilman I lick up the blood. "I'm Windy! This is the Simurgh!"

Devilman I float over to her

Devilman //

Devilman fine. I look down. "What happened?"

Wildbow "Step away from the body," Matraque calls out.

[ERROR] The command “/” is not known to the server.

Wildbow //

Devilman I drop the glass and back towards the angel

Devilman //

Wildbow You realize your wounds are open again. You're bleeding,

just barely on the bounds of consciousness. Backing toward the angel, you hit a slanted surface, and stumble away - a half-folded wing, deflecting you as the angel moves closer to the body.

Wildbow You're left to stumble away, rejected, ignored. The angel looks down, and the gravel on the rooftop begins to rattle.

Wildbow As you watch, an invisible force seems to push the man's wounds closed. Blood that pooled on the roof flows backward, leaving only traces of blood on skin as it moves back to the wound, back into his body.

Wildbow Factotum's chest compresses, pushed by an invisible force, once, twice, again.

Wildbow He gasps in, taking in a ragged breath. He touches his slashed throat, now intact.

Wildbow As all eyes are on him, you feel a pressure, ominous. The same force that was putting the blood back in the man is now pulling your blood out of you. As you involuntarily take a step back, steadying yourself, it gets less severe. As if to say, go, or this will continue.

Wildbow //

Devilman I leap off the building and fly away

Devilman //

Wildbow ////

-->| Devilman2 (Devilman@net-bnq.g99.254.155.IP) has joined #WD_Lausanne

-->| Devilman3 (Devilman@net-bnq.g99.254.155.IP) has joined #WD_Lausanne

|<-- Devilman has left irc.parahumans.net (Ping timeout: 181 seconds)

-->| Devilman (Devilman@net-bnq.g99.254.155.IP) has joined #WD_Lausanne

|<-- Devilman2 has left irc.parahumans.net (Ping timeout: 181 seconds)

|<-- Devilman3 has left irc.parahumans.net (Ping timeout: 181 seconds)

-->| Devilman2 (Devilman@net-bnq.g99.254.155.IP) has joined #WD_Lausanne

-->| Devilman3 (Devilman@net-bnq.g99.254.155.IP) has joined #WD_Lausanne

|<-- Devilman has left irc.parahumans.net (Ping timeout: 181 seconds)

|<-- JustLurking has left irc.parahumans.net (Quit: <http://www.kiwiirc.com/> - A hand crafted IRC client)

|<-- Devilman2 has left irc.parahumans.net (Ping timeout: 181 seconds)

|<-- Devilman3 has left irc.parahumans.net (Ping timeout: 181 seconds)

-->| Stoic (Stoic@net-n3k0uk.nj.comcast.net) has joined #WD_Lausanne

|<-- Stoic has left irc.parahumans.net (Quit: <http://www.kiwiirc.com/> - A hand crafted IRC client)

== Dolyn is now known as Dol|AFK

== souldpelt| is now known as souldpelt|sleep

== Emphy is now known as Emphgone

== Thalia is now known as Thalia|Katie

== Nonagon is now known as Nonagon|Sleep

|<-- Dol|AFK has left irc.parahumans.net (Quit: Leaving)

Lil' G-step & Lex

Lausanne 'Albatross' Arc - 2.4

This session proved to be a bit of a doozy. Two new players, Lightningsteps (abbreviated as Light'gstep so his name wouldn't warp a table, later shortened to Lil' G-step in chat as a joke, and is hereafter referred to as Gstep in this doc) and Lexicon.

The pair joined for the second arc via. blind draft. As explained before, each player could bid up to 1000 points on the options, deciding which trigger event they wanted. Lex bid 600 for Starry Eyes, and Gstep bid 502 for White Knight - putting both in the middle for determining perks and flaws: each got one perk and one flaw.

The short version of their triggers is that Gstep/White Knight was a guy who made a point of standing up for the weak, being a good guy in general, advocating for gays and minorities in his high school. Things came to a head when he turned up at a party, stood up for the host when the host's brother turned on him, and was subsequently confronted by the host he'd rescued, who called him annoying, arrogant, and said nobody liked him. White Knight triggers as the people he'd befriended and saved avert their eyes, tacitly agreeing with the host. Full trigger [here](#).

Lex/Starry Eyes was a friend of White Knight, suppressing romantic feelings after White Knight saved him from bullying. Mixed feelings and overwhelming guilt push Starry Eyes to stay quiet instead of standing up for White Knight. Save White Knight and someone's going to snatch him up. But if he lets this happen, then White Knight is alone, free for Starry Eyes to take. Moments later, however, he sees White Knight staring off into space, broken... he doesn't know that White Knight is triggering, and Starry Eyes triggers as well. Full trigger [here](#).

With Multi-triggers, the two get powers that mirror each other, a suite:

White Knight	Starry Eyes
Can create a giant knight minion	Can create an immobile archer minion
Touch inflicts frenzy/haste effect	Touch inflicts hesitation/slow effect
Can manifest marble-like plate armor	Manifests marble-like armor, hulk form
Emotional radar tracks nearby foes	Empathy scan, attention-awareness

White Knight's first and second power are arguably stronger. His minion is tough, with sword and shield, mobile, and dangerous, and his touch can buff it, granting added attacks and movement/turn, at cost of the armor (or anyone else touched) being unable to retreat or take actions other than attacking. He can grow his own costume and simple melee weapons, and can detect foes within a radius around him, knowing exactly where they are, provided that they have emotions. He rolled a perk and flaw, getting the power perk Alumnor, which lets him nurture powers around him, those who spend enough time around him get perks... and he can take those perks away/reverse the perk to cripple them. He also got Fight Prone, which discourages him from backing down from fights and makes him more aggressive in general.

Starry Eyes' third and fourth powers are the stronger ones for him. His emotion sense is deep, helping with face to face social interactions should he want it, and a fine-tuned part of it feeds into his combat ability - he can easily and readily sense when opponents are distracted or unaware and capitalize on it, gaining free attacks on foes who aren't in cover & who turn their focus to something other than him/his minion. He grants the same bonus to his minion (more on that in a second). His armor growth is better & more comprehensive, and allows the creation of finer implements and tools with the white marble. Should he wish, he can simply keep growing his armor to create a hulking armored form with increased reach, size, durability, and reduced mobility. The first and second powers are weaker - the archer manifests as a head, shoulders, and arms on a pedestal, with a longbow that fires skewers. It's more fragile, immobile, and it can fire once/turn, but penetrates armor and has the advantage of being ranged. The touch imbues lethargy and forces opponents to make Guts rolls if they want to move/attack. Starry rolled the power perk Magnetism (similar to what Jack has), granting a bonus to first impressions with anyone that has a shard, and parahumans in Starry's company have the negative effects of any flaws they have reduced. A neat mirror to White Knight's Alumnor! As flaws go, however, Starry gets Clunky Power. The power is harder to set up - armor is slower to grow, as is the archer minion, and Starry needs to grapple an unwilling target of the touch power before applying the effect.

Gstep/White Knight decides that his character lost their will to do good, and is angry, turning over to the dark side. He wants to be a villain, he wants power.

Lex/Starry, meanwhile, wants to be a hero, and is trying to turn White Knight back to the side of good.

The names do get confusing. We have Anthony, who goes by Citizen and pretends his created minion Medieval is the real cape (a la Siberian), from the White Knight trigger, played by Gstep. Then we have Lucas, who goes by Panoply, from the Starry Eyes trigger, played by Lex.

Things get more confusing halfway through when they split ways, but I think the session is worth the read!

I had no idea what to do with them, as their goals were so different, so I put them together and told them to figure it out...

The first half was a bit of a chore, really. I'd post something, wait a full 5-10 minutes for a reply from one player, wait another 5-10 minutes for the other... **tears hair out**

Session Start!

Wildbow The real estate market in Lausanne seems to be a fast moving one. Too many people making their exit from the chaos, and quite a number that are coming for the 'angel'. You fall in the latter camp, in a way. It's late in the day, you've eaten, and you've done your research. Problems are already arising, however, and it's not an unfamiliar fight. Anthony has done the research and has an idea of where some of the seedier areas of town are, even if the nature of the internet and the chaotic situation in the city makes it hard to find out particulars.

Lucas, however, was able to find a long string of reports on recent deaths, murders, and the extent of the chaos. Things seem to be heating up, and it looks ugly. It's daunting and concerning.

The process for renting the apartment didn't even involve an intermediary- to the point that you wondered if it was a scam. A key in the mail, paperwork to sign and mail back, and then you were here. Now you stand in the shared apartment, trying to decide where to go from here, despite your rather different perspectives.

Lexicon "Anthony, people are getting hurt here, we have to help them. Something is going on, and the entire city is suffering for it."

If we're moving to Lausanne, we should at least try ensuring the city doesn't get worse. But that's not how Anthony seems to see it.

Gstep Looking around the apartment the first thing I notice aren't the walls, the furniture or the view. It's Lucas doing the same thing again, trying to save people and shit...

"Look. It's a shitty world and this city is a bad place. To change the situation we have to get stronger. Better. More equipped to deal with all those who would stop us. How do you propose we do that? Join a hero team? What are they doing right now? Absolutely nothing. We can change things only if we're strong enough to change them ourselves and the power to

be able to do that doesn't come from wearing a white cape."

Thal|Venganza (secret@net-ehma5b.or.comcast.net) has joined #WD_Lausanne

I look into his eyes and place my hand on his shoulder. "Trust me on this. Things will have to get much worse to get better, but we'll get there."

Lexicon This feels right. Anthony right here, and for that brief moment, looking into his eyes, he sound just like his old self. Maybe... maybe he's right?

"O-ok. We'll try it your way first. But we have to try soon, ok? I just... I need to do it."

He'll understand. I know he will. That's a part of why I love him.

Gstep I nod and remove my hand from his shoulder. "Soon?" I say as I move towards a window. "We'll start immediately, my friend. Our rise shall be monumental - both inspiring and terrifying at the same time. It's either that or death. No middle ground." I turn to face him. "But I need to know you're 100% with me. That you won't flinch, won't hesitate. There will

be no half-measures."

Lexicon I let myself smile a little. Dramatic as ever. I'll bet he's quoting some corny cartoon I've never heard of. I take a step towards him.

"Yes, Anthony. I'm with you." Another step closer. "Always."

Something from his little speech hits me, and my smile drops to a fraction of what it was.

"But we don't kill, not unless there is no other choice. We don't become the people we fight. We can't."

Wildbow **As Anthony returns to his open laptop, he finds some notes on the areas with higher crime and the shadier areas of Lausanne. He know some of the things to look for, the language, the trends, and where things are sold. Options include downtown, which is hectic, crowded with people and rife with opportunity, as well as some of the areas along the side - the artist's quarter, a touristy area...**

...with a lot of con artists and shady dealers, if not a lot of muscle, and the harbor, where a lot of the black market trade happens.

Gstep Looking through the data I motion Lucas over. "These here? These here are opportunities. Springboards, if you would. We need to get some muscle and ideally, some sort of income - the bigger the better. Our powers will allow us to get both. Honestly, the harbor is calling to me. Black market, a bit removed - sounds perfect. What do you say we perform a hostile takeover there?"

Lexicon It doesn't sound particularly heroic, but I guess, if Anthony thinks it'll work...

"Right. The less the criminals are able to get a hold of illegal stuff, the better off everyone is."

I nod, more to myself than Anthony. "Let's do it."

Wildbow The destination isn't far - it's a long walk, but public transportation and Lucas' motorcycle are both options, though it's winter and a motorcycle makes for dangerous riding. It's a question of how early you want to put your costumes on, or if you want to find a place once you reach the harbor.

Gstep I smile at Lucas' naivety. "Good man! We'll be catching a bus though, it's far too cold to ride a bike this time of year"

Lexicon "Agreed. Let's go."

I fetch my bodysuit, and stuff it into a backpack, along with the rest of my cape gear, and a few empty garbage bags.

Wildbow The bus is prompt, and you start your ride from the east end outskirts of Lausanne to the harbor to the south. It's your first time in the city, and you're treated to a view of the scenery, rolling hills, snow-dusted houses in the old fashioned styles, and a view of the more distant downtown area. You're too far away to see the angel.

The bus reaches the harbor, and you can see the water, unfrozen, lapping against the shores. Your individual powers to sense emotions take their general forms, with Anthony's being precise enough to highlight the groups of people indoors, and the approach and passing of bystanders on the street. For such a big city and an area where you can see down the length of the road and the coast,...

...it's remarkably devoid of people.

You can see some people gathered in parking lots outside of a large building, warehouses, and paths leading into thickets of trees. Past the parking lots and trees there are docks, but as with the streets, the docks are fairly barren, without many boats.

Gstep Well... This doesn't seem like a lucrative business. Might just be the cold and all. I look around for an alley. "Let's change into our bussines suits, shall we?", I say with a smile.

Lexicon Hmm, suspiciously few people. I try to think if I heard anything about this area. Maybe something scared everyone off? In any case, it would be smart to use my thinker power to sense if anyone is focused on me before I revealed my costume.

Wildbow **Between your two powers, you're aware of where people are and whether they're focused on you. Clear of both, you're able to change costumes without much concern. Your powers, mirroring one another, create material with the durability of stone, though much lighter, textured like white and black marble. The armor crawls over you, expanding and extending, and forms crude joints and connections, leaving you freedom of movement. For Anthony, the material is akin to proper armor. For Lucas, the material forms a simple bodysuit for now, with armor panels.**

((Street smarts checks))

A quick survey of the area suggests a few possibilities. Down by the water isn't as good - it's too cold, the wind makes it worse, and people aren't liable to gather there. The thicker collection of warehouses is liable to be better.

((In your actions, let me know how covert/open you want to be, what your plan is, etc.))

The armor panels of Lucas' suit continue to expand, growing into a sleeker mirror to Anthony's own suit.

Gstep I start creating the statue, Medieval. "I'm going to need a couple of minutes. It'd be ideal if you could find some higher ground from which you could support me while I'm on my way to that warehouse." I point to one where I've felt a number of people gathered. "Sound good?"

Lexicon "I'll go set it up, take care." I turn away and move to the entrance of the alley, and look for the best place to set up with my archer.

Wildbow ((Wits checks, both of you))

Lexicon ((tactics apply?))

Wildbow ((Yeah))

Lucas, now Panoply, surveys the battlefield and finds a fire escape, leading up to a perch on one of the taller buildings in the area. His power informs him that nobody has seen him. The creation starts to manifest, stone growing into the form of a pedestal, which unfolds and opens to grow the torso, arms, and head of his minion creation, twelve feet tall from top to bottom, holding a bow longer than Lucas is tall.

In the meantime, Anthony waits, letting his creation form. A knight of the same material the archer is made of, white and black ivory, with a shield and sword. While just as tall as the archer, the armor isn't fixed to any pedestal.

He decided to go by Citizen, while the armor is the 'true' cape, known as Medieval. He makes the approach to a building with a high concentration of people within, on the far end of the street.

((Wits check))

Circling the front of the building, he checks the windows, but frost and moisture on the windows has obscured the view inside. There are people there, but his vague awareness of collections of emotion and emotional intensity are more accurate than the blurry smears on the other side of the glass.

I'm winging it, so I roll to decide what kind of encounter is within. Good-aligned civilian, neutral civilian, villainous civilian, empty, hero, villain. I get the first. I

roll for what kind of good-aligned civilian. Pillar of the community x Muscle? Sure. Let's figure out what that looks like...

Gstep Can't see anything... Well, the polite thing to do is knock. First things first, though. I spend a bit of time creating a sword on my back. Then I proceed to pound the door 3 time, with Medieval looming behind me.

Lexicon I focus on Citizen and the statue, creating a spear, and readying my archer if this turns ugly. Hopefully, Anth-no, Citizen, won't help it escalate to a fight.

Wildbow **The door swings open. A man stands on the other side, muscular, tattooed and stern looking, wearing far too little in the way of clothing for the climate - a tank top and shorts. His eyebrows go up as he takes in Medieval and Citizen.**

"Problem?" he asks in gruff German.

Gstep The guy says something in German and the only thing I can make out is "problem". It might well be that. I hope that someone in there speaks something other than German. "Sprechen sie Englisch?", I ask with a rather bad German accent.

Wildbow **The awkward question seems to affect his take on you. He folds his arms. His English is somewhat stilted, "Is there a problem?"**

In the background, more people emerge and approach, a group of them, similarly dressed in tank tops and t-shirts.

Gstep I look at the people and smile behind the mask. "No problems, friend. Only business." I point to Medieval. "My boss here is new to town. He's looking to make friends, help the businesses grow... Together we could achieve quite a bit." I look towards the mostly empty docks. "And it seems like you are in need of some help."

Wildbow **The muscled man looks up at Medieval, then back to you, "Can your boss speak for himself?"**

Lexicon ((can I see the scantily clad people?))

Wildbow **((Yes))**

Lexicon Interesting. That is definitely not suitable clothing for this weather, so either their space heaters are absurdly powerful, or something weird is going on in there. Drug production maybe? Or a cape? I look at the rest of the building to see if I can get any clues.

Wildbow **((Wits check))**

The building is brick, squat, and sturdily built. You can make out some of the contents, looking down through the higher windows - metal rigging and ropes.

Gstep "Speak? Unfortunately not. His power made him unable to use his vocal cords. He can talk just fine though." Medieval taps me on the shoulder. "And hear, as well." I turn towards him and watch as he rattles off a couple of hand signs which include him pointing at the man and making a gesture that seems rather obscene."

I turn back towards the man. "My boss is asking you to talk to him directly, if possible." At my last words, Medieval backhands me quite strongly. In fact, just strongly enough to slightly crack the right side of my helmet. "Apologies. My boss is telling you to 'talk to him directly, you fuck.'" Medieval nods in the background.

Wildbow **((Go ahead, Lex))**

Lexicon I pull out my burner phone and dial Citizen. He hated anything tarnishing his reputation, and this probably wouldn't help. I talk as soon as he picks up. "Ask them about why the area is so empty, tell them to report anything strange in the area, and give them the number for the public burner mobile. Then leave. That's a gym, not a black market warehouse."

Wildbow ((Roll social, Gstep))

"Your boss should treat you with more respect," the man at the door says. Still, he takes your advice and looks up at Medieval. "Heroes aren't usually interested in doing business. I take it you're not a hero."

The phone rings, and you hold up a finger while raising it to your ear. You get Panoply's message.

Gstep

I turn sideways in order to be able to follow the conversation. Medieval makes signing motions again. First he gestures to himself and, after making a weird-ish shape shakes the hand in a negative motion. Then he points upwards, gestures back to himself and then to me and makes a wide sweeping motion to include all the other people in front of him. I'm of

course, making sure he makes similar motions for similar ideas in order to portray the usage of a language. "'I'm no hero, you're right. I plan to rise high and all those who are with me will rise along.'" Medieval makes a couple of questioning gestures for the end, a couple of them looking like hiding something in the pockets and one pointing to his wrist.

"Do you do black market trade then or do you not? Am I wasting my time?"

Lexicon

Well, he got the message. I guess he's seen something I didn't. Hopefully I didn't make matters any worse.

I still don't like this. It's just weird, surely everyone couldn't have just left to see the angel or something. I take a look at the other buildings we noted as uninhabited, there's something here I'm missing.

Wildbow

"You're doing worse than wasting your time," the man at the door says. "This is a gathering place. One for upstanding members of the community. My friend over there, he works in construction. Building, not tearing things down. The man standing next to him is a police officer."

Gstep Again, Medieval signs a couple of words. "I don't suppose you could point me towards black market trade gathering place?" Even though no sound escapes from Medieval his whole body shudders in what could conceivably be a chuckle. I add to the notion by chuckling myself. Medieval starts signing again. "Nice going you have here in your 'community'. You sit

around doing nothing while the city falls apart. Sometimes you have to burn the weeds for fruits to grow. I suppose your police officer friend isn't going to do anything about me right now?"

Wildbow **"I was considering calling friends," the police officer speaks from the background. "A group of people more on your level, as a matter of fact."**

His voice is hard. The group seems collectively unimpressed.

Lexicon Shit, looks like the conversation is getting heated.

If it gets to a fight, I'll put an arrow in front of the doorway, scare them off.

But right now, there's not much I can do even if I did leave the archer unattended.

Gstep Medieval signs again. This time his motions seem almost mocking. "You were considering?" Next he signs a couple to me, with a walking motion on the end. I chuckle again. I pat Medieval on the side casually while also imbuing him with my striker power. Medieval proceeds to quickly reach out and grab the man in front of us with his right hand. Then he signs.

"Make a move and he dies. Simple." As I finish translating I nod to Medieval and turn and walk away towards the alley we came from.

((grabs him by the throat))

Lexicon Shit.

God fucking damn it Anthony, what are you doing?

I keep the archer trained on the gym, and call Citizen.

Gstep I pick up the phone. "Don't worry, all's good. No black market trading though. I'll let Medieval dissipate once we're far away enough."

Lexicon "They're not black market, so you take one of them hostage!? That never works, Citizen!"

This is nothing like what a hero would do. I... can't keep doing this.

"I'll meet you at the alley, but let the guy go quickly."

No time for this now. I'll deal with it once Anthony is out of danger.

I get to the ground, trying for a compromise of stealth and speed. The archer is still there, waiting.

Gstep "That's not how the conversation went. Not exactly. Can't exactly let them call the police, now can I? See you there." I hang up the phone.

Wildbow **The two of you make your way to the alley. The trip is somewhat uneventful. In the distance, your creations, unable to act without your input, remain stationary. Given time, or a fresh summoning, they'll crumble.**

Lexicon I dismiss the archer, and my armor, once back at the alley. I change back to civvies in a bit of a panic.

Gstep As I walk into the alley I let my armor crumble to dust around me. With a thought I cause Medieval's right hand to close up a bit. Not enough to break the neck, but enough to cause strangulation. After 5 seconds of that I let Medieval crumble away as well. Let them think on that. "Oy, Lucas. Not quite according to plan, eh?"

Lexicon "What are you thinking? The police?" I can't focus, there's just too much. I thought maybe Anthony would calm down, stop picking fights. But there he is, acting like he doesn't even care about what he just did.

Gstep I laugh out loud. "Well what did you think we were getting into with black market and all that?" I clap him on the shoulder. "Come on, man, lighten up, these are baby steps here we're taking. Let's get out of here, shall we?"

Lexicon "I... You go. I need a walk to clear my head. I'll meet you at the apartment later." I edge past Anthony as I leave the alley, quickly peeking out to check for anyone looking.

Wildbow ((Lex, you can head on over to #WD_Lausanne2))

Lex departs the room - to explain, this was preceded by a bit of a private convo between Lex and I, where Lex echoed my initial instincts about how their styles and goals really didn't mesh at all. I then had Gstep in WD_Lausanne and Lex in WD_Lausanne2, running both sessions concurrently.

Was actually quite nice; things moved faster, with none of the 10 minute waits for them to declare their actions that happened above... While both sessions ran concurrently, I'll just go back and forth here, starting with Gstep in WD_Lausanne.

Gstep "Thought I could count on you." I shake my head in disappointment. "See you later then. Take care."

Wildbow You watch as Lucas departs, walking off into the maze of streets of the harbor, snow falling around him.

Gstep Time to get out of here. I start walking towards the closest bus stop with a crisp pace.

Wildbow The crowd that was in the parking lot earlier is now

gathered around the bus stop. Others have gotten into cars and pulled away. Many are smoking, others are talking, excited about something they call 'Capelight'. A glance at the bus schedule suggests the bus might be a short while.

Gstep Capelight? I approach one of the smoking groups. "Could I borrow a cigarette?", I ask in French.

Wildbow ((Social roll))

Gstep ((is presentation a thing again?))

Wildbow ((No))

The woman you ask nods, and taps the pack, before extending it your way, one cigarette sticking out of the hole in the corner. She stands ready with a lighter.

Gstep I take the cigarette with a smile and let her light it. "You are a lifesaver.", I say between first few drags. "Quite a crowd here. An excited one as well. I'm new to town, any idea what the 'Capelight' might be?" I take another drag.

Wildbow "A play. The theater, it's over there, see? We just finished attending the evening show," she says. "What were you doing here?"

Gstep I stop a bit as if I'm weighing something on my mind. "Well, I thought about telling you how I went looking for a job or how I caught the wrong bus. Honestly? I just needed a really long walk with as little people as possible in sight. Being new in town is more stressful than I thought, needed to clear my head. " I smile at her. "The day is getting better already. I'm Anthony." I extend my hand towards her.

Wildbow "Mari," she says, taking your hand. "And attached,"

She touches the arm of a man standing a short distance away. She's attractive, but very much done up, with crimson lipstick and carefully managed hair. Dressed up

for the show.

An ambulance passes down the street, siren going, heading in the general direction of the gym where Medieval strangled the man.

Gstep "Ah. Unfortunate for me. Still, pleasure to meet you both." I nod towards the man. "Do you have any interesting places in mind for newcomers?"

Wildbow She touches your shoulder, offering to lead you a short distance from the bus stop.

Gstep I make a confused face. Where is she leading me? "That interesting, that close? And mysterious to boot? Color me interested."

Wildbow She stops when you're out of earshot of the others at the bus stop. "You're new to town, you're curious about vague, 'interesting' places, and you're wandering around alone in a place like this. Am I wrong in assuming you're, ah, needing something that isn't available over the counter?"

Concurrently, in the other chatroom with Lex...

Wildbow You walk away, taking your own route through the harbor area, filled with frustration and mixed emotions.

Lexicon I just wanted to be a hero. To help everyone, like Anthony helped me.

Like he used to help me.

But since he got his powers, since I betrayed him, he's changed so much. He picks fights, hurts people like it's nothing. It was especially bad at the start, before I knew he was a parahuman too. He'd be the one starting brawls at parties, not finishing them. And that's just in his civilian identity.

News about the new capes in town was spotty at best, but the general consensus was that they were brutal. Once I figured it out, and started working with him to oust villains, he seemed to settle a fraction. But news of the powersuits and opportunity in Lausanne brought it all to the fore.

I don't know what to do, so I keep walking.

Wildbow **A couple of minutes pass. You hear sirens. The vehicle passes a few streets down, going the opposite direction you are.**

((Wits check))

Your power picks up a flicker, before the people in the ambulance are out of your range again. Their attention, like a compass needle, points in the general direction of the confrontation you had with the gym bros.

Lexicon Oh god. Anthony must have really hurt that guy.

I need to make up for this. I can't help directly, but I can help others. I'm going to be a hero.

Preferably in another section of the city. Time to find a bus.

Wildbow **You choose a path that keeps you from going to the same bus stop Anthony might be at, assuming he's leaving and not hanging around the area. In the course of taking this route, you spot a trio of capes, moving in a triangle formation, one in the lead, two on the sides. They're headed in your general direction.**

Lexicon Not good, not good.

Ok, I can act casual, at least until I'm sure they're after me. I use my thinker power, I've got to know if they're after me.

Wildbow **You're aware as they turn their attention toward you. One of them has a very peculiar means of turning their attention your way. It's not with sight or hearing.**

((Social roll))

Lexicon ((fails))

Ok, they're looking at me.

Maybe this isn't all bad. I didn't hurt anyone, after all.

But it doesn't hurt to be prepared. I look for a good place to fight, as covertly as I can, just in case. How much time do I have before they get to me?

Wildbow The act of looking for a place to fight seems to sharpen the focus on you. They're only a short distance away, now. If you were going to bolt for cover or a staging ground, it would have been better to do it earlier.

The man in the lead is wearing a robe, sporting a goatee and a hood with a mask built into it, while the one beside him is dressed in black, a quiver of javelins at his back. The third is the one who is paying peculiar attention to you. She's pale enough you can see the blue of her veins, wears a white mask, and a pale blue cloak with fur trim. She narrows her eyes as she looks at you, then says, "There's no reason to be afraid."

Lexicon "Are you sure? Usually being surrounded by parahumans is a cause for alarm."

Well, they didn't attack on sight, so maybe I have a chance with this. It's probably too late to summon my armor anyway.

Wildbow "Perhaps you're afraid because you've seen something? We got word that two figures in white and black armor just hurt some people."

Lexicon "The statue guy by the harbor? I saw him, but I didn't see him actually attack anyone." There, it's technically true. "I left quickly, you know how it's been recently."

Wildbow "You don't need to lie," the woman says, without missing a beat.

Lexicon Clearly half truths won't cut it here. Maybe it would be better to find out who they are first. "Who are you?"

Wildbow **The man with the quiver of javelins speaks, "Help. I train at the gym, I have friends there. If you know anything, please. The man who died was a paramedic."**

Lexicon "S-someone died?"

Anthony. He'd... killed someone.

And then he'd laughed about it, to my face.

Oh god, he wasn't joking about that little speech.

He's changed. He's not my Anthony anymore. I don't know what he is, but I know it's my fault.

And he's my responsibility.

"What do you need to know?"

Two betrayals. The first time, it was because I couldn't speak up. Now I can't stay silent.

Wildbow **"Anything you can tell us, the direction he was moving, what he was doing," the quiver-man says, again.**

The woman with the mask cuts in, "I know you feel guilty, horrified, just tell us anything, and we'll be grateful."

Lexicon What should I tell them? This is so hard.

"I saw him heading ((direction)). The big statue thing dissolved though."

Wildbow **"Albescent," the man with the quiver says, starting in that direction, "You can help me find him. I need your eyes."**

She glances at you, pausing, waiting for one last moment.

Lexicon "Wait."

Lexicon "I can help you. Just, please, try not to hurt him too badly."

Wildbow **The one with the javelins starts off in the direction, leading the way. The woman touches your shoulder, urging you forward.**

"Help how?" the man in the robe asks you. "Do you know more?"

Lexicon "Yes. But that's not it."

I let my changer armor flow over my hands, pushing for it to be as white and gentle looking as it can. I don't want them attacking me right away.

"I can help you catch him."

I'm sorry Anthony.

Back to WD_Lausanne1 with Gstep...

Wildbow **...Am I wrong in assuming you're, ah, needing something that isn't available over the counter?"**

Gstep Now that is interesting. This might not be a waste of a day after all. "Well, yes, actually. I might be looking for something along those lines." I wait for her to take the lead.

Wildbow **"I'm not a dealer," she says. "But I know one. I could arrange a meet, if you make it worth my while."**

Gstep "That sounds rather lovely. How 'big' is that dealer though? I don't want to buy stuff from some small fry that cuts his stuff with god knows what. I can smell that from a mile away. And what's the price? For arranging the meet, I mean?" Now this sounds like a business opportunity to me.

Wildbow **"Big? Not big, not small. But I've been buying from him for a while. It's good. If you want to make this worth my while, here, well, I don't know, twenty? More if you want me to put in a good word?"**

Gstep "Tell you what. The better guy you manage to get me, the bigger cut you'll get. That 'medium' guy of yours has to know a bigger guy, right? If he does, and you can get him to get me the bigger guy, I'll make sure you're both more than happy. As you probably realized already, money isn't the problem for me. It's the absolute lack of any connections. If we decide to go through with this, I'll be putting all my trust in you. Can I do that?"

Wildbow **"Ah, you're not a hobbyist looking for a fix," she says. "That gets a little more complicated."**

((Roll social))

((Fails))

She shakes her head, "I'm not sure I'm comfortable with that. But I can connect you to my dealer, and you can decide what you want to do from there."

Gstep I smile apologetically. "Ah, understandable. I'll be buying one 'medium' dealer and 'the best word' then." I chuckle lightly.

Wildbow **She takes out a scrap of paper from her pocket, and she jots down a number. "From pay phones only. The fourth number on a pay phone is always a seven, he has caller ID, and he will know. He's particular about that."**

Gstep I take the scrap and after brief examination place it in my pocket. "And how do I get you your share?"

Wildbow **"Take out your wallet, and hand me the appropriate amount of money," she says, rolling her eyes.**

Gstep "Ahhh, I assumed you were getting a cut of the actual product." I take out my wallet and rifle through the notes. "And what is the appropriate amount? It does depend on how much your guy can get me, after all." I hand her the wallet. "How about you take as much as you think is necessary? I have a feeling you'll stay honest." I wink jokingly.

Wildbow **"I'll rephrase," she says, very patiently, "I handed you the**

phone number. You give me twenty. Or more if you feel like it. Then we part ways, and I don't worry about what you're getting up to. I don't want to be involved any deeper than this. Understand?"

Gstep "Ah, misunderstood. Apologies." I take out 50 francs and hand them to her. "This should do then."

Wildbow She accepts it, pocketing it. She gives you a funny look as she retreats back to her boyfriend's side, leaving you standing a short distance from the bus stop.

Gstep That girl... Who asks for a cut when dealing with drugs and then actually asks for 20 francs? Weird city. I go back to the bus stop, a couple of feet away from Mari, and look around to see if there are any payphones around. No need to waste the time.

Wildbow ((Wits check))

((fails))

You circle the block, looking, not wanting to be too far away in case the bus arrives early. You take a moment to cross the street, peering past trees and leaves, trying to see if there's one closer to the water, which might be a picnic area in the warmer months, but it proves fruitless. You have the option of taking another look, or you would, but you can sense people moving in your direction. Balls of emotion ranging from anger to outright rage to guilt and shame.

WD_Lausanne2 with Lex...

Lexicon I'm sorry Anthony...

Wildbow The man in the robe reacts, and as he does, the one with the javelins turns, sees, and reaches for one of the skewers at his back. Where you were running a second

ago, the group halts, turning on you-

The woman in white grabs your arm and pulls you back, partially shielding you from the others.

"You gave them the armor!?" the one with the javelins raises his voice.

Lexicon "No! That's not it. He... our powers, they're similar. Identical, nearly. But I wouldn't help him kill someone!"

I dismiss the stone gloves as quickly as I can. "I'm a hero, I swear."

Wildbow "If he's lying, he's got a power helping him," the woman, Albescent, says.

Her word seems to be enough. The one with the quarrels wheels around, clearly angry now, his emotions heated. The rest of you hurry to keep up, the group of you now running in Anthony's direction.

"Who's the other one?"

Lexicon "The other one?"

Wildbow "The big one, or the regular-sized one. You said there was one with powers similar to yours."

Lexicon "There's only the one. The big guy, the statue? He's a minion, called Medieval. The guy controlling him, the regular sized one, goes by Citizen. He's the one like me."

Wildbow Drawing closer to the area where you first arrived, you sense a connection, a turn of focus and attention toward you, from quite a distance. You know the particular flavor of attention that is, and the person who would know. He's sensed you on his 'radar'.

Lexicon I slow, feeling like an idiot. Of course he'd know. "He's knows I'm here."

He'll know what I'm doing, he'll get away!

No, I can't let that happen.

I get an idea. A terrible, terrible idea.

I speed up to run through the middle of the capes, and dive to the side, forming armor as I go.

"Fight me, it'll bring him to us", I loudly whisper as I go past.

Wildbow "Fight you?" the one in the robe asks. "How violently?"

Without waiting for an answer, the one with the quiver grabs you, swings you by the arm, and lets you hit the wall of the nearest building, shoulders and head cracking against brick ((Roll Guts)).

WD_Lausanne1...

Wildbow ...you can sense people moving in your direction. Balls of emotion ranging from anger to outright rage to guilt and shame.

Gstep Those emotions sound... interesting. Maybe they can tell me where the payphone is? I laugh inwardly.

Wildbow The individuals draw closer. They're only a block away, needing to round two corners to come into view

Three of the figures, still brimming with emotion, turn on the fourth.

((roll wits))

((fails))

((Go ahead))

Gstep ((Is there an alley in the vicinity where I could create and stash Medieval))

Wildbow ((No. You could head in the direction of the theater, or head toward the water, where there are trees, map inc))

Gstep I create small armor plates beneath my clothes as I start moving towards the group. Not big or thick enough to be seen, but they should help in case of an altercation. I also create two small knives which I then slip behind my back under the belt.

Wildbow **((Wits check))**

Back to WD_Lausanne2 with Lex...

Wildbow ...Without waiting for an answer, the one with the quiver grabs you, swings you by the arm, and lets you hit the wall of the nearest building, shoulders and head cracking against brick **((Roll Guts))**.

((Fails))

((I roll to wound him, get the least bad possible result))

You bounce off of the wall, sprawling on the ground. It's bullshit, but while your armor is technically better once fully grown, it's slower to create, as is your minion. It hasn't grown enough to shield you from the hit.

Thankfully, the hit is minor - it takes the wind out of you, but you won't even feel it in a moment

((Lesser wound, disappears after a round)).

Lexicon I roll to my feet, and let my armor continue growing, getting into a ready stance. Anthony can sense emotional strength, but not so much the emotions themselves. This could work in my advantage. I focus on the blue veined woman, Albescent, and try to let a sense of gratitude well up in me. Hopefully she'll understand.

Immediately after, I shout "Medieval! Help!". Oh god I hope this works.

WD_Lausanne1 with Gstep... Almost done with the back and forth!

Wildbow ((Wits check))

((pass))

You can hear a distant shout, coinciding with a flare in the intensity of one dot. It's Lucas.

Try as you might, you're not the adroit armorsmith that Lucas is. The initially uneven growth of armor beneath your clothes is hard to conceal. If you're going to continue, you'll have to either give up the private aspect, or you'll have to stop growing it.

Gstep How did he manage to get in trouble so fast?! And these plates aren't going to work... This day just keeps getting better. I let the plates crumble. Can't exactly go save Lucas in his civilian identity while armored up. Not without killing the attackers. Then again, I might not be able to save him unless I get armored up. Ah, fuck it. I spare a quick glance

to check if there are any civilians nearby and start building up my armor and spiked mace. Should be up before I round the corner. On second thought, no spikes. Lucas wouldn't like the spikes.

Wildbow **You have to slow down to make the time for your armor to manifest, collecting it around the areas that conceal your identity first. You round the corner, and see the individuals in question - three capes who've surrounded Lucas, who, like you, has only partial armor.**

Gstep Just another 20 seconds or so... What to do until then? Better question, who are they? Asking seems like an option. Definitely the option. "Hey! What's going on here?"

Wildbow The three capes include a man with a quiver of what appear to be javelins, a woman in a white mask with a blue cloak, and a man in a robe.

The one with the quiver speaks, wheeling on you. "You. Are you the one?"

WD_Lausanne 2...

Lexicon Immediately after, I shout "Medieval! Help!". Oh god I hope this works.

Wildbow Your power tells you he recognizes you.

Anthony pauses for a moment, waiting, then picks up speed as he rounds the corner. He's manifesting a melee weapon and basic armor, his identity concealed, even if the armor isn't quite complete.

"Again?" the one with the quiver asks, voice low.

Lexicon Quietly, I reply "Let mine form."

I wave one hand behind me, though it isn't necessary, and summon my archer ten or so feet in that direction.

Wildbow The one with the quiver turns toward Anthony, "You. Are you the one?"

And the two are reunited. Lex remains in Lausanne2, any stuff in the box is stuff he says there, private to me.

Gstep The one who what? Threatened the 'upstanding members'? This seems way more serious than that... I stop in my tracks and let my mace waver in my hand. "It wasn't me, it was my boss! He has my family hostage!" I lace my voice with desperation and panic. "If you capture me he'll come for me, you don't understand - he'll kill you all." I point to Lucas. "He is in the same boat as I am, please, for your own sakes, listen to me."

Wildbow The man who spoke glances at the woman in the mask, who looks to Panoply.

Lexicon "It's true, he has my sister. There's nothing we can do against him, he's unstoppable!"

Wildbow ((<http://i.imgur.com/PzXfkpF.png>))

((Oh, roll social for lies))

((Both of you))

Almost fucked up here, meant it for Lex in Lausanne2. 'Both of you' follows fuckup. Was wanting to see if Gstep clues into what Lex is doing.

((Rolls))

((Rolls Wits for Gstep, who fails, not surprising given his low base Wits score - this is going to hurt him))

The one with the quiver of javelins lowers his voice, just barely restraining himself from attacking. "Who?"

Gstep "He calls himself Medieval. He can't speak and as I was among his first victims he taught me some bastardized version of sign language. That's why I was there in the first place. But he cares nothing for us. If you've asked those people you know he almost ripped my head off for mistranslating a single word." I let a note of resignation slip into my voice as

I drop my mace. "Kill us or let us go. Anything else will end with your deaths as well."

Lexicon "Citizen, wait! They could help us, save us, even."

I turn to the capes.

"Please, just let us tell you how strong Medieval is." And let the archer finish growing, I don't say.

((Roll social for lies))

((Rolls))

((Rolls for Gstep, who ties the roll))

Wildbow Citizen can sense the guilt welling from Panoply, coloring the radar dot that is his friend.

"Who or what is he? He's the one who killed my friend?" the one with the quiver asks.

Gstep I start creating Medieval around the corner. "My best guess? Some combination of brute and breaker. From what I've gathered he doesn't eat or sleep or does so little of those that it doesn't matter. He doesn't get tired and what's worst - he doesn't die. I've seen him blasted to pieces numerous times. He never gets back up right away." I shudder. "You always think it's the final time. Sometimes he's gone for days, even weeks. But he always comes back..." I let my voice trail off.

Wildbow ((Social roll for lies))

((@ Gstep))

((Rolls - abject failure))

"I believe you," the one with the quiver says, glancing at the woman in the mask. He starts to speak, then stops.

Lexicon I turn facing the center of the cape group, but leave my head looking straight at the quiver cape.

Lexicon "If anyone would kill someone, it would be him."

Lausanne2/private:

I concentrate, forming an impression of an arrow on my chest plate. Pointing straight at Anthony. "If anyone would kill someone, it would be him."

Wildbow The woman with the mask speaks up, "If this is true, then that monster has hurt all of us. Will you come with us?"

Lexicon I turn to Citizen, looking to him for a response.

Wildbow ((At this stage, the archer is 99% complete. Medieval is 66% complete))

Gstep ((Done after this round, righto?))

Wildbow (('round', sure))

Gstep I wait for a couple of seconds in silence, turning my head to the woman with the mask and back to Panoply. Lots of shit to weigh. "What of our families then? Can you guarantee their safety? Can anyone?" I shake my head as if to dispell the horror of my situation. "I really want to come with you, I really do. But I need some assurances."

Lexicon "Can we meet again? We're not meant to be gone so long, and I can give you a number. If we can go our way", I gesture towards the end of the alley with the archer, "and you go yours, we can maybe work together to stop the killer. Will you please let my friend come over to me?"

I keep my archer on high alert. If Anthony brings out Medieval, I'll put it down with an arrow.

Note: Lex is using his tactics skill. He can delay an action, waiting, guess enemy action, and interrupt their turn/actions if the guess is right.

Wildbow They tense as they see the archer.

"What's that supposed to be?" the one in the robe asks, raising his voice.

Gstep

I check the progress on Medieval - all done. Excellent. He starts moving toward the street we're all at. I make him stomp a couple of times in order to draw the attention away from the archer. Lucas, I'm counting on you... "He's here!" I scream in panic as I pick up my mace and stand in a defensive position. "Help me! Please! He knows!" Medieval doesn't seem

surprised by seeing me there. Instead he signs a couple of words. The last few seem particularly ominous what with him crushing a balled fist in the open palm and all that. "I can't let you do this anymore!" He signs a couple more and they seem to grow more and more violent. "Noooooooooooo!" I charge the guy and he tosses me behind him as if I was a toy.

Wildbow

Virtually none of that happens - the moment Medieval rounds the corner, the archer shoots-

((Lex rolls a 1, adding +1 for archer minion's stats for a miserable attack roll of 2))

((Roll dodge for Medieval))

((Gstep rolls a 1, -1 from knight minion's stats for a 0))

Things are starting to get bogged down - the two are fast enough at posting when in individual/one-on-one chat, but it's approaching midnight, there's somehow a ten minute wait for either one to say something/roll die, so I do the wound roll.

The way damage works in Weaver Dice is that each character has X number of wounds. When you take a hit, you get wounded, which takes away one of your wounds, and applies side effects, based on damage type - bleeding, injury, getting knocked down...

Piercing attacks can graze and do negligible damage, they

can hit and do nothing special, they can potentially hit something vital for more damage, or, given a lucky enough roll, they can score a headshot. The highs and lows are very pronounced.

The archer rolls a 4 on the wound table and scores a headshot. 50% chance it's a serious wound, 50% chance it's instant death. I roll a 100 sided die...

The arrow pierces Medieval's armor and plunges through, skewering him through the head. The head obliterated, the body shatters, and the entire construct crumbles.

((Lex's go))

Lexicon "ARCHER'S MINE, WARRIOR WAS HIS!" I yell at the capes.
"HE WAS LYING!" I scream, torn by having to stay still so long, lying to Anthony's face, drawing out the betrayal."

Tears burning the corners of my eyes, I charge at Anth...
Citizen.

Wildbow The one with the quiver seems to take the statement as fact. He draws a javelin, and flings it-

((Roll defense, Gstep))

((rolls - passes))

The shot misses.

The woman with the mask glances to one side, then disappears, a violent, flickering disappearance that makes your head hurt and your ears ring, even though there's no visual or auditory stimuli.

((Gstep's go))

((Map inc))

<http://i.imgur.com/qz1J2q6.png>

Gstep ((how far is the bus stop? or the closest aggregation of 10+ people I've encountered?))

Wildbow ((Just past the bottom right corner of the map - ~3 turns to get that far.))

Gstep I decide to let Lucas charge at me. My armor is far heavier. While he's charging I grow stone spikes on my helmet. Once he tackles me, I use my striker power to imbue the guy with frenzy. Not ideal, true, but he won't think much - won't defend much. I then proceed to pound his head with my spiked helmet.

Wildbow ((Both of you roll Brawn))

((rolls 2))

((rolls 5))

Lucas/panoply hits Citizen with surprising strength, knocking him to the ground, taking the advantageous position. Lying flat on his back with Panoply straddling his waist, Citizen can't headbutt Panoply or retaliate.

Anthony's power flows through Panoply, stirring up already complex emotions and pointing them in one direction - rage.

((Lex's go, then mine))

((Btw, imbued with his power, you're limited to attack options))

Lexicon ((Oh that went through? I'm guessing striker doesn't count as an attack?))

Wildbow ((Nope, too passive, requires too much focus))

Lexicon ((and cementing him too the ground by armoring up is also out?

Wildbow ((List of grapple options on the table below, here: https://docs.google.com/document/d/1_glfQsPjDklbeZatO1Gsr5l3VNnGmESNUU2P28jL1x4/edit#heading=h.103dk3asx1ib))

((Yes, also out))

Lexicon ((struggle helps me hold him tighter, right))

Wildbow ((Yes))

((You can take two actions, as you're frenzied))

Lexicon I struggle, trying to pin Citizen down further.

Wildbow ((Both of you roll Brawn, x2 if you're double-struggling))

((Rolls 4))

((Rolls 3))

Lexicon ((I was))

Wildbow ((Then again))

((Rolls 2))

((Rolls 3))

((aaand attack roll))

Finding a good position, Panoply raises up Citizen's head, then punches it into the ground, gauntlet smashing through the face-pane of the helmet, armor at Citizen's neck and shoulder breaks as well. (-1 armor)

The one with the javelins approaches at a light jog, drawing another javelin. With Citizen unable to get away, he's able to lower the point of the weapon to Citizen's throat, holding it there.

"Surrender."

Gstep "Sure thing, but get this guy off of me, he's feral! Not getting out of my armor until you get him off!" I slowly let the lower back of my armor to dissipate, while keeping the rest of it there.

Wildbow ((Taking any action?))

Gstep ((Nope))

Wildbow The man with the javelins doesn't say or do anything as the 'feral' Panoply lashes out.

It seems he can't bring himself to spare you.

((Two attack options, Pan))

Lexicon ((Can I force out words? Also, does pinning him further mean hitting him again))

Wildbow ((You can roar/growl, and yes. You're frenzied))

Lexicon I growl, deep and angry, as I struggle, and then strangle him. Teach that fucker to dare use his powers on me! He'd better get the fucking hint soon.

Wildbow ((Roll Brawn, Gstep roll Guts))

Fingers reaching past the damaged armor, gripping Citizen's throat, Panoply strangles the breath from his former friend. ((-1 Ath))

The man with the Javelin moves the weapon's point, stepping on Citizen's wrist to limit his movements and speed things along ((Roll Brawn, Citizen))

One arm pinned against the ground, Citizen's struggles are limited ((-2 penalty to rolls from here on out - Gstep's turn))

Gstep As the Javelin guy steps on my wrist I use my striker power on him as well. There's really no way to tell who'll be his target now. The moment Javelin guy goes for Panoply I go for one of the knives I've stashed behind my back and stab Panoply wherever I can.

((If the Javelin guy goes for me I'm dead so here's to hoping :P))

Wildbow He doesn't go for Panoply. You're in no position to defend yourself as he brings an iron toed boot down on your head, again, and again.

The one with the robe catches up, hurrying to pull the javelin wielder away, but that does nothing to stop

Panoply, who attacks further, while citizen is unable to recover. The woman in the mask approaches at a run from the direction of the bus stop - she'd moved to cut off the retreat, and was ill-positioned to stop a bad situation from being turned into a mauling. She does what she can...

...to pull Panoply away, but the frenzy effect is slowly fading.

Pulling panoply away, as it happens, is one of the worst things she could do. With latent traces of aggression still informing his actions, Panoply gives an order to the archer statue.

The skewer makes a wet sound as it passes through vital flesh and punctures the roadtop on the other side. The frenzy wears off of Javelin and Panoply, leaving them stunned at what just transpired. The woman in the mask, an empath, winces, as she feels the keen emotion.

Lexicon

I stare down at the body on the road in front of me.

"no."

"Anthony, no."

I stumble over to his side, hands at the wound, willing the strange stone-like substance to cover the site, maybe that will help! The, the ambulance will be able to get to him, and I've stopped the bleeding, that's good right, I can save him I can save Anthony!

I can do it

I...

I

"No, no don't leave me. Please Anthony, you saved me that day, don't leave me alone!"

"I... I loved you".

Wildbow The woman puts a hand on your shoulder, and pulls you away before you and your power make too much of a mess of things. "The anger inside of him was frightening. I don't think he was the person you knew. And when this happened, the violence... that wasn't you either. Okay? I want you to tell me you recognize that."

Lexicon I can't even look at her. I stare instead at Anthony, his face cut and bloodied by the javelin user's boot. "It was my fault. It was my fault he even triggered. If I had just spoken up... It was my fault he changed."

Wildbow ((Any last actions, before session end?))

Lexicon I lean down over Anthony's body, and whisper "Goodbye. I'm so sorry."

I kiss his forehead. I leave.

Non/Lumen & Meg/Epiderm

Lausanne 'Albatross' Arc - 2.5

[Part I](#) - [Part II](#) - [Part III](#)

The last of the new members who joined Lausanne in the second draft, Nonagon (Non from here on out) and Megafire (Meg) are both experienced Weaverdice players, though I've only ever played with Meg in the past.

As mentioned in prior installments, the players bid blindly for their choices in the draft, opting for a given trigger event or character background. Points weren't spent from a pool, but spending more points meant a higher chance of getting a given option and also a higher chance of getting character flaws instead of perks.

In this case, Meg and Non had very different approaches: Meg's bids included 650 for 'Graft Man' trigger, 600 for 'Traitorous Troll', 550 for Starry Eyes, 400 for Little Boy Peep, and 350 for 'No Powers', all the way down to the entries where he had the lowest interest, 150 points on 'Gambling Man'. Megafire got his highest pick, Graft Man, and while he tied Dolyn in bidding 650 points for something, Graft Man was less popular overall and was thus deemed the second most expensive bid to Dolyn's most expensive.

Non, conversely, bid 9 points for his highest pick, 8 points for his lowest pick, all the way down to 1 point for his absolute lowest pick. He didn't get his highest pick, or his second highest, or his third highest. His #4 pick was 'Cauldron' (which surprisingly didn't get much attention at all).

Meg's Graft Man trigger, to summarize, was a young politician in Lausanne's leading political party. Brought on board by way of nepotism, he was quickly introduced to a variety of forms of institutionalized corruption. Playing ball up to a certain point, he was left as one of the targets when a group of vigilantes began retaliating against perceived corruption, with the vigilantes invading his home, cornering him in his bed, and starting to literally flay him alive.

Meg's trigger made him a kind of Brute-Breaker hybrid. In his breaker form, thick ribbons of skin become satellite to a body of energy. He's utterly invulnerable and strong in his breaker state, capable of using the orbiting ribbon of flesh for added reach,

but the longer he maintains his form, the greater the cost, a gruesome sort of scarring that lingers as his skin knits back together, penalizing stats and taking hours or days to return to normal. While in his invulnerable state, he has to get stuff done fast.

Non declined (why!?) to roleplay the buy/consumption of the Cauldron vial as Anti/Reimann did in session 0.0, and instead got a list of options. He was interested in stranger and thinker options, and I gave a list of about four vials that worked for what he was asking for. After some hemming and hawing, he decided on Optic:

Grants thinker power suite oriented around the eyes. Involves 3-5 vision modes, with ability to switch between them at will, and a lesser secondary power of ambiguous and offensive nature, frequently requiring some study or figuring out to master.

75% chance of very minor mutation to eyes, 50% chance this mutation is only visible while powers are active. 5% chance of mutation, with more severe mutation to eyes always occurring in such cases. Ambiguous secondary power is of the 'you need to figure out the particulars in the field' sort.

He didn't get any mutation at all, despite the very high chance of getting glowing eyes, purple eyes, or something in that vein. His vision modes include motion detection with some minor combat/tracking bonuses, binocular 'zoom' vision with a magnifying-glass-esque analysis of small objects, ability to 'see' mood and disposition, and a kind of x-ray vision specializing on seeing living things. There's more to the vision modes that he wasn't able to figure out in Cauldron's labs. Finally, there's a secondary power, a 'taser' style, short-range blast (5' out from fingertips) that carries a charge and shoves things away.

As for perks and flaws, Megafire's Graft Man cost him 650 points, the second most expensive pick, which meant he had to roll three flaws and pick two. He ended up taking Power Incontinence and Emotional Shift. The former is the same thing Dolyn/Rainbow got, but given his power, his is Guts focused. Guts is the stat that determines toughness and willpower, and he gets a penalty to Guts. In addition, even mundane things that others wouldn't have to roll for have to be rolled for (being bumped too hard, bright sunlight after being indoors too long, getting hurt, getting sick), and a failure on the Guts roll mean his power kicks into effect, shunting him into a partial or full-on Breaker state, with all the consequences that follow (including the temporary scarring as he pulls himself back together). Emotional Shift is the same flaw Burnscar has... using his power puts him in a different frame of mind, with effects accumulating. In his case it's a colder sort of aggression and arrogance.

Spending the least points of anyone in the draft, Nonagon's Cauldron trigger got to roll three perks and decide which two to keep. Nonagon opted for Empathetic (+3 points to the Empathy skill, reading and detecting emotion, and can do quick reads on people's emotional or mental state) and 'Wing', a power buff that gives the power a use in boosting mobility. The character can add to their movement with a short range (10 foot) teleport (tied to the same blast that she generates from her fingertips) in the direction that she's already moving.

The pair decided that Non's character is Meg's wife. After the home invasion, they pulled some strings, and the wife (a detective with an artificial leg who left Japan after Kyushu) acquired a vial. They're very interested in finding the vigilantes who attacked them.

Their session starts half a day after the Simurgh lands. The first session was cut short, as I noticed definite delays in responses, and correctly surmised that Meg (who lives in a different time zone) was drifting asleep on us. The second short, in a very similar way, was cut short; this wound up being long-ish, as the other multi-player sessions did.

#WD_Lausanne

Wildbow

You've been to events like this before. It's the evening, and the lights around the theater are tinted a soft orange, and sleek black cars are stopping on both sides of the street, people in form-fitting dresses and black suits climbing out before a valet or their personal driver takes the car away.

Everyone wears coats, but they're often just enough to get you from the street to the front door. The sidewalks have been meticulously cleared of snow. All of this is normal.

Less normal is the guard. Armed guards at the entrance and the corners, police officers off duty and in nice clothes standing with their hands folded in front of them, their breath fogging up. Private guards and, perhaps, less legitimate sorts of enforcers stand just inside the door, waiting to greet you.

Before you're inside, you can hear the music playing, piano and violin. The violinist is an up-and-comer, a recent winner of an international talent show.

Meg

Walter had been to parties like these before. Quite a lot of them, even. This one was a little different, though, and despite the easy smile that appeared on his face entirely out of habit by now, he was a little nervous.

He stepped out of the car and waited for his wife, his eyes on her.

Non

Mariko steps out of the vehicle, balancing on her good leg awkwardly, not fully trusting or used to her prosthetic. She offers her husband a smile, hooking one arm around his, to take his lead, and for the slight aid to her own poise.

Meg

Walter smiled back at her, steadying her a little before walking inside, a little slower than he would on his own. "Well, at least the music's top notch," I whisper to her, smiling still. "Let's see if everything else is, too."

Non

"Mhm," Mariko replies shortly, half-distracted, some ambient paranoia making her look around a bit more than she otherwise might, looking for anyone or anything out of place.

Wildbow

There are members of the three major political parties here, with your party, the True Progressives, PTP for short, outnumbering the rest two to one. There is also the environment-and-agriculture focused PAR, Partie Agro-Rural, and the Partie Liberal (PL). You can see the older police chief, looking his best, and a handful of the local business owners who have ties to the criminal element....

... None of the local leaders of organized crime have shown up, but now that you're closer, you can verify that some of the men who are standing guard are theirs. They might be planning to make a later entrance.

The local leader of your party is here, Alexander Raichel,

and he is busy talking to a good looking man with blond hair and a man in a suit who also happens to be wearing a mask. To one side, you can see Albert, Eugen and Wilhelm, the former two of which have their attractive wives in tow. They're the closest thing Walter has to peers, and they're also the closest thing he has to rivals.

Wilhelm in particular seems to be besotted with the attractive violinist on the stage at the far end of the expansive room. There's space to dance and there's space to sit, with tables scattered seemingly at random, some more private and some more communal.

Meg

A bunch of people he did want to see, a bunch of people he did not want to see, a bunch of people he wanted to see, but not in polite company. Pretty much exactly what Walter had expected.

"Anyone in particular you'd like to see, dear?" he asked Mariko, his own eyes drifting towards Alexander Raichel and his two new associates.

Non

"The police chief," Mariko answers, instantly. "I'm interested to hear how the investigation is going."

Wildbow

((Wits check))

((investigation applies))

The police chief is talking to several of the business owners.. He's an old man who has just enough grit to project confidence, and enough infirmity that, perhaps, he's not too great a threat to the people in attendance at the party.

But that infirmity may be an act. The man wears a gun beneath his suit jacket, and his eyes are alert. He knows full well what's going on, and who the business owners he's talking to are - what they're involved in.

He recognizes Mariko as the two of you make your

approach, smiling and leaning in close to give Mariko a kiss on each cheek, before offering Walter a handshake. "How are you two doing this evening?"

Meg Walter shook his hand, a little less firmly than he would before the attack. "Better, thank you," I answer him, smiling. "Yourself?"

Wildbow "Working very hard to avoid thinking about work this evening," the man says. "It's too much. Too much, all put together."

Non "I'm sure that's not easy, given everything," Mariko comments. She activates her power, turning it to the mode that detects mood and disposition.

Wildbow ((Roll Empathy, +2 for power))

The man is more tense than he's letting on. As far as your power can grant you an understanding of the latticework of light that surrounds him, he's worried about the future, primarily his prospects in that future. His career is in jeopardy.

This isn't a place where he can relax - he's likely only here because he's trying to salvage his job or his retirement.

((Since nobody's chiming in/adding anything...)) ...

"It's not easy, no," he responds. He gives you a light smile. "I don't think it's easy for anyone here. Except, perhaps, the heroes."

His hand gestures in the direction of Raichel, the blond man and the man with the helmet.

Meg "Oh? You imagine they have an easier time of it?" Walter asked.

Wildbow "Their responsibilities are clearer cut. The complexities simply aren't there."

Non "I hate to bother you when you're trying to relax, but I am still anxious regarding..." Mariko makes a vague hand motion.
"You know. The investigation into that incident. Is there anything you **can** say that would put my mind at ease?"

Wildbow **((Social roll))**

"If I was willing to discuss work tonight, then I would have to be more concerned about those men I was just talking to, and about that group across the room, or the fact that I know one of the men standing by the door has a history of- ah. Can't let myself fall into this trap, no. I'm sorry, dear."

Meg Walter managed to resist raising an eyebrow at that. "That's a shame," he said. "Still, we're sure your department is doing all they can to get to the bottom of this and, well, everything else."

Non "Well, I hope you have a nice evening, at least." She gingerly tugs Walter away. No point wasting time talking to the police chief if he won't help her.

Wildbow **"Everything else, yes," the old man says. "So many things. A good evening to you as well, Mariko. I hope your face heals well, Walter."**

The old man indicates the bandages you still wear.

Meg "Thank you, sir," Walter answered, nodding to him, before allowing Mariko to tug him along.

They approached Raichel, and Walter didn't hesitate to insert himself into the conversation. "Good evening, gentlemen," he greeted the leader of his party and the two heroes.

Non Mariko offers a polite smile and a nod, letting her husband take the lead for the moment.

Wildbow **"Good evening, Walter, Mariko," Raichel says. He's a man that's built like the school bullies of the children's movies, broad in the shoulder and belly, deep voiced,**

dark hair immaculately styled, his eyes a bit too small, his smile a bit too fake. Still, he gets the job done, and thus runs the city council and, by extension, the city.

"Gentlemen," he turns to the other two, "This is Walter Berset and Mariko Berset. Walter is an up and coming councilman we have high hopes for. Walter, these two gentlemen go by Andrew Nordmann and Factotum. Leaders of the Patrol and the Suits, respectively."

((Know rolls to determine how much of a sense you have of the teams))

((You're aware of both teams and what they represent - both are major up-and-comers aiming to get a foothold in Europe. The Patrol is smaller right now but perhaps more promising in the long run))

Meg Walter reached out to shake their hands. "A pleasure to meet you both," he greeted them. "I must confess, I've been a little out of it lately, but I imagine you're both rather busy men, these days."

Wildbow "The angel arrived six hours ago," Nordmann says. "In a way, it's simplified things. She's settled in, there's now one thing everyone is focusing on, at least for now, where the 'capes' are concerned."

Non "Oh?" Mariko frowns slightly. "I would have thought that, well, people would still be concerned with whatever they were concerned with before. What's so interesting about her that everyone's focusing in?"

Wildbow "Hope," Factotum says. His voice is remarkably clear despite the helmet. "The idea we might have a chance in the long run."

Meg "That is a nice thought," Walter agreed. "But we don't know what, exactly, she's doing, do we?"

Wildbow "We're getting hints," Factotum says. "Since her arrival,

we've traced a signal. It interferes with internet, with phones, producing a consistent tone. She's, we think, trying to work out a way to communicate with us. A lot of people are reporting that listening to her is soothing and pleasant. Their stresses and issues wash away. Alcoholics suddenly don't want a drink nearly as badly....

... A villain in custody, a lunatic, was weeping with joy, because he could think clearly for the first time since he got his powers."

Meg **Walter couldn't help but show his amazement at that. "And is there a way to spread this signal, or whatever it is? If it's that benign, it would be worth letting everybody hear it, no?"**

Wildbow **"For now we're content to leave it be. There are radio stations people can tune to that approximate the signal, and word is spreading, but we're not encouraging it. The concern is that if she's trying to fine tune how she can express herself, she may overstep one way or the other, before she finds her footing."**

Meg **"Right, right," Walter said, his brow furrowed in thought. "Perhaps I am thinking a little too small scale, still." After all, there was a rather personal problem he wanted dealt with.**

Wildbow **"A dangerous thing for a politician," Nordmann says, smiling. "This may be as big as things get. The world stage."**

He looks at Mariko, aiming to bring her into the conversation, "Don't you think? One more major player in the game, to fight off Endbringers and get us some breathing room? And this one seems more... focused, if the communication attempts bear fruit."

Non **"That would certainly be nice," Mariko says, offering a polite smile. "But I don't think it's wise to get one's hopes too high, as a general rule. Scion didn't stop Leviathan from destroying Kyushu."**

Meg "On the other hand," Walter chimed in. "I can think of a few issues I would not mind the Angel's help with, if she's offering. It might help me, hmm, adjust my view to a larger scale."

Wildbow Nordmann nods. "If we had a -second- Scion, they might have been able to step in, no? I think we would all appreciate her help... ah, and speaking of."

He's looking to the door, and it seems the party has new guests. Men and women, aged sixteen to thirty five, are making their way into the theater. Each is immaculately dressed, beautifully made up, in the best clothing, and they seem to have timed their entrance with the beginning of a new piece by the violinist on the stage. With their entrance, the tone of ongoing discussion seems to...

...shift, growing quieter.

A dark haired woman walks in, elbows linked with a thin blonde woman's. There's a very short man with a large nose and thick eyebrows in a fancy suit, a pixie of a girl with her short hair in curls, a model you dimly recognize on her arm. A man that stands inches above even you, Walter, with muscles clear despite his nice suit.

And there are others, in their company. Different, without the same presence. The men and women who don't wear masks in their off-time.

Non Mariko's eyes run over the new arrivals. The way everyone's reacting has her on edge, and she turns back on her mood-reading vision mode, trying to determine their threat. ((Can I use the perk-bonus empathy scan here?))

Wildbow ((Sure))

The atmosphere is one of resentment mingled with fear. These eight or nine individuals are the local supervillains in power, or they were before the city became inundated with

capas. The people with them are the local crime families and established gang leaders. The ones who play by and enforce the rules.

Meg

Oh, that was just wonderful. There were probably people there he wanted to talk to, but he'd hardly be able to in this atmosphere.

"So," he said to his companions, making sure only they could hear him, "who invited them? Or is this a classic case of them simply inviting themselves?"

Wildbow

"They're regulars at the high-profile events, but they usually turn up one at a time, a trio at most, so it's no surprise you don't recognize them," Raichel says. "They're showing their strength. I'm worried, though. Too many are angry that they didn't help when we were asking for it."

Non

"I can't say I'm unaware of the feeling," Mariko says. "Though it would be very foolish to start a fight with so many of them."

Meg

Yes, Mariko, thank you. He'd figured that out on his own. He made sure not to shoot her a look, though, instead keeping an eye on the group of villains.

"Cowering away from them would send a bad message, though. We ought to at least show we have control of the situation."

That said, he took a couple of steps towards the group, very obviously looking them over with curiosity and just a hint of distaste. "Good evening, ladies and gentlemen," he greeted them. "How nice of you to join us."

Non

"Walter," Mariko says, gently tugging at his arm. "Please, calm down."

Wildbow

((Roll Social for subtlety, Lumen))

Non

((Does the Empathy skill apply?))

Wildbow ((Nope))

The woman seems to take note of Mariko's tug on Walter's sleeve, and smiles in a sly way. "Of course. It's our pleasure to be here."

She extends a hand for you to shake.

Meg Walter nodded to her, shaking her hand with a smile. "And you've made so many new friends since we last saw you, as well." Making a clown car joke would probably be pushing it.

Non Mariko decides that saying anything would just make it worse at this point, and remains quiet.

Wildbow "This is my American friend, Elizabeth, hm, Heron? You might already know Morton Black and the others. I go by Marie Roux, tonight, I think. You might say we're so numerous, but we're very few in number, compared to the number of visitors to our beautiful city."

Meg Walter smiled. "And how does the old guard feel about that?" he asked her.

Wildbow "We'll manage, I think. For tonight, we're simply reassuring our friends that we're here and we're available. This only works if we're all in it together."

Meg "I'm not sure how much value people would give to your promise of availability, all things considered," Walter said, before taking a step back, moving his arm to direct them to the rest of the party. "But, by all means, enjoy yourselves."

Non "Walter, perhaps we should go back to speaking with Raichel. We weren't quite finished."

Wildbow "Oh, that sounds nice," Marie says. "I'll join you."

Meg Walter grit his teeth for just a moment, but was all smiles the next. "Suit yourself," he told Marie, before taking Mariko's arm and walking back to Raichel.

Wildbow You return to Raichel and introductions are exchanged.

It's fairly clear the villains aren't going to great lengths to pretend they aren't villains. Even the names they chose for themselves seem to be aliases that mirror their cape names.

"Walter here was suggesting people wouldn't value our promise of availability," Marie says. The statement earns you a dark look from your party leader and superior. She continues, pretending not to notice, "What would you like to see happen, to turn things around and re-establish a positive relationship?"

Meg Well, that was awkward. Still, this was no time to freeze up. He raised an eyebrow. "Re-establish?" he said, emphasising the 're'. "That's quite the implication. I don't recall we've ever so much as exchanged phone numbers, Marie."

Wildbow "Whatever our councilman may think," Nordmann says, "I'd be interested in exchanging phone numbers, Marie. With the current state of things being what it is, it would be -invaluable- to have a resource who knows how things work in this city."

Non "I would appreciate a phone number as well, actually," Mariko says politely. "It might be useful to have."

Meg It would be useful to have, and he was very glad his wife had asked for it. Still, it wouldn't do to show that, so, instead, he made it look like he was trying to hide a look of betrayal, instead.

Wildbow Marie provides very nondescript business cards - they're eggshell white, with what looks to be an inked outline of a fox with gray watercolor painting inside those lines. No name, no business, only a phone number. "I'm more focused on information gathering and, hm, shall we say problem solving in terms of people problems? In a very 'not likely to be a problem again' sort of way. If you...

...need other sorts of help, either call me and I can put you through to the others, or approach them."

Non "Mhm," Mariko says, noncommittally, as she pockets the business card.

Wildbow The conversation continues, but Raichel approaches you, putting a hand on your shoulder, leading you away from the ongoing discussion between the hero leaders and 'Marie'.

"You have to let your feelings go," he says, once you're out of earshot of everyone critical.

Non Mariko gives Walter a look, showing she more-or-less agrees with Raichel. "Acting like a belligerent drunk won't solve anything, Walter."

Meg "What does?" Walter whispered back. "Are we just going to pretend this-" he indicated his bandages, mostly for show, but still "-didn't happen? And I don't mean to me personally, I mean to us. Do we have a plan to deal with that, or are we just going to try jumping into the ship that left us to rot again?"

He took a deep breath. "I'm upset, is what I'm saying."

Non "Walter," Mariko says. "I understand how you feel, but this is not a useful way of dealing with the problem."

Meg He nodded, trying to calm himself down. "I am in dire need of one."

Wildbow "I agree with your wife," Raichel says. "If you stay here and cooperate, you can build something. How we act today can mean great things for your future tomorrow. People are dropping away, leaving the city out of fear of the vigilantes. If you stay, if you're brave and if you work with the locals, you could ascend faster than anyone. There are so many resources here, all you have to do...

...is use them."

He pauses. "If you can't, then take a breather. Go... let out your aggression, if you must. I'd be disappointed, but

not participating is better than sabotaging yourself."

Meg "I," he took another deep breath, "I think I can manage, sir, thank you."

Wildbow He raises a hand- ((Wits check))

-intending to give you one of his characteristic too-heavy pats on the shoulder ((roll defense))

Mariko puts herself in the way, a hand going to Walter's shoulder before Raichel can clap it.

Meg Walter cleared his throat in the hopes of breaking through the awkwardness. "Sir, if you'll excuse us, we'd like to go socialise."

He pulled her away from his boss, and quickly whispered a most sincere "Thank you," to her.

Non ((Marie's still speaking to Factotum/Nordmann, yes?))

Wildbow ((Yes))

Non Mariko gives Walter's shoulder a brief squeeze. "Look. Let's focus on the person responsible. Marie's speaking with Nordmann and Factotum. It might be a tad suspicious for us to ask too many questions about the vigilantes while they're listening. She came with a group - we can speak to one of the others."

Meg Walter nodded, looking around to see what the other villains were up to, hoping to find someone not already engaged in conversation.

Wildbow The number include the small man, Morton Black, off on his own at the foot of the stage with the violinist, a fellow with a broad belly who is eating and drinking a little too much, though polite enough to swallow before speaking to the police chief who stands next to him, the woman who was called Elizabeth Heron has broken away from Marie and is talking to the sixteen or seventeen year

old...

...with the short curly hair...

A woman with a rabbit fur around her neck, head and ears included, is talking to a woman with black feathers on her little black dress. And a dashing rogue of a man with a gun at his hip has joined a woman with evocative eye makeup in talking to the local business owners.

Meg Considering his options, Walter settled on the woman with the rabbit fur around her neck. The two of them approached her and her companion at a leisurely pace.

"Hello, ladies," Walter greeted them. "Enjoying the party?"

Wildbow The woman with the rabbit raises one hand to the black fur and bites her lower lip a little as she sizes you up with an up-down glance. You can see her look at Mariko, then take in your wedding rings, before a flicker of distaste passes over her face. The look gone, she smiles charmingly, "I am, councilman. How might we help you?"

Meg "Well, my lady, a while ago, my wife and I had our home invaded, with some rather serious consequences." Walter grimaced a little at the memory. "The man responsible for it has since disappeared, and we're interested in finding him."

Wildbow "No idea," Rabbit says. "But good luck to you."

"I might have an idea," the woman with the black feathers says. "Was it a common criminal, or one of the Disaffected?"

Meg ((Does that name ring any bells?))

Wildbow ((Not at present, no))

Non "I don't recognize that name, but he attempted to flay me and my husband alive for 'corruption,'" she uses the word with disdain, "if that helps narrow it down."

Wildbow "Flayed alive!" Rabbit exclaims, a touch too loud.

"However did you get away?"

Meg "We had hired security," Walter fell in smoothly. "They manage to scare them off and call the ambulance for us."

Wildbow "That doesn't fit their usual pattern," the woman with the black feather says. "Hmm. The reason you haven't heard the name is because I just made it up. Don't get me wrong, they're a definite group, with a definite agenda. I've been made aware of their movements, and we've had talks about them. There's a very good chance that when all the excitement has settled, they'll have maneuvered...

...themselves to be a permanent presence in Lausanne.

"I couldn't help you find an individual, but I could point you in the right directions."

Non "That would be greatly appreciated."

Meg Walter nodded his assent.

Wildbow "They fall into three groups, which I'm collectively calling the Disaffected. They want a revolution, and that revolution is being spearheaded by a group of citizens who call themselves the Bloc. Older, established locals who meet in secret. They brought a group in from out of town, those you personally ran into, it sounds like, and they look to be recruiting a younger age group, who we...

...know as the Young Nationals."

"The head of the vigilante mercenaries is now a member of the Bloc, and they've been absorbed into that contingent, though their methods are different. You won't find him or any of their key members now, unless you can get answers from the groups themselves. I know where the mercenaries hang out, and that's a very direct route to whoever you may be looking for.

"I also know that, say, the Young Nationals are holding a meeting with some Bloc representatives. If you wanted

to hurt their entire organization, then... well. I would interfere if I didn't have other focuses at the moment."

Meg "And you'd give us this information for free?"

Wildbow "With goodwill," she says. "And goodwill to be granted in the future? I do hate talking in terms of favors. It implies you can't ask me for more than one until you've repaid me. Or that I can only ask you for one in the future, if I need many. You're a married man. You must understand that the best relationships don't keep count."

Meg Walter shot her a smile at that. "Certainly. For that to work, however, an actual name would be most useful."

Wildbow "Ah, I do hate having to come up with names to use. I've been agonizing about it since Marie suggested the idea earlier, the scamp." she touches her forehead, clearly thinking. "Gail Ténèbre, if you will."

Meg He chuckled a little, before nodding. "Gail it is, then. What do you have for us?"

Non Mariko perks up, attentive and obviously agreeing with her husband.

Wildbow "If you want to know where to look, you could look for the mercenaries in the plaza. Downtown, above the red brick shopping center, there are apartments with a shared rooftop garden in the center. They're there, if they're not out and about. There's also an artist's district where the Young Nationals are. They'd be meeting tonight, which would limit who you could hire... Otherwise I...

...might say that Marie or Morton might be the people to hire."

Meg "We will definitely consider it," Walter said. He was tempted to just go in and do it himself, but there were probably far better ideas, and he'd like to discuss those better ideas with his wife, first.

Non "Thank you very much for your assistance," Mariko says.

Wildbow **"I wish you luck," she says. "I would like to say I'm sorry for what nearly occurred... but if circumstances were the same, I fear I would do the exact same thing the second time around."**

Meg Right. He wasn't even sure what to say to that, but that was the price for dealing with supervillains, he guessed.

Once he was sure they were out of earshot, he turned to his wife. "So, any ideas better than the ones I'm having?"

Non "If you're thinking of going in by yourself - we *could* hire someone," Mariko says, her voice low. "Additional force, a warm body to hide behind if worst comes to worst. Other than that, I could use survey it, wait for the best moment, figure out their movements, where to hit them, and provide cover if you need it."

Meg "Well, if we get involved directly, Gail will know who we are, or, at least that we have some muscle on our side that they clearly don't know about," he said. "Which we could use to our advantage, and I would like to do something myself, but there are a lot of risks associated with it. I'm a bit biased, so do you have any preference?"

Non ((Actually - *do* we have the money to hire somebody?))

Wildbow **((As it stands your assets don't favor money. I'm assuming it's tied up in your home, car, computer, general stuff, etc.))**

Non "We hit the mercenaries. They're the responsible party. We go to the place Gail gave us, I scope it out and figure out the best avenue of attack and offer support while you go in and... do your thing."

Meg Walter smiled at her. "I'll try to focus only on the man who actually hurt me, but I can't really make any promises. Shall we?"

Non "Yeah. Let's call it a night for the party," Mariko says, giving only a cursory look over the place as they go.

Wildbow You collect your coats and the person at the door makes the call to the valet parking. It's only a minute before the car pulls up. Raichel was the one who organized the company car and driver.

"Where to?" the driver asks you.

Meg "Home, please," Walter answered. They should prepare a little more, before they went out.

Wildbow The drive is a quiet one, and not too long. You arrive at your house, walking up a lengthy set of stairs to the front door. You can see the splinters where the door was pried open, something like the jaws of life or another contraption used to sever the lock. You still don't know how they got access without the security team reacting.

You make your way inside, locking the door behind you. It's time to get prepared for your night out.

((This would be a nice time to describe costume))

Meg Walter first got rid of the bandages. His body had healed properly after the attack, and he was as handsome as he'd ever been, if he said so himself.

His costume was nothing altogether special: a warm, dark blue pair of pants, shirt and jacket, with a mask covering the top half of his face. His pants had humanity's single best invention, which is to say, pockets, where he kept his phone.

After using a generous helping of hair gel to get his hair entirely out of model, looking more than a little wild, he was satisfied nobody would recognise him.

Non

Mariko gathers the materials that make up her costume, a full-body affair with a pair of repurposed goggles. The full-face mask, shirt, and pants are all done in urban camo colors, greys and blacks mixed in a static pattern, not useful for defense (and in fact, the surplus materials they're made of are prone to ripping), but useful to hide her from easy visibility.

For her leg, there's a mixture of cloth padding and a carefully shaped bit for her prosthetic to fit into one of the boots, to disguise her most distinctive feature - her missing leg. If one doesn't know to look, it's functionally impossible to tell that the leg is a fake.

She also retrieved her gun. She was licensed to own it, but not to carry it in public - but if she needed it and didn't have it, she'd be dead, and if she was caught by the cops tonight, her gun would be the least of her problems.

Wildbow

The mall that 'Gail mentioned isn't far from your place; walking distance. It's late enough you don't need to worry too much about being spotted. ((Any particular approach?))

Took a break here. Resumed a week and a half later...

Wildbow

Last time, in WD_Lausanne... husband and wife team Walter and Mariko Berset attend a party with the upper crust of Lausanne. Walter, a young politician, was only just recently targeted by vigilantes who flayed him alive, he got powers, but he also harbors deep resentment. His wife, Mariko, sought out and drank a Cauldron vial in hopes of better being able to defend herself and get

revenge....

... The discussion at the party is broken up as the local well-to-do villains and heads of organized crime in Lausanne show up, not even trying very hard to mask their identities.

Asking around, the pair get some details on where two of the three major subsets of the vigilantes are setting up shop, and decide to target the mercenaries who committed the home invasion and attempted mutilation of Walter. Returning home, they don their respective costumes, and remain set to decide just how they'll approach the mercenaries, who seem to be occupying a set of apartments...

...crowning a nearby mall.

Meg Walter was, of course, going to be the one out in front. There was no doubt in his mind about that, and it might not be a bad idea for Mariko to stay out of sight entirely, but that left them with a lack of ability to communicate, which would be a problem.

"So, dear, I am sorely tempted to simply knock on their door after you find out how many of them we're dealing with. Have a pleasant little chat to see if they can point us in the right direction, that sort of thing," he said. "But we do need a way to stay in contact."

Non "Do you have your cell?"

Meg "I do," he said, "but it's a little conspicuous."

Non "Your power is much more conspicuous. It's not like we have another option, to keep in touch, beyond me yelling at you."

Meg Walter grumbled a little at that, but found he couldn't disagree. "We're getting ourselves something more convenient after this," he muttered. "Where do you want to be, dear?"

Non "We scope out the area, find a good location for me to act as spotter. I scope out the building, tell you how many there are and where, and provide covering fire when you go in, if possible. I'd prefer something higher up, for a better vantage, but it really depends on where I can get to without attracting too much attention."

Meg "Right," Walter agreed. "Let's go scout the area, then. It's going to be a long night." He pressed a quick kiss to her lips, before leading the way out.

Wildbow **The mall isn't far away, and it's late at night, so the trip is relatively painless. Living in a nicer place closer to the city center does have its benefits, and access to the more important areas is one of them.**

As you approach the vicinity of the mall, you can see that it is well lit. LED lights on the outside shine on the window displays and the large brand-name signs hanging above windows and doors. It's a large mall, with roughly thirty stores, and seems to exist in two pieces, with a sort of path or plaza bisecting it, that path riddled with benches for people to eat outdoors in warmer...

...months. The broad, one-story building is crowned by five or six individual buildings, the apartments you heard mention of, where the mercenaries are reported to live. Given that people live there, access doesn't look like it would be too difficult, as they seem free to come and go at all hours. Approaching unseen might be harder, given the lighting and the bystanders - it's eleven...

...o'clock on a Friday night, and stores closed only an hour or two ago. Employees are still closing up and working on going home.

((<http://i.imgur.com/f6lWCSF.png> - people are smaller than they appear. Darker shapes = taller))

Non ((Sorry, which part of the map is the apartments?))

Wildbow ((Dark shapes atop the large, complicated building in the center))

((sorry it's unclear))

Non Lumen's first instinct is to scan the buildings as best she can from here, using her lifesign vision, trying to determine where - if anywhere - is an unoccupied vantage point is for her to claim as a perch.

Wildbow ((<http://i.imgur.com/ySqvAjQr.png>))

The lifesign vision flares, and the world dissolves into shades of white and black, with a faint red fog where bacteria and other lifeform are only barely surviving the winter cold.

On the upper floor, in the apartment nearest you, two people are inside the apartment. On the lower floor, you can see the marks of people going about their day, closing up the stores or walking through the plaza.

Vantage points are harder to figure out - it's very possible the mercenaries chose this location to live because of how defensible it was. The entrance to the upper floor would be through the plaza, and the apartments seem to give a good view of the surrounding area and of anyone coming up to the upper floor.

((Actually climbing up to higher ground would mean crossing the street to get to another building, at which point you're almost too far away to see/do anything.))

Non Lumen tells her husband the basic info she's gotten. "There doesn't seem to be any good perches, outside the mall. All I can think of is - we could wait for people to clear out, you could just go in now with this limited info, or I could try to use my power to help me sneak in, since it lets me see people through walls. What do you think?"

Meg He considered this for a moment. "Wait for the place to clear out a little, at the very least. It'd reduce witnesses and potential casualties, and we can use your power to sneak in after."

Non "Let's hope they don't lock up the apartments, then."

Wildbow ((Where do you wait in the meantime? - there's only open space/parking lots to the northwest and southeast of the building, and roads))

Meg ((Further back? Find an alley?))

Wildbow ((Across the street, where you don't have as much of a view?))

((<http://i.imgur.com/UXNHPSX.png>))

Meg ((I'm cool with that, the point is more to wait for the place to clear out than to see who is coming and going, exactly.))

Wildbow ((Roll sneak, both of you))

You cross the street and find a place where you can stand and huddle together in relative comfort, while you wait for things to clear up. From your vantage point, you can see the occasional employee getting ready to leave, and the headlights of cars in the parking lots flare on, then pull away, until only a scattered few cars remain.

You're too far away for Lumen's vision mode to detect whether people are within.

Non "The rest of the cars are probably the people living here. Let's go," Lumen says, using her life sense to try to reduce the chances of anyone seeing them as they approach and enter the apartments.

Wildbow **Only a few people remain on the ground floor, and they seem to be staying mostly in one place. Managers in offices, most likely.**

You approach close enough to be able to stand near the

walls, more or less out of view. Stairs lead to the two halves of the mall, the southeastern half being more populated than the northwestern half. Ramps with railings overhead connect the two halves, and an elevator leads up near the center ((toward middle of mall, the building with the small rectangular building, adjunct to ramp))

Meg Walter was a little out of his depth at the moment. The place was rather sizable, and he was not quite sure where to go. Armed mercenaries would probably prefer less company, right? So, heading up to the northwestern half first would make the most sense.

Non Lumen follows Walter's lead, trying to keep them both out of sight.

Wildbow You look around, and with Lumen's guidance, are fairly certain you're able to ascend to the roof without being seen. One person is up on the northwestern half, within a building, and he's not moving much at all. Four buildings stand at the far end, each with a number plate and a nameplate. The rooftop itself appears to be broad concrete tiles with gravel filling the gaps between them.

...

...Lamps at the boundary of the rooftop itself illuminate the roof. Three of the apartments aren't occupied at present.

((<http://i.imgur.com/kIBSEo5.png>))

Meg Walter lead the way closer towards the apartment buildings, trusting his wife to keep an eye on the lone individual on this side while he tried to get a look into the empty apartments.

Wildbow ((Wits checks))

The apartments are curtained, and a glance between the curtains suggests desks. There's a plastic case with locks that might be for weapons, and a desk littered with

papers.

((Another wits check, and take your actions))

Meg The place certainly looked interesting, and it was definitely worth finding a way in. Maybe one of the windows was easy to open? Not likely, with trained mercenaries, but trying couldn't hurt.

Non "You want to knock on the last door and see if the occupant is a merc?" Lumen suggests, quietly, to her husband.

Meg Walter shrugged. "Yes, why not?" He made his way to the door, knocking on it, not too hard.

Wildbow There's a long pause. Lumen can see the shape on the other side of the door start, then move. He's close enough that she can see the general shape of his organs.

He moves in a zig-zag, to one end of the room, then to the door, which he opens a crack. He's pale, with dark hair and circles under his eyes, and he smells like cigarettes. "Yes?"

Meg Walter greeted him with a grin. "Goodevening, sir, I hope we didn't disturb your sleep tonight, but me and my associate here," he indicated Lumen, "are following up on a lead of suspicious activity, and we were wondering if you know who lives in the other apartments here."

Wildbow ((Wits checks))

Wildbow He looks between you, a frown on his face, then shifts position slightly. The hand at his side moves to point at the door, and you throw yourselves to either side as bullets rip through the wood, Lumen reacting to the movement of the hand, Epiderm moving in response to Lumen. The sound of the gunshots is loud and punchy, and most likely gets the attention of everyone in a quarter-mile radius.

Meg Walter's power was somewhat frustrating. He had to actively work to keep it contained, and it was like holding up a heavy weight by a rope. Every minor bump threatened to make him lose his grip, and the constant focus got to his nerves.

"You really should've stopped to talk," he said through gritted teeth, before simply letting go and lunging at him.

Wildbow ((You'd have to go through the door to access the guy))

Meg ((Sure would.))

Wildbow ((Brawn roll))

You easily tear your way through the door, and find yourself in the room. After shooting, he immediately relocated to the far end of the room. One hand holds an assault rifle, and the other is on his desk. There's a button under his palm, orange.

The idea of treating the mall like a defensive emplacement apparently extends to the building having a security system or a silent alarm.

Wildbow ((Go ahead, Meg))

Meg Epidermis imitated a disappointed sigh, before flying forward, aiming to hit him straight in the face.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll))

The man raises his hand to defend himself, but the fist of glowing energy, wreathed with a ribbon of skin, slams through flesh and bone, decimating both up to the elbow.

It's not an injury that a hospital is going to easily handle, unless a limb transplant is somehow available.

((Non's go))

Non Lumen uses her lifesign sight to sweep the area, looking for anyone coming for the sound of the gunshot, and simultaneously moving towards the cover of the space between apartments and drawing her gun.

Wildbow ((Apartments closer to epiderm or further away?))

Non ((Closer.))

Wildbow There are men with guns approaching, two from the southeasternmost apartment, and one from the easternmost. One fires a single shot from an assault rifle as he aims at a retreating Lumen.

"My arm! My goddamn arm!" the merc in the one apartment screams in French. The injury is just about severe enough that he looks to be out of the fight. "I hope he damn well kills you, you freak bastard!"

Non "Three incoming!" Lumen shouts to her husband. She uses her lifesign sight to take aim at the nearest of the group, peaking out of cover for as short a time as possible to take her shot.

Meg It took Epidermis a moment to pull himself back together, drawing back in on himself. It would be better, in the long term, to not keep his power active unless he was directly in need of it. He grinned down at the man, making sure his gun was nowhere near his reach. "So violent," he said. "Y'know, I really did want to talk."

He shouted back to his wife. "Our friend here rang the alarm, there's reinforcements coming! We may just want to grab this guy and leave!"

Wildbow As flesh knits back together, it overlaps and blends together, knitting into a bulging black scar, extending from one corner of Epiderm's mouth to his ear. Muscles in his face are paralyzed. ((-1 soc))

The three men approach, fanning out. Now and again,

they fire a shot, experimental, just to give you reason to duck your head down and make sure you know they're there.

Non

Lumen fires at her target, the closest man to them.

Wildbow

Pulling the trigger and squeezing out two shots, Lumen misses with her first shot, corrects, and hits with a second - right between the eyes. A thug goes down.

Non

"If you want to grab him and go, we can try that, but you'll probably have to swap back," Lumen says. She eyes the distance to the ground - it's just a one story drop, and her power should be able to carry her down, right?

Wildbow

((Carry down, no, but shorten the effective distance, yes - keep in mind 1 story for a mall is different than 1 story for a house, higher ceilings, etc. It's about a 25 foot drop))

Meg

"I could handle that," Walter told his wife, the words a little slurred as he tried to move muscles that weren't responding. He stepped aside so he could watch the entrance to the apartment and the thug at his feet in sight. He turned to face the man on the ground, seeing if the man would survive the trip. "How's about you, buddy? Think you could make it?"

Wildbow

The man on the ground grimaces as he crawls further back, away from you and the door. ((Wits check))

One hand moving to the underside of a shelf, he comes away with a pistol, moving it to point and to fire at Epiderm while the man is more distracted.

((Roll dodge))

The bullet punches through Epiderm's chest, and he hears and feels a strange, loud -bang-. The air goes out of him, and a massive pressure seems to weigh on one side of his upper body.

Dimly, you recognize what just happened, as the blood

pours freely, dripping onto the ground. Punctured lung.

((-2 to Brawn, Ath, Dex, death sentence.))

((<http://i.imgur.com/ycvpNi2r.png> - adjusted))

Meg With no other options, Walter activated his power again, eyes focused on the man in front of him, ready to rip into him.

Non "Fuck," Lumen says, at the sound of the gunshot, looking over to see her husband get shot. She'll have to trust he's okay and can handle himself - she shimmies down the alley, keeping an eye on the men, then moves to lower herself, hanging onto the roof by the edge before dropping down and then activating her power to shorten the distance.

Wildbow **((Roll Ath))**

The landing is a hard one, the artificial leg doesn't support your weight, and you tumble, falling down to the ground, more than a little dazed. ((Staggered, knocked down, minor wound)).

The man with the gun unloads into Epiderm... but even if any shots were to hit, they can't penetrate the breaker body.

There's noise of the others moving beyond the confines of the room.

Meg His eyes bore into the man in front of him. Epidermis was going to kill that man, and it was going to be so utterly satisfying.

But first, he had more important things to take care of. He rushed forward to grab the man by whatever was most within reach of his hands.

Wildbow **((Brawn roll))**

As you reach for him, the man struggles, doing his best to put himself under the bed, hooking a leg there, so he can't be picked up or lifted from the ground.

((Non's go - you're staggered, so only half turn's action))

Non ((How well-lit is the ground here?))

Wildbow ((Well lit - as described in the initial scene, there are LED lamps shedding light on the building exterior, signs, and sidewalk around the building))

Non As Lumen struggles to her feet, she swaps her vision mode, going over to movement detection and periodically glancing over her shoulder as she limps northwest.

Wildbow As much as she's able to see the movements of the others, Lumen can't communicate it to Epiderm. The men make their approach, appearing in the doorway, guns raised, only for the one on the ground to squeeze out the words "Bulletproof!"

Instead of firing, they seem to recognize what it means, and immediately throw themselves to either side of the door, outside of Epiderm's line of sight and reach.

Meg Aww, the poor sod had to warn them. Epidermis had been just about ready to pick this guy up and throw him at his buddies, but now that was no longer an option. He stamped down on the head of the guy lying down, and then went after the other two.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll))

Your foot comes down, not on his head, but the shoulder of his good arm, stomping through and crushing bone.

Non ((If I go towards the parking lot to the northwest, when would I get there? This turn, with no time to shoot? Next turn?))

Wildbow ((You could reach the trunk of the nearest yellow car this turn))

Non Lumen makes her way to the parking lot to the northwest, continuously glancing up at the roof to try to make out what's going on.

Wildbow **The roof intervenes, but you can see the life signs of the people on the rooftop, standing outside the building.**

((Meg))

((Also, wits check @ non))

Meg So, the one guy was no longer going to bother him, but the other two... Well, they were either going to ambush him, or they were going to ambush his wife, and both of those were silly, but one of them was far more acceptable than the other.

Epidermis went to rush outside, swinging at whatever mercenary he spotted first to make sure his wife could escape, and then he was going to fly to the nearest hospital to get himself fixed up. He wasn't going to risk turning off his power before then.

Wildbow **((Wits check @ Epiderm))**

As Epiderm takes to the air, he can see Lumen reacting to the approach of a pair of capes, from the far end of the northwest parking lot.

Both are tall, but that height has to do with what seems to be green and gold power armor, which adds about two feet of breadth to their shoulders and two feet of height to their stature. Both have helms with golden masks, and both are identical.

Non Fuck. Capes. Probably reinforcements for the mercs. Lumen moves to reposition herself so she's hidden behind a car, crouching down and hoping they'll fly over to her husband without noticing her.

Wildbow **((<http://i.imgur.com/VEuYoNB.png>))**

((Whoops, should be gold, not purple. Oh well))

Meg That was unacceptable, they were not going to hurt his wife.

He ignored the thugs behind him, flying towards the other capes in order to buy her time to get away.

Wildbow Their attention not really on the air, they seem to be talking to one another, and don't notice either of you.

((<http://i.imgur.com/fpl1db.png>))

Non Lumen watches the edge of the roof, keeping her gun at the ready for if the thugs try to peak their heads out. Armored men was more Epidermis's sort of business than hers, and she didn't want to get surprised by being shot in the back by some two-bit merc.

Meg Epidermis was not feeling well. This situation wasn't being resolved and the longer it took, the worse it'd get for him when everything was finally over.

He landed in front of the two capes in suits, making sure not to give any indication that there was anyone else nearby.

Wildbow The one to Epiderm's right spots Epiderm as he starts to land. Abrupt, moving at a good clip, the armored cape reaches for and grabs the car to its left-

((Roll dodge/guts/whatever))

Epiderm floats back and out of the way as the cape grabs the car and swings it like an oversized club. The exterior of the car rips free of the gauntlets as it gets swung, and the car sails in Lumen's general direction, falling short of hitting her cover.

The other armored cape lunges, swinging a punch at Epiderm (Again, defensive roll if you want it)

The gauntlet slams into Epiderm, who braces against the hit, and comes away dented from the impact. The owner of the power armor hardly seems to care as they pull back. The damaged gauntlet vibrates, flashes gold, and in a moment, is back to pristine condition.

Meg Well, Epidermis had just about had it with people attacking before actually talking, and these guys were clearly pretty intent on killing him.

He felt more than justified, at this point, to simply bash their heads in, and he swung his fist at the one that had tried to hit him.

Wildbow ((Attack roll))

The incoming fist meets a raised arm, and only manages to scuff it.

Non Lumen swaps vision modes, going to lifesight, and doing a quick sweep to see if the mercs were retreating, or recuperating, or what, then (assuming they weren't about to come up to the edge of the roof and start shooting) turning to peak through the car windows at the armored figures to see where they are in their suits.

Wildbow **The people on the roof are retreating, reaching the point where they're fading beyond the visible range of your lifesight vision. It looks as though they're going for the stairs, either to get away or to circle around.**

Looking at the people in the armor, it look as though their feet reach down to the knee of each suit, the hands to the elbow, their bodies are center-mass. Both are women. Your vision sharpens momentarily, giving you a view of their vitals. Very similar women, physiologically.

The woman in hand to hand combat with Epiderm swings her fists at him- ((defensive roll))

And he manages to block the hit, denting the metal armor once again. The woman in the distance moves toward another car, lifts it up, and then hurls it in Lumen's general direction-

((Dodge roll))

Wildbow **The car slams into the cover and rolls into Lumen, who gets thrown to the ground. Staggered, the air knocked out of her, it feels as though a rib might be broken.**

((Heavy exertion like running will deliver a minor wound))

Meg Right, that did it. Epidermis was now genuinely upset, and he couldn't even vocalise it, which probably only made it worse.

He swung at the person in front of him again.

Wildbow Another swung punch, this one connecting solidly with the golden mask, tearing it free of the housing and sending it flying into the distance. The actual head of his target is buried within the torso, just out of reach, but from the reaction of the suit, it looks like functioning of the armor has ceased entirely, leaving it paralyzed. You can hear swearing from the person within.

((Non's go))

((Half action, so the broken rib won't have any impact since you're not really capable of running or doing any heavier action atm))

((<http://i.imgur.com/QSer6au.png>))

Non Lumen moves slightly to one side, away from the wrecked car, before swapping vision modes again, this time to zoom, as she takes aim at the armored suit that her husband didn't just knock the helmet off of. She tries to ignore the pain in her ribs as she aims for center mass and fires.

Wildbow ((Roll to shoot?))

As you zoom and focus your sight, things grow ever sharper. It's something like you experienced in the Cauldron lab, that you couldn't quite get a handle on, an aspect to your power you haven't quite been able to grasp. It's not that the zooming effect is stronger, or that you're more accurate. Something else-

All the same, the bullet hits armor and glances off.

((Roll investigate))

The headless armor flickers and glows gold, and then lunges forward. It has a head again, and it's coming out

swinging-

((Defense roll @ Epiderm))

Epiderm easily tanks the hit.

Lumen's attention is on the armor attacking her husband - she's noticed something. Where the armor is now entirely intact, it has a scuff mark at the chest, matching the one where the bullet glanced off the other armor.

Meg Alright then, punching the head wasn't going to do him any favours. About damn time he buried his fist in her chest, instead.

Wildbow ((Attack roll))

With a solid hit, Epiderm caves in the chest of the suit of armor...

There's a wet sound within. It sounds very much like he did some serious damage to the occupant.

Non "Hit both of them! They heal off the other!" Lumen shouts at her husband, at the same time as she moves slightly to the north, trying to angle for a minimally obstructed shot, before pressing her hand against a car, trying to angle it so that it's shoved towards the uninjured armor, and activates her Striker power.

Wildbow The striker power was another thing that didn't get enough testing or clarity. Lightning visibly crackles around the car as it slides toward the power armor, which...

...reaches out and catches the car that is sliding right toward it. Had the car been closer, it wouldn't have lost more momentum and would have been harder to catch. As the electricity crackles, the person in the armor pulls away.

The other suit of armor begins vibrating and glowing,

and in a flash and a moment, is back in fighting shape.

It slams a fist in Epiderm's direction-

((Defensive roll))

and is yet again deftly blocked.

Meg Hit both of them? How on earth was he supposed to manage that with the way they kept him occupied!?

Actually... That could totally work...

Wildbow **((<http://i.imgur.com/p8LrS7m.png>))**

Meg He grabbed the one standing in front of him, with the aim of throwing her straight into the other.

Wildbow **((Brawn roll))**

His reaching tendrils of flesh are smacked aside.

Non **((How high is Epidermis hovering?))**

Wildbow **((3-5'??))**

Non Bullets won't work, but the car seemed to have an effect, with her electric charges carrying over. Lumen moves to shove a car into the nearer of the two armored figures with her Striker power, the one her husband is currently fighting. "Go for the other," she tells him, hurriedly.

Wildbow **((Dex roll))**

The car slides under Epiderm and into the suit, striking it at knee level. The suit folds, both hands on the roof, and the occupant makes a faintly heard noise, looking up at Lumen as fingers bite into the car's frame, gripping it.

((Dodge roll, Lumen, block roll @ Epiderm))

Seeing the incoming attack, a battered Lumen is slow to move, but Epiderm manages to put himself between the hurled car and his partner. The car practically folds in

half around him.

The other suit, meanwhile, lifts the blue car that Lumen shoved at it earlier, aiming to do much the same thing, targeting Lumen.

((Brawn roll, Epiderm))

Epiderm manages to tear at the car that slammed into him, pushing it aside, but too slow and too little for him to repeat the act, intervening for Lumen.

((Rodge roll, Lumen))

Lumen is too slow to move as the car slams into her cover, an eerie echo of what happened earlier. Hurlled to the ground, she's badly battered and bruised.

((Thrown aside, staggered))

((Plus moderate wound))

((Roll guts, Lumen))

((you good))

Meg Epidermis quickly threw the wrecked car next to him at the one furthest away from him, before throwing himself at the closer one, smashing at her chest again.

Wildbow ((That's two attack actions))

((Want to try it but with a penalty to the second action?))

Meg ((I do.))

Wildbow ((Brawn roll and then Brawn roll -2))

The car collides with the more distant suit of armor, and once again, strikes the armored chest. It's solid armor, but a head on collision with a flying car serves to repeat what had happened earlier, driving the metal inward, crushing the occupant within.

Moving fast to try and capitalize on the opportunity, Epiderm swings a punch, only for the other suit to block the hit with folded, raised arms.

((<http://i.imgur.com/BgBrDsy.png>))

Non Lumen activates her zoom as she aims and shoves the car between them at the nearest armor before moving towards the cover of the cars, activating her flash step to increase the distance covered.

Wildbow **((Attack roll))**

The car, prodded by the power, slams into the armor. Lightning crackles around it, and the armor flails, staggering back.

The armors opt to do nothing this turn but to try and regain their footing and free themselves from the cars.

Meg That was their chance. He fainted towards the near one, before dashing towards the far one, punching down on its head.

Wildbow **Smashing the head seems to leave the armor stunned. It isn't healing the damage that was done earlier, at least not yet.**

((<http://i.imgur.com/FAAq7p9.png>))

Non Lumen swapped vision modes, going to lifesign, and shoves the nearest car into the nearer armor before checking over her shoulder quickly for any sign of the other two mercenaries.

Wildbow **((Dex roll))**

Both suits of armor continue to take a beating, and things have well passed the point where the armor is able to put up a fight. You continue the onslaught, and eventually reach the point where you're free to deliver the final blow, or otherwise decide how you're going to

wrap this up.

Meg Epidermis made to pull the woman out of the suit, hoping to leave her alive, tearing through the armour as much as he had to.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll))

Wildbow The armor is peeled aside, and the woman is hauled free. She wears a mask and a costume, all green and gold, and has her dark hair pleated into a braid that hangs on the left.

Wildbow Her legs are in bad shape, but considering the damage to the chest of the armor, the rest of her is surprisingly fine.

Non Lumen smashes at the suit with cars until she feels confident enough to close, activating her power to pop the helmet off and demanding the woman inside surrender.

Wildbow The woman inside the suit looks up, then gets sparking and damaged armor to open the chest compartment.

Wildbow Her legs are in bad shape, but considering the damage to the chest of the armor, the rest of her is surprisingly fine.

Wildbow "I'll surrender," she says, jaw set.

Meg Epidermis grabbed the other one, forcing the metal of the surrounding cars into something resembling cuffs for her before shooting his wife a look. His life was still very much in danger, and the longer he spent like this, the worse it was going to get.

Non "Come on then," Lumen says, trying to pull the woman out of her armor. "Use your own muscles, your arms still work."

Wildbow The woman winces, the damage to her feet and the metal surrounding it appears to make climbing free a little too painful. She stops trying after just a few seconds, then relaxes, letting her head settle against the headrest.

"My friends are going to come," she speaks in French. "I

can't get free, and you can't carry me, I don't think."

"Can I negotiate for you to spare me?" she asks. She winces in pain. "I was asked to help them. I don't want to die for this job."

Non Lumen pretends to consider the offer. " My clients want some information. I want to know everything you know about the men who kidnap people and flay them alive. If you tell me, I'm done - I don't have any business besides that."

Wildbow **"Okay," the woman says. "Then have your friend carry my other half away somewhere and return. I'm not going anywhere, but at least I'll know she's safe."**

Non Lumen looks over at her husband and frowns beneath her mask - it was a long fight, and he still hasn't left his Breaker state. "Epidermis!" She yells over to him. "Can you take her," she gestures at the woman he's captured, "somewhere safer?" It's a genuine question, not just a polite request.

Meg Epidermis recognised that he was not in the best of states at the moment, but he was also very much aware that the information they could get here was very important. He was technically fine now, and any help he did need might just involve his wife, so the faster the interrogation was over, the better.

As such, he nodded, grabbing the woman next to him and flying off, fully expecting her to give him directions.

Wildbow **"Thank you," the woman tells Lumen. Then, in a different tone, she says, "Damn suits weren't worth the price."**

Non

"I've given you a show of good will," Lumen says. "Let's talk. There are men - affiliated, I believe with the mercenaries up there," she jerks her head towards the roof, "who have been running around kidnapping people and flaying them. I want information on those men. Where they work, who they work with, where they live, anything that would help in dismantling their organization."

Wildbow

"The mercenaries I was asked to help are R.E.C. Red Eye Contracts. Canadian mercenaries, English and French. They are the ones who are doing the dirty work you speak of," she says. "But I have not heard about this flaying. It has been different punishments for every individual they target."

"A small part of their group is here. The rest of them are over the other side of the Atlantic. I can tell you about them in a general sense, but I couldn't tell you particulars. I was asked to come here and help, I am a mercenary myself, but I don't know the full story, or their addresses.

"You would have scared them off, after this. They will make an attempt to rescue their friends and pick up anything important they left behind, paperwork, weapons. But they will relocate. They will be harder to find next time... unless they decide to find you, keep you from being a problem in the future."

She groans a little at the pain.

The two twins have effectively been separated.

Epidermis flies off with the other version of the woman, very swiftly out of sight.

Non

"I see," Lumen says, mentally calculating. That's not good, but perhaps she can gather some of the paperwork before they can fetch it. "How big of a group is here in Lausanne? Do you know of any parahuman members?"

Meg Epidermis looked at the woman as he flew off with her. He wasn't sure where to bring her, though, and did his best to give her a questioning look. If there was any part of his power he hated (besides the scarring, obviously) it was the fact that he wasn't able to talk.

Wildbow "No parahuman members, but they are working with, ah, my employer. In that, we are on the same level, neither subservient to the other. There are thirty of them. Less, after tonight. I'll leave it to you to do basic subtraction," the woman tells Lumen

On Epidermis' end, the woman waits some time, and it seems almost as if she's passed out, until her head and arm move, and she points. "There."

Non "Would your 'employer' be likely assist them in any vengeance they might seek to mete out against me or my clients?"

Meg Thank god. He was almost starting to get worried. Flying around aimlessly after all of that would have felt so silly. He nodded and flew in the direction she had indicated.

Wildbow "I think my employer is very much on the same page as them," she says. "The mercenaries are part of a pairing. Soon to be a trio. The head group of this vigilante faction and my employers are... almost indistinguishable."

Non "Okay," Lumen says, slowly, trying to process. She considers just putting a bullet between the woman's eyes to obscure her identity - Gail's words about them 'changing their methodology' coming back to her, fucking stupid to have mentioned the flaying - but imagines that the entire reason the woman told her to take her other half somewhere safe was so that she could survive such an attempt.

"What are you willing to tell me about your group, then?"

Wildbow "-My- group is me," she says. "I'm a mercenary, solo. I just happen to be working with R.I.C. right now. My

employer wanted me to help them after the alarm was sounded."

In the distance, the other woman indicates for Epiderm to set her down. "Here is fine."

Meg Epidermis did as told, setting her down on the ground and then taking a look at where the hell he was, exactly.

Wildbow The environment seems to be a suburb, with a few scattered businesses and restaurants. It's a nice part of town. The woman can't stand, and seems content to be draped on the side of the street, her back to a telephone pole.

Non She's been evasive about her employer; it's probably a waste of time to try to get more info out of her on that subject. "I guess that's all my questions, then." Lumen moves away as best she can, with the damage from the cars and her prosthetic, flicking over to lifesign scan and headed back up to the mercenary's apartment, in the hopes of grabbing whatever evidence she can.

Meg Epidermnis thought that was odd, but he had fulfilled his role and, after looking down at the very, very vulnerable person before him for a moment, he decided to fly off. Any damage she took would be healed anyway, so there wasn't really a point. He would rendezvous with his wife and figure out what to do about his wounds. Maybe she had an idea better than 'hope doctors could fix the giant hole in his chest'.

Wildbow Lumen circles around toward the mid-section of the mall, where the stairs lead up to the upper floor. Her life detecting sight doesn't reveal any life other than mice and bacteria on the ground floor, and a few mice on the upper floor. Her bruises and scrapes make themselves felt as she limps her way up the stairs toward the apartments that crown the mall.

As she arrives, Epiderm makes his return flight, having covered far more distance. The two are reunited.

Non "You've been in that state for a long time," she says to Epidermis, a note of worry in her voice. He'd been shot, but it hadn't been a killing shot - had it? "Are you okay?"

Meg He shook his head, then mimed his hand as a gun, put his fingers against his chest and 'pulled the trigger'.

Non Fuck, fuck, fuck. Okay. Worse than she thought. Panic gives her a bit of room to think. She immediately pulls out her cell, finding that stupid card that Marie - Maria? - that he fox-woman gave her, and dialing the number.

Wildbow The phone rings. It doesn't take long for someone to pick up.

You recognize her voice, and you recognize the sound of the violin in the background. "Hello? You're a new number. How may I help you, sir or madame?"

Meg Epidermis waited patiently. There was little else to be done at the moment, and his current state made him feel oddly detached from the actual problem plaguing him.

Non "This is Mariko Berset," Lumen says, trying not to let her panic get in her voice. "I'm looking for, ah, Marie? The fox. I need some help, and she said earlier tonight that she was here and available."

Wildbow "Marie Roux is at the party, Malin the Fox is on the phone with you right now. How can I help?"

Non "My husband's been shot, and it's very bad. Do you have - know - anyone who can heal him?"

Meg Well, that was their cover with the villains of the city probably gone, but it wasn't like he could do anything about that right now, either. Maybe he'd be able to concoct some story later, but probably not. That was a little annoying.

Wildbow "To the best of my knowledge, there are no less than five different tinkers who work with human physiologies, and two non-tinker individuals who can heal people, in

Lausanne right now. Sorry, wait, four biotinkers. The last I heard, one ranted, flooded his power armor with enzymes and threw himself from a window. Likely for the best that we didn't entrust your husband to that one."

"Where are you?"

Non Lumen gives the address. "Thank you so much for this," she says, almost breathless.

Wildbow ((What address?))

Non ((Where we are right now? The shopping mall's roof.))

Wildbow "Okay. You're not about to tell me that you and your husband took the information you got from Gail and immediately marched out there yourselves, only to get yourself shot?" she asks.

Non "He's getting worse with every passing second," Lumen says, exasperated. "Please, you can make fun of me all you want later, but I really need help ASAP."

Wildbow "I'll have you know that I was having a very nice evening," she says.

You realize that her voice didn't come from the phone. She's standing behind you.

"And your husband seems to be holding his own."

Non Lumen closes her eyes in irritation for a moment before turning off her phone. "His Breaker state damages his real body worse the longer it lasts, and he was already wounded when he entered it."

Wildbow "Takes pieces out of his real body, I assume? I'm trying to decide who to call."

Meg Epidermis made a so-so gesture with his hands. It wasn't quite correct, but he had no idea how to explain the actual process without having a mouth to speak with. That was really getting to him.

Non "Scars it, all over. Reduced mobility, problems talking. He's never been in it this long so I don't know how bad it will be when he leaves it or what will happen."

Wildbow "Okay. If it was missing bits, then I would have Manticore try to fill the gaps. As it isn't Manticore..." she belatedly hangs up her phone, terminating your call, and then dials. Phone held to her ear, she says, "It's going to be a minute before he arrives. Did you really dispatch everybody here? That's impressive."

Non "Half, the other half ran when the twins in power suits showed up." She looks over at the apartment of the mercenary that shot her husband. "Do you mind if I go look around, see if they left anything important behind, in case they come back?"

Meg Epidermis shook his head at his wife's question. He was definitely a person still here, and he definitely still had a say in the way things were going. He was still pretty expressive with his hands, indicating she was free to go inside.

Wildbow "Oh. I can safely say I don't mind, Mariko, but I have a means of slipping away if and when they decide to show up in more numbers. Unless you were very, very scary, I would imagine you should be leaving sooner or later. Do your thing, but be fast about it. The longer you spent digging around, the less time you'll have to actually run away."

She perks up, "Yes! Hello there, Leperous. I imagine you're at home or your headquarters. How would you like a test subject?"

Meg Epidermis shot her a look at the phrasing, but was otherwise in no position to object.

Non "Obviously," Lumen says, quickly moving over towards the mercenary that shot her husband's apartment. She didn't see any human lifesigns when she came in, so he's either dead or gone. She tries to go through what's there as quickly as possible, looking for a bag or suitcase or similar first, and stuffing any papers or other possible leads in it.

Wildbow ((Wits roll, apply Investigate))

The search for a bag or a suitcase turns up only a gym bag. It's not big, and you have only so much time. There's an assortment of things lying around as you look over the apartment, and it's your choice what you grab...

((Roll again? Meg too, if he's helping))

((Guns and gun licenses / pill bottles / body armor (bulky, counts double) / car rental receipts / phone numbers / letter to family / what appear to be printouts of R.I.C. internal documents / newspapers with circled portions / documents with Lausanne police letterheads / printouts of emails and webpages that seem to be rooting for the RIC / paperwork re: leases / files that seem to pertain...

...to old jobs -- Non can pick 3 to grab, Meg can pick 2, to start))

Non Lumen grabs the R.I.C. internal documents, the old job files, and the phone numbers, stuffing them hurriedly into the gym bag.

Meg Epidermis grabbed the documents with Lausanne police letterheads and newspapers, doing much the same.

Wildbow "He's on his way. You could fly to meet him, if you wanted. He'll be on his motorcycle, and I told him to keep an eye on the sky. I don't think either of you would miss each other," Malin says.

((If you guys want to stay, you can pack more into your bags, but there's a chance the RIC thugs turn up))

Meg Epidermis nodded at her, hoping to impart his gratitude, at least, before he took off to meet his potential saviour.

Non "Thank you very much," Lumen says to Malin, as she starts to leave, headed back towards her home.

Wildbow **"Leperous is really a nice fellow. Your husband is in good hands," Malin comments, as she watches Epidermis depart. "He has picked up a bad reputation, though. Grave issues. Put him in the middle of a conflict, and he's a danger to himself and to others," Malin comments. As she did at the party, she joins you as you attempt to retreat. "That ranting, frothing at the mouth supervillain?...**

Wildbow ... That's Leperous, once you get him agitated."

Wildbow **"Now, with a mind to payment..."**

Non Lumen stops, quirking her lips beneath her mask. "You really want to discuss this here and now?"

Meg One thing that sort of made up for the lack of ability to speak? Flying. Flying was definitely a perk Epidermis enjoyed, as he looked down to spot Leperous.

Wildbow **"To be honest, I would rather not have to bring it up at all. Polite customers, like polite Johns, discreetly, politely, and honorably handle the payment, in such a way that the interaction between the client and the person rendering the service isn't spoiled," Malin says. She smiles. "I'm not going to spoil things further and be crass in asking for money or even favors, don't worry."**

Epidermis spots the man on the motorcycle. He's surprisingly easy to miss, because Epidermis was looking for a motorcycle, and glanced right past the hulking form that was easily mistaken for an oddly shaped car.

In fact, it's a man in power armor on a very large, broad

bike. This vehicle is to motorcycles what tanks are to cars.

Meg Epidermis descended before him, making sure not to startle the guy driving a fucking tank. He wasn't exactly sure how to feel about his soon-to-be doctor driving something that bulky, but beggars could hardly be choosers.

Wildbow The man in the power armor is armored, with vials at his waist and along his chest. His sword has a syringe built into it. All of the fluid seems remarkably thick.

"Good evening," he says. "You're the one Malin is paying me to help?"

Meg Malin was even paying the guy. My, she must really like the two of them, or expect they had a lot to offer her in the long run. That was probably true, too.

He nodded, trying to appear as non-threatening as possible, which was not easy.

Wildbow "Alright," he says. "Short notice, and short notice tends to be a bad thing when you're a tinker, but I'm going to give this a shot. No pun intended," he says. "You don't talk, huh? That makes this harder."

Meg Epidermis wasn't actually sure if his eyes were visible in his current state, but he rolled them anyway. He shrugged, shaking his head a little.

Wildbow "Okay," he says. "So. We turn you off, you're going to start pulling back together, and we're going to have a life-threatening gunshot wound and the side effect of your power to work with. One needs pieces put back into place, another needs pieces pruned back. My specialty is nanomachines, and a task this intense means we're going to have to get invasive, my friend."

Malin looks at Lumen, "I don't want money or a favor, but I can't do this for free, you understand. In the interest of

building a better working relationship, I'd like you to let us know, the next time you're taking action. Figure out what you're doing, the Lodge will send somebody with you. We can't expend resources on you if we don't know what you're doing."

Non "That sounds fair enough," Lumen says.

Meg Epidermis nodded along with his explanation. He did not quite like the sound of 'invasive', mind, but what he liked even less was that this guy was talking instead of doing. Time was costly, here. More time meant more scars, and more scars meant more time, and he had already been like this for what felt like ages.

He motioned for him to hurry up, already.

Wildbow **Malin makes her departure, disappearing literally in the blink of an eye, as Lumen closes her eye and then opens it, there is only the afterimage of Malin's life-signs in Lumen's vision, swiftly fading to nothing.**

"You're going to have to change back," Leperous says. "This shouldn't be painful, but it's going to be uncomfortable."

Meg Epidermis nodded, taking the mental equivalent of a deep breath before changing back.

Wildbow ((Guts roll))

Leperous draws his needle, quickly eyeing the wound and watching as the skin begins knitting together.

As he raises his hand, ready to plunge the syringe in, you feel the pain hit you, and automatically shunt back to your breaker state.

Leperous stops, syringe poised, confused.

Meg Okay, flying, as a perk, definitely did not measure up to the annoyance here, and he couldn't even explain it properly.

He wanted to groan in frustration, but held up a finger to signal patience, before trying it again.

Wildbow ((you know what to do - Guts roll))

You start to zip yourself back together, and Leperous moves, ready to jab you. He stops just in time to keep the needle from breaking on your invulnerable exterior, as you automatically unzip yourself.

"You need to go back to your usual form," Leperous says.

((You can probably utter one or two words at a time as you make an attempt))

Non After having had multiple cars thrown at her, Lumen heads home in the vain hopes of going to sleep.

Meg Yes, thank you, good doctor. He hadn't figured that out, yet.

He tried again, hoping the word 'automatic' would at least escape his lips to let the man know what was happening.

Wildbow The needle breaks on the ribbon of skin as Leperous jabs. He swears, and quickly grabs another tinkered needle-head, screwing it on.

"Auto- Matic," you manage.

He glances at you. Then he swears under his breath.

"Three options, off the top of my head," he says. He holds up his fingers, to make it clear that he's numbering the options, and to make it easier for you to keep trying.

"We keep doing this, my equipment maybe breaks, you get tired, and you put yourself in a worse state in the long run...

"Second option is you take my word for it when I say that your wound doesn't look fresh. Your power is doing something behind the scenes, and you might heal... but it would be... a very long time. Slower than that wound

would take to heal naturally. You just keep doing what you're doing, stay in this form, unable to talk, and eventually you should be able to turn back.

"Third option? I try my God's honest best to fuck you up in this form, enough that I can get a syringe in you, despite you being... what, invincible? Nearly invincible?"

Meg Epidermis nodded at his final question before considering his options. He held up one finger on one hand, indicating he wanted to try the first option. Holding up two fingers on the other hand indicated he wanted to try it twice more.

Wildbow "First option, then second option?"

"Alright, whenever you're ready."

Meg Eh, he'd roll with that. He tried to pull himself together again.

Wildbow It takes effort, and you only really have a brow to sweat bullets with for a few seconds before you're sweating bullets, working to pull your body together.

The needle plunges in, next to the wound.

"Hold form," he says. "Next needle in three seconds."

((Guts roll))

You hold yourself together long enough for him to drive the next needle home, in your lower stomach, some distance from the gunshot wound.

You feel your flesh crawling, quite literally, as it takes on a texture like iron filings or coarse sand in metallic hues.

The crawling is happening -inward- around the wound, drawing the wound closed as it fills the damaged areas. The crawling is spreading out in a broader way from the other site, creeping out to affect all of your skin. As your skin meets, it is expanding, unfolding like a blossoming flower, into waves of scar tissue, creeping outward in its own way.

It's becoming very clear that the creeping is taking over your neck and your mouth, and it's going to cover your airways. The effect of the anti-scarring treatment isn't reaching far enough or high enough.

Meg

That... was not good. Very much not good. Nevertheless, some of what was happening was good, and he always had an emergency escape if he needed one, so he simply took a deep breath while he still could and waited it out.

Wildbow

Hands become mittens, then clubs, and arms bind to the body. The effect of the treatment allows Leperous to work on freeing the arms, retaining mobility. He isn't curing the side effect, he's just keeping you functional.

You belatedly wonder if you should have managed a warning or notified him as to what was going on, as you realize you've lost the ability to speak, scar tissue taking over your throat and mouth. It's at the point where you're suffocating, he's focusing on your limbs and your bullet wound, and you can't communicate what's going on.

Meg

Right. Well, shit.

Nevertheless, he did have his arms free, and he should be able to attract his attention and point to his throat with those, right?

Wildbow

((Roll social, as base, unmodified by power penalties))

You manage to get his attention. You point to your mouth, which is at the point where it's almost not a mouth anymore.

"Damn it!" he says. "Alright. Hold very, very still. Do everything in your power to avoid going back to your breaker state, because that's going to hurt everything, across the board."

He picks up his greatsword.

Meg His eyes widened for a bit, but he nodded all the same, steeling himself.

Wildbow ((Guts roll))

He holds the sword poised above your mouth, one gauntlet holding the flat sides of the blade, and then drives it downward, cutting through scar tissue and one side of your mouth.

He holds the sword there, in the slashed gap of a mouth, until the scars seem to have mostly formed, before he withdraws it.

You lie there, letting the nanomachines do their work, as the discomfort slowly subsides. The scar tissue is bad, twice as bad as you've ever experienced, but you're more or less capable of speaking (albeit slurred) and moving around. Even your fingers are somewhat functional. Your wound is healed.

((You've preserved a 1 in each stat))

"No gray goo," Leperous comments. "Today is a good day. Sorry about your face. I think you're going to need more help than I can provide, after the scars go away."

Meg Walter didn't move for a little while, instead simply staring up at the night sky, his breathing heavy as he slowly came to fully appreciate exactly what had just happened.

He summarised it with a single utterance, clear even through everything else: "Fuck."

Belayed, he finally nodded to the tinker as he slowly crawled back on his feet. "Thank you," he slurred out. "Owe you one, beyond payment."

Wildbow Leperous offers a hand in helping you to get to your feet. "If you need me, you can find me at the Lodge. I mostly run with Brew and Weep. Not even really Lodge members, but when everyone else turned up, well, they

were happy to bring in people they knew over outsiders, you know? Looking at you right now, you might fit in with us."

He claps a hand on your shoulder, soft, not hard, and then heads over to his bike.

((We just about done, up to you guys if you want to do anything before wrapping up))

Meg ((I'm entirely cool with the mental image of both of us stumbling back home and crashing into bed, really.))

Non ((I'm good here.))

//// Session End ////

Ace/Cuttlefish - Lausanne

‘Albatross’ Arc - 2.6

AceofSpade last had a turn in the very second session of WD_Lausanne, which was a while ago. I was doubly sure to include a recap at the start of this session, to bring people up to speed. For those who don't remember, Ace manifested brute powers that create tentacles with reach and a lot of raw strength. His character, Claude, also got a mutation, her body gaining a large eye around the point her right breast and shoulder would be, large enough that the front of it juts out in front of her and the back of it sticks out behind.

Ace, I think, benefited from the fact that he went second. I hadn't yet set a bar for difficulty for the sessions and probably went a little easy on him, being forgiving of the sort of mistakes I wasn't necessarily forgiving of in other sessions.

I don't want to put this in too harsh a way, but as the person running Lausanne, I wasn't overly enthused for Ace's next session. The last session wasn't one of my favorites: though he replied fast, I think he was too slow to adapt to a tough situation and the character sort of lacked hooks to really make me feel like they would be interesting when things hit the climax/endgame. Couple the fact that this session was really hard to schedule (Ace found his way halfway around the world, putting him in a time zone where he was having dinner/sleeping when I wanted to have sessions), and I sort of told myself that if he wasn't available to play today, I would drop him so the rest of the players could get their sessions.

As it happened, we did have a session. It went better than expected.

#WD_Lausanne

Wildbow	Last time, on WD_Lausanne (a long, long while back, now)... Claude gained the powers she would later wield as Cuttlefish after being wrapped around a piece of industrial machinery. Mutated, with a large eye sticking out of her chest and shoulder, normal employment was impossible, and she took up a job as a bounty hunter. Picking her mark, she searched an area of town for a troublemaker...
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...with Brute powers, who had been tearing through the residential areas, being loud and destructive.

The fight was not a pretty one, and even though he was concussed by Claude's sneak attack, the villain (later dubbed 'Axehead') proved himself to be a decent martial artist and a blade-covered wrecking ball. A second dirty trick with a false truce fell apart due to an injured limb, and the fight continued, with Axehead eventually coming out on top.

After three days in the hospital, she returns home to find a bloody scene, dead birds, and a note.

A sudden thud disturbs Claude from her research online. Leaning back in her chair, she can see through the living room of her apartment to the kitchen. Where the birds came through the glass, there is now a barrier. Apparently a piece of plywood, still being opaque, hasn't stopped the birds from flying at the window, going through the glass or through an open hole to hit a kitchen wall.

((Having taken the time to do research between sessions, Claude gets a +1 bonus on Knowledge rolls regarding the Z-suits for this session & the next.))

Ace

Well that had been informative... but that and patrolling wasn't doing any good to her bank account. A girl's got to eat... time to go bounty hunting again, she'd spent enough time recovering. Maybe she would take the opportunity to go by the tower and see the angel if the bounty wasn't time sensitive, all the cool kids were going there apparently.

Then again... maybe one of those suits would help better than a simple bounty. She decide to search for a suited villain, maybe she could just take him or her down and get her own...

Wildbow

A second glance at the computer screen shows only scattered news articles - names are few and far between,

powers are mentioned in passing, and nothing is concrete. Still, it's knowledge that can be used to put a power to a face, or connect the dots.

((Roll Dex + Know))

That in mind, the search for a concrete location isn't a confident one.

You know some general areas, but it would be something of a hunt with some crossed fingers.

A second thud on the plywood at the window nearly coincides with a knock on the front door.

Ace Maybe she should search for bounty in these area and investigate as she went to collect them... wait what? Who could possibly be knocking on her door? She did not get much visitors. Curious she stand up and goes to the door, taking a quick glance through the peephole before opening. She wasn't really a Hero yet but she might have pissed off some people with her patrolling... better safe than sorry.

Wildbow A note is tacked to the front door. The message simply reads: 'We are coming. Be ready'. You recognize the handwriting.

Ace What? Them? But... she thought she was supposed to prove herself like... on her own terms. She had NOT expected a house visit. Shit. Were they going to test her? No time to think too much, she put on her costume as fast as possible and check her small apartment making sure the cinderblocks she had bought where in tentacle range. It was one of the simplest idea she had gotten to use her power more effectively, that way she wasn't dependent on rumble, and these things were kinda cheap. One last look around and she sit down, waiting for them to... turn up she guessed? The note did not give the impression that they would be using the door.

Wildbow You don your jeans with patches that the tentacles you

manifest can slip through, the motorcycle goggles, as well as the vest you've styled to allow your mutant eye to peer through.

You sit down to wait, and the computer goes to sleep, the monitor going black. Headlights pass as cars move down the street outside of your apartment, the light momentarily flooding into your apartment. Then one car stops halfway, the lights shining in through your window. They're parked outside of your place.

Ace Oh. Be ready. She was going to meet them, okay. She stand up and goes out, calmly walking to the parked car, she wouldn't be able to bring the cinderblocks but in the cramped space of the car everyone would be in reach for her tentacles, so she did not feel too nervous, worst case scenario she could probably get the car to crash. She eyes the car a

bit suspiciously as she approach though, making sure getting in is what she's supposed to do...

Wildbow The 'car' as it happens is an old military surplus vehicle, one that might normally have canvas strapped to the rollbar at the back half, where small vehicles and supplies might be transported. Instead, however, the outside is something akin to fiberglass, but thick and stippled, doubly reinforced, and the normally open rear has a door. The logo on the side is unrecognizable, and the...

...language that goes with it is one you don't recognize. A man in a mask stands by the back.

It's easy enough to climb in, joining the three others who are sitting on benches there. Two have seatbelts on. A man with pale hair and a cat mask, and a woman with long, straight hair and a snake mask. - the other two are nondescript, wearing only nice clothes and generic, detail-less masks.

Ace Nobody said a word when she got in, doesn't look like a good time for small talk. This was getting a bit creepy but she would

go along with it... for now at least. She doesn't buckle her seatbelt, too uncomfortable with her third eye, security be damned. If something happened she would use her tentacles to anchor herself in place. She tries to remember if she has heard of the other people in the car, that could be precious information.

Wildbow **The man who stood by the rear of the truck does not get in with you, but you hear the passenger door at the front of the truck open and then close. The truck starts up and pulls away.**

"This is Ouroboros," cat-mask says. "I go by Kilkenny. We are glad you got our notes."

((There's no need for ..., it just makes it harder to format later - only if there's multiple players, and sometimes not even then))

Ace "Cuttlefish but you already know that don't you? Hard to miss the notes, I would have had to be blind really." The other two must be henchmen or something then. "Sorry to cut to the point but say... What is this meeting about? Given your first note I was under the impression that I was to prove myself out there."

Wildbow **"That was the plan. You fought Axehead and ended up needing care. We did some looking and some asking around, and it seems you are a bounty hunter, oui?"**

Ace "Oui, I am. Girl's got to eat and I can't have a normal job. Or a civilian identity for that matter. Might as well embrace the cape life. Still starting out though so yeah, probably not the best around... yet."

Wildbow **"We can't and won't help you with the funds problem, but it's a scary city," Kilkenny says. It's clear from his accent that he's not a native French speaker, though he's not making any mistakes. "Many people are coming and there is much attention around the angel. Perhaps for these reasons, we have lost some footing. Three of our**

customers have run into trouble. One is in the wind,...

...another is dead. You are on our list, a tentative prospect, and we thought a bounty hunter would be helpful."

Ouroboros speaks, "We would pay you with armor, to start. With money, later, if you wanted to work for us in the longer term."

Ace Claude squints a bit "I hadn't realized getting an armor meant working for you... This is optionnal if I understand correctly? I can get the armor for my help and then I don't have to keep working for you if I don't want to right? If so yeah I'm interested, tell me what you want and I'll tell you if I take your offer. "

Wildbow Killkenny nods, "It is optional, oui. If you want to be another one of the people with armor, you may. But to get us started... there are some individuals who have caught our attention. We can point you in the right direction, and you can pick and choose from among the targets."

Ouroboros speaks, "We maintain a total of twenty-four positions. Each time a person earns their place, we meet with them, and we build them a suit. Killkenny provides the armor and weaponry, I specialize in tinkering that magnifies and alters power. Each of the positions are named for one of the twenty-four zodiac-"

"Z for zodiac," Killkenny adds.

"And you would be aquarius, I think," Ouroboros says.

Ace "Yeah that's the one I applied for" she had no idea what the difference had been between pisces and aquarius, she had picked aquarius because a quick search had told her it was the water bearer, and she was stronger when bearing things, there was only one thing she wasn't sure about, might as well ask now. "Twenty four. There are twelve zodiac signs. You're using the chinese zodiac as well?"

Wildbow **Ouroboros says, "The Western Zodiac are more mine to oversee. The Eastern are Kilkenny's. Should you decide to take on a contract, I would be your primary contact. Half now, half later. You would get either the benefit of Kilkenny's work, which you might appreciate given your recent injuries, which look nicely healed up... or my help, to expand your options, which might assuage any...**

...worries with your power."

Kilkenny speaks up, "A woman named Crane the Harmonious has allied with local villains. She trains martial artists. I would not ask you to fight her. I would suggest you attack her 'dojo', for lack of a better word, her headquarters, and perhaps target any adult staff and scare the youths. She is trying to build something, and it puts her at odds with us.

"If you weren't comfortable with that, then there is the person who killed a suit wearer, who we lack information on, and there is a pair, a man and woman, who we do have some information on, who destroyed two suits... the wearer of that suit has grown frustrated and cut contact with us."

"We would perhaps suggest targeting the lone individual first," Ouroboros says.

Ace **"Yeah that seems more sensible" Also she wouldn't have too much regrets pummeling a known killer and throwing him in jail. "What info do you have? You must at least know what he did to destroy the suit and get at the person inside right?"**

Wildbow **"We believe that the killer is one of two people who wanted a suit, coming to the city for the express purpose of acquiring one. We have a cape in our employ, currently our Goat. She can tell us about danger and troubles, and these two individuals seemed dangerous to us and our organization. We turned them down, and they were upset. One is a, ah,"**

Kilkenny snaps his fingers, trying to recall.

"He changes, from man to ghost," Ouroboros says. "When he is a ghost, he dances, hm? And the dance changes the world around him. Very dangerous. The other one, a controller. Bugs? Bigger ones."

Ace "Sort of a Breaker Shaker then? And a minion Master. What was the victim's power and capabilities, those of the suit included. That could narrow it down."

Wildbow "These are terms we are not familiar with," Kilkenny says. He seems annoyed. "Are you making up these words?"

Ouroboros puts a hand on his arm. "American terms. The victim was our eastern bull. A friend of our western one. Enhanced speed, but blind, short distance, all of the energy stored from movement slamming out, extending forward, a rush, move forward thirty feet, a kinetic slam out for the next thirty. Our power let her move with more care. Dead, cut to shreds."

Ace "Mmmm sounds like it could be either of them... do you know where I can find them? I'll get one and if it's not the right one I'll get the other one... And I think I'll take the power magnification and alteration half of the suit."

Wildbow "We know where to find them. Which would you want to target first?"

Ace She think the bug master is more likely to have been vulnerable to the victim's power so that would make the ghost dancer the most likely suspect... but she has no idea how to fight a ghost. "The bug one" hey maybe she would be lucky and she wouldn't need to fight the freaky Breaker Shaker?

Wildbow ((You're choosing the bug?))

Ace ((Yes *suddenly question his choice but decide to stand by it*))

Wildbow Ouroboros says, "We know where she lurks. It is in the northmost area of Lausanne. People are poorer up there,

the buildings not in the same quality, and the police have largely abandoned it for now, focusing their efforts on the heart of the city. Many disturbed and dangerous individuals have chosen to stay there, and it is a festering nest of corruption and decline, one that is creeping...

...in on the remainder of the city, day by day. This is where she lurks. We can give you a neighborhood. It is very likely that you will know when you are close to her. You will not have the opportunity to get the drop on her."

Ace " Well that's not ominous at all. Thanks for the warning anyway. You said her bugs are bigger. How big are we talking exactly? Cat sized? Dog sized?"

Wildbow "Many are," Ouroboros says. "We do not personally interact with potential customers every time, so it is hard to say anything for certain. I believe we are close to our headquarters. Tell me now, if you want your powers improved... how would you like them altered?"

Ace She take a moment to think about it. "I'll take the improvement" It wouldn't do to have to re-learn about her power because they had been altered. As they where she knew them but a boost would be nice. She was curious to see what Ourobors was going to do.

Wildbow "The improvement? No, I am asking how you would like them improved, Cuttlefish."

Ace "Oh I though your ppower would tall you what's best or something. Mmm... I'd like for the tentacles to be stronger, so that I could rip out parts of buildings or from the pavement to bulk myself with. Sharp tips to dig into the ground and walls for chunks of rumble perhaps and maybe to be used as weapons?" That was friggin' strange, it wasn't every

day one had the possibility of changing something like this...
"or maybe you could make them more resistant so that they don't get cut, that way I could grab the bugs without risk and use their bodies to bulkmyself."

Wildbow **"Can you produce a tentacle here, for me to see? It would help to have an idea."**

Ace "Sure" Cuttlefish hold her arme out and produce a few tentacles toward Ouroboros so she can see for herself.

Wildbow **Ouroboros touches the tentacle, testing its range of movement. Kilkenny shows some interest as well.**

"Three options. One is that I engineer a field. It would extend about a foot from you. Reaching through it would armor anything reaching through, and I could give a limb like this a sharp cap. It wouldn't provide any protection to you, and without Kilkenny's armor to house it, the generator for that field would be a vulnerable target..."

"The second option is that I use the berserker template, you remember the one, Kilkenny? For the original Ram?"

"I remember."

"Shapeshifting armor. I would not have time to make it proper armor, though, but it would suffice while your tentacles were at bay, and would adapt to accommodate, given a few moments, once they were, while leaving you vulnerable. Heavy and slow."

"And, the last one, hm, not a field, but a floating array. You would wear a harness, concentric rings set inside one another, linked, like the rings of a tree or an onion. Stabbing a tentacle through one would let the ring unfold and layer the tentacle as the innermost ring was pushed out, each successive ring forming another layer, like scale mail, but finer."

"More general defense, the rings would block some attacks, and would be freely available. A good balance, but perhaps not as sharp or offensive as the other options."

Ace "I like the first option best, field that protect the tentacles and

give them a sharp cap" Even if the field's armor only protected the tentacles partially she would probably be able to use the tentacles themselves to block some attacks.

Wildbow **She nods, and is clearly in deep thought as you make your way out of the vehicle and into a parking garage. The three of you step into an elevator, as the staff remain behind in the garage and with the vehicle.**

Kilkenny speaks, letting Ouroboros do the thinking. "While you are conducting this job, you should give thought to your next bounty. Finding the killer of the one power suit will buy you what Ouroboros is crafting right now. The second job would be targeting one of our enemies. I do believe you masquerade as a hero?"

Ace **She squints at him, she remembered french isn't his first language, maybe he used the wrong word by accident. She decide to give him the benefit of the doubt. "Yes, I'm trying to be a hero, even if I have to be a bounty hunter."**

Wildbow **"Then we will have you target the troublemakers, so our newest hire can sleep well at night." Kilkenny holds up a finger. "Two tinkers, calling themselves Armada and Templar De Sang, showed their faces to local villains. A spy of ours has reported that the local villain establishment found even those two were too noisome and cantankerous for their tastes. The pair of tinkers was evicted....**

... We would like to see them evicted from Lausanne, with violence if necessary. For the safety of others, and to ensure we have a monopoly on the local tinkering."

A second finger, "Crane's proteges and dojo. She works with the villain establishment, the rumors surrounding her are unpleasant, and she is an avowed enemy of ours."

And a third, "And there is the pair we mentioned earlier. A flying man and a woman with an electric strike. They destroyed two of our suits. Given their position in society

and our existing alliances, we would like them removed.

"After this, you may pick one of them, and you may target them for your next bounty, to earn the completed suit. Take the meanwhile to think about it, decide who would be best."

The elevator door opens, and you step out into an office space without walls - there is only glass throughout. Several people in power armor stand around the premises, waiting patiently, while others wait, wearing nothing but their costumes. Tinker workshops have been set up in two opposite corners of the building, and offices in the other corners. The space in the middle seems to be...

...where capes can congregate.

As open and transparent as the inside space is, the windows to the outside are tinted and painted over. It looks as though you can see through, but closer examination suggests that they are actually glowing screens. The arrival in the parking garage and the nature of the 'windows' seem to prevent anyone from looking beyond and figuring out where in the city this particular office is.

The light that comes from the screens casts everything in a faint orange tint.

Ace

Well of course these two must like their little secrets, with all theses notes and observing people from afar it was kind of obvious. She stay with the tinkers but she take a good look at the other capes present, especially the ones in power armor -she might be wearing one of those in the near future after all- and she tries to compare what she sees with the research she did before the Z pair showed up.

Wildbow

In power armor, there are three individuals - a young girl sits in a cushioned seat within a large red and silver suit. The chest has opened up and head lifted away to reveal her. Even inside the armor, she wears more armor,

including a horned helmet. Petite enough to be a teenager, her design is clear enough to make her the second 'bull'.

There is a man in armor with a great bow, and he seems content to keep the armor closed up, one mechanical foot tapping, and a short distance away, lying on a bench sturdy enough to accommodate her, is a woman in a suit with long curved prongs in place of feet. You've seen the sort used by amputee runners who participate in the olympics, but this is something else entirely.

Her, you recognize from your reading. She's killed a number of heroes in town, lately. Going by the 'cat' design, she would be Kilkenny's Tiger.

Of the others, you think you recognize the girl with skin that flows like water, who sits on a bench, her face in her hands. Witness reports link her appearance to a brutal attack by a young boy with an area-of-effect power. She gained her powers in the course of that attack, and reports suggested that the boy was later found dead.

"Wait here," Kilkenny says, as Ouroboros walks over to her workshop. You're left to talk to the group.

Ace Shit. At least one of those is a confirmed multiple murderer. She didn't know for the others but she doubted they were good guys. Was there even ONE hero here except for her? Might as well try to gather some info. " 'sup? I'm Cuttlefish, bounty hunter." technical truth, the best kind of truth.

Wildbow "Who'd you beat?" the archer asks. His voice is synthesized, coming through the helmet.

Ace "Nobody yet, so I'm only getting a half armor, I'll be getting the other half if I get my target. Some gal with big bugs minions, and maybe a dude who turn into a ghost too if it turns out she wasn't the one who pissed the Zodiac duo."

Wildbow The girl with the horned helmet nods. "Them. One of them killed my partner, the armorers say."

Ace "Yeah that's why they hired me. Since I don't know which one is responsible I might have to get both but I'm hoping to get lucky on the first try."

Wildbow **She raises her head to give you a funny look, then shakes her head.**

Ace "Don't think I can do it? It's alright, I think the armorers are risking me because I'm less valuable to them than those who have already earned their suits."

Wildbow **She snorts, and there's a bitterness to her words as she says, "I don't think you can do it. I don't think my partner could do it, and she had power armor. I don't think I could do it, and I have power armor, too. Do you really think you'll succeed without any? Are you that good, bounty hunter?"**

Ace "I know my weaknesses... and by the way one of them is a lack of info on my target, you seem really confident in the fact that you wouldn't be able to do it, do you have more info than those two did?"

Wildbow **"Which one did you say you were going after? The bugs? Never fought her. My partner lived in that area, they crossed paths, she picked a fight. Deep slashes, cutting through metal. The woman is insane. There's no reasoning with her, so don't even try. Kill her, run, or die."**

Ace "That'll help." Especially since it confirmed that it was the bug one, so she wouldn't have to fight the breaker. The Master sounded like a tough fight but at least she would be able to land hits on solid opponents

Wildbow **((It doesn't confirm anything))**

Ace ((she said they crossed path... oh previously? I thought she meant the time they crossed path was the time the other bull got killed sorry))

Wildbow **Ouroboros approaches, holding a crystal braced in a tank**

of glass and reinforced metal. She gestures for you to stand, and measures something, then returns to her workshop.

"Be careful," the archer says, his head turning slightly toward Ouroboros. "What we're doing here is only a small part of a much bigger picture, I think. They have a plan, and we're only step one. The suits are literally being given away, now, but the requirements to still be wearing those suits in the later stages of the plan may be much steeper."

Ace "Yeah I figured, but I could use the boost, even temporary, bounty hunting for a living isn't that efficient." She turn back toward the Bull "What about the other one, the ghost dancer, did you fight him?"

Wildbow **"Never heard of him," she says.**

Ace Well hopefully she wouldn't have to fight him. And it did not look like any of the others were that talkative. Starting to get bored with waiting she take her pipe out and ask "Does anyone mind if I smoke?"

Wildbow **Some heads shake. You're left to smoke and there is only periodic small talk before Ouroboros eventually returns. The same container as before has been slightly modified and reinforced, and now has straps attached to it in an 'x' pattern, so it can be worn at your back. She sets it down on the bench, pulls a notepad from a lab coat pocket, and jots down an address.**

"The car will drop you off nearby, unless there's something you need to do, first? You can flip the switch to activate the tank. For now, there's only an hour of charge. You can split up the time as you wish, twenty minutes here, twenty minutes there. With the complete suit, it should fit your form better, and apply to all tentacles you create."

"For now, it will only apply to those that reach out beyond, hm, about a fingertip of distance."

At this point I have to tell someone off in the #weaverdice channel for giving advice to Ace: "You should recruit her!"

Ace admits later that it's fair that he gets shut down hard, because it wasn't his idea, and he wouldn't have thought to ask if the advice hadn't happened.

Still, I set up this whole encounter in the hopes that Ace would branch out and give me more character interaction to work with & to make things more interesting. I had notes for these characters and everything, but Ace doesn't really offer much or extend much effort. Perhaps prejudiced against the murderers in the group?

Oh well. I've warned him about the difficulty of the scenario and tried to give him the opportunity to recruit or seek out other resources. His loss if he goes in alone into a situation I intended for him & an NPC assist.

Ace "Noted, and no I don't think I have anything else to do unless someone want to join me on that apparently suicide mission" One hour of charge... well actual fight tended to last much less than that. She tries on the generator "It'll do."

Wildbow "If you'd asked earlier, I might've," the girl with the bull helmet says. "Now that I've thought about it... no, I don't think so. You can die alone."

The generator flicks on. A bubble appears around you. You experimentally touch a tentacle to the boundary. It feels cold, and metal coalesces around the tentacle, like quicksilver, but proves hard as you touch it to the bench, scratching the metal seat.

Ace She turn the generator off, no need to waste charge and this wasn't really the place to test out her new abilities. "Can you have the car take a detour by my place, I need to get something before going to the fight." She needed any edge

and seriously she hadn't bought these cinderblocks for nothing, at the very least she could use them to protect the generator.

Wildbow **Ouroboros nods, but she's already looking at the girl with the crawling skin. "Talk to the driver downstairs."**

Ace Cuttlefish shrugs, take the paper with the adress and goes down using the elevator. Once she's at the garage she gives the instructions to the driver and get in the back of the vehicule.

Wildbow **It's a swift stop back at your apartment, and as you drive by it, you can see the pile of ten or twelve dead birds that have formed a pile at the edge of the ice-frosted gutter below your kitchen window. The wood where they have been flying into the panel is now bloody and splintered from the repeated, high-speed impacts.**

You collect the cinder blocks and return to the truck, getting a ride to the north end of town. You're able to position yourself to see through the little window in the back door, looking out at a city at night-time, dusted with snow. The downtown area seems to be aflame with the congregation that has formed there, people and the lights that illuminate them. All of it shines up and...

...skyward, at Taoua Tower and the angel that hovers above it, her wings spread.

From that scene of light and beauty, it's somewhat sobering to drive past it, into shadow and desolation. As with Axehead's habitat, you can see the marks here and there of old fights. A trio of buildings overrun with thick vines and large pods like very plump string beans, a woman who looks like a ghoul, standing in the middle of the street, so that your driver has to circle around her.

Eventually the truck comes to a stop. The driver knocks on the back of the cab, signaling for you to get out.

Ace Cuttlefish get out, the cinderblock arranged as an armor

around her, especially on her torso and around the generator, she flicks it on to see if the field covers already extended tentacles or if she needs to put the blocks down and extend the tentacles again for it to work.

Wildbow **It seems it's the latter. Already extended tentacles only get a ring of the liquid metal around them where they touch the field, with nothing for what extends beyond or inside it.**

The cinderblocks don't make for terribly good armor - you do what you can, but it's not the most effective thing. Even the affected tentacles don't make for very good protection. From what she described, this was the most offensive-leaning option. At least the injuries from your past fight have all healed and your patrolling didn't hurt you any.

Looking around, you take note that several streetlights have been damaged or broken. So strange, to have gone from one area of Lausanne that is so lively, to one that is so desolate. This is a ghost town.

Ace One hour of charge. A few minutes already used. She would have to take the risk, putting the block down, extending the tentacles again so they are covered and picking up the block as armor that way. A fight shouldn't last long, but still, better to hurry toward the adress. She would know when she reached it and she wouldn't be able to get the drop

on her target... hopefully that would mean a direct fight rather than hit and run tactics.

Wildbow **The address, as it happens, is an intersection. The walk there is quiet and dark, with only one streetlight to offer light. You arrive at the center of the intersection, looking around, and see only houses without lights on. A row of birds sit on a wall, huddled together, staring off into space.**

((Wits check - Passed))

You can see further down the street. A gutter hangs in two pieces. Something has slashed it at the middle. Squinting reveals that the outside of the house is scarred with long cuts.

Ace That looks like it. Cuttlefish walk toward the slashed house at a brisk pace, keeping an eye around for sentry bugs or whatever it was that Master would be able to do to get advance warning.

Wildbow ((Wits check - failed))

((And again - passed))

You stop in your tracks as you see something. It's a bug, chewing on a pigeon. Its limbs are like a praying mantis', and the other limbs similar in style, biting into the stone at the top of a wall that borders a property. It's the size of a medium sized dog, thirty pounds or so, but its rear half hangs off the back of the wall.

The armored plates at its back give it an almost pyramid shape, though that pyramid sweeps backward.

Now that you know what you're looking for, you're able to glance around. You walked by one, which is perched in a tree.

Ace Well... this is it, the moment of truth. Are the new tentacles capable of killing the bug minions? She take a deep breath and lash out at the closest bug using two tentacles, aiming to impale it through the abdomen.

Wildbow ((roll Brawn))

The metal-capped tentacle stabs through the creature's armored head, tearing past organs and other tissue, leaving ichor to spill down and out over the wall.

The creature doesn't die, but it drops the pigeon from its mandibles, and it screams with a volume that seems impossible for something of its body weight.

In the next moment, it lets go of the wall with all of its legs, and it seems to float, with no wings to keep it aloft.

Waving in the air, still screaming, it soars skyward, up to a height of roughly twenty feet, a long and narrow centipede body following it, each side of the body lined with rows of the praying mantis limbs, sharp and hard enough to have bitten into stone.

Fun fact! These giant centipede-creatures have two wounds each, each needing several solid hits to take them out of action, barring the bonus effects of those wounds.

They're also, as it just so happens, exceptionally dangerous. When they attack, they roll two die and keep the highest, in addition to getting a +1 bonus. They do the same when they roll to dodge.

These aren't just minions with good stats. They're minions with good stats and combat ability on par with someone who is *trained* to fight.

Ace

What the hell it's not dead?? The tentacle went through it's friggin' head! As the insect rise Cuttlefish suddenly realize she's in even deeper water than she feared. It's swim or die now. She get out as many tentacles as she can, using some of the to tear at the wall while she attack with the others, trying to pierce the centipède all over it's long body.

Wildbow

((Brawn roll x3))

You use the metal-capped tentacles to collect enough rubble to extend two 'arms'. Unfortunately the time spent doing this means you're too slow to deliver the attack. The centipede lunges past you-

((roll dodge or guts))

and slashes deep, past the metal your tentacle was

armored with, and into flesh. It hurts a surprising amount, taking the wind from your lungs (One of four false wounds you've created via. added tentacles have been shredded)).

Ace **Shit. Fuck. Balls. Motherfucker. Well if piercing them wasn't enough maybe these bugs would be more vulnerable to being squished. Using she uses the rumble collected by the extended tentacles as a big hammer to hit the centipede.**

Wildbow **((Brawn))**

A heavy blow strikes at the bug, knocking a section of its middle to the ground. Its forward momentum is arrested, its head cracks against the ground, and the extended top half writhes and lashes about madly, striking at nearby houses and walls with its own head and claws.

The screaming subsides. For a moment, there is only silence and a ringing in your ears that seems to go on for too long in the wake of the mad scream the thing made.

The other bug on the more distant tree branch watches you, staring.

Ace **Cuttlefish tries to quickly finish the centipede with a blow to the head, the other one wasn't hostile yet but she didn't need to bet that the reinforcement were coming, she would need to tear apart more rumble after the blow.**

Wildbow **You walk the fifteen or so feet to the head of the bug, and you plunge tentacles into it, tearing the head to smithereens.**

The bug on the branch watches, silent. Then, abrupt, it screams, just as the first one did.

The scream is picked up by another in the area, from a nearby house.

Then another, and another, and ultimately a fifth, all in areas surrounding you.

The bug lurches, and like its brother did, it soars skyward, its lower body protected and hidden by the branches of the tree. It stares down at you from a point higher than any of the buildings in the area.

((Wits check))

Ace Since it's not attacking immediatly... The tentacles strike everything around her, digging the pavement and walls, and snatching all the available rubble, bulking up her tentacles, this time she's looking for added power instead of armor.
((trying to get bonus brawn instead of false wounds))

Wildbow ((Roll Brawn x2))

You're able to gather more rubble. You try to mend your damaged set of tentacles that the centipede cut, and form it into a crude club-like construction.

The bug who looms above you lunges, snapping-

((Roll Dodge or Block))

You manage to fend off its bite as it tries to sink mandibles into you. In the next moment, its up, back, and out of even your extended reach.

((roll Wits))

One of the screams you're hearing is different from that of the bugs. The cadence and continuous nature of it is similar, mimicking them, but the scream is- human?

Ace What is she doing? The bugs aren't the target, she only attacked because she expected them to be guarding their master, the master was the target. She tries to locate the direction of the human scream and start going there, not turning her back to the centipede until she's out of his reach though, that would be stupid.

Wildbow The centipede's reach, as it happens, is such that you can't exactly escape it. As you move further down the

street, toward the sound of the scream, the centipede follows, matching every meter you run by drawing a meter closer, wrapping its middle around the roof and gutters of nearby buildings.

((Wits check x2))

You spot the woman, standing on a rooftop at the end of the street, a hundred feet away. The act of noticing however, leaves you blind to a sneak attack from your flank-

((Roll Brawn - passed))

Teeth pinch you as they grab at your flesh, but they scrape against your leather jacket and fail to dig in. With sheer strength, the bug tries to clamp on and lift you, but you're able to leverage your strength and twist yourself free. They seem to want to grab you.

The woman stands on a roof, her hair shaggy, dark circles under her eyes, her face covered in blood that isn't her own, to the point it's nearly a mask, her features contorted into a scream that seems endless. She wears a dress so stained with blood that it's stiff and hard.

Ace Ah! The bug who tried to bite her hasn't retracted yet, it's position is perfect, Cuttlefish immediately club it over the head with her heavy club-arm. She would deal with the woman as soon as she was done with this centipede, she had an idea...

Wildbow ((Roll Brawn))

The head is well out of reach, but the body isn't. You strike it hard enough to leave its body like a noodle of spaghetti. It topples, collapsing backward and well out of reach, landing across the roof of a house and through someone's fenced-in backyard.

Ace Good enough for now, the Master was still the priority. She turn toward the woman and advance, grabbind one of the

cinderblock protecting her torso and using her tentacles as a makeshift trebuchet, fling the heavy projectile toward her. Throwing wasn't her thing but she didn't really need to be precise, at the very least a flying cinderblock should

startle her enough to stop the scream. And if she scored even a glancing blow...

Wildbow ((10' base range, +40' for Brawn from power, -2 to hit at this distance, roll Dex - Miraculous roll))

You whip the projectile a considerable distance, and it flips through the air. She tries to dodge, but is a little too slow to move, and it catches her in the side of the stomach. She practically pirouettes as she falls backward, out of sight.

The scream has stopped, but the bugs around you haven't. The bug you knocked over is fast to recover, head lunging over the wall and sliding past you, legs cutting like a saw might. The other one who just emerged tries again to bite you.

((Two defensive rolls))

The sawblade legs shear past your tentacle, cutting past metal to dig at the flesh. You've lost one of your four good tentacle arms, now.

Teeth bite at you and fail to pierce your clothes, but the mandibles pinch, and- ((Roll brawn))

-you manage to keep them from seizing you once more.

Ace Shit. Ow. She quickly use the club tentacle to try and squish the saw centipede. At the same time she tries to get more tentacles out to pierce the one who tried to bite her.

Wildbow ((Attack roll))

You whiff the attack as the thing sways well out of reach. Another one appears, on the far end of the street, near

where the woman had been.

As you watch, another rises. But this one holds the woman like the first one you saw held the pigeon. Mandibles grip her head, folded around her face and neck, and the other limbs clutch at her body and clothes. Her arms and legs hang limp as the thing reaches skyward, hovering thirty feet over the ground with her in its clutch.

((The woman's body is about 70' away horizontally and 30' up, vertically))

Ace Is she getting eaten by her own minion? Doesn't matter. Cuttlefish decide to take a risk, dashing for the centipede holding the woman, even if running toward her mean she has to turn her back to the others. If she can she need to hit the centipede holding her before it retreat.

Wildbow There's a house and 70' of street between Cuttle and the centipede that holds the woman, and in the first 50 or so feet, Cuttlefish draws attacks from two of the creatures.

((Two defensive rolls))

((roll Brawn))

Teeth reach past Cuttlefish's armored tentacles and seize her leg. Here, the clothing isn't as much protection, and mandibles tear into her calf. ((moderate wound, no side effects))

Up above, the creature that holds the woman moves, veering back and away. Its body bends, forming a loop that extends forward under her feet. It lets go of her head, revealing that no damage has been done, and lets her drop down to stand unsteadily on the loop of its extended body, supported by the centipede.

Ace Well no shame in using the same trick twice, Cuttlefish get a cinderblock and hurls it at the woman again, she was a bit closer so this should be a bit easier...

Wildbow ((She's higher up, even if you're closer, so same penalty))

The wound to your leg leaves you stumbling, and your aim is off. The rubble flies well past her, sailing into the distance to dent a garage door or shatter a window somewhere.

She screeches at you, extending an arm as if she unconsciously knows where the other creature is. Between the one-sided sway of the creature she rides, moving to draw closer to another, she manages to get herself handed off to the creature, covering a distance of roughly a hundred feet with only a single step to make the crossing.

The two nearest you bite-

((Defensive rolls))

You manage to deflect them with armored tentacles.

Ace Oh no she can't let the ringleader get away, once again she dashes, and when she reaches the house in her path she uses her tentacles to climb it, not hesitating to plant the tips of her tentacles in the walls to get a grip. She needs to get that woman, she's the real danger.

Wildbow ((Roll Ath + Brawn, add modifiers))

You manage to scale the exterior, and plant yourself on the rooftop. The woman moves a good fifty additional feet away. Between the centipede that first carried her up and the other two behind you, you're now surrounded.

((three defensive rolls))

((And brawn roll))

With your unsteady footing and needing to watch three directions at once, you're seized firmly in the jaws of one of the creatures. Your feet no longer touch solid ground as it lifts you up.

Ace Cuttlefish immediatly lash out, aiming all her tentacles at the centipede's head, trying to get more out to stab the creatur with even. It wouldn't be able to keep grabbing her if she destroyed her mandibles.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll))

In the process of being thrown from side to side, you can't get a good strike in, your tentacle glancing off the armored carapace.

((Roll Brawn))

((And roll defensive))

Busying yourself with attacking rather than fighting the closing jaws bought it an opportunity to close its jaws further. You feel it clench around you like a vise. Only your natural toughness and hardiness keep you from being crushed like hamburger. The creature lifts you up and away, carrying you away from its master and higher off the ground.

Ace She choose to hit the jaw directly, with her club arm, hoping to break it before the centipede can take her too far up.

Wildbow With a solid strike you're able to bash the creature's head in-

The hit is solid enough to knock the creature's wits out. It lets go of you, dropping you a solid twenty feet to the ground.

((Roll Athletics - failed))

You hit the ground and sprawl. You're unable to do more than crawl for the next few long moments as the bugs mass around you. Two remain, a third holds the woman, and from the sound of screeching, there are others in the area.

It strikes you that more preparation and finding or

negotiating for allies would have been a good idea. The girl with the horned helmet told you outright that you were probably outclassed here.

Ace

She had actually gone into this fight more prepared than she had been for Axehead... still not enough. And she doubted that she would be able to get out of this one with some quick wits. But isn't dead yet. She just got the wind knocked out of her... she won't give up. She might die but dammit she'll die fighting! She stand up and try to club the nearest of the two centipedes, if she could get them of her back just a moment... she could try to get the Master again maybe? ((How far is the Master? Still more than a hundred feet?))

Wildbow

((<http://i.imgur.com/9y4DxNg.png> - she's about 300' away at this point))

You swing blindly as you turn over onto your back, looking up to face the centipedes, but they are hanging back, well out of your reach. With their extended bodies, they're free to lunge and snap, and they don't have to remain close enough for you to strike at them.

Ace

Then... she need to strike as they are trying to strike her. Maybe use their own movement against them, aven them implale themselfe on extended metal tentacles as they lunge, Bash them as they are about to bite. She doesn't attack, catching her bearing, but she's ready to react as soon as her adversaries make a move.

Wildbow

((Roll Social))

A centipede starts to lunge before stopping short. You manage to mask your intentions. Three centipedes then attack in concert. Your timing is off, and you're too slow to strike out. ((Roll defensive x3))

I roll a 5, 3, and 5 for the attack values.

Ace has high ranks in Withstand, allowing him to roll

two dice each time he rolls to block or avoid being shoved around/thrown/whatever, and then take the highest. He also has a +1 from stats.

That said, he rolls an effective 7... a 7... and a 7.

With the Withstand skill, getting a sufficiently high block roll vs. an incoming attack can stagger an attacker, leaving an opening for a counterattack.

You -are- ready, it seems, to protect yourself from the attacks. With armored tentacles wound around rubble, you manage to deflect two lunging bites and one saw-leg movement as a centipede lunges past you. As you deflect one slash, you manage to get one clip of a hit in against the centipede's face, keeping it from retreating as legs thirty feet away lose their grip on a rooftop. The head...

...is right in front of you, vulnerable.

Ace She bashes it immediatly, there is no wasting the opportunity.

Wildbow Carapace caves in vs. rubble as you smash the head against the ground.

The tenor of the distant woman's scream changes, and the centipedes, rearing up to lunge at you once more, seem to change their minds. They twist around, preparing to retreat.

((<http://i.imgur.com/ENaZaEu.png>))

Ace They are turning their backs to HER? This is too good to pass up! She use the respite to get up and charge the one in between her and the Master, the head would be out of reach but maybe she would be able to destroy the body enough to cripple it.

Wildbow ((Brawn roll))

You climb to your feet, brace yourself, and run after the

retreating centipede. It moves too fast, and your fist glances off the body as it moves, winding around nearby buildings while it makes its retreat.

((Wits check))

The centipedes are smart enough to know how to fight, and they're quick and nasty, but in making their retreat, it doesn't seem as though they're taking any particular evasive maneuvers. You aren't equipped to catch up to them, but you can definitely see the direction they're going.

Ace They must be retreating to the nest... Which mean either more centipedes or the chance to surprise the Master as she think she's safe. Maybe it isn't a retreat, maybe they're just regrouping... Cuttlefish decide to take the risk an follow them as quickly as possible, grabbing anything she can as rumble. She also check the time to see how much charge she still has, the fight can't have lasted that long...

Wildbow Between the lead-up to the fight and the fight itself, a mere ten minutes have passed. You limp slightly with the wound on your leg as you make your way down the street. The centipedes are visible from a distance as they go over rooftops, moving in a straight line. There's a point, several blocks away and around a corner, where they seem to be stopping.

Ace Probably regrouping. Charging in is a bad idea. But mayyyybe... Ah she'll at least go take a look. On the way she look around for a good projectile, if she could just get close enough to aim right a good thrown could end it all without even a real fight.

Wildbow You pass a garden where several stones have been stacked and fit together like a jigsaw, unmortared, to bound the dirt. You pull several good throwing rocks free of that retaining wall, holding them so they're ready to throw.

Rounding the corner, you see the house. It's... not really in question that this was her destination. No less than nine of the centipedes are present. Each and every one of them is wound around the house, as if constricting it. Their bodies block the front door and many of the windows.

Ace Ah she retreated and now she got her minions garden her fortress. Nine of them. That's about six or seven too many. If only she had gas, she might be able to burn the house down, forcing her to get outside, and then she could get her... She had matches. She look at the nearby buildings to see if she can maybe get access from the roof. Or something

Wildbow With the reach of tentacles, it would perhaps be possible to scale up to the roof or one of the available windows. A particularly bad move could mean bumping against the centipedes or disturbing them.

Ace Risky, she would rather see if there was a gas station nearby from which she could siphon some gas to make molotov cocktail.

Wildbow ((using google maps to figure it out... and, not really))
Scaling a nearby building for a vantage point, you look around. The only gas station you can see is separated from you is on the other side of a highway, and the lights are off. This area of town truly is a ghost town.

Ace Too far, are there still cars on the street, any vehicle still here probably won't be missed, maybe there is a car small enough for her to throw, unless someone left their keys on the contact

Wildbow The smallest car is one of the new hybrids. You test your strength to see if you can lift it-

((roll Brawn))

The lift of the end of the car isn't a strong one, even as your tentacles wind around it. The rear end comes down hard, with a loud bang.

You tense, expecting the centipedes to react. They remain stock still, frozen, not so much as a leg twitching.

Ace Oh. That's it, they have different states? Before she attacked they where hunting, not paying any attention to humans then the one she attacked defended itself and the other went into attack mode, now she had them in defense mode or something like that. Maybe the plan to climb while carefully avoiding the centipedes wasn't that bad after all. She tries to get closer to the house, to see if they react to proximity or from seeing someone approaching.

Wildbow ((Roll Wits - dismal failure))

You approach, watching carefully. You don't see anything wrong. A movement of a tentacle doesn't seem to make a leg twitch

That said, with the fatigue of the fight and the darkness playing a part in things, you're not confident in those observations.

Ace Especially since these assholes know how to feint, they tried it when she was recovering from her fall and was waiting for their attacks. Climbing could be a trap. She didn't have anything to put on fire. Except cars but she wouldn't be able to throw them, maybe not even move them... still it was worth a shot. Cuttlefish tries to get a car closer a

nd place it so that the wind will carry the smoke toward the house. Then she thrown a lit match on the seating and walk away. hoping that the smoke will force the Master out or at least make the centipedes move so that she can enter.

Wildbow Some time passes. Several minutes, without sign of smoke or fire.

The match wasn't sufficient to light the car seat.

Ace Isn't synthetic seating supposed to be super easy to burn? Ugh. She's running out of ideas. And it's not like the ones she

did have had been that good anyway. Except for the cinderblock thrown, that had been good. Maybe the best idea at that point would be to turn around and come back later more prepared? But that idea left a bad taste in her mouth, it was her second big outing and for both the conclusion would be that she had managed to stay alive. Well at least she was still in fighting shape this time. That was progress. Finally she decide to throw one of the rock at an exposed window, to see what will happen.

Wildbow ((Car seats in most areas in Europe are required to be fire resistant))

((Roll Dex - rolls a high 6))

The rock crashes through glass. But for the sound of the breaking glass and the reactionary barking of a dog somewhere in the neighborhood, there's no reaction.

The centipedes remain still.

Ace These things communicate by screaming, they can't be deaf... maybe they are just bad at recognizing sounds outside of their language? Anyway Cuttlefish decide to risk it, she approach slowly and take her time to climb carefully, avoiding the centipedes to reach an exposed window, not the broken one though.

Wildbow ((Roll Ath + Brawn - easy pass with brawn bonus from tentacles))

You wrap your tentacles around the gutter, the window frame and shutters, and begin your ascent. With the strength afforded by the extra tentacles, it's easy enough to climb

Your foot taps the side of one centipede and you freeze, watching as it moves, constricting tighter against the house, feet digging into siding.

The window isn't locked, and opens. It's fairly clear at first

exposure that the house isn't heated. No lights are on within.

Ace As Cuttlefish gets in one of her first reflexes to smell the air, in case it was some sort of trap. Then she move inside the house, carefully exploring each room, looking for the Master... she needed a better name than that... Centiqueen? That would have to do.

Wildbow Moving through the window and into the room, Cuttlefish finds herself in what seems to be an office. Bookshelves, a desk, a computer that is now collecting dust, and, as her eyes adjust, she notes the body of a centipede, extended across walls and ceiling, covering almost a third of the room's interior.

Ace Okay THAT was the catch, dodging the centipedes outside wasn't enough, she needed to dodge them inside. Well still better than fighting them. She move carefully inside, making sure not to step on the thing, she need to get out of the room and explore the rest of the house.

Wildbow ((Roll Ath))

You step over the body of the centipede, and make your way into the house interior. Beyond the office is the upstairs hallway, a railing looking over on the front hall, the stairs, and many more centipedes, still as they clutch the inside walls and furniture.

You pass by a nursery, dark, the door open. A book shows a green caterpillar with a red head and a large apple.

And, as you reach the top of the stairs, you find yourself looking down. The woman is slumped against a wall in the hallway.

Ace Cuttlefish ready a tentacle, poising it to strike and end the madwoman's life, but something feels wrong with that picture. She slowly approach, squinting to discern if the woman's chest is moving and trying the discern the sound of her breathing in

the silence.

Wildbow **The suddenness with which she looks up at you is startling. Her eyes are wide, and the dark circles that you can see beneath the caked-on blood are darker than they were when you saw her before.**

"Ah," she says. Her head sinks. Her hands aren't moving much. She has clearly torn or had a centipede tear at her dress, exposing much of her stomach. It's swollen to a gruesome degree, the flesh bruised to the point of turning black.

Ace Got her good... the cinderblock throwing really had been a good idea. But before she kill the woman she need to ask something. "Internal bleeding. You haven't got long... I can make it quicker but before I need an answer. Are you the one who killed the power armor wearer, the Bull?"

Wildbow **She looks up at you, eyes wide in confusion. "Na."**

Ace "Ugh... well I can still make it quicker. I don't think I could save you even if I rushed you to a hospital." Wrong kill. Shit. Well she can't let the poor woman suffer now. She take her time to aim so as not to make her suffer any more than necessary and plunge her metal covered tentacle at the base of her brain, where it met the spinal cord, hope

fully killing her instantly and painlessly.

Wildbow **"Boh," she says, raising a hand, pointing toward the upstairs.**

((Make your attack roll when you want to follow through - Ace rolls a headshot. Instant kill.))

With a metal-plated tentacle, you puncture her cranium.

Ace Wait shit, she had been saying something right before. Bo? Boh? Something about upstairs. Still minding the centipedes in case they are still alive after the Centiqueen's death the walk upstairs.

Wildbow You make your way upstairs and head in the direction she had been pointing. You find yourself in the doorway of the nursery. The book you noticed before is there. Bo- the first syllable of the word book? Perhaps she'd wanted to see the book before she died.

It's clear that she made the room into something of a nest, and not of the creepy sort. It is, in fact, the only room in the house that you've seen that the centipedes haven't touched or occupied. Blankets and a mattress have been moved to the foot of an empty crib. A child's whiteboard and markers were propped up nearby, with portraits and pictures. The woman, just a year ago, a young mom, and presumably her husband. More pictures, more things.

Writing on the whiteboard is in an eerie child's scrawl - I miss you I love you I miss you I miss you babies protect me from this- (it takes several tries to read the next word) awful world. Protect me from this awful world, is the last bit.

Ace Well now she felt like crap. The woman had had issues but who doesn't? She hadn't been a nice person but she did what she thought she had to do. Perhaps in other circumstances she could have turned differently and worked for good... Cuttlefish decide to go out the same way she came in. The centipedes will probably die without their master, it might take a bit of time but their last order had been to protect the place so they probably wouldn't move from here.

once she's out she goes back to her apartment, right now she only wanted to drink and sleep

Wildbow

//// Session End ////

Poor Centipede Queen.